

A woman is lying on her back on a tan leather car seat. She is wearing black fishnet stockings and black lace underwear. Her legs are raised and bent at the knees, with her feet resting on the seat. The background is a blurred view of a car window.

LEARNING LESSONS

A **LOSING HIS WIFE** NOVEL

KT MORRISON

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A Losing His Wife Novel

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PART I

DATE NIGHT

INSIDE OUT

THURSDAY, AUGUST 11TH

Pete put the boys to bed at a quarter after eight. They complained. It was too early, they said. But ‘Inside Out’ was over—fuck, they’d seen it fourteen times already—and he was crawling out of his skin. He kissed them and put them to bed. Little Andy begged for a story and he sat and read for both of them but he was a hundred million miles away.

Now he was sitting in the living room, his second Dewar’s melting ice cubes on the end table at his elbow. She’d looked so beautiful when she’d left. Standing in the hall looking at him with one hand on the doorknob, ready to leave. She seemed nervous, fearful, her eyes were wide. He’d put his hand on her shoulder, gripped her arm—reassured her. She nodded and braced herself. He kissed her on her warm forehead so he wouldn’t muss her lipstick and she put her arms around his waist and hugged him for a long while. Then she left.

He’d watched her walk down their short driveway. She had dressed herself up and he longed to be the one she’d done it for. She wore heels, the first time he ever remembered her wearing them. Black, not too high, enough to make her legs seem even more shapely. She stumbled to the minivan learning to walk on her toes as she went. She got in and he saw her face in a brief instant lit up by the dome before she closed the door. Her long, pale blonde hair, thick and lightened by the summer sun, pulled up and away from her still beautiful face, done up in a bun held in place by two metal sticks. It showed off her long, elegant neck. In that little second, lit up in their six-year-old minivan, he saw her for the last time as he’d known her. His beautiful wife. Third Grade teacher. Bill payer. Nose wiper. Loving

partner. Number one mom. He didn't know who was going to come home to him tonight but he knew they would be changed forever as a couple. It gripped him, excited him—absolutely scared the living shit out of him. He had held his breath as the silver van crawled across the night-time blue of their little cul-de-sac dripping water from the exhaust.

Pete took another sip of his drink. He squeezed the glass in his fist, felt it cold and hard. He took another swig, drained it, and set it quietly back down. His lips were numb from the ice as he stared into the dark room.

What was she doing right now? Right this moment terrible things could be happening to his wife. She could be bent over the bench seat in the back of their van, her rump tilted up, skewered by her foul-mouthed co-worker, panting and grunting, fogging up their windows, the suspension squeaking as he fucked her.

He hated the thought. He cherished the thought. His passionate wife really getting it like she wanted for once. He hoped she loved it. He hoped she cried out so loud when she came that she deafened that ape.

Pete didn't like her choice. But he had to abide it. That was their rule. He'd wanted this first, she wanted it too, but it was her choice, not his. She could have picked anyone. Anyone from her work, at a bar, or even find some stud online. She only wanted one man. She wouldn't consider another.

Was Tyler her type of man? I mean, physically he understood. Tyler was ten years younger than them. Taught gym to the older grades at a sister school and he was very fit. But too muscular. And his personality was muscular too. Brash, arrogant, loud. He had too much to drink at the little end-of-summer get-together they had two weekends ago. He had to be reminded at least a dozen times to watch his language in front of the children. He looked out of place amongst their normal suburban mom and dad friends with his thick but athletic body. And Tyler had to wear long sleeve shirts when he was at school but at the party, everyone could see the tattoos that covered both his arms and over one shoulder onto his chest. Dragons and demons and swords, random Americana mixed in with all that. Bunch of kid shit.

That's what his wife liked? He couldn't believe she would fall for all that show. She seemed to—he'd seen her talking to Tyler in a quiet corner later in the party when it had got darker. She was tracing the lines drawn on his arm with her forefinger. She was flirting with him, her bare, tanned legs drawn up underneath her, looking up at him through her eyelashes, almost

empty glass of white wine held crooked in her other hand. Pete took that hard. The arrangement, as it had come to be known, was already under way, but it still hurt to be confronted with it. It hurt but it turned him on and he hated that it did.

That big, dumb fuck was with his wife right now, thinking that Jess was sneaking out on a little date behind Pete's back. He bet that Tyler would be high-fiving himself all night thinking he'd got one over on Pete, fucked his wife, never realizing Jess was the one doing the fucking, and doing it with her husband's blessing.

The room was lit up with headlights coming in the driveway. He watched his silhouette glide across the fireplace, the bookshelves, the framed finger-painting Pete Jr. had done of the family. His mom and dad and brother and their Irish setter, a red hot dog shape with fat legs standing in thick brushstrokes of bright green grass. He heard the van door slam, heels on brick.

His heart was gripped. It was done. He got up and walked to the door, watched her come into the dark house. She was aware of him in the hall, standing near her. She paused a moment, keys still in her hand.

"Hi," she said, her voice so quiet he hardly heard her say it. He moved to her and hugged her.

"Did it happen?"

"It did."

He could have fallen to his knees but he was prepared for this. He looked into her eyes, lit up dimly by the streetlights. Her hair was out of the bun, dishevelled, her makeup was gone, her mascara running. Had she been crying? "Come in," he said, closing the door. He walked her into the living room, his hand on the small of her back.

He sat down on the couch and turned the table lamp on, lighting them both up soft and gentle in pale yellow. Jess stepped out of her heels and stood in her bare feet.

She put herself down on the couch carefully, sitting on one cheek and tucking a leg underneath her. She winced. "A little sore," she said.

Pete's heart raced. It was true. She had fucked him. There was no turning back. Who was this woman he used to know sitting in front of him? He was excited to find out.

"How was it?"

She bit her lip, prepared herself for this. "It was...Pete, it was incredible," she said.

"Tell me what happened."

She had her hands together in her lap. His little slut wife putting on the demure act. Trying to act like she used to.

"We went out for drinks at that place on the number Seven, by the Harley dealership—where all the college kids go. We only had two drinks...he was really flirting, putting on a show, you know—"

"Yeah?"

"So I leaned in and told him I just wanted," she paused, then whispered, "to fuck."

"You said that to him? What'd he do?" His heart was pounding in his ears. Jess never said that word.

"He was cool about it, he just nodded and threw down some cash and then he, you know...took my hand and marched me out of there." That made her laugh, thinking about it.

"Then where did you go?"

"I just took him into the van," she said, making a funny face like she hoped that would be all right.

"You fucked him in our minivan?"

"Oh, yeah," she said, laughing again. Was it going to be just like he'd pictured?

"How'd you start?" Pete's whole insides, from the top of his heart right down to his asshole had seized right up. He couldn't breathe. He really thought there was a chance he could pass out. Jess reached out and took his hand, saw him struggling. They were in this together.

"Well, he didn't waste much time. We got in the van and he started kissing me, kissing down my neck. He lifted my top up over my head—"

"Did he touch your breasts?"

She squeezed his hand, held it tight for a moment, then said, "Of course he did. I took my...I took my bra off for him and he sucked on them...sucked on my nipples."

"Oh boy," he said.

Jess moved herself into him, cuddled up with him. She said, “I love you. I love that we’re in this together.”

“Yeah, keep going.” He wasn’t sure how much he was into it anymore.

“He took his shirt off—oh my gosh, Pete, his body. I almost came running my hands over him. I wanted to take more time with that—enjoy it—but we were moving pretty fast. He was squeezing my breasts while I did it, maybe a little too hard, but I just let him. Pete, he has muscles on muscles.”

“Uh-huh.”

“But I was dying for him to put it in me. I was shaking so bad. I undid his pants and pulled them down...” she hesitated. Pete saw that she was feeling like this was getting a little delicate.

“Tell me,” he said.

“Well, I’d already kind of heard...” she was stuck for a moment.

“Heard what? That he had—”

“Yeah, I’d heard that he had a really big one.”

“Who told you that?”

“Sara Bridge—Grade Two—she heard that from a friend of a friend. Someone saw him in a shower at the gym.”

“You...is that why you picked him?”

“Yeah,” she admitted, shrugging her shoulders.

“I wondered why you’d pick someone that arrogant—”

“Oh no, I like that too. And that body...”

“And now his big dick...”

“I’m in love with his penis.”

“So it was big?”

Jess rolled her eyes. She held her hands apart a distance that Pete couldn’t believe.

“Oh, come on, I thought bodybuilders were supposed to have small ones,” he said.

She clutched his arm, “Pete, I’m serious. It was hard to move around in the van without it getting stuck on something.” She made a wide-eyed face at him, then held her hands up like she was holding a hot dog, said, “Like really, really thick too.”

“Really?”

“Biggest one I have ever seen,” she said, putting her hand over her heart.

“Bigger than—”

“Brad? Way bigger. I mean way bigger.” Brad was a boyfriend she’d had her first year in University and she’d sometimes tell Pete about him during their dirty talk. He had been her biggest until tonight.

“So...” he said, struggling. He was feeling a little sick now. This might be too much to take all at once. He suddenly didn’t want to really talk about this anymore. Maybe later, just take a little break.

He felt Jess’ hands come to his waist. She fumbled with his buckle, undid it, then slowly did his fly down. She fished his little thing out, it was hard as a rock, sticking straight up barely poking up out of his pants. She peeled the fly apart, exposing it, a silver string of semen lit up in the light stuck to the inside of his zipper. She touched him with her finger and it poured from him.

“So you were saying...you were saying that he had a really great cock?”

“It was even more than I’d hoped for,” she said. She held his dick in her fingers looking at his shame. The reason they’d agreed that she could seek out pleasure from another man.

“Did you put it in your mouth?”

She shook her head, said, “I didn’t want to waste time, I just wanted it inside me.”

“How did you do it?”

“I just laid back, I put my leg up on, you know, over the back of the bench. Then he...he put it inside me.” She stroked her husband, giving him what she knew he liked.

“Did it hurt?”

“A little. I definitely felt it. But Pete, I was so wet it really...it really did just slide in there. I was surprised. It’s been so long since I’ve had a real one inside me. I’m used to this cute little guy.”

“You really needed it.”

“I really did.”

“So you fucked him face to face? Were you kissing?”

“I think so, probably. I was pretty overwhelmed, it just really felt so damn good. I could’ve been doing anything, but I was just thinking about his size inside me.”

“Jess, did he wear a condom?”

“Of course he did, Petey. I wouldn’t do that.”

“Okay.”

Jess leaned over his lap and she reached out with her fingers, snagged a folded blanket on the arm of the couch and she pulled it over. “So, Pete, then he was making love to me. He was doing it so hard. He was making me gasp.” She opened the blanket, unfolded it and lay it across his lap, covered up his erection. “I’m worried one of the boys might come down.”

“Yeah, okay,” he said, desperately wanting her hand back on his little dick, dying to hear more. She slid her hand over his thigh and under the blanket.

She searched around for it, found it, said, “Oh, here he is. He’s so hard, Pete. You like hearing about a real man putting his huge penis inside me, don’t you?”

“I do, Jess. I want you to be happy.”

She stroked him with just her soft fingertips, running them gently up and down the sides of his throbbing little hard-on. “Tyler made me very happy. He really filled up my insides, stretched me out down there like I never felt.”

“Tell me how he fucked you.”

“Just like I told you. We didn’t switch around or anything. He just shoved that big thing between my legs and we were face to face. We made love like—”

“He fucked you.” She hated the word but he needed to hear it from her.

“He fucked me, Pete. He fucked me hard. He was amazing. I felt his stomach while he was inside me. He pounded me and I ran my fingers over his abs, felt his muscles flex. It really was incredible.”

“Did he make you come?”

She kept stroking him, her eyes watching the blanket move as her hand worked him under there. She bit her lip. Maybe he didn’t want to know.

“No, he didn’t. But, Pete, it was so close. In a way, it was like I was coming the whole time, it was so...I don’t know, so crazy, so exciting.”

“He came?”

“Oh, yeah, he did. It didn’t actually last that long. He...fucked me...hard and fast and I felt his stomach all over. I wanted it to go on forever. But he came. Just a couple of minutes. I could feel him inside me coming, you know? Even though he was wearing a condom I could feel his penis flexing inside me and I could feel his...come...shooting into the end of the condom. Isn’t that crazy?”

“Oh God, Jess,” she had him on the edge now. It wasn’t the dirty talk he expected. He thought she’d tell him how Tyler made her come like mad. How she thrashed under him and screamed his name out and had the orgasm of her life. This story was dirtier somehow. She *almost* came. She could feel his load fill up his condom inside her. She was so dirty. He could feel more precum stream out of him, could feel his wife’s hand get slipperier on it, flick on his glans quicker and quicker. “Shit, Jess, what happened then?”

“We kind of looked at each other for a minute. It was weird and uncomfortable, really. He got nervous, like, maybe he realized he just had sex with another man’s wife. A man he’d met.”

“Something tells me he doesn’t care about that, ah...” one of her fingers danced across his hole.

“Maybe not, but it got strange. He pulled it out of me and that was a really funny feeling. Like I felt empty or something. Then I watched him zip it up and he said he should get going. I wanted more but it was...it felt wrong all of a sudden. Then he left. And I watched him go to his bike and I drove around for a while. Then I came home.”

Jess was quiet for a while, flicking her wrist on him, her thumb on the underside of his little cock, three fingers along the back, hidden in his pubic hair. “Don’t you think it’s so unfair? I mean, you were born with this tiny little penis and there’s another man out there who can drive a woman crazy with something two, maybe three—maybe four times what you’ve got. Wouldn’t it make sense if everyone was kind of the same? When you see the ends of the spectrum, that’s when you really see the difference in sizes. You’re at the smallest end, so, so tiny, then he’s got this big, fat beautiful thing, you just can’t keep your hands off it.”

“It is so unfair. I can’t even please my beautiful wife.”

“That’s all right, we’ve got someone who can now.”

“Are you going to fuck him again?”

“I can’t wait to. You’re not going to try and stop me are you?” Her hand was on him, she had complete control. He looked at his beautiful but now very dirty wife. She had an innocent face. So pretty, with fine features and a

long beautiful neck. Her eyes were big and expressive, the lightest crystal blue—when she talked people were rapt, lost in her gaze. She was so kind and so warm—no one who knew them would ever imagine she would go out on a date with another man, fuck him in their minivan, then humiliate her husband with some of the dirtiest talk you could imagine while she stroked his small cock. She could get away with anything with that sweet face.

“I want you to get what you want.”

“I’m serious. I wanted to go again right away, but the whole thing felt so odd when he came. He buttoned himself up and got out of there. I would have gone all night with him and that big, thick penis.”

“He got what he wanted.”

“He doesn’t know what I want. Not like you do,” she whispered in his ear, her fingertips gliding over his sensitive tip.

“Oh God, Jess, I wish I had what he had.”

“I do too. It’s all right now. I think we’ve found someone who’ll play along with us. And I want to go back to that well every time I get thirsty.”

“Will you let me watch you next time?”

“I might. I’ll ask him. If he doesn’t like it you’ll just have to sit at home alone again and think about me with him. Think about me crying out when he forces that big club into me. Think about how he’s making me come, over and over again.” She was watching him, her face so close to his, watching him tremble on the verge of a monstrous orgasm. She was toying with him, building up something that was going to make him crazy.

“I really want to watch you next time.”

“You know what I want?” she said, “I want to give him a handjob while you watch. Is that weird? I don’t know why. I’d just love to have you watch my hand struggle around that big thing. I want to make it last too, a nice, long handjob, and I want you to watch me make him come. I want you to see what I can do to him.” She was gasping as she whispered into his ear, he could tell she was turning herself on as she spoke.

“God, Jess, you’re making me crazy,” he said, and he stopped her hand. He was so close and he didn’t want to do it like this, sitting on the couch with her hand stroking him under a blanket. He needed her, needed to be inside her. “Please, Jess, I’ve got to be inside you.”

“Don’t you think I should clean up first?” she said.

“No, I can’t wait, Jess, please...”

“You want to fuck my dirty little hole?” She frowned at him, pretending to be disgusted by him. His heart stopped when she used those awful words; couldn’t believe they were coming out of his pleasant, mild-mannered wife. She was the Third Grade Teacher of the Year, three years in a row now.

“Please, Jess...”

She was already lifting her skirt, though, slowly, seductively. He watched it rise up her tan, oily legs. She stopped at her thighs, making him beg. Then quickly revealed it. She wasn’t wearing any panties. She was shaved bare specially for her date and her lips were plumped out from her, still dark and engorged, still looking damp and used.

She whispered to him, “I’m a little sore but I don’t think you’ll hurt me.”

He couldn’t take it. He put himself over her, his throbbing cock headed between her legs. He brought the blanket with him, throwing it over his shoulders like a cape.

“Wait, Petey, no, no,” she said and she put her hands on his chest to stop him, keep him at bay.

“Come on, Jess.”

“No, not down here, Pete. We have to go upstairs—the boys...”

“Yeah, yeah,” he said, hoping he’d make it up there. He was on the edge, so very close.

“Are you sure Jess? They won’t come down, honey,” he said, trying desperately to convince her. But she was already moving, getting herself out from under him, sliding along the couch.

“I’m sure, Petey,” she said. She got up and headed for the stairs and as she went she slowly lifted her skirt for him and he watched the tops of her thighs revealed slowly, then the tight jiggle of her cheeks as she strutted through the arch and headed for the stairs. He followed and she let him watch her rump move and work as she sashayed up the stairs.

When they got in the bedroom, she locked the door behind them, jiggled it to make sure it had taken. He went to put his arms around her, wanted to take her down right there at the door and finish this on the floor with his pants around his ankles and her skirt hiked up.

“Get a condom,” she reminded him. Shit. He went to the night table and yanked the drawer while he watched her. She didn’t take her clothes off, she lay on the bed, feet still on the floor, and pulled her skirt up at the front and he could see the sheen on her shaved mound in the lamp light.

“Hurry up and get this over with,” she said, teasing him, “I’m exhausted and I want to go to bed.”

His hands were shaking with anticipation ripping the foil open on his condom packet. He pulled it down his shaft while he rushed to get himself between her legs. She watched him and she was grinning.

“Can’t believe you’re going to waste my time tonight with that tiny thing after I told you I just took a real man...”

“Oh, J-Jess,” he stuttered, barely able to think he was so out of his mind with lust. He slid himself inside her. Maybe he imagined it, but she felt stretched, like he made no impact on her insides, and he slid all the way up inside her with no friction. But it wasn’t like he would normally spread her apart...

Jess felt her husband enter her. His penis wasn’t terribly big. He was the smallest she’d been with, but she felt it and it worked too. His little penis had delivered two of the greatest things in her life. It had given Jess her little boys—her Andy and her Pete Jr.

It was Pete who was the first one to mention his size. The first one to bring up the elephant in the room. She’d always known it was small but she loved him. Maybe a few times she had thought to herself that she wished he was a bit bigger. Not huge or anything, just maybe average.

He’d brought it up to her while he was inside her one night. She was horny and turned on and he asked her if he was too small. He kept making love to her, sliding it in and out of her. She told him he was fine. Pete turned it into dirty talk. He told her to be honest and he was working her, teasing her. She felt almost drunk with ecstasy that night. He’d gone down on her and he was so very good at that. He had her primed. Then he was inside her urging her to say dirty things about his size. She felt safe. So she told him the truth. The truth didn’t hurt him. He liked it. She found too, that she liked to say it to him. She liked to tell him dirty things if he wanted to hear them.

She told him he was the smallest and that was true. She told him he was unsatisfying which could also at times be true. He asked her about her other boyfriends. That was odd at first, difficult to think about let alone talk about. They weren’t just disembodied penises to her, they were real men

that had been in her life and for the time she was with them they meant so much to her. Some of the breakups were not so fun.

But it brought her back to Brad Evans. While her breakup with him broke her heart he was truly a standout in the sack. She remembered her times with him quite fondly. Naughtily, maybe. The first time she'd been with him she pulled his penis out of his underwear and she laughed. It was the biggest one she'd seen. She was only twenty at the time but she'd seen a few. She loved that thing he had, but she also loved him and that was a big part of their lovemaking. Still, he was big and he also knew how to use it. So she told Petey all about him, his penis and what he would do to her with it and how much she loved it. She couldn't believe how much it turned her on to relive those stories, to tell Pete about them; and how strangely enjoyable she found humiliating Pete was.

Pete was pumping himself into her urgently now. Her story had him on edge and she knew he wouldn't last a minute. "I wish I had saved his used condom, Petey, we could slip it over your little penis and show you how it would slide right off you."

"Oh, ah, Jess..."

"Petey, I can't stop thinking about how good Tyler felt—how big he was..."

She didn't really care about size—not all the time at least. Not enough that she wouldn't have married Pete. A big one was nice when you got it—but a little one wasn't the end of the world. There was something about humiliating Pete though, that really turned her on. She hated that it did. She was a good woman. A good wife. People respected her. If anyone were ever to hear the awful things she said to her husband they would be mortified. She would be mortified. She could never show her face again, it would be so humiliating. She got a tickle from saying the absolute worst things she could think of. Things that should hurt him.

She rubbed Pete's back, whispered in his ear, "Hurry up and fill that little snug-fit condom, Petey—"

"Oh, God, Jess..."

"Petey baby, do you know how small you feel? You feel like Tyler's finger..."

"I'm going to come, Jess."

"Come on, Petey, Tyler wore me out, I just want to go to sleep."

He shuddered as he came, drove himself into her again and again as deep as he could get it. His face contorted but he was silent. He finally buried his little thing into her, held it, and she could feel it pulsing inside her. She knew she had really done it for him, had really sent him over the top. His body was racked with sobbing breaths then he collapsed over her, held himself up on elbows so he wouldn't crush her.

About a year ago he said he wanted her to be with other men. She wasn't incredulous at the outrageous suggestion. It seemed like the logical next step. It was crazy but in a strange way it wasn't *that* crazy. She never imagined she would ever be able to do it. Pete told her he fantasized about watching her with another man—one who could really give it to her. She'd said, No. Eventually though she let that idea leak into her subconscious and then gradually it became part of their lovemaking. Dirty talk about the things another man would do with her.

Thinking about it, while she was with Pete or maybe alone at night with her fingers between her legs, became an exciting proposition. The thought of being seduced by another man, or seducing one on her own became a solicitous distraction. One she looked forward to fantasizing about but not something she believed they would ever make happen. But she made up rules any way. Things that Pete would have to concede if she were ever to do it. That was just part of the fantasy too. But every time she made a rule, or came up with a man she'd like to sleep with, the whole thing became more and more real.

"Oh, Jess, baby," Pete said into her neck. He was hot and sweaty and he was still huffing. "You're so incredible."

THE MINIVAN

FRIDAY, AUGUST 12TH

Jess got up around six, but she'd been lying awake since around four-thirty. Mostly she'd been staring at the ceiling, and she might have drifted off again in that time, but she was up now doing her morning routine and she was exhausted already.

Little Andy was so sleepy this morning. When she'd gone in to wake the two of them it was like he'd been hit with a tranquilizer. She lifted him up and cradled him like a baby, laughing at him as his head lolled around on his shoulders; his sleepy eyes couldn't even open. She kissed him awake and Petey stood next to her laughing at his younger brother. She stroked his long, silky hair as he came aware, giggling as he tried to look around and remember where he was. *Your bedroom, kiddo, just like every morning*, she whispered to him.

She reminded him that they were going out today, going to go and do something fun with her friend Sara Bridge and her four year old. That got them moving and as they came down for breakfast Andy was so excited now when he jumped on to the chair in the kitchen he overshot it and slipped off the other side. It looked so funny she had to cover her mouth so he wouldn't hear her laugh. He got up and acted like nothing had happened and he tried again, got himself up and she ruffled his hair as she passed.

She made them a real breakfast this morning. Made pancakes and bacon and some scrambled eggs. Pete was moving around upstairs and she heard the squeak of the taps as he got the shower turned on up in the master bathroom.

Sargent was at her knee, a persistent wet nose pressure against her as he subtly urged her to speed up the feeding process. She went into the laundry room and hoisted his heavy bag of dog food out of the bin and scooped out two cups into his metal bowl. He was on a new food, a special gastrointestinal recipe. It was expensive but she got the feeling it wasn't a very good food. She didn't like the ingredient list but their Vet insisted that they use this food to help with his problems. It cost a lot and it wasn't working. She'd already cleaned up one big sloppy pile this morning that she found when she came down. Almost stepped in it too.

Back in the kitchen she leaned on the counter and watched her boys, waiting for Pete to come down. She'd be back to work in three weeks, back to school facing a whole new classroom and she couldn't wait. She had all new lesson plans put together, new activities she'd discovered online. She'd filled up a whole Pinterest board with ideas for time structuring that she was going to implement.

For now she was very happy to be in her kitchen in her short PJs and her robe and slippers. Nursing a coffee and watching her baby boys pal around and eat their home cooked breakfast.

"Yeah, Cedar Point, Mom!" Andy's eyes were wide, both hands on his plastic sippy cup with the curly straw. It was Petey's ploy: get Andy excited about Cedar Point to put more pressure on old mom.

"Petey," she said, chastising him and rolling her eyes. "You know we're not going to Cedar Point." They'd already gone twice this summer and a day there cost an arm and a leg. Pete Jr. was just trying to ramp his brother up, trying to get the excitement to snowball and hopefully Jess would be powerless against them.

"We're going to go to the zoo," she said to them looking out over the tops of her black framed glasses. The zoo was about a fifth of the price and then she and Sara could get a little peace and quiet, walk and talk behind the boys.

"Yeah, okay, Mom," Petey said, happy still, but not as happy as he would be if they were going to an amusement park.

Pete's feet were beating down the stairs and she felt a little nervous to see him this morning. She sucked her lips into her mouth in anticipation. He stepped in to the kitchen and he slowed as he saw her, a smile creeping across his face as he came and stood on the other side of the island across from her.

He was handsome still, looking good in his suit. He was losing his hair and a bit of his jawline as he got older but she could see old Pete in there.

“Good morning,” he said, and she had to look away she was so embarrassed. She got the courage, braced herself, and turned back to him, held him with her gaze and watched him melt. She knew what she did to him, she knew the power she had over him. She watched him blush, then he was the one so embarrassed *he* had to look away. He turned and sat at the table with the boys.

“So, you boys are going to the zoo today are you?”

The amusement park was forgotten and they were both excited now, telling their dad about all the things they wanted to see today. Jess brought Pete’s breakfast over to him, put it down on the placemat and rested her hands on his shoulders while he listened to the boys. She pressed her lips to his growing bald spot and kissed his scalp. He put his hand over hers.

Pete ate a strip of bacon and he sighed, said, “Ah, you’re amazing, Jess.” He squeezed her hand.

“Pancakes are my favourite,” Petey said, and he swooshed a forkful through a pool of Aunt Jemima. He was so active this morning, eating while sitting, then standing, then sitting on one leg. He was going to be a handful today.

“Guilt pancakes. They’re my favourite too, Petey.”

“What are *gill* pancakes?”

“It’s just the way your mom makes them, Petey,” he said.

Jess rubbed his neck and walked back to her coffee sitting on the island. She sipped at it, feeling really so good this morning. A little tired but there was an inner calm. Like she’d been on rough waters and woke up to a placid sea and tranquil sky. She watched Pete with the boys. Her heart swelled watching her men. The kitchen was warm and sunny. Sargent had a ball in his mouth and Andy handed him a piece of pancake and he dropped the ball and snatched it from him. Future sloppy poop but she didn’t care. She wished they could all stay like this in the kitchen for another hour.

“You boys know there’s a new tiger exhibit, right?”

“No.”

Pete put some bacon in his mouth, talked around it. He got lower to tell them, hushed his voice to build excitement. “Now you walk through a dark Russian forest. There’s poles that the tigers climb on, and a stream that they swim through.” He had them leaning forward, listening intently. “And

there's a meadow," he waved his hands out in front of them like he could see it himself, "and you can watch them stalk through the tall grass. And get this..."

"What?" Petey said, his eyebrows high, his mouth agape.

Pete looked up to the ceiling over the kitchen table, said, "The tigers pass from one habitat to another right over your head, looking down on you," he recoiled as if he saw a tiger up above him.

"Holy..." Andy whispered.

Petey had been half sitting, one foot on the floor, as he listened, but now he was up and moving. Telling his little brother all about tigers. She'd helped him in the spring with a report for his Grade One class. It put him madly in love with tigers, and he was telling Andy all about them like he was an expert.

He was talking a mile a minute and he was getting to the good bits now. The predatory aspect and how they kill their prey. "Okay, Petey," she said, "let's not scare your brother. He won't want to—"

Petey was wheezing. Pete was already up and moving to the drawer on the opposite side of the island. He opened it smoothly and carefully. He was calm. Jess came around and sat herself in Pete's seat and rubbed Petey's back. He was gulping for air, his eyes wide and wet. His breaths were a ragged gurgle.

"It's okay, Petey," she said, rubbing her hand in circles around his little back, "Daddy's coming."

Pete put the bronchodilator to his mouth and Pete Jr., also very calm, put both his hands on his dad's wrist and he took two puffs from the inhaler.

Little Petey had asthma but he was working with it well. Sometimes he could get too excited and that could trigger it. Especially this time of year. But they'd taught him to be calm, to keep his head in the game and take his medicine.

"I'll give him a Uniphyll before we go," she said to Pete, "It's probably going to be a pretty exciting day." Pete stood next to her, his hip against her shoulder, and put his hand on the back of her neck, rubbed it.

"I wish I could go with you guys," Pete said.

"Me too, Dad," Andy said, his eyes wide and his cheeks rosy from the action. Petey was still getting himself under control. He was going to be okay, but he nodded his head and she could see him swallowing. Poor kid, still trying to open his airways. He cleared his throat.

“Me too,” Petey said, still a bit wheezy.

Jess had never dirty talked him so well as last night, something really got into her. The things she said to him drove him crazy. He had a fitful sleep, tossing and thinking. He dreamed he had watched it happen, watched another man take his wife in front of him.

Had she really done it this time? The last time they got this close she'd come home and told him a similar story. A different guy that time. A co-worker, some teacher at another school who she met at a conference. She liked to pretend they were going to fuck. She went out one night and when she came back late in the evening she'd told him a similar tale. *They went out for drinks, she came on to him, he took her out back, he had a really big cock, he fucked her in the van, it felt so good, Pete.* But when he went to the car in the morning, he could see the child seat still strapped in, her work bag undisturbed on the bench. It was a tall tale. She told him that story to turn him on. He knew it turned her on too. She enjoyed the telling. She had an orgasm that made her scream that night after she relived this imaginary encounter to him while they made love.

Pete stood in their driveway with his keys in his hand looking into his wife's minivan. Did she dress up for a date, leave Pete in torment sitting and imagining? Did she go out and see a movie then eat at a drive-thru like last time? Sit in a parking lot and look at her watch waiting to come home and humiliate him with her fantasy? Jess was a little too shy to do the things she fantasized about. He saw the car seat had been taken out and thrown to the bench behind. That was a nice touch, Jess. The bench had been cleared in a hurry, items knocked into the footwell.

Did she sleep with Tyler last night? She might have. He hoped she didn't. Not Tyler. At least she remembered to dress the stage this time. Make it seem authentic. One day she would do it for real. One day this wouldn't be a fantasy anymore. He wanted it. He wanted it for himself of course, but he wanted her to have it. Knew she wanted it, needed it. He couldn't give her what she needed, and he desperately wanted her to have it. He wanted her to be satisfied because he loved her.

He stepped to the driver side of his old Buick and that's when he noticed her panties. He wasn't sure at first what he was seeing so he went closer. Standing at the rear of the van he could see into the very back and draped over the bench, stuck to the rough velour was a pair of panties. He saw the frilled edge of her soft pink pair that she wore on special occasions. Her dress panties he called them. They were crumpled and hanging from the grey bench as if tossed in passion. Very good work, Jess, he thought. Unless...

He could picture it like he was standing in this spot next to the van last night. Standing, peering in, while Tyler fucked his wife. Standing in the cold and the dark, the windows of the van lit up by the logo of the bar and his own aghast reflection. He pictured her moving in the dark of the van, Tyler's muscular body over hers, pulling her panties down and tossing them to the back of the van. She would put her head back and look into Pete's eyes while that stud pierced her and made her his woman.

He unlocked the van with his fob and climbed into the back. He picked up his wife's panties and held them in his fist, felt the soft, satiny fabric running under his thumb. He looked around before risking giving them a little sniff. He put them in his pocket and sat for a moment in the quiet space of the cabin. Did she put her bare feet up on the roof as he fucked her? He looked up but there were no marks. He didn't really think there would be.

He sighed into the space, felt its energy. Imaginary or not, this little bench seat figured into every one of his hotwife fantasies and it seemed to figure into Jess' too. She may even have really been fucked by another man right where he was sitting.

He shrugged and exhaled, felt a dreadful tremble in his belly. He better get to work.

IMAGINARY FLING

FRIDAY, AUGUST 26TH

“Hey, Mr. Mapplethorpe,” Rodrigo said with a big smile, looking up at Pete as he walked behind his push-cart filled with flattened cardboard headed for recycling.

“Morning, Rodrigo,” he said as he passed him. Pete had seen him through the big, front windows of the Save-Mart as he’d walked up from the back of the parking lot. Talking to Rosalita, leaning on a clothing rack, giving her some sweet talk while she flirted back. At least she kept pricing, kept working. Now, here Rodrigo was, oh-so-surprised to see Pete (like he hadn’t seen him coming) hard at work with his recycling.

At least he made the effort to look busy. Pete ran a tight ship here. Rodrigo knew enough not to be caught half-assing it when Pete was around. This Save-Mart was first in the region. Square footage wise it was number one in the state, out-performing some of the other stores in the more populated urban areas when you accounted for size.

Pete got up to the second floor, into admin, said hello to all his staff up there. Closed the door to his office behind him—PETE MAPPLETHORPE, MANAGER in white Arial font on a black plastic rectangle stuck on it with two-sided tape. Pete got right to work. Busted out all his reports he’d finished before closing last night, double checked them once again, spent an hour verifying his work, then sent that off to Corporate. Quiet digital swoosh letting him know his mail was on its way.

He had a lot to prepare for next quarter, goals he wanted to set and notes he wanted to make for his weekly staff meeting tomorrow morning. It was a quarter after eleven, so he went out and grabbed a coffee from the lounge—

take a break, cleanse the palate before he started new work. He sat back in the vinyl office chair, swivelling around with his heels planted in the durable carpet. His hand worked the mouse, getting him to eBay.

Shit, there it was. One hour left and this beauty would be his. A 1980 Lionel Loco 726 Steamer. The Berkshire. Not the best condition, listed as C-6. Probably a C-7. Pete couldn't afford a mint one. Wouldn't pay that price.

His \$95 bid was intact. He *wanted* this train. Came in the original box, from the year he was born. He remembered that old packaging, seeing it in the shops when his dad would take him around the hobby stores when he was a kid. Sunday mornings when his brother was in chemo, his dad would take him through the mall out by the hospital.

The cow catcher was kind of beat up and wasn't attached but he could fix that. The lights worked on it and the horn too. And it ran, even in reverse. A few cosmetic touch-ups were all it would take. He shut the browser down, didn't want to jinx it—staring at it while it was counting down was a sure fire way to bring out adversaries.

Pete was out on the sales floor when Julio caught up with him, said, “Hey, boss, we have a situation.”

Pete just came out here to be away from the countdown on his train. He couldn't afford another bid anyway. Wouldn't afford it. He wanted to resist all temptation. Now Julio had roped him into a ‘situation’.

“We got two little ladies here walking off with a lot of cosmetics.”

“Which ones?” He said. Julio was about the best guy you could ask for in Loss Prevention. He was excited by the job and he took pride in his skills. He never half-assed it.

“Two hotties over there,” he said, pointing at two teen girls cutting through Household like they didn't have a care in the world. Two cool customers.

“Don't call them hotties, Julio.”

“Sorry about that.”

“You sure?” They looked like a couple of rich kids. Shouldn't even be in a Save-Mart.

“Positive,” he said, pulling down the lower lid of his right eye, which Pete took to mean Julio saw it happen.

“All right, why you telling me?”

“Could use your help, they look like the type to split up, make it hard for me. I’m here alone today.”

“I got it, I got it. What did they take?”

“Five lipstick. Seventy-five dollars. Maybellines.”

“Shit, okay, okay, you cover that front door, I’ll go to the east side.”

“Cool, chief.”

Pete fucking hated this. Why the fuck did he get roped into it? This kind of confrontation was his nightmare. If he could just find another staff, send them off to do this. Goddamnit, his heart was racing. He looked over his shoulder, Julio nodded to him, his head bobbing along over an aisle of laundry detergent.

Fuck, there was no one else. No one to signal over and take this away from him. He walked on reluctantly, but he was looking around for the girls.

Fucking shit, here they were. Targets approaching. They’d headed to the front, that’s why he sent Julio that way, but maybe they pegged him for Loss Prevention and started for this east door.

His blood pounded in his neck, beating on his ear drums as he walked towards them. Couple of alpha princesses. Both tall and thin, deathly beautiful, painted lips, long legs in skinny jeans, a sliver of bare belly above the waist bands, expensive shoes, LeBrons or Jordans or whatever. Medusas who instead of turning him into stone they turned him into the 16-year-old loser he was in high school. If he said shit to them right now he knew his voice would squeak.

They saw him coming, locked this old, balding creep with their hardest bitch faces. He could feel everything shrinking up in his underwear, tightening, retracting.

They got closer and closer, they were going to pass each other in just a moment. He had to say something.

“Huh-hey...duh-do you know what time it is?”

“Do *you* know what time it is?” one said, scowling at him.

“Fuh-fuh-fuck off,” the other one said and that made the first one cackle. Throw her head back and laugh at her friend’s cruelty. They bumped their shoulders together in camaraderie, still walking, never even broke

their stride. That was it, then they were gone. Couple of sixteen year old bitches who saw right through him, saw him for what he was.

Julio caught up with him at the cosmetics counter a couple of minutes later. Pete was handing cash over to Wanda at the checkout.

“Hey, Mr. Mapplethorpe, what happened?”

“Huh?”

“Did you get them?”

“Yeah. They freaked out, gave me cash. I let them go.”

“You let them go? We’re supposed to—”

“I know, I know. I felt bad for them. They were shaking.”

“They bought all five?”

“Gave me enough cash to cover. I got them before they were out of the store, so technically they hadn’t stolen them yet...”

“Still...couple of rich girls ought to learn a lesson.”

“I know but I didn’t have the heart.”

“All right, Mr. Mapplethorpe, they should be glad was you then, it was me got them...” He lightly punched one fist into his open palm.

“You’re doing a good job, Julio. We came out all right here,” he said to him as Julio got himself back to surveillance.

So old Petey was going to take the *L* on this one. No win for Sad Sack today. Seventy-five dollars plus tax out of pocket. He hoped to God he didn’t win that auction now.

He hustled back to his office and closed himself in. Why the fuck did he go out on the floor? He had plenty to do in here.

He refreshed his browser. Well, *Daryl1979*, you just saved my bacon. He was outbid by five dollars. Normally he would think Daryl was an asshole but today he was Pete’s best friend.

Jess checked to make sure the bathroom door was locked. Twisted the worn, brass knob for a third time. *Yes, Jess, it’s still locked.* If one of the boys walked in she’d be mortified, so there was no harm in being careful. Come on Jess, bedroom door locked and bathroom door locked.

Another late August teacher bash tonight. Faculty and family getting together one more time before it was back to school for them all. Familiar

faces, friends, and who else? Well, you just never know. Her muscular stud might turn up. She hoped he would.

She moved her stool over to the door and sat on it, put her back up against the hollow-core door. Just in case. The water in the shower was running to drown out any noises that might lead to someone asking through the door what she was doing in there. Water running cold, she wasn't going to waste hot water.

The hard plastic seat on the stool was cold on her flattened cheeks. She pulled her towel off the rack and draped it over the stool she usually used to sit and put her makeup on.

Finally satisfied, she could begin. She arranged the tools she'd need on the formica vanity. A brand new pink lady razor fresh from the cell pack, six for \$4.99, a bowl she brought from the kitchen and filled with very hot water, a can of shaving gel, cocoa butter, and a hand mirror she'd wiped spotless with a facecloth.

There was only two weeks worth of stubble down there. But it had to go. You never know...

Thirty-five years old and she'd never shaved her lady parts until two weeks ago. That was the first time. Surprised her what a thrill she got from it. Her girl bits had tingled like crazy, put butterflies in her tummy.

A blast from the shaving gel can gave up a pleasant blueberry-pomegranate breeze. She hunched over and looked at her little lady. She definitely needed a trim.

The gel went on smooth as silk, turned to frosting under her fingers. She inhaled and closed her eyes at the touch of her own hand. She was a live wire. She worked it in, let herself have two little swipes up the middle that got her heart beating. Just two though, she wanted to keep herself on edge tonight.

She hunched over and wiped her hands on the towel. Her butt cheeks were mashed flat on the stool. She didn't have a fat ass did she? She didn't think she did. It looked real good in clothes, she caught people looking. Maybe it was just an unflattering angle. Her skin was still perfectly smooth, and there was not a trace of cellulite. She had a great, healthy ass. She would double check when she stood up, and made a mental note not to spread her legs on a stool in front of any guys. You know, should that ever come up.

The hot, wet blade felt so good sliding across her mound, leaving a bald, shining path through the foam. After each careful, slow swipe she'd wash the blade in the hot bowl. Keeping it clean but also getting it nice and wet and warm to give her that little thrill as she passed it over her skin. *Scratch, scratch*—she went over herself until the blade was silent, until it passed over her soft, wet, mound without a sound.

The bowl she'd brought to shave with was one of the deep ones that had a handle on it like a huge teacup. They usually used it for pasta night—kept the mess down with the kids, since they always wanted spaghetti. Thumb hooked through the handle, resting it in her lap, while her free hand used the hot water to wipe her bald, little thing clean. Patted herself dry with the towel and then brought the hand mirror down to give herself a good inspection. Everything looked smooth as silk down there, no little nicks, or red skin or anything. Just smooth and ready. The cocoa butter went on like velvet, almost feeling too good. She had to bring her thighs together at one point. Clamped them together on her hand to stop herself from going too far.

This endeavour with Pete, and these last few weeks, had turned her into a horny little teenager again. She hadn't felt so alive between her legs since—gosh, when? University, probably.

Jess packed her things up, put away her blade and gel, rinsed the pasta bowl in the sink and left it where she wouldn't forget to return it to the kitchen. She cranked the shower lever to the right for the hot and stood naked in the narrow master bath, one hand under the stream waiting for it to come to temperature. She let her mind wander to all sorts of dirty places.

“Did you get your train, Dad?”
“No, Petey. I didn't.”

“Aw, that's too bad.” He came to Pete and stood looking up at him while he worked away. “There'll be other trains.”

“You're right, kid. Come on, sit up here.”

Pete was on his stool at the command centre of the 1957 Calumet Bay Rail Road. A twenty-one foot by thirty-two foot exacting recreation of the old steam line that went through Calumet Bay. Done in O Scale, started by

his Dad, finished by Pete. Although he'd never really be finished. There was always something left to tweak, something to be fixed or to be made better. He would never be done.

Fifty-seven was the last year Calumet Bay ran steam. His dad loved the steam trains. Calumet Bay Rail Road chartered in 1835 and his dad could have told you everything about every train they ever ran. His dad grew up in Calumet Bay and so did Pete. Maybe someday Petey Jr would take this over, make it his own. He'd have to show him where he grew up sometime, show him how it's all changed. Tell him how it used to be. All the trains out there these days were boring old commuters now.

Petey climbed up into his lap. Kid was getting heavier every day. He put his hands around his waist to keep him in place.

Pete was dressed and ready to go to the party. Showered and shaved, clean khakis and a button up--he was just waiting on Jess. So he brought the boys down to the basement where it was cooler, and they could spend some time with the trains while they waited.

Petey said, "Can I do..." and his open hand stretched out and hovered over the flat aluminum knob that would operate the drive of one of the trains.

"What's the rules down here?"

"I know," Petey said. Andy climbed up on to his footstool next to the table so he could be tall enough to see the trains.

"We don't operate the trains until we're old enough. We don't mess around down here, these aren't toys though they really look like it, I know. Some of this stuff is probably pretty valuable. But soon Petey, soon. Real soon." He hugged him, felt his disappointment. He felt stupid being hard on them over a train set but it was the same way that his father had taught him to respect the work he'd done. To be respectful in general.

"Okay."

"Someday, Pete—someday this whole darn thing will be your responsibility," he said looking over the enormous table that took up almost the entire main room of the unfinished basement.

"I know, Dad."

The table spread wall to wall against one far side, partially blocked off the door to the furnace room—you had to turn sideways and squeeze past every time you needed in there. It was a man-made miniature landscape of rolling hills, trees, a little village with a general store and old pickup trucks

from the forties and fifties. The train and its yard were the focus. Tracks went in and out of the switchyard and Pete and Andy loved to watch him switch tracks and back the trains up so a faster one could pass through.

“Can we make some more foliage, Dad?” Andy asked him, blowing him away that he remembered the word and was able to say it so well.

“Sure, Andy, we can do that tomorrow. That’s a great idea. Your mom and I are going out soon, but we can definitely do that tomorrow.” He’d taught the boys how to make realistic looking trees, twisting out eighteen-gauge wire into tree shapes, spackling them, then arranging pre-made foliage around the wires to make a natural looking tree. The boys, he discovered had a real talent for it.

“You guys have another party?” Petey asked, looking a little forlorn.

“Yeah, Petey, just across town, we won’t be late. Some of your mom’s friends from work getting together before it’s time to go back. You looking forward to going back to school too?”

“Mm, yeah, I guess so. I can’t wait until next year when I’ll be in mom’s class,” he said.

The doorbell rang out upstairs followed by Sargent scrambling from his dog bed, nails scratching on linoleum as he barked his way into the front hall out of a sound sleep. “That’ll be the sitter,” he said and he lifted Petey down to the floor. “Come on, boys. Let’s go let her in.”

They went up and Petey took Sargent out to the backyard. Pete could see a girl through the lace curtains over the window of the front door. He opened the door, surprised to see a young girl there, very heavy set, pleasant enough but not who he was expecting.

“Hi, Mr Mapplethorpe,” she said, beaming. Somewhere in the back of his brain he remembered something about Nicole, their usual babysitter, going off to college.

“You’re here for the kids?” he asked her.

“Yeah, sorry, Mr Mapplethorpe. I’m the babysitter.”

“Oh, come on in,” he said, “you look familiar—”

“I just live across the street.”

“Ah,” he said, escorting her through to the kitchen. Great—now he got to go over all the rules, phone numbers, bed times, asthma...

“Wow, Mom, you look so beautiful,” Pete Junior told her.
“Aw, thanks, Pete.”

“Really, you look like you should be on TV.”

Jess paused a moment, her face breaking into a smile, lipstick poised on a powdered lip that was starting to stretch itself out. This kid. Her hands went down for a moment and she turned to him.

“Pete, thank you. I really wanted to hear that.”

Petey was standing one foot over the other while she sat on the stool in front of the mirror. He had one hand in his back pocket, the other was toying with the pasta bowl, tilting it and rolling it on the round edge of its base.

“Careful with that, Petey,” she said. *And don’t you dare ask me why it’s in the bathroom.*

“I’m not gonna break it, Mom.”

She held his warm soft cheeks in her palms and looked at him. Then she put her big soft, red painted lips right on the flat of his forehead and pressed a kiss on him.

“Aw, Mom, for crying out loud.” He recoiled, pushed her away from him while she laughed at him.

“You look ridiculous,” she said. He had an almost perfect, cartoonish, red kiss mark dead centre on his forehead between the bangs of his parted hair.

“I can’t believe you did that.”

“Come here,” she said and pulled him to her side so he could see himself in the mirror. She squeezed him into her and couldn’t help laughing again.

He looked at his reflection, said, “Oh, no, Mom, the babysitter’s here...”

“Uh-oh—Petey, is she pretty, you worried she’s not going to like your make-up?”

“Mom, clean it off.”

“There’s the Kleenex, Petey. Now you’ve got something to do besides rolling that bowl around like I told you not to.”

He stuck his tongue out at her and she did the same.

“All right, come here,” she said and she dabbed a wet facecloth on her lip marks. “There, you dry yourself off. I’ve got to do my lips all over again. Look what you did to them.”

He rubbed a tissue on his forehead and shook his head at her, a wry smirk on his face.

The trick to pulling off these big red lips in the summertime, she had read, was keeping all the other make up completely neutral. Her face was fresh and youthful enough she thought that she could get away without eyeliner and blush. She just put some black on her lashes and moisturized the hell out of herself until she shone.

She put down a purple-red base over her lips and then went over that with a liquid lipstick that was a fiery orange-red. She knew she'd spent too much on that brush-on lipstick but looking back at her reflection—how it made her feel to see herself look like this—it was worth the money.

“So, Petey, is she cute? The babysitter? Do you have a crush on her?”

“Gross, Mom.”

“You want me to give you another big kiss?”

T Tyler had shown up around 10 P.M. Pete could tell his wife had been so anxious. He could sense a despair from her, desperate for her fling to show up. Imaginary fling? Either way his pretty wife was getting off on another man. It drove a stake through his black heart but somewhere deep in his belly there was a pleasurable ache. It radiated out from there, warm but dreadful, clutched his heart and made his breaths come short. Why the fuck did he like that feeling?

Pete and Jess got there, on time, at about seven when dinner was served. Like normal adults. Like everyone else that was there that night. It had been a fun evening, just under twenty people, hardly any of them looking forward to being back at school in two weeks. They were more honest about it as the night wore on and the drinks took their toll. Not his Jess. She loved her job and she loved those kids of hers. She got so sad as every school year closed and she wouldn't be seeing the little faces she'd grown attached to. Jess had a great heart. Open, honest, giving. Those kids would never grind on her. She would never get bitter or broken by them.

The party had dwindled, some of the gang had said their farewells, some of the tiki torches had snuffed—then he heard the motorcycle.

Knew right away—10 P.M., loud bike, quiet residential street—Ah, Tyler must be here. Riding in on some fancy high-speed ninja bike.

Jess' face lit up right in front of him. He could see the fucking excitement in her. She was wide eyed and bubbling. Like it was 1965 and the fucking Beatles just got here. Frankly, Jess wasn't the only one. A lot of female faces looking around, looking knowingly to one another, funny, dirty looks on their faces. Yes, ladies, your stud had arrived. He wondered if they'd all heard the rumour he was also packing a real salami too. If that was true. If it wasn't something his wife had made up to tease him with. Three possibilities there. One, it was made up; two, it was really a rumour she heard; three, it was a rumour proven true to Jess when that asshole fucked his wife with it in the back of their minivan.

Funny dynamic here if number three was true. These ladies all looking at each other aroused by his arrival didn't realize that one amongst their coven had actually fucked this kid. Oh, man, would they fucking hate her if they found out. They would wring every detail out of her then rip her to shreds behind her back.

Then, in the panther strode. T-shirt with dumb calligraphy on it struggling to stay on top of his bulging pecs and bis. Tight jeans sitting low on his hips, sneakers. A twenty-five year old dressing like a teenager. Whatever. It worked for him. He had these ladies slippery between their legs. Pete's beautiful Jess included.

He watched intently for their first contact. Let's see these two together. Tyler came in, said his hellos, winking, high-fiving, clasping backs, kissing ladies' cheeks. Knowing he was giving them the thrill of their month.

Jess stood to the side, he could see her waiting for Tyler to find her. She wasn't going to him. She was waiting to be found. She was breathtaking in her tight black dress, her bright red lips. How on earth did he get so lucky? And how the fuck was she thirty-five? She, without a doubt, was hotter now than when he met her.

Tyler found her all right. A brief spark between them when their eyes met and it floated in the breeze and lit up Pete's dry tinder soul. It set him ablaze and consumed him. He was racked with one heavy sob, caught himself. His eyes teared. His breath caught in his throat. It was true wasn't it? His legs trembled. He sat in a lawn chair behind him, carefully lowered himself. He was dizzy. His hands shook on the beer bottle he clutched to himself.

There *was* a spark. He saw it. The two of them shared something across the party, an intimate moment between them. They stood a dozen feet apart. Tyler stopped when he saw her and a devilish smile crept across his face. His eyes narrowed. And his wife—she went bashful and demure under Tyler’s masculinity. She sucked a lip under her teeth and smiled for him, bowed her head to him, looking up under her lashes. Then the two of them came together like magnets. Standing too close.

Don’t give it away, Jess. Not to these people. Don’t give it away if it’s true. *God, it was true wasn’t it?* She’d really done it this time.

Dread turned to inexplicable joy. His wife, his fucking best friend in all his life, was happy right now. Natural, healthy girl energy. She was beaming. And that happiness radiated to her life partner. Shouldn’t it? Pete’s heart swelled in his chest. Look at her out there. She was a woman. A happy goddamn woman. Was her heart pounding, her pulse racing? Pete’s was. Hilarious—her husband’s was.

Did she have a tingle in her sex? Butterflies in her soft, warm tum-tum. He knew she did. Knew it. And it delighted him. She deserved that, deserved the pleasures of life. If anyone on this shitty planet deserves happiness it was that five-foot-five blonde-haired angel.

He watched them together. What a good-looking duo. They were careful now not to make a scene, not to attract attention. Tyler leaned on the fence, Jess stood under him. She’d backed off a bit, their shapely shadows cast on the pressure-treated fence by a fading Tiki torch. Jess looked good lit from below by warm torchlight. He could see her sweet face flushed. Red blotches spreading down her neck and across her chest. This kid really lit her up.

Pete’s cock was like steel in his briefs. It ached. Why was he like this? He wanted to get home her home and talk to her. He wanted to make love to her. He wanted to hear her story all over again. *Goddamnit, it was true.* She had done it this time.

He was on top right now but he felt something dark under it all. Something ugly and jealous. But he didn’t want to even open that door a crack. Something so dangerous was likely to kick that door open and barge through once it was given a little light. He didn’t want to face that right now

sitting in this lawn chair with a hard-on. He did not want to lose his shit here in front of all his wife's friends.

Jess could tell Pete had something to say in the car on their way home from the party. He was bristling with energy. He was nervous and twitchy, he would start to speak, open his mouth, then stop. He'd shake his head and she could hear him grumbling. Or maybe she imagined he was grumbling. He had that demeanour. Oh, she knew what it was. One hundred percent knew what it was. But if he didn't want to broach it in the car then she wouldn't push. In fact she would make it easier for him. She closed her eyes and put her head back on the rest and pretended to sleep. Now he had less temptation. She did nod off a bit somewhere along the way, feeling pretty good after five white wines.

Now they were pulling into the driveway and she came awake. Pete's lips were still pursed. She knew they would send the babysitter off, check on the kids, then they were going to have a talk. And she had something big to tell him too.

Mad and distracted, that's how he was, she thought, following behind him up the walk to the front door.

"You'll have to cut the lawn tomorrow," she said, looking out over their patch of grass lit up by the porch light.

He said, "Yeah," picking through his key ring looking for the right one, jingling as he went.

It made her laugh. Why would she torment him when she knew he was upset? Why did she like needling him? There was something in him that enjoyed it. Gosh, if he liked it and she started to really like doing it, how far would this go? Given the right circumstances, she could drive him to want to strangle her. Poor Petey wouldn't do that, it wasn't in his eyes. All he had was love for her.

"Hey, Mr. Mapplethorpe," the babysitter was in the hall, shoes on and bag over her shoulder.

"How were my boys?" Jess asked her.

"They were fantastic—they were only up for an hour before it was their bedtime, but we drew for a little while, then they made me watch some of

their shows, then Andy,” she motioned with her two hands next to her cheek, sleeping. “So I put them both to bed and I haven’t heard a peep from—”

“Do you want me to drive you home?” Pete asked her.

She was taken aback slightly by his briskness. She said, “I...I live across the street, Mr. Mapplethorpe.”

“Oh, yeah,” he said, leafing through his wallet.

Jess touched her arm, said, “Thank you, Ashley.”

“You look so beautiful, Miss Mapplethorpe.”

“Mrs.,” Peter said, giving her a few folded up bills.

“Huh?” she said, taking the money from him and counting it.

“Mrs.,” he said again.

“What did I say?”

“Never mind.”

“Hey, Mr. Mapplethorpe? This is twenty-four dollars.”

“Yeah?”

“No tip?”

“Pete,” Jess said, she couldn’t help laughing.

Pete regarded her for a second, blank face, “Sorry,” he said and gave her another five.

“They watched her walk down their steps and she rubbed Pete’s arm, “Pete, you’re terrible.” She kicked her shoes off and left them in the hall.

“Can’t believe that fatso called me on it.”

“Pete,” she said walking up the stairs, still getting a chuckle out of her cheap husband, “if our boys are still alive up here we are going to want to call her again.”

Then she said down to him, still standing in the dark hall, “Don’t scare this one yet.”

“Make sure there’s two of them up there first. And that they’re both breathing.”

Jess opened the boys’ room door, quietly, peered in on them. Both asleep, little angel faces turned to the side, open mouths. Her cherubs. She snuck in and kissed each of them on their messy hair. She stood a moment, enjoyed it. Their little boy smell, their quiet breathing, their nightlight projector casting dim cartoon fish that drifted, swam across the bedroom walls.

The light from the hall shining through the sliver of the open door went dark as Pete filled it up, looking in and smiling at his wife standing with his boys. She gave him a thumbs up.

Pete went softly across the hall and she followed after him into their bedroom. She knew it was time. She knew this was going to come.

She closed the door behind her, and came to him, stood face-to-face with him a few feet apart in their tiny bedroom.

"It really did happen, didn't it?"

She nodded.

"Oh, Jess," he said, his voice trembling. She saw his knees buckle. His face looked ghostly. Like a ghost just punched in the stomach. "Really?"

"Yes."

"Oh, God," he crumpled, took a step back and sat heavily on the corner of the bed, put an arm out behind him to support himself.

"Pete," she said, came to him.

"I'm okay," he said, put a hand up to stop her. "I...shit," he said, face pained, he clutched at his side.

"Are you sure you're okay?"

"Oh, my God, Jess, how? Like you said?"

"I told you the truth," she said, sat behind him, put her hands around him. "I told you everything."

"With Tyler?" More incredulous than a question.

"Yes, Petey."

"Oh, Jess..." He said it so quietly. He covered his face with his open hands. Then the sobbing started. He lowered his head and she rubbed his back. "Oh, Jess," he said again breaking up into sobs, carrying her name off into a cry.

"There, there," she said, rubbing his shoulder.

He moaned loudly, long, mooing almost like a cow. He doubled over and lay on his side on the bed. He howled in pain, loud enough to wake the kids.

"Petey, Petey, Petey," she whispered into his ear. "It's okay, baby. I'm here, I'm here."

"Oh, no, no, no," he howled again.

"It's okay, baby, don't wake the kids, shhh..."

She rubbed his arms, and soothed him, shushing in his ear. He was in horrible, mournful pain and it tickled her. It made her belly feel funny like

when she thought of Tyler's beautiful body and that big, hard dick he pulled out of his pants that night. She had this amazing power over her husband. It felt incredible to control him like this. To see his love displayed like this. To feel how easily she could wound him so deeply. He was dying under her fingers.

His sobbing travelled up through her arm like electricity, got her sobbing now too. Her eyes teared up and she blinked one off, felt it splash on her cheek and roll down. "Pete, Pete, stop, stop, stop, please..."

She soothed him until he lay still on the bed. His face was red from crying, a vein bulged out on his forehead. He seemed okay now, sleepy, and she'd feel him tremble under her hand every few breaths. He'd cried himself out.

"Baby, this is your fantasy," she said.

"I know. I know. Don't feel bad, I'm just catching up to what you already know," his voice was a whisper.

"I told you every detail already."

"I know. I wasn't sure it was real. I didn't think it was. You never looked in my eyes and told me, *One hundred percent, Pete, it's true this time*. I fooled myself thinking it was just another story."

"Well, it happened, baby. I thought you might not want to talk about it. I was giving you space."

"No, I'm glad. I'm glad." He was looking out across the room while she fooled with his hair.

"Pete?"

"Yeah?"

"There's more."

"Oh, no, Jess, oh baby—"

"More to come, I mean."

"It's not something you've already done?" His eyes pleaded with her.

"No, baby, it's something I'm going to do. And you're going to watch."

"I am?"

She stood up and went to where he could see her at the foot of the bed. His wet eyes went over her, took her in, standing there in her slinky black dress and bare feet. Her arm went behind her back and she drew the zipper down, let him hear the teeth unclenching in the quiet room.

"There's a chance," she said, "we can get you what you want."

“Really?” his face was drawn and anxious. This was too much for him and it was delighting her.

She held her dress up by the bust, pinching the two cups between her thumb and forefinger. She wiggled her hips a little bit, let it drop, lowering it by her fingertips. Down over her bare breasts, catching on her hardened nipples.

“You’re bare,” Pete said.

“Just wait...” She swayed a little, helping the fabric slide down her flesh. She slowed as she got it to her hips, dragging out her revelation.

“Jess...” Pete’s eyes were as wide as they could be. Waiting to see her revealed.

She let the dress sit right at the V of her thighs and the crease of her hips. Then her fingers opened and she let it fall to the floor, standing completely naked in front of him.

“Jess, you had nothing on under there all night?”

She stepped between his open legs and ran her fingers through the hair at the back of his head.

“I wanted it to be easy for Tyler to fuck me.”

“Jess, you didn’t—”

“I was prepared for it. I wanted it. I got myself wet thinking about it.” She watched him swallow, his face tense but beaten.

“You wouldn’t. Not there—what if you got caught?”

She smiled and shrugged. “He’s worth it.”

“You’re killing me.”

“I know,” she laughed, put her arms around his neck. “Touch me.”

His hand felt warm going up her thigh. He slid the knuckle of his thumb up until it bumped into her folds. His thumb opened, the tip of it parting her and sliding right inside her with ease.

“You are so wet.”

“That’s from thinking what Tyler would do to me if I pulled him into a powder room when we were there,” she whispered to him.

“What did you want him to do?”

His thumb worked her, made her close her eyes. “Take me from behind, bent over the toilet. Pull my dress up and fuck me with that big cock. Put his hand over my mouth so I couldn’t make a sound.”

“You really thought about him.”

“I really did.”

“Is that what you want me to watch?”

“Do you want to see that?”

“I do,” he said, his voice trembling.

“Are you ready for the next step?”

“Oh, Jess, I am.” He closed his eyes and rested his head on her chest.

“I invited him for dinner. He’s coming a week tomorrow. I told him you had to go away for the weekend, a conference.”

“Oh, God.” He hugged her to him tightly, he squeezed her so she could barely breathe.

“He’s coming here to fuck me. He thinks he’s going to spend the night here, do all sorts of dirty things to me. We’re going to have to convince him it’s okay to do all the filthy things he wants while you watch.”

“He thinks you’re a dirty, cheating housewife.”

“He doesn’t know about your little penis. Doesn’t know you don’t think it’s fair that it’s the only one I’ll get.” Her voice was a delicate whisper that tickled his ear.

“Jess, baby, I can’t believe how wet you are.” His fingers worked inside her. The room was so quiet except for the obvious slurping sounds being made between her legs.

“Sit back, baby, sit back,” she said.

He let her go, reluctant to do it, leaned back on the bed.

“Take your little dick out,” she told him. His hands were shaking, working his belt, but he got it, and then he was tugging on the zipper. He pulled his cock out for her, showed it to her between a thumb and finger.

“You are going to die, Pete, when you see what Tyler’s got.”

“Jess, please,” he clutched a hand over his heart. She was hurting him. She was going to kill him.

She laughed as she got to her knees between his legs, said, “I can’t wait for you to see me with it,” then put his cock right in her mouth, all the way to the base. He was so hard she didn’t think he’d last a minute.

Pete groaned out above her, loud, and he fell flat back on the bed. Precum surged from him, filled her mouth up. She smelled it in her nose when she exhaled. Her fingers pushed his balls up under her bottom lip, then she popped them into her mouth, doing it one at a time. Her mouth was stuffed with him. Her tongue stroked the belly of his cock, going up to the tip then diving between his balls, pushing them apart. He was making all sorts of crazy noises above her, saying her name; she could feel him

thrashing about. He exploded down her throat. So much semen she thought she might choke, but she breathed and swallowed it and took it all. Pete was roaring out and slamming his fists into the bed as she drank his bitter seed up.

“Oh, God, Jess, oh, God...”

She climbed up him, got face-to-face with him. She wiped at her bottom lip with a finger.

“I love you so much, Jess,” he said looking in her eyes.

“I love you too, baby,” she said. “Will you still love me when you watch me do that to Tyler?”

“I will. Is he going to come in your mouth?”

“I’m going to drink every last drop of him. His balls are so big, I bet it’s a huge load. I wonder what he’ll taste like?”

“Steroids, probably.”

He broke her spell. She collapsed on him, her head into his collar, laughing into his neck. He caught her so off-guard, he had her cackling, her back shaking.

“Oh, Pete, you got me, baby,” she said, sitting up, straddling his chest. “You think he’ll taste like steroids?”

“Creatine? I don’t know. If you swallow his load and your back breaks out in zits we’ll know he’s juicing.”

She unbuttoned his shirt for him, smiling at him. “Come on, he’s my sexy toy. Don’t make fun of him.”

His face went serious. “Jess, you’re so beautiful. Too beautiful for me.”

She put her hands on his bare chest, said, “Thank you, baby.”

She dipped her head down and kissed him. “Okay?” she asked him.

“Yeah.”

She walked her knees up over his shoulders so her sex was over his face. She lowered her dripping wet mound to his mouth, his hands locked over her thighs, took them firmly, and his tongue worked through her. He was an absolute master down there and he had her panting in no time. He punished her back for all her games, bringing her close then letting her go. He had her heart hammering in her chest and she was sweating.

“Oh, Tyler,” she cried out and grabbed handfuls of sheets in her fists.

Pete gave it to her now. He went wild, his tongue pounding her swollen button, and she knew she had his permission.

So she shouted out, “Tyler, Tyler,” over and over again, thought about that night two weeks ago when her thirty-five year old pussy took that kid’s huge cock in the minivan. She thought about his hard body under her fingertips, and she came on Pete’s tongue, barking out her lover’s name and picturing all the things she was going to make her husband watch her do to him.

PART II

DINNER FOR THREE

COCONUT CREAM PIE

SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 3RD

Jess, Pete Jr, and little boy Andy were at Pete's sister's place at 3 P.M. Jess had asked Patty for an overnight with their favourite aunt and uncle, told her that she and Pete had a date night and wouldn't be back until late. Jess could practically hear the wink-wink over the phone with her. *If she only knew*. What would she think about the crazy thing Jess and her brother were going to get up to tonight? Would she still want to sit the kids?

"All right, babies," Patty said, standing at her open door, "run in and say Hi to your cousins. They're in the basement playing games, there's snacks, there's—"

They were gone already, Petey taking Andy's hand and escorting him down their hall to the basement.

"Date night, huh?" Patty said, wry smile, arms folded.

"Patty," Jess said, looking away, feeling herself blush.

"Hey, good for you two. When you take ours, Russ and I are usually in bed by nine."

Patty and Russ lived about ten minutes away and they would swap nights alone once a month—tonight was a special, extra request. "You two have fun tonight," Patty said, gave Jess a knowing smile. Jess blushed again.

Two? If you only knew, Patty.

"We'll see how it goes," she said, backing down the steps to the house. She turned and headed along the walk, "Knowing us, we'll probably fall asleep on the couch after dinner." She waved to Patty over her shoulder as she got to the minivan, heard Patty laugh behind her.

Pete's sister waved to her from the doorway as she backed out of the driveway and drove off. She had a strong urge to just go back, go down to the basement and kiss her boys, scoop them up and put them back in the van. Tell Pete and Tyler that tonight was off. This was *too* crazy. But if she did that, told them it was off, there was a strange reality. Tyler would be disappointed. Jess would be disappointed. And most crazy? Pete would be really disappointed. It might be the sanest thing to do, but no one would like it. Besides there was a carnal drive in her belly that was like a burning steam powered engine room. A roaring fire in there that was operating all her moving parts. Chugging the gears of her arms and legs. Operating the hydraulics of her size six foot that was planted on the pedal, roaring the old van to the drug store to buy some extra-large condoms for her lover.

Jess went out to the Walgreen's on North High Street. It was out of their neighbourhood, less chance of running into someone she knew. She ran around behind a wobbly cart hoping she wouldn't run into any of the parents of the kids she taught. She'd gone out in white sweatpants and flip-flops and a tight T-shirt. She didn't even know how that happened. She was just so worked up about tonight that she'd left home to do errands wearing the old things she wore around the house. She hadn't done her hair or makeup yet, her hair was a spiky blonde mess. Hopefully, if someone saw her, they wouldn't even recognize her. She had a ball cap on and her glasses. It was like she was wearing a disguise.

She went through the aisles grabbing some random items—utility stuff, things that they kept stock of in the house. Q-tips, toilet paper, lady shave gel... Then she grabbed a big bottle of wine and headed for the condoms.

Jess had slept with twenty-two men before she was married and they were really all the same size. A few smaller ones, then Pete at the smallest. Then there was Brad. She thought Brad was huge. Until Tyler.

There were so many different kinds of condoms she was a bit overwhelmed. She thought that this would be easier. Pete bought his own condoms. She knew the box. Knew they were the smaller size, snug-fit they were called.

There were Magnums, then there were Magnum XL. Were they even bigger? Did Tyler need the biggest size? He had to, right? I mean, it wouldn't be possible that you could be much bigger. What if XL was too big and it slipped off? Shit. That had to be impossible. What if it was too small? She felt her shoulders shake with a silent laugh, hunched over in the

condom aisle like a weirdo, hat pulled down so no one would recognize her. What if Tyler took some XXL condom she didn't even know about, that the store didn't even keep in stock? Maybe he custom ordered them. God, look at all these boxes of XL condoms they had. How many men in this town were packing what Tyler had? Whatever. Tyler was getting the XL. It couldn't be too big and too bad if it felt too tight for him. He'd be bringing his own condoms anyway. She just wanted to be prepared. Didn't want the night to be ruined because no one was smart enough to bring protection.

Her neck started to get hot standing in line. She hoped she wasn't getting red. There were three people ahead of her, a young girl at the checkout. The girl was maybe sixteen—Jess did some math, she'd been teaching in this town for seven years—this girl could have been one of her students. Jess studied her face from the middle of the line. *Please, don't let her know me.*

It's not that buying condoms was the biggest deal. The enormous guilt that came with her purchase couldn't be recognized by an outside party. So what? She was buying condoms. The most likely thing someone who knew her would garnish was that old Pete Mapplethorpe was apparently packing a whopper. No one would ever imagine the dirty thing sweet Jess was going to try to do with some stud while her husband watched.

Her flip-flop was tapping while she waited anxiously. She had a horrible thought. What if the condoms were too small, and he stretched it over himself too tight, and it broke inside her? Did she want to be a thirty-five-year-old divorcée carrying her young lover's baby? Oh, boy—or AIDs or gonorrhoea... Her palms started to sweat. Who knew where her hung lover had put that thing. Who knew the string of little sluts he'd been with and all the dirty places *they'd* been. Maybe she couldn't do this. So what if they were all disappointed? This was insanity. She could miss out on this. She was a married woman, for crying out loud. She loved her husband. She loved her kids.

“Ma'am?”

It was the young girl at the checkout. Geez, calling her ma'am at thirty-five. It seemed like yesterday she was a kid herself. She looked at this pretty blonde teen with her ponytail and her Walgreen's tunic. When she was her age a boy came inside her after his condom had slipped off. They panicked, struggled like crazy to get the rubber out of her without going to

the hospital. They retrieved it, but she was crushed with dread, cried herself to sleep every night for two weeks until her period came.

She put her items up on the counter. The wine, the condoms, and all the other things she'd added so she wasn't just buying wine and condoms. The condoms would be fine, she was being hysterical. Nerves, anxiety—he wasn't too big for them, come on, Jess, be real.

She kept her head down while the girl swiped her items. Blondie didn't even look twice at the Magnum XLs. Just swipe-beep, and dropped into the bag. She paid with cash and got her bags out to the minivan, then raced home.

Jess got herself home, got water boiling and prepped the roast. She pat it down, her hands moving fast. Seasoned it, coated it in flour and then seared the roast in butter, rotating it quickly around the pan, crisping up all the sides. Then she grabbed her pasta bowl and ran upstairs and locked herself in the bathroom. She shaved up between her legs, too nervous to get a thrill from it, jumped in the shower and gave herself a good scrubbing under the hot water. She put her contacts in, then ran back down the stairs and chopped up the potatoes and put them in the water that was just about to boil over. Everything was on schedule.

She held her hands out over the counter and watched them. They trembled. Nervous energy travelling up her wrists and shooting into her shoulders. She gripped her hands into fists and rotated them in circles, tried to ease out some of that tension. This was huge. This was crazy.

She'd already made love with him, but somehow tonight was the *real* first time. When they'd done it in the van, it was all about speed. It was hot and passionate, but it was quick. And it was a surprise to both of them—happening before they even realized it. He stuck it in her and hammered until he came into his condom. Then he ran off. She didn't get to take her time, she hardly got to explore him, she didn't even put her hands on his penis. Tonight, if they could convince him, they would go slow, make it last. And Pete was going to watch. She was going to take her hands and touch every part of that kid's hard, beautiful body. She was going to kiss his abs, let her lips brush every hard ridge. She wanted to suck his nipples, his

balls. Poor Pete. She was going to make him suffer. She was going to break him down, make him hurt.

The recipe called for two cups of wine so she skimmed a little for herself—she'd bought a big bottle of the cheap stuff. She filled a kitchen glass to keep her company while she cooked. It might numb her a bit too, calm her mind. The wine was terrible but she was going to finish it.

The dutch oven went over the burner; olive oil, onions, carrots, leeks in there. This onion smell better not stick to her, she thought. She should have showered after she was done but she was running out of time. She got them sautéed, added the rest of the wine and a splash of cognac, threw the roast and the other vegetables in and waited for it to boil.

Pete's car pulled into the driveway and she watched him jump out, suit jacket and briefcase tucked under his arm, and speed-walk up the path. He threw the things down in the hall, she heard the hollow sound it made on the deacon's bench. Then he was in the kitchen, eyes wide, wrought with anxiety. He didn't say anything, only watched her, just his eyes moving, tracking her in the kitchen.

"What is it?" she said.

"It's still on?"

"Oh, no, why?" *Had he changed his mind?*

"No—I want it to still be on..."

"Yeah, yeah, Pete. It's on. Come here."

He came around the island and stood next to her in the cramped kitchen. She said, "I need you to cut up these vegetables and put them in the dutch oven—"

"What's that?"

"The black thing here, Pete, come on."

"All right, okay."

"I need you to boil them and then in about fifteen minutes put it in the oven—covered, Pete—and then watch those potatoes, take them out when they're ready and strain them."

"I don't know, Jess, this cooking thing—I'm not really—"

"Pete, I'm not going to let him make love to me if I smell like onions, all right?" She put her hand between his legs, squeezed him a bit, said, "So if you want to watch me get pounded by a real man you'll watch these pots for me while I wash my hair again."

“Yeah, okay. You go, I’ll figure it out. Go, go,” he said, sending her out of the kitchen and rolling up his shirt sleeves.

Pete had to call it off. Right? He just had to. He couldn’t go through with this. In principle, it was very sexy. He fantasized all the time about his pretty Jess on her back, being delivered into ecstasy in a way he could never do. He could picture her face, her eyes closed her mouth in a mournful shape as some hung stud drove his big salami inside her. She deserved that. Isn’t that what people dream of? Being delivered into ecstasy. He wanted that for her. He didn’t know why he wanted it—why it turned him on—but it really did.

However, this was the zero hour. It was going to happen right in front of him and no matter how many times he’d already pictured it, wanted it to be real, maybe in actuality, he *couldn’t* do it. This was huge. It would be *live*. He would hear her sounds, he would watch her face. But he’d also hear Tyler’s sounds, animal grunts, he would probably smell his sweat. Kind of hot, but maybe it would be too intimate. It might be too much for him. Jess had already been with him, maybe that would be enough.

Every time he thought he’d decided to put a stop to it, he’d get that image again, the one that always came to him: Jess being pounded, her face filled with dirty, ecstatic joy, her legs wrapped around another man’s waist—

Then he’d shake his head, tell himself he *could* do it. It was a constant battle while he did his best not to ruin Jess’ dinner, standing over the dutch oven while the wine boiled. One time he even got half way up the stairs, on his way to break it to her. *Sorry, Jess, we have to come to our senses.*

But it was now or never. A real stud—no matter how little Pete thought of him—was going to ring that doorbell in an hour and a half. He was muscular, young, handsome, and apparently had a real stick of dynamite in his underwear. If he didn’t go through with this, the chances of bringing all these crazy elements into play again in the future sometime would be impossible. Cold feet, that was all. He absolutely would not call this off.

He got the vegetables in the dutch oven and had it boiled, put the lid on it and put the whole thing into the old green Maytag stove that was still

holding on. Jess had it preheated and he just twisted the timer, following along with the recipe she had left open on the counter. He strained the potatoes out in the sink and left them—who knows what she wanted to be done with those. Now he was sweating, his shirt sticking to his back, and drops of sweat coming off his nose. He opened the cupboard and splashed a little Dewar's around the bottom of a glass and knocked it back. He gripped the edge of the counter a moment and closed his eyes. This was really goddamn happening.

He went up the stairs to the bedroom. Jess was there, her back to him. He looked at her beautiful body standing there in their little bedroom in bare feet. She looked at him over her shoulder, her face sad, guilty. She was just wearing a pair of red, lacy panties. They were bright, sexy, not at all like anything he'd seen her wear before. She was breathtaking. The thong back slipped in between her cheeks, disappearing between her legs. Her perfect ass flaring out from her tiny waist as she stood, hip cocked.

"Jess, you look so incredible," he said.

She bit her lip, didn't answer him, looked down at the floor. He stepped up behind her and he put his hand on the warm shower-fresh skin of her shoulder. This was his. This was his shoulder, his skin, his perfectly formed flesh. He ran his hand down her back, feeling the beauty he possessed—feeling it being pulled away from him. She was going to be shared tonight. She *wasn't* his. She was her own. And he wasn't enough for her. It didn't hurt anymore, it was something he came to grips with a long time ago. He wanted this for her. He wanted it for himself.

His hand swept down over her firm cheek, and he watched it. Watched her flesh yield to his touch so slightly. He looked at the swoop of her thigh, her thin knees, her dainty feet nestled in the shag carpet. She had painted her toes for Tyler.

"Tyler doesn't deserve this," he said.

She looked in his eyes, said, "Thank you, Pete."

He put his lips on her bare shoulder, kissed it very gently. "Boy's got to my sister okay?"

"We can pick them up at lunch tomorrow."

"You ready to put this kid through his paces?"

“I think so.”

T Tyler got there on time. Surprise-guy who’s always late shows up right on time when he thinks he’s going to fuck Jess behind Pete’s back. No one would show up late to fuck Jess. Pete was sitting in his chair, Dewar’s on the side table, when he heard the motorcycle come up their street in first gear, heard the squeak of rubber as it went up the slight grade of their driveway. His balls literally climbed up high and tight, he could feel his hairs rubbing in his briefs as his sack tightened. Here it was—it was time.

He stood behind the door and let Tyler knock before he opened it. Tyler gave the door a hearty one-two; a solid, manly knock. Pete swung the door open wide and forced a pleasant, fearless look on his face.

“Oh, hey, Tyler,” he said, trying to beam.

“Oh, hey, Pete,” he said. Surprised.

Tyler was looking good. Plain T-shirt tonight, super-tight, tight jeans, sneakers again. His hair was combed up like James Dean. Pete could see it. He could see wanting to fuck this guy if he were a girl. Even his normally sensible wife. He could see the appeal for her. Tyler stood, expecting Jess to answer, hip stuck out, posed, holding some flowers and a bottle of wine. What else did you bring tonight, kid? Some extra large condoms so you could stuff that thing in my wife? A bag of weed or something? All the kids doing that these days. How did you see this going down tonight, Tyler?

“Yeah, my trip got postponed. Looks like it’s just you tonight, Jess said the Walkers had to cancel.” He let that sink in. Let him figure that Jess had told Pete she’d invited more people for dinner, lying to her cuckold husband.

“Oh, that’s too bad, I was looking forward to seeing them.” Okay, he caught on. Wasn’t as dumb as he looked. “You sure it’s okay? We can make it another time...” Kid didn’t figure he’d be sticking it to Mrs. Mapplethorpe so he wanted to go do something else.

“No, don’t be crazy, dinner’s practically ready, come on in,” he said, held the door for him and let him past.

Jess came into the hall, paused, let them both look at her. Beautiful in a simple summer dress, flats in the house, and Pete knew the sexy panties she had on under there. Tyler looked her up and down as she stepped to him.

“Hi, Tyler, so glad you made it,” she said. She lifted herself up on her toes to kiss him, Pete saw her soft lips press onto his cheek. Her little hand clasped his fingers, steadying herself. Tyler was stiff, unsure of how to greet her in front of her husband.

“Good, to see you, Jess,” he said and Pete saw him softly squeeze her thumb.

Jess whispered, “Sorry,” to him. It made Pete tremble. Who knew his wife could be so bad?

She thanked him for the flowers and the wine and she took them from him. They both followed her into the kitchen. Pete opened the wine, turned his back to them so Jess could talk to Tyler. He could see them in his periphery, she was close to him, explaining to him how Pete had cancelled last minute.

He poured three glasses of wine, handed one to his wife and she took it. She was all smiles now, beaming. Her face was flushed. He loved to see her so aroused, so exuberant. Tyler took his wine and Pete caught him give his wife another good once over, looking up the back of her pretty legs, the sweep of her rump under her light floral dress. Her shoulders were bare and the tanned skin she was showing was even turning Pete on, and he’d touched her thousands of times. She must be putting an ache between this kid’s legs.

“So, Tyler, Jess tells me you used to play ball in college.”

“Huh? Oh, yeah,” he said taking his eyes off of Jess. “H-back at Albright.”

“Albright’s D3?” Pete took some weird pleasure in putting his accomplishment into perspective. Even though he’d only had one small sporting accomplishment of his own, ever. And D3, while not D1, might as well have been the fucking NFL because it was light years beyond Pete’s physical abilities.

“I feel super lucky to have got the job there,” he was telling them. Tyler had only been in town about ten months. He did the last half-semester at the high school last year and he was just starting his first full year there in two weeks.

Joe Watson, the vice-principal, got him the job. Sounded like Joe knew Tyler was in a rough patch because Joe is a cousin of Tyler’s old defensive coordinator at Albright.

“You had your license for Ohio already?” Pete said.

“Yeah, I was at a school down south.”

They were having dinner at the dining room table. A room rarely used. This table usually, during the school year, was littered with Jess’ paperwork, tests to be graded, boxes of arts and crafts. Jess had served the dinner on regular plates using regular cutlery, didn’t want this to get too weird and formal.

It had become a little uncomfortable already. Felt like they were interviewing him. Asking him questions together as a team. One would ask him something then the other would ask a follow-up. Was the kid getting wise? Could he see through them? They might have been more obvious than they thought. On the one hand, it would be kind of insulting that Tyler would think that they were seducing him, but they were doing exactly that. Maybe it would be better if he knew what they were up to, save them from climbing that enormous mountain, save them from having to ask him if he’d sleep with Jess while Pete watched.

“Where were you before here?”

“Fairville District, down in Queen City.”

“Boy, that’s a small town,” Jess said.

“Oh, I know it.”

“Why’d you leave?”

“Things got a little hot down there, it was best if I moved on.”

Pete asked him, “Trouble at work?”

Tyler shifted in his seat. “No, no, woman trouble.”

“Sorry to hear that,” Jess said.

“She was no good for you?”

Tyler laughed, said, “Well, her husband was no good for me.”

This scumbag fuck. How could Jess fall for this? Wasn’t she smarter than that? She’d fucked him—wouldn’t he be embarrassed to reveal another married tryst to her? How dumb was this kid?

Jess's roast was a little tough and he knew she'd be sweating it. Everything else was great, the meat couldn't be helped, and she had put on a wonderful meal. Pete just knew she was on edge already, could see the tension in her, hoped that she wasn't hurting. He just wanted her to be happy all the time. This endeavour shouldn't be a trial. Tyler ate it up without a worry anyway, two helpings of everything. No leftovers for Pete's lunch tomorrow.

Jess asked him, "All your family is still in Altoona?"

"Yeah, well, not there anymore, they moved, not far from there, Rock Hill. Closer to Harrisburg."

"Is it tough to be away from them?"

"No, not at all," he laughed. "Not my family, but I miss my friends."

Pete said, "You haven't made any friends out here?"

"Mm, not really. It's hard—"

Jess said, "We're your friends aren't we?" She gave him a warm smile, the wine starting to take its toll on her.

"Well, yeah, of course. I just mean, everyone I know is married, has kids, I haven't really met single guys to hang out with yet. Everybody's so busy..."

Jess poured Tyler another glass of wine. Talking and moving absently. Pete knew she wanted him a little worn out, a little more receptive to some crazy ideas. She wanted him drunk. She wanted to take advantage of this kid, frankly.

Pete's nerves started to get the better of him. He felt a tremble in his cutlery, could see the knife shaking in his fingers. He was scared. He wanted this so badly but he was scared. Maybe Tyler wasn't right. Fuck, though, he was. Pete didn't like him but look at him. Look at his broad shoulders, big chest and big arms. Of course, his wife wanted him. It was just sex. Why was Pete intimidated by him? Was it just taste? Like if Tyler looked the same but had no tattoos and an office job would he feel better? Something just rubbed him the wrong way. But this kid was a gift for a hungry woman, wasn't he?

Jess was getting more and more nervous, preparing to make the leap here, get this going. It was closer to the time she had to do it. What if she never got the nerve? Let him say his goodbyes and get on that bike and ride out of their life? That really could happen.

Plus there was a very good chance he'd say no, get himself the hell out of here. They were going to ask him to do something horribly ridiculous. He was kind of a macho guy—what would he think of being naked with another man in the room? She had to be sure he understood Pete was only going to watch. Pete wasn't going to take his clothes off, wasn't going to try and touch his penis.

Even fully clothed, she'd spent most of the dinner distracted by his body. She might see him bare tonight, get to explore his perfect form. She'd been admiring his skin, his tattoos, his thick neck and traps, his square jaw, that full head of dirty blonde hair. He looked so out of place in her sweet household. This stud sitting in the home she shared with her boys and her husband. He took up so much space too. Their house was small, just a three bedroom and eighteen-hundred square feet. Tyler filled up the rooms when he was in them.

His hands looked so big, so foreign on her familiar steel cutlery. The stainless she'd brought from home when her mother died and her dad moved out to Arizona. The same cutlery she used when she was a little girl, that her family used every night. It gave her a naughty thrill seeing it in the hands of this dirty savage who was going to split her in two tonight—who'd already been inside her.

Those hands were thick and muscular. Well-groomed nails too, clean. The letters of Live Free were tattooed across his knuckles done in the font from the dollar bill. The skin on the back of his hands was all inked; George Washington, water, maybe the Delaware, muskets. She knew Pete hated this, thought the tattoos were silly but it turned her on. There was something sexy about it and she couldn't put it into words. It *was* so wrong. *Tyler was so wrong*. Pete was right about that. Something about Tyler, however, made her tingle. When he came into a room, her heart quite literally skipped a beat. He turned her into a shy girl. But a shy girl who ached to be penetrated by him.

Yes, he wasn't suitable for a mother of two who taught third-grade, Teacher of the Year Award winner, though that was mostly a popularity contest. That was probably what put that thrill in her belly. Being with him

was ugly and selfish. That's who she wanted to be sometimes. Ninety-nine out of a hundred days she was the world's best mom, she was a phone call away for any of the parents of the kids she taught, one night a week she gave a dance lesson for free at the school. Ninety-nine days out of a hundred she was a good person. Caring, loving, and sweet. One day out of a hundred she'd like for it to be okay for her to get dirty. To roll up her sleeves and do the things that would shock her friends and family. One day out of a hundred would be for her.

"Well, that was great, Jess, thanks for dinner. I hardly get a home cooked meal anymore," Tyler said.

"My pleasure," Jess answered him. Dinner was done. This was the home stretch. She was going to have to make things happen here, as scared as she was.

Everyone was finished, staring at each other over the empty plates. She wasn't ready for this. She had to stall him with pie.

"I'll clean this up a little later," she said, "There's pie, but we should sit a minute, maybe..."

Pete said, "Why don't we go into the family room and relax for a bit? Can I get you a whiskey?"

"I better not, I gotta ride my bike home," Tyler said. Shit, they were going to lose him.

"Coffee?" Jess said, hearing the desperation in her own voice.

"Sure," he said. Whew. She'd bought some more time.

Pete took Tyler into the family room while she got some coffee into the coffee maker. She had no idea, no plan at all, for how she was going to do this. Should she take her clothes off in here and just walk into the room naked? If he said no then everyone would see her sad face on her naked body. A little embarrassing. God, running down the hall after him trying to apologize, her flesh jiggling as she went. Not good.

She'd have to be honest. Try and explain it to him, but make it interesting. If this worked they'd never get to that pie. All she had to do was find the nerve somewhere deep within her to get this party started. She talked a big game. She could be mean to Pete, humiliate his penis, tell him all the things she would do with Tyler. But that was when she was safe with Pete. She loved Pete, she knew him completely. She didn't know Tyler. He'd given her a quick one in the back of the van, but he was a human being with a mind of his own. She wanted to use him like a living,

breathing, warm human dildo. He could say no. Very likely say no. He could be disgusted by them. Who on earth would want to make love to a woman while her husband watched? He'd be right, they were kind of disgusting. And that's what frightened her. The unknown. It was going to be up to her to warm him up, seduce him in front of Pete. She hoped Tyler would be okay with this. Hoped he wouldn't be bothered with another man in the room while he did his thing. He could possibly freak out at the prospect, even be angry.

The coffeemaker hissed away and she prepared to join them. She rubbed her hands together, they were sweating. That was sexy. Hope Tyler likes thirty-five-year-old women with sweaty hands who want to have sex while their husband watches. Was she a freak? Little-girl-Jess could never have pictured this day in her future. No sexual freakiness for young Jess. Meat and Potatoes. When did she get so crazy?

Pete sat in his chair, the recliner, a La-Z-boy that he could lean back on and flip up the footrest. He'd run out of things to talk to Tyler about. He didn't care about football, sports either, of any kind. It was getting a little weird in here. Jess came into the room finally, relieved him. She stood for an awkward moment, then smoothed her skirt under her and sat next to Tyler on the couch.

Pete thought Jess might die right there next to him. All the colour had drained from her, she looked horrified. She knew what she had to do, but Pete thought she was going to lose the will. She didn't look like the kind of girl who was able to make this happen. Not right now.

He could see her trying to swallow, poor girl had got herself dry as a bone. There, she took a sip of her wine. Now she ran her hands up and down her thighs anxiously, even Tyler realized she had something important to say, and he looked to her to hear it. What was her plan? How was she going to do this?

Then she said, "I was telling Pete how big your penis was and he didn't believe me."

Well, Jess, nothing like diving into the deep end.

“You what?” Tyler’s eyebrows peeled right back bunching up the skin under his pompadour.

“He didn’t believe me.”

“Uh-huh.” Tyler was in a bit of shock, maybe. Probably thinking this is the part where Pete pulls out a pistol.

“Would it be all right if I showed him?”

“I don’t know.” Kid didn’t know where to look.

“I don’t want him to think I’m a liar.” She smiled. She was trying to be funny and light. Pete understood her strategy. *This was all fun, Tyler.*

Tyler looked from Jess over to Pete, everything getting clearer to him. He sat closer to the edge of the couch like he was getting ready to leave. “Hey, I get it, you’re one of those couples. For what it’s worth it’s not the first time someone asked me to have sex with their wife. I just think it would be cool if you had let me know.”

Jess said, “Where’s the fun in that?”

“I get it.” Tyler stood up, he looked a little mad, maybe he just didn’t know how to handle this. Who would? This was insane.

Jess was upset now—this was getting away from her and Pete could tell she wanted it to come together very badly. She said, “Hey, don’t be upset, it’s okay. We didn’t know how to let you know. We’re letting you know now. This is the best way we could come up with.”

Tyler shook his head and shrugged, put his palms up. “You guys are crazy,” he said. But he wasn’t making his way to the door yet.

Jess stood up to face him, she put a hand on his arm but she struggled with what to say.

Pete said, “Tyler, it’s already done. I’m happy you two got together. For her. I love her, I want this for her. I want to see her happy.”

Jess said, bolstered now, “We hardly got a chance to get into it. I feel like I just got a taste of how good it could be. We’ve got all night, it’s warm, it’s quiet, we won’t be disturbed. We can show each other a real good time. Go really slow tonight and make it last.”

She didn’t come on too strong, didn’t rub herself on him, squeeze his muscles or hump his leg. She gave him his space. *This is crazy, Tyler,* she was admitting, *but we’re not crazy people.*

“I won’t say a thing. Won’t even know I’m here,” Pete said.

Tyler sat down on the arm of the couch. He wanted to stay. Wanted to be with Jess, he was looking to give himself permission. Pete knew it was

going to happen now. If it wasn't this kid would already be revving that crotch rocket down the street, annoying the neighbours.

Jess moved into him slowly, her thighs pressed against the side of his leg. He looked at her and she gave him her best sexy, bashful look. Expectant, glistening eyes, parted lips. She'd sunk him. He couldn't say no, not to Jess, not when she was right here and in the mood.

She moved her lips towards his, drew him into her and he fell for it. Their lips touched and Pete shuddered. He struggled to keep it in, keep himself together. He heard his breaths raspy as he pushed away the urge for them to turn to sobs. His face was stone but inside he was screaming. It was horrible.

The two of them looked so good together, their soft lips pressing into one another, he wanted Jess to feel that excitement, know that passion. But she was being ruined right now. Ruined for his touch. He would never make her wet by taking his shirt off. He would never have a head of hair like that. He could take as much steroids as he could handle, he just would never have a body like that. Jess would never dream about Pete's cock. And all those things that Pete wasn't and was never going to be were here right now for her to enjoy, pulsing under her fingertips. Would she ever even desire him after this? How would they survive something so enormous?

His hand came up and covered his mouth, he pulled his cheeks down; a man witnessing a horror.

Their kissing was passionate, they rolled their heads and slowly tasted each other. He could see their tongues sliding over one another, see Jess pull his tongue into her mouth, bite at it gently with her perfect teeth.

Tyler's hand came around her waist, rested on the crest of her buttocks. He squeezed her flesh gently, and she moaned. The wet sounds of their mouths working over each other were going to drive him mad. Smacking, slurping, kissing. The room was dead quiet but for those noises and they seemed too loud, too dirty for the room. But he couldn't deny that he'd stiffened inside his pants. He could feel himself throbbing down there, the head of his dick was pressing uncomfortably straight out, twisted in his briefs and sticking the front of his khakis out. He twisted it out of the fabric and pushed it to the side.

Jess broke away from Tyler and they looked into each other's eyes. It was like Pete wasn't even in the room. Both of them stared into each other, breathing heavy. Jess rested her hands on his broad chest, ran them down

his body, over his shirt. She watched her hands on him, watched her hands pull his shirt out of his pants and slide it up his body. She watched him being revealed. Pete saw him, vain, flexing his abs for her, straightening and crunching them down. She pulled the shirt up and over his head and he lifted his big arms for her, so she could get it right off. He let her take him in. He liked being looked at.

Pete had to admit, he looked like he was out of a movie. His chest was a broad slab, capped by shoulders like cantaloupes. His waist was narrow, his abs bulging, defined. Jess drank it up. He saw his wife admiring his body, running one hand over him, feeling his hardness. She looked mesmerized.

She bowed to him, kissed her way from his neck down his body, her hands up above her going over his chest and shoulders. She took a nipple in her lips and she sucked on it. She worked it gently, her head rocking around, her eyes closed as she pulled it into her mouth and gently ran her teeth on it. It was getting Tyler. His eyes closed and he leaned his head back. Jess worked on the other one, kissed her way over to it, took that one into her wet mouth. Her hand was on the ridged column of his midsection. Her fingertips squeezed at the slabs of muscle, her fingers traced the edges of each ridge, moving over him like she was drawing him.

Then something bizarre. She stopped, gasped, high and breathy. Her thighs clamped together and he could see her rump flexing under her tight dress. She did it again, said, *Ah*, and hunched a bit, her hands turned to claws on his skin. Then she was immobile. Pete was one hundred percent certain his wife just came. His little brat got herself so worked up she just made herself come by touching this guy's beautiful body. His heart went out to her. He wanted to cross over and give her a big hug, crush her against him. He was so happy for her. This was what he wanted. He wanted her to feel that crazy ecstasy, get herself charged up. Enjoy those feelings that Pete would never put into her. She was a beautiful young woman. Happy, healthy, hard-working, and kind. This was what she deserved in life.

When Jess had his nipple in her mouth, and she felt its hard masculine shape under her soft lips, she felt something coming. Had felt the same thing in the minivan that first night with him. A shudder

about to happen, like on the verge of a chill. Froze, waiting for it to happen. In the van, it subsided. Receded, and as it got farther it occurred to her that it could have been an orgasm. But that was crazy, you didn't come from touching a man. And here it was again. Only now she was aware that it could be. Could be an orgasm. So she let it happen, coaxed it towards her. Like pushing away any thought that might break a sneeze when you were about to go off. This was no sneeze. When her hand went over his abs, felt them hard and ridged under her fingers, felt his tight bunched skin there, it happened. Her heart opened its bomb bay doors and something explosive fell out, plummeted to her sex and then went off. Low yield, maybe phosphorous, because it lingered and spread in waves, consuming her. It was gentle and warm, not fiery, and it spread through her, racking her body in clusters. Then it was gone, and she couldn't believe it had happened. She came from touching this stud. Her eyes teared up, and she blinked one off and touched her eyelids to dry them. She looked back at Pete and he was beaming. Absolutely beaming. He knew her body, knew her reactions. He knew she'd just come. She chuckled once and covered her mouth.

Tyler seemed bothered, like they were sharing something—jealous, worried they were making fun of him. “What?” he said sharply, frowning at her.

“I just came,” she whispered to him and covered her mouth back up.

It was Tyler's turn to beam. “Really?” he said, he looked confident again.

She didn't even answer him. She attacked him with kisses, sucking his lips into her mouth and biting his tongue. That long strange orgasm had not sated her at all. It had the opposite effect, and now she was ignited with ten times the arousal she had before. She wanted his cock out, wanted it hard and plowing into her.

Pete watched his wife's hands urgently fumble with Tyler's button and zipper on his tight jeans. She was trying to move too quickly. She hooked her hands into his waistband and slid his pants and shorts down, getting control of herself and doing it slowly. She had them down over his thighs, his cock pulled down, hiding somewhere in the bunched up fabric

on his thigh. Jess' lips were on him again. Kissing his belly button and down to his pubic hair. Her fingers traced along the edges of the muscles at his waistline, a sharp V that pointed down to his cock, showed her where it was in case she was looking. She watched her fingers on his skin. Then they were back on his jeans sliding the fabric down, waiting for the star of the show.

It was revealed, the fabric clinging to it until his wife peeled them right down over the tip and his penis sprang up, bobbed and then fell to the side until the tip touched his thigh. It was huge.

Jess looked at Pete over her shoulder. "I told you," she said. Pete's mouth was dry. Everything was dry. He could feel his heart pounding in his brittle body. His wife had been fucked by that. She loved it. Couldn't wait for tonight so Tyler would put it in her again.

Jess pulled Tyler's pants right off him and dropped them on the floor next to the coffee table. She knelt down and pulled his socks off for him too. His cock hung next to her and Pete couldn't believe how large it was, the engorged tip tapping against her shoulder.

Tyler spread his legs, put his arms back on the edge of the couch and looked down as Jess put her mouth over one of his balls. She took up his sack in one hand, scooping them up and forward so she could suck on them. Even his balls were big. Jess moaned quietly as she sucked one in, let it drop then took up the other. She went on like that driving Tyler crazy. Her other hand went around his cock and held it out of the way, up against his belly. Tyler closed his eyes while Jess went on. Every once in a while he'd shudder and Pete thought he might come but he didn't.

Finally, Jess stood up before him and turned for him to undo her dress. He pulled the zipper right down to the top of her ass and she stood up, made sure he was watching, then she let it drop to the floor. Pete had a great view. Her perfect ass, firm and womanly, her red thong showing off its curves then diving down and disappearing into her warm places. Pete's favourite place on earth. Her back was bare, she was braless. Her blonde hair danced on her shoulders, her arms were moving, she was rubbing her own breasts, giving Tyler a show.

Tyler's hands came around, gripped her bottom, her flesh yielding to his strong touch. His fingers ran under the panties and cupped her cheeks, then slid the panties down her thighs. The two of them were completely naked now. Pete's stomach tightened again and a wave of dread washed over him.

He felt suddenly nauseous and warm, too warm. Feverish. Part of his brain almost put him in action, he practically felt himself rise up off the recliner to tell them that that was it. That they had gone far enough and there wasn't going to be anymore. Like if they stopped now he could preserve his dignity. His wife's dignity. Preserve their marriage.

He stopped. He knew he wouldn't stop them. He knew he was going to watch her get fucked in just a few minutes. He could feel as terrible as he wanted but the result was inexorable. Tyler was going to take that huge cock and slide it up inside his wife and she was going to love it. Nothing was going to stop it. His hands clutched the armrests of his favourite chair.

Jess told Tyler to sit back.

"I didn't get a chance to look at this thing in the van," she said.

Tyler smiled and he leaned back in the couch. She looked at his cock sitting between his legs, hanging, heavy looking, but hard enough that it wasn't resting on the seat. "That's really big," she told him.

She spread her palm across the top of it. The shaft was longer than the spread between the tip of her thumb to the tip of her little finger. She stroked her open hand up and down it.

Tyler's hand explored her back, his touch felt so good on her. She could feel how large his hands were on her back. She cuddled herself into his side, felt how hard his body was against hers. He was going to feel so good making love to her naked tonight. She couldn't wait to press her flesh against his hardness, feeling this huge penis inside her at the same time. Her breaths were short with anticipation.

She put her fingers around his penis, gripped it lightly, and stroked it up and down gently, admiring it in her hand. He was three or four times as long as her fist, thick too, she'd have to squeeze it to get her thumb to touch her middle finger.

She leaned over it, dipped her head above the tip of his cock and held it steady in her hand. She let a stream of warm spit from between her pouted lips, and it touched his glans, rolled down the underside of his cock. She ran her hand loosely through it, polished the end of it with her quick moving hand. Her fingers danced and squirmed over him, running through all the

grooves and ridges of his engorged cock. He went to steel, she could feel his pulse through it.

"You're so hard," she said and she laughed. He had swelled even larger now.

"Shit, Jess, your hand feels so fucking good."

"Your cock feels so good," she told him.

"I'm not going to last, you're going to make me come."

"Just come. I want to watch you."

"Yeah, make me come," he said, sliding himself through her grip.

"Then you're going to fuck me," she said, and she looked to Pete, made sure he heard her say it.

"I'm going to make you scream," he said, his voice low and serious.

Whew. That made her tingle.

It was so big in her hand. She had small hands to begin with but his cock was enormous. Couldn't believe that this had fit inside her. It was like she was stroking her tall can of Lady Shave Gel. With the lid on. The head of his cock was as broad as her thumb. The hard feel of it in her slippery grip was making her ache between her legs. This dreadfully sexual object in her hand made her tingle. She wanted to explore it, trace every vein and wrinkle on it with her touch. He was circumcised, his scar running jagged and brown a third of the way down his shaft. The end of his shaft glistened bright and taut. Her fingers feathered his tip. She let them slip along the edges, drawing little designs on his sensitive head. She traced around his hole, tickled it, then down his channel, running along his underside to his balls and back up again.

"Oh, Jess," he said. He flexed his rump, his hips lifting off the seat, and a shining bead emerged from him. She held his cock upright, midway, she squeezed him and more streamed from it, rolling over the bell of his head and running down and over her thumb. She was going to work this thing. She was going to torture him. Give him a handjob he would always remember.

Jess was watching Pete watching. She could see him past her fist wrapped around Tyler's penis, sitting in his La-Z-boy like he was watching TV. He was quiet and blank but she knew he was on fire inside. She was going to put on a show for him tonight. She wondered how she looked together with Tyler to him. The two of them naked on the family couch, her

little hand wrapped around another man's impressive sex organ. Watching herself jerk him off, waiting for this other man to ejaculate for her.

What was he thinking? What did he think of the size of this thing in her hand? He had to be intimidated by it. Jess was. She couldn't believe this was going to go inside her. If it hadn't already been in her she would be thinking about backing out right now. Was Pete worried? Tyler was so much bigger, so much sexier. But that was what Pete wanted. She didn't know if she should feel grateful or worried. She had a husband who was going to let this Amazing Sex God make love to her. But then: what kind of man would allow that? How did Pete's mind work that he was all right with this?

Tyler's flat, hard belly danced for her while she stroked him. It turned her on like crazy. Feeling his big slippery size between her fingers then watching those abs twist and flex from all the pleasure she was giving him. She started to feel very wet. When she brought her hand up high and gave that big glans some quick light strokes, his rock hard belly would suck in, the six pack abs pushing their sharp ridges up against his tight skin.

She used her hand to keep him at the very edge. She loved watching the tension sizzle through his muscles. He wanted to come but it was all up to her hand. He wanted to show her his seed and she wanted to see it, but only when she said it was time. He'd closed his eyes, his brow was furrowed and it was like he was willing it to happen without her. But she was in control. Every time she felt him at the brink she would plunge her hand down to his very thick base, watch his penis flex, struggle to shoot his semen, then fade. Then she was back up and down it, and she had him quivering.

She bullied him like that for a long while. Did it until she was the one who couldn't stand it anymore. She wanted him to come. She wanted to see it burst from him, know that she had done well for him.

She crossed a leg under her and sat on it. Tyler's hand still caressed her back, still explored her, venturing down to touch the plump flesh of her buttocks and around to the front, his palm going over her left breast. She took his cock in two hands and gripped it tightly. She stroked them up and down him, doing it firmly. She said, "Come for me."

His eyes closed and he bit his lower lip and nodded. She had him sweating. She added a little more spit, dropped into the hole in his glans and then swiftly spread with one quick hand, her other one gripping his big sack, feeling how large his balls were. She felt her wetness on her own ankle. She was so turned on right now. She stroked him faster and faster,

using only one hand, the other one gripping him tightly at the base. “Make this big dick come for me,” she whispered to him, “show it to me.”

“Shit, girl, I had no idea...you were so...dirty—”

His knees jumped as he came, and his body buckled. He grunted and snorted as it shot out of him. She kept stroking him, running her hand over his bursting glans, twisting it. He shot stream after stream of his, thick, young seed up over his chest and across that beautiful stomach.

“You make me dirty, Tyler,” she said. His face clenched as she kept working it, squeezing and stroking, short white pulses still splashing from him. She rubbed the heel of her foot tucked under her against her wet sex, felt herself on the verge of coming as well.

“Oh, my gosh, you’re so hot,” she said to him, her hand easing on him. She looked at the lines of semen across his hard body, his handsome face staring at her, dreamy and sleepy, enjoying the pleasure she was giving him. She traced a fingertip through his hot seed, drew lines along his muscles, spread the blobs around, connecting one line to the next. Her eyes darted to Pete. She wanted to make sure he saw this. This was for him. She wanted him to see her as dirty with her boy toy. As dirty as she could be with him sometimes. Rob him of some of their intimacy. Let him see her share her dirtiness with another man. His face was drawn and cold. He looked like a corpse sat up in his chair. She smiled at him, her fingers still playing with Tyler’s semen. She saw him swallow.

“I always thought you were a real goody-goody. I had no idea,” Tyler said and laughed.

Jess laughed too and she lowered her lips to his chest and kissed his skin. Kissed him right next to a hot splash of semen. Make her husband sweat. She asked him, “Do you think I’m bad?”

Tyler held his palm against her cheek, he said, “Yeah, I do.”

“We’re just getting started.”

She stood up, felt his eyes move over her naked body above him. She had one hand out, her fingers spread wide, dirtied with strings of his semen, she held her other hand cupped underneath it to catch any drips. “I think I’ll go grab us a tea towel,” she said. She walked out of the room, conscious of

her gait, letting her hips sway, knowing that Tyler and Pete were watching her bare ass as she walked into the kitchen.

Pete didn't know what to do or say right now. It was just Tyler and Pete alone in the room. Tyler was still laying back on the couch, that huge cock up on his belly, come all over his stomach. He was looking around but not over at Pete. He and Jess had agreed that he wouldn't say anything while she had sex with Tyler. If they managed to make it happen at all, they would add—now here they were, actually doing it. He'd wanted to say a lot while he watched his wife jerk off that kid's big tool. He wished Jess would have said dirty things to him. But they'd decided that she shouldn't do that either. It might freak Tyler out. And ultimately this was *about* Jess, and *for* Jess. She should just enjoy it and Pete should count himself lucky he gets to sit and watch his beautiful wife have sex with this stud.

He wasn't that big a fan of Tyler's but really Jess couldn't have found a more perfect specimen for this arrangement. She might have picked some other guy from around town who was their age but he was starting to realize that that would be nowhere as exciting as seeing her with a young, handsome, endowed boy. It was a little scary to think his wife was hot enough to pull this dimepiece. If she could get this guy to fuck her twice, bring her flowers and wine, what was she doing with a balding old fool like Pete?

Jess came strutting into the room holding a few tea towels, putting on a sexy walk for them. She looked more confident and happy than he'd remembered seeing her in a long time, walking on her toes like she was wearing high heels—showing off her legs to Tyler. She kneeled next to Tyler on the couch and she kissed his lips, he bent his head back for her and closed his eyes. She ran a clean dry towel over him, mopping up his wet spots. She watched her hand work, and Tyler flexed for her, his stomach muscles rippled as she dried him.

"Your body is so incredible," she told him.

Tyler said, "So is yours, Jess," and his hand came around and smoothed down her back, his big hand spreading across her rump. He drew her to him, gazing into her eyes, and she parted her lips, put them over his. Pete

watched them kiss again. Twisting and rolling, sucking tongues and biting lips. Jess's hand had a towel wrapped around the kid's cock and she was stroking it, drying it, going down between his legs and rubbing his balls. Tyler had never gone soft. He came, then faded a bit, but Pete could see his swollen glans, taut and shining, bulging out the end of Jess' towel-covered grip.

Tyler put a hand on either side of her waist and he lifted Jess up like she was nothing. She folded her long legs up and Tyler brought her over top of him, straddling his hips. They kissed like that for a long while, Jess stroking his cock hidden in between them. Tyler's hands smoothed over her back, crested her cheeks and spread them, showing her glistening wet sex to Pete, showing him how hot he was making his wife. *That's it, kid, make my girl scream.*

Tyler said, "Condoms are in my jacket."

"I've got some in that box there on the coffee table," Jess told him. She got herself off his lap and Tyler watched her ass while she did, reached out and touched it as she went to the square teak box on the table. She dragged it over to her making a rattling sound from the lid as it slid on its round brass feet. She lifted the delicate lid off by the small knob on the top and brought out a string of condoms that rolled out like an accordion. His wife had planned ahead—knew where it was going to happen. He wondered if she had condoms stashed somewhere else too, different spots in the house she thought she might need them. They'd have to find them all in the morning before the boys got home. They'll have to do their own dirty Easter Egg hunt.

He tried to picture Jess buying condoms. Magnums. Fuck, Magnum XL. Which store did she go to? Did someone she knows see her there? Did she wear a disguise? He kind of hoped not. Bit of a thrill to think that someone out there might think Pete had a big one. He'd love to have someone start a rumour like that. No one would ever find out the truth anyway.

Tyler stood up behind her as she tore one of the foil squares open. She sat on the arm of their couch and Tyler presented her with his big, bobbing cock. She squeezed the tip of the condom and rolled it down his shaft with the fingers of her other hand. She looked up at Tyler standing over her, she seemed a little worried, her eyebrows raised in the middle making a little crease in her smooth brow. She'd sucked her lower lip a bit under her front teeth. Jess had been in control up until now. Now she knew that her turn

was over. Her stud was in control and he was young and powerful, had a big, thick cock and he was going to fuck her. Probably fuck her hard. It might hurt her. Tyler bent and picked her up again, his hands grabbing her around her little waist. He lifted her to her feet and he turned her around. She knew what he wanted and she lifted one knee up to the seat of the couch, put her elbows on the arm, bent herself for him and showed him her dripping wet entry. Pete couldn't remember ever being more excited, more turned on. He loved this woman. He loved her, and look at her, how aroused she was, how excited and happy her face was. That tension he'd seen had eased and now he could tell she wanted it. Desperately wanted this kid to drive his thing inside her, push her little hole wide apart and make her go wild.

Tyler rubbed her back again, couldn't get enough of his wife's soft smooth tanned skin. He took his cock in one hand and lined it up between Jess' legs. She looked over her shoulder trying to see his cock, wanting to see him put it in her. He rubbed the tip against her wet mound, up and down, over and over, pushing her pink folds open and it made Jess moan. Then he let it go and eased it inside her, pushing the big head of his cock past the tight ring of her opening. She gasped and her hands clenched into fists. He kept it going, sliding it deep inside her. She let out a breathy sound that caught in her throat.

"Oh, my God, Pete, he's so big," she said, breaking her own rule and he wanted to kiss her for it. *I'm here, baby, I'm watching and I love you.*

"Oh, Pete, it's hurting me, it's so thick. Oh, baby, Tyler don't stop. Fuck me, please, fuck me." Using her dirty words for him. Pete's heart pounded in his chest.

Tyler might have liked her saying that to Pete. He seemed bolstered by it, giving Jess a little soft slap on her thigh while he slowly fucked her. Wonder what that must feel like to be so sexually powerful another man's wife would fuck you in front of her husband. What would it feel like to have women tremble under your big cock and your beautiful body? Tyler had Jess's eyes closed, giving her what looked like incredible pleasure. Her mouth was open, her lips curled over her teeth; she looked amazing.

Pete thought of the sunny morning in June seven years ago, pulling up the drive, bringing home his wife and his newborn son. He walked them in and Jess came straight to the family room, exhausted, and she sat right where she was this moment and cradled Pete Jr. while the sun came in the

window and lit them up until they glowed. Pete had sat down in this same chair, feeling overcome, so filled with joy, watching her, weak but resilient, as she rocked their baby hidden away in his pale yellow blanket with the blue teddy bears on it. Now Jess was stretched out over the arm, her little hole that had delivered Pete his boys being stretched wide in a different way. She was still beautiful, he still loved her, in many ways he was overcome by his love for her just like that June morning.

The muscles of her back rippled, her lats flexing with each thrust, a glimpse of her ribs pressing out her skin when she inhaled when he got too deep; her breathy gasps as she encouraged her young stud to deliver more pleasure to her, her pale blonde hair swinging, lamp light turning it white where it passed through. He watched the jiggle of her perfect woman-ass as Tyler's palms spread it wide and his hips thrust against it, the muscle of her thigh, the tendons of her knee as she flexed and gave this kid something to drive against, her pretty feet, so small, her toes splayed out and clenching the carpet. This was the woman he loved. This was who she was. This was natural human copulation, and she was loving it. This was her without Pete, and it was wholly dangerous, but she deserved this gift—deserved to be delivered to a heart-pounding orgasm by a physical specimen that made her dampen her panties.

He'd like to think Jess would return the favour if he found himself with a willing Playmate. Some twenty-year-old vixen who wanted Pete inside her. She might, but that would never be tested. He was not going to attract any buxom young ladies. And if he did he still wasn't going to rock their world with what he had between his legs if he ever even managed to find the courage to take it out of his pants and show it to them. Besides, he had his Jess. Really, he would take her over any lay with some sexy cutie-pie stripper or whatever. She was ten times the woman. She understood her husband and they worked like a team. She was also goddamn gorgeous.

“Ah, Pete, he feels so good, oh, baby.”

Tyler bit his own lips into his mouth and slammed it into Jess so deep Pete thought he must have hurt her. But Jess bucked against him, let him bury it all the way inside, drive it in to his balls and hold it, probably flexing it inside her. She moaned and tilted her head back, said, “Oh, yes.”

Tyler grabbed a handful of her hair and pulled her head back hard and started pounding again, sending ripples through her flesh. Jess' fingers dug

into the arm of the couch and she cried out into the ceiling, her eyes shut, her face clenched—somewhere between pain and pleasure.

Pete's scariest thought crept up to the surface, bubbles breaking the liquid tension. How he'd landed her, this girl so out of his league. His fear was great; it was an intersection of unusual circumstances that brought them together and under any other condition that he'd met Jess he would never be with her. They could meet a hundred times in a hundred ways under normal circumstances and she would smile and pass him by. He really shouldn't be with her.

He met her on the one day of his life that he'd had confidence. Never had it before. He'd spent two nights studying, foregoing sleep, for his Human Resource Management final. Twenty-eight-year-old Pete back at school looking to get his Master's. He was running back then and he'd just taken a third place ribbon three days before for a cross-country half marathon. He was walking out of the exam room, half asleep, on cloud nine—he knew, absolutely knew, he had just scored a one-hundred on the final. A combination of endorphins, recovery chemicals, seventy-two hours without sleep, and a glowing satisfaction of acing a test he'd worried about had turned him into someone else. A veritable Frankenstein monster, unthinking, made up of parts that weren't his own. Then he was presented with a girl so beautiful he'd been stopped in his tracks.

Jess was a mature student too. A twenty-six-year-old coming in from the unfriendly workforce and looking to get her Teacher's License in Ohio, specializing in Early Childhood, a Master of Education program. She was lost in the Human Sciences Department, looking for the Fitness facility. She was wearing a University sweatshirt and black dance leggings. Everything about her told Pete she needed help. Then he did the last thing Pete Mapplethorpe would do. He walked right up to this beautiful girl with her perfect face and her long, silky blonde hair and he said, "You look like you need help," his voice unusually deep and firm. She told him she was just hired to teach a dance class for the Faculty Staff Fitness Program, she was so late, she'd just come from class, she was lost, she needed this job—the money—so badly...

He knew where she needed to be and he picked up her bag and slung it over his shoulder, told her to follow him and he got her there fast. Not a big deal, really. But she was thankful, her eyes were wet, like she was ready to cry. He was probably in love with her right then and there. Wanted to put

his arms around her and be the one to take care of her forever. He told her he wanted to take her to dinner. She said, Yes, she hugged him then darted in to teach her class. It was that fucking easy.

Jess, that day almost nine years ago, was a construct of negative experiences. The opposite of Pete that day. She was a vessel provided to Pete to receive his attempt at a performance of confidence. He wasn't confident in that moment, he was just *acting* confident. And the lack of sleep removed his inhibition. That was how he won her. That was how he pulled off a David Blaine level magic trick and made a girl too good for him fall in love.

They went for dinner and he learned she was in a bad place. A lost job, a failed engagement. Jess was hurting back then and he was there for her. He became her best friend. Then gradually there was romance. Then they made love.

“Oh, Pete, he's going to make me come again.”

That drove Tyler mad and he pounded her faster, turning her gasps into a long unending warble. A long, high, girl-moan undulating with the drive of his hips against her bottom. She cried out loud, a sharp yell—almost scary hearing her voice echo off the walls like that in this familiar little room. On a normal night he might be sitting here with her watching a movie. Her head shot back and then forward, her hair whipping, making a soft sound as it brushed across the fabric of the couch. She was about to come, he could hear her making soft high sounds, could see her back heaving and trembling.

“Oh, God, stop, oh, stop—”

Her hand came back and she clawed at his hip, she held his thrusts at bay with her little hand. Then she came hard, she told them too, said, “Oh, ah, I'm coming.” Her body tightened and she flexed her rump, her thighs, her head fell forward then arched back, her mouth open like she was screaming but she didn't make a sound. “Oh, Tyler, Tyler,” she moaned.

He slid himself out of her and she turned to him, put her mouth over his, her hands up on his broad chest. They embraced, kissing passionately, Jess's arms going around his back, exploring his muscles. Tyler's big hands pulled her into him, one hand sliding between her ass cheeks and Pete knew he was sliding a finger inside her. His cock was between them, really filling out that extra large condom, angry red under the latex, ready for action, it looked as long as his wife's milky thigh.

Pete's relationship with Jess had been a whirlwind once they were intimate. They graduated, moved in together. He proposed, she accepted—crazy girl—short engagement, married ten months after he met her, and nine months later Pete Jr. was born. He locked Jess up before she could come to her senses.

Jess lay back on the seat of the couch, her head pushed forward, watching Tyler. Pete could see her eyes tracking his body, admiring his muscles. Her knees came up to her chest, she exposed herself to him. She bit her lip. Her stomach was bunched up, her breasts thrust out. Her sex looked wounded, bruised. She was slick with her fluids, her folds were engorged and ruffled, abused looking. Tyler lowered his hips over her sex, put a knee on the couch. He held the tip of his cock up on his belly, practically in his belly button, then he let it go, let it fall and slap onto Jess's shaved mound. She gasped and flinched, smiled.

"It's heavy," she said.

Tyler thrust his hips, ran his cock over her grooves, let it run along her belly. She watched it slide over her. Her hand came up to her mouth and she licked her fingertips then put them on the head of his penis, a string of spittle winking in the lamp light. He let her massage the head of his cock through the condom while he gently ran himself over her. The kid's cock went up past her belly button. Did that really go all the way inside her like that?

He dragged it all the way back, that big round ass of his thrust out, until the head of his cock rested in her heat. Jess's fingertips guided him into position. Then he drove it forward and she yelled out.

"Oh, baby, ah, Tyler," she gasped.

He worked it in and out of her, slowly, both of them watching his thick thing sinking into her dark flesh then pulling out her bright parts. She rested the soles of her feet on his hard thighs. Then he got her bouncing, thrusting so he found a rhythm that had Jess singing, her pretty breasts swinging around in circles. Her face was a frozen pained expression, her mouth agape, her lips hugging her teeth again. She was in love with fucking this guy. He was doing it to her like she maybe never had it done before. Not Pete, nor any of her boyfriends probably. I mean, she came from touching him, for crying out loud.

Jess ran her hand over the muscles of his belly, said, "Oh, baby, oh, your body..."

Tyler forced her knees up over her shoulders. Too far. Pete maybe didn't like seeing his wife being forced like that. Hurt like that. But Jess made no complaint. She was exposed to Pete now in an ugly way. His lip twitched. Her rump was up off the couch, her feet swinging over Tyler's shoulders like they'd come unhinged from her ankles. Jess was skewered, her pretty sex forced wide apart and he saw her anus tilted up to him. Saw it brown, winking at him with every thrust Tyler gave her. It was a little ugly.

Tyler made it worse. He put one foot up on the couch then the other, his legs spread wide, his hips pounding that fat meat into Jess. Jess loved it, screaming out now. He could see her eyes clenched shut and her hands searching behind her, looking for purchase on the back of the couch looking for something to grab on to.

"Oh, Tyler, oh, yeah," she hissed.

Tyler was pounding into her and he had his wife gasping. That little voice recognizable in the joyful pained yips he'd never heard from her before. She dug her heels into his hard rump, and he could see Tyler's thick cock spreading Jess's sex wide open. She was pink and wet, almost injured looking. Each time the kid pulled out of her he seemed to drag his wife's tight membranes out with his thick cock. Her insides were clinging to him. She was gasping out affirmations, letting him know he was hitting all her good spots, whisper-yelps like *yeah, ah, oh, uh-huh*, a different one with each thrust. Her thin hand made an appearance between his legs, trapped between them. Her fingers went around his sack and she grasped his balls. She pulled them into her with each thrust. Pete watched her familiar hand with the wedding ring on it work with Tyler's big balls. She squeezed them, fondled them, squished his bag hard forcing the kids testicles out to the sides of her grip.

"Oh, yeah, fuck me," she said, "empty these big balls inside me."

"You like those balls?"

"They're so big," she gasped, she was out of her mind.

"You like this big cock?" he grunted into her.

"Yes, I do. Come for me. Come inside me. Fill up that condom inside me."

Tyler growled like a dog and doubled his thrusting. Jess scratched at his arm and shoulder.

"I'm coming," she cried out.

“Come on my cock,” he barked at her. And she did. She thrashed under him, her head twisting left and right, her bright blonde hair tangling up on her, dragging through her sweat and catching under her ears and on her earrings. She looked so amazing.

“That’s it, Jess,” Pete said under his breath.

“Oh, yeah, oh, yeah,” she cried out loud. She tensed and Pete watched her toes curl right up like they were cramping. She dug her heels into Tyler’s hard ass.

Tyler buckled, drove himself in deep, thrust quickly out and then dove back in and held. Pete watched his balls rise up, almost disappear into his body. Tyler was filling up that condom inside his wife. His muscles bulged, veins like cables down his arms. Jess was watching his face intently, watching him come inside her.

“That’s it, baby,” she said to him quietly. “Fill me up,” she said, breathless. She ran a finger over his forehead, pushing a lock of his hair out of his eyes.

“Oh, God,” Tyler said, trembling. He was still coming. His balls were raising and dropping now as he pushed every drop he had into Jess. “Oh, fuck,” he said. The kid was drained.

He pulled himself out of her, and they both hissed, both of them were so sensitive right now. They looked at each other and laughed a little. Laughed at how ticklish they both were. Tyler rolled off her and collapsed next to her, he put an arm over his face, hid himself from Pete.

That big thing wagged around stiffly between his legs, the reservoir tip swinging, filled with his seed and hanging down to his shaft. Jess put her legs down slowly, touched her feet to the floor. Her face was flushed red, she was sweating, her chest and collar splotchy. She looked at Pete and looked away. He thought she looked like she might cry. She covered her face with both hands, and he swore she was sobbing. Pete wanted to go to her, to hold her. But he felt like this was still her moment and that space she shared on the couch right now with Tyler was her space. He sat upright, leaned forward.

“Wow,” she said, finally and her face brightened. She rested a hand on Tyler’s abs, waited for him to look at her. He moved his arm away, and they watched each other’s eyes for a moment.

Jess looked away first. She watched his fading erection sagging between his legs. She took his cock up in both her hands and squeezed him from the

base to the tip, emptied out his cock into the condom. She squeezed it, her forearm bulging with effort. Then she gently took his condom off him and tied a knot in the end. Always a mom, always a homemaker. No cum stains on Jess's couch.

She sat for a moment on the couch, silent, looking down at her hands fiddling with the condom. Her hands were shaking.

"I'm just going to clean up," she said.

She stood and left the room pinching the condom in her fingers, padding out naked.

Pete finally breathed. That was incredible. He sat back again into his chair. Wished his Dewar's wasn't empty. He felt numb in his extremities but he tingled inside. His cock ached, throbbed in his pants.

Tyler stirred on the couch. He avoided Pete, stood up and put his boxers on. Then stood there, holding his jeans over an arm, flipping through his phone.

There was nothing Pete could say. Nothing Tyler could say. So they both acted like they were the only ones in the room. Tyler got his jeans on, picked up his shirt then stretched it over his muscles.

Jess stepped into the room, arm bracing herself, holding onto the edge of the archway. She was wearing sweatpants and a sweatshirt now, slippers on her feet.

"I served some pie here," she said nodding her head to the kitchen.

It was uncomfortable, sitting at the table eating the store-bought coconut cream pie. She just didn't know what else to do. No sort of protocol or manners ever set up for post-coital cuckolding. She wanted Tyler gone, she wanted to go to bed. She'd have to get Pete off first, but that wouldn't take long. Then she just wanted to go and lie down.

That was the craziest, wildest, hands-down best sex she'd ever had in her whole life. It wasn't with her husband. And that hurt her now, three orgasms in, when she was feeling dry and rational. She felt suddenly dirty. Bad.

Zero regrets, though. She would do it again in a heartbeat. She hurt a bit down there, Tyler had really given it to her. She wanted it again, regardless.

She wasn't sorry she'd done it. Who knew where this ennui came from.

Tyler finished first, clinking his fork on the plate and getting up to go in the same instant. Pete had barely touched his, but he had gone through another whisky.

"Dinner was fantastic," Tyler said. "Thanks so much."

Jess nodded and she smiled at him. "Dinner?"

Tyler looked around the room, glanced at both of them, made eye contact. There was a bit of a smirk on his face. He said, "You guys know how to throw a party."

"Maybe we'll have you over again sometime," Jess tested. He was walking down the hall, his back to them, Pete and Jess following behind him.

He turned at the door and said, "Yeah, I'd like that. Any time."

They all stood awkwardly in the hall, Tyler's hand resting on the handle ready to go. Jess saw everyone's faces were showing the traces of a smile. It was all okay.

"Night, guys," Tyler said and walked out. She stood with Pete and they watched him get on his bike, fire it up, light up their minivan with his headlight, then he walked it backwards, revved it up and he was gone.

Once they'd watched Tyler's bike disappear down the end of their street Pete turned to his wife. Jess looked down, she looked ashamed, afraid to look him in the eye. Pete reached out and pulled her to his chest, couldn't stand to think of her upset, worried that he'd been hurt watching her being taken roughly by another man.

"I love you, baby," he whispered to the top of her silky blonde head.

"Are you okay, Petey?"

"I'll live, Jess. You were amazing."

"Are you sure?"

"You looked so hot. Jess, it was hard sometimes, but I loved every minute of it."

Her arms went around his waist and she hugged him. "That was so intense," she said.

He craned his neck back, looked her in the eye, he said, “Are you okay? Did you like it?”

She nodded to him, her ice blue eyes big and expressive. “I liked it, Pete, of course. He was really incredible.”

He kissed her forehead and ran his hand over her hair, hugged her head into the crook of his neck. “We’re still okay, aren’t we?”

“Of course, Petey,” she said to him. She pushed her tummy into him, purposely grinding herself into his hardness. He ached for her.

“Pete?”

“Yeah?”

“I’ve never felt more alive,” she looked up at him again. “I love you. I...this new sexuality—it’s been overwhelming. I’ve never felt like this before.”

“Tyler really gets you going.”

“No. Well, yeah, I mean, of course...but it’s more than that. It’s not really him. He’s a big part of it—maybe it’s my ego or something. I can’t believe I can attract such a young, handsome stud. But you’re the biggest part, Pete. Supporting this craziness, being able to get past jealousy and just let me be empowered, or whatever you want to call it. You don’t try and own me—”

“No,” he laughed, “but we’re still married.”

“I know, but you know what I mean.”

“I don’t own you but this isn’t an open marriage, right?”

“No, I know it’s you and me, but right now I’m finding out just about the *Me* side.”

“Should I be worried about the *Me* side? Is that like the Dark Side?”

“Come on, Pete. It used to be just about you. I would tell you dirty things and I would love how hard it made you, how turned on you got. And that was what turned me on. But those little games have blossomed. I feel...now it’s about me. Now it’s my turn. You get to share it too. And I love that it turns you on, just like it turned me on to tell you those stories. Now I don’t have stories, I have the real thing, I know. That’s why you’re such a big part of this. I don’t think another man would allow me to be shared.”

“Would you like it if I was more possessive? Do you think I should be?”

“No. Maybe? You are who you are. We’re making this work. I love you for who you are. And now it’s brought me here, where I feel like a sexual—

I don't know—powerhouse. I tingle all day long. I feel like I'm the prettiest girl in high school, like sex is new and exciting, and I'm dating the captain of the football team."

"Did you just read *The Big Book of Cliches*?"

"Ha ha, funny man," she said and reached up and touched the tip of his nose. "Maybe that's not the best way to put it. But I'm trying to dumb it down for that slow brain of yours." She pressed her head to his chest. "I just want to thank you for this gift. You've made me feel like I'm sixteen again. You're selfless and wonderful."

"I don't know about that. Don't forget how much I enjoyed seeing you get it."

"Did it really look good?"

"Honey, you are so beautiful. I just wish I could do those things to you. Make your face twist into those shapes, make you cry out like that."

"In a way you are, aren't you?"

"Yeah, I guess I am."

Jess' hand came around his thigh and up between his legs. She put her palm over his throbbing erection. "Let's take a look at that little dick of yours."

She had his heart racing now, talking dirty to him. His hands were shaking as he undid the front of his pants.

"What did you think of Tyler's cock?"

"It was pretty big."

"Yeah, Pete, it's *pretty* big."

He pushed his pants down, let her see his erection, sticking straight up out of his pubic hair. She ran her index finger down the underside of it, from the tip down to his scrotum. "And that's *pretty* small," she said. "I guess you're going to want me to do something with it."

"Yes."

"Do we even bother fucking anymore?"

"What do you mean?"

"I don't see the point." She circled his cock with an OK sign, lightly stroking the end of it.

"You don't?"

"I mean, I want to get you off. But I don't get anything from fucking you. If I'm with Tyler now—"

"Is Tyler going to take over for me?"

“Don’t you think he should?” She was watching her hand on his little penis. Did he seem even smaller to her now?

“I don’t know.”

“Pete, come on. Didn’t you see that thing between his legs? Didn’t you see it in my hand? He fucked me with that. Do you know how good that feels?”

“No.”

“Well, it feels unbelievable. He made me come so many times,” she whispered to him.

“Please, Jess, let me fuck you.”

“Here in our front hall?”

“Right now, Jess, I have to.”

“All right, I mean, if you want to go through the motions.”

“I do.”

She turned and put her hands on the shuttered doors of the hall closet, exposed her behind to him. He didn’t waste a second, pulled her sweatpants down over her cheeks and they fell to the floor. She felt him sliding himself inside her.

“He left me a little beat up down there, so you’ll have to tell me when it’s in so I can act like I can feel it.”

“It’s in Jess,” she could hear his voice trembling.

She actually turned herself on again joking around with him, hurting him and humiliating him. She felt a little wet. She smiled into the closet door. Her hand reached back and grabbed his ass. “Try and act like you’ve got a dick and give it to me hard.”

He pounded into her and she felt a tingle. She couldn’t help thinking about Tyler, what they’d done tonight. She thought of the difference between the two men and that made her wetter.

“Fuck me, Pete, fuck me with that tiny dick.”

“Oh, Jess,” he choked.

She knew he was going to come fast. She tickled her darkest thoughts, she wanted to be lifted over the wall again, one more orgasm and she’d sleep like a baby tonight.

“Do I feel looser, baby?”

“No, Jess, you’re so tight.”

“No, Pete, tell me he ruined me for you, tell me he stretched me out,” she whispered.

“You feel like an old hooker.”

“Come on, Pete, work with me.”

“God, Jess I can’t even feel you.”

“Did he ruin me, Petey?”

“His big cock ruined you, how can I ever fuck my wife again? Why did we do this? How can I ever make love to you again?”

“That’s it, Pete, fuck me,” she hissed at him, getting into it now.

“Did he hurt you?”

“He stretched me so wide, Pete. I can’t even feel you right now. What are we going to do?”

“We’ll have to get him to, ah, come back. Fuck you whenever...mm, you need it. I can’t do it anymore.” Pete was thrusting his thing into her, he was frenzied and urgent.

“No, there’s no point. I’m sorry, baby, I have to take the better man now.”

“Ah, Jess, ah shit.” He pulled his dick out of her and she felt his hand stroking himself behind her, bumping against her cheeks. He came hard, she felt his hot seed splashing the backs of her legs. He roared out behind her, the loudest he’d ever been. She was making him crazy.

She put her hands between her legs, drove her fingers into her hot wet folds and worked herself, rubbing her hard button under her fingers, thinking of Tyler pounding her. She clenched her face and ground against Pete still spurting between her legs and she got it done. “Augh,” she blurted out as she came so hard she saw tingling stars in her periphery. One more for the road. She slumped against the wall as Pete huffed behind her. She was exhausted.

PART III

CAUGHT IN THE ACT

BANANA SONG

TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 27TH

Jess's classroom was neat and organized. Some of the other teachers kidded her that it was obsessively so. Keeping the room like a tidy home became discipline for her kids. If there was a place for everything and everything was in its place then there were no distractions. And when there were no distractions there was only function.

Every morning when they all came into her classroom there was no confusion, no time for any one to get lost in any extraneous activity. It took a couple of days before they all learned the routine, how to come in, where to put your things and find your seats, and these days she never had to intervene and remind anyone what they should be doing.

Some teachers would just wait it out, let them burn off that steam that built up. It could be a tough transition to come from your home and then into this cinderblock institution, it could create a tense anticipation, a pent up energy especially in the first weeks of a new school year. But Jess had her room very warm and inviting, she hoped it was very much like their own homes.

She used table lamps instead of keeping the fluorescents on, and a few floor lamps. A whole corner of the classroom really almost looked like a living room. It had a bookshelf full of great books, a comfortable chair, a throw rug and a side table. It attracted everyone—when it was reading time, or free time, everyone was drawn to that part of the room.

Right now all her little kids had their heads down, working through a very short list of questions she had given them. Some addition and subtraction to solve, and then a division doozy at the end. The classroom

was quiet, everyone knowing they had just a brief time to concentrate, a few minutes to come up with their answers. Jess was moving down the rows of desks watching them work but she'd stopped at Kevin Campbell. She could see that he'd got himself stuck on the last question. She scooped her long skirt and tucked it behind her knees and kneeled next to his desk.

"You can do it, Kevin," Jess said.

Kevin looked down at the paper, his face sullen and resistant. He twisted a lock of his hair around one finger, fiddled with his Number Two pencil with the other.

She smiled at him, trying to put him at ease. He'd been having trouble but he was making progress these last two weeks. However, this was a tough one and she knew it. But she was pushing him, she knew he'd earned the skills to figure this one out.

"You can draw it out," she reminded him quietly. It was twenty-seven divided by three. Big intimidating numbers but he could do this. He had the concept now he just had to apply it broadly. He drew three circles on a spare sheet of paper, then drew little stars in them one at a time, turning division into addition which he was already good at.

Last year Kevin was in Sara Bridge's class. Jess took her out to coffee when she first noticed that Kevin was having trouble with the grades he was getting. Sara told her that Kevin had coasted through on his enormous charm. He was a good-looking kid, tremendously cute, and he'd learned a lot of behaviours that helped move things his way. He was one of those kids that could make an adorable expression that would reach out to you and make you smile, make you want to scoop him up and hug him too tight. This year he had to face quite a few more challenges and he'd been struggling. He might smile his way through English or Art, but math was math. It was right or it wasn't. Poor kid was getting anxious about it. Where did his good grades go?

He wasn't doing poorly, he was just facing the first time in his life where his abilities were really being tested and measured. His grades weren't even terrible but they had dipped from where he was last year. His parents had grown concerned and that was now putting a lot of pressure on his eight-year-old endocrine system. He was stressing.

She called Kevin's parents before they were the ones to call her. Some parents found it easier to fight with the school. Put the blame on the teacher or on the administration, maybe the curriculum. That was an easy way out.

It was much harder to put the responsibility on your kid. You can call the school and fight. Hang up and it's like the problem is gone. But if you have to put the responsibility on your kid, the accountability, then it was in your face every day. Something *you* had to do, to make better, and it was right there every single day, looking up at you from the breakfast table over a bowl of Cheerios, playing tag in the yard, being tucked in at night. School was a big change in that dynamic—that parent-child relationship. It was hard for some people to make the switch and gear their kids up for all the chores of life. Let go of that sweet baby and push them gently on the back and watch where they succeed and where they fail. You have to take the failures, examine them, make them better, help your little baby find a solution. Blaming everyone else was the worst thing some people could do. The worst thing for their kid.

Kevin's parents were making an investment in him. Sending notes three times a week, letting her know how he's been progressing with his homework, their opinions on what he might be missing. How could you ask for better input? It was as simple as that, they worked him at home, let her know how it went, she did the same here, and then wrote them a little email twice a week.

"Nine?" Kevin whispered to her.

She pat the back of his little hand. "You're a smart one, Kevin," she said. She looked at the LED stopwatch she'd fixed to the wall. Another seven minutes had passed.

"Okay Kevin, let's take a break here."

She stood up and walked over to her whiteboard. Three smiley faces drawn in a row. She stopped the timer. Everyone's eyes were on her as she drew the fourth smiley face, squeaking the marker across the board, then two dramatic taps to complete it with its eyes.

"That's four, everyone."

Someone at the back said, "Body Break."

"That's right." For every seven minutes of work she drew them a smiley face, then after they'd earned four of them, they took a physical break, getting up and moving around, dancing, singing, whatever the consensus was. It broke the work up into segments for them, smaller chunks that were easier to tackle when they could see them getting closer to the reward. Two twenty-eight minute chunks, plus body breaks, covered a whole subject group. It compartmentalized their learning and she'd had great success with

it since she started it last year. Pinterest had brought her so many great ideas. She had huge boards with all sorts of things she wanted to try.

“Who wants to peel the banana?” she asked. Faces lit up. It was a solid go-to after math. Shake them out, get them moving and singing. Plus the big finale kept all their little brains invested, waiting to go crazy at the end. It was a great release for them.

“Who loves bananas?” she sang to them, getting low, singing in a hushed whisper.

“We love bananas!” they shout-sang back at her.

“Peel banana, peel, peel, banana,” she sang, pretending she had a big banana in one hand, peeling it with the other. They sang back the same, mimicking her movements, shaking their hips.

She took them through the actions of the song. She would call the action, dance it, act it out, and they would repeat it. Chopping the banana, slicing, mashing, eating. Then the kid’s favourites: barfing the banana, bending and retching, and pooping, sticking her butt out.

Then real quiet, barely a whisper, “Shh, banana, shh, shh, banana.”

“Shh banana, shh, shh, banana,” everyone whispering, fingers pressed to their lips. A giggle, the tension was palpable.

“Go bananas! Go, go, bananas!” she screamed to them now.

“Go bananas! Go, go, bananas!” she lost them, they all went crazy. She watched them as they all came up with their own crazy dance, running, hip-shaking, jumping. They were all laughing.

She let them go on for a minute watching them be crazy kids. She said, “Class, class, class!”

It was a call and response. When she called they knew to respond and they found it fun, and it always got their attention. They stopped their movements, turned, each at their own pace, but they did turn. They answered, “Yes, yes, yes!”

She put her hands up to her mouth, poised like she was going to say something loud through them, like a megaphone. She whispered, “Recess.”

11 A.M. had snuck up on them. They all looked at the clock, surprised.

“Go on,” she urged them.

They lost their little minds as they left the room. That was still a work in progress. They burst into the halls, mingling with more kids coming out of the other classrooms. Jess grabbed an apple from her desk drawer and her water container and went out, looking to catch up with them out in the field.

Sara was coming out of the break room with two paper cups of coffee. "Some morning," she said, handing one of the cups to Jess.

Jess put her water into the pocket of her long dark cardigan and took the coffee with cream. Sara just turned twenty-nine, had a young boy the same age as Andy. She was divorced, trying to do it all alone. She didn't always have a great, positive attitude but Jess loved her, and she really appreciated having another friend near her own age at the school.

"God," she said, "we've got that MEC meeting after school tonight."

"Yeah, it's supposed to be short," Jess said. The Music Education Coalition was organizing a Music Monday, two weeks away, a State-wide day of recognizing music and the importance of it in the lives of children, emphasizing the need to teach it in the schools.

They walked out into the bright fall day, over to the edge of the playground. Sara said, "Bunch of music teachers trying to save their jobs."

"Always the cynic," Jess laughed.

There were about one hundred and fifty kids in the yard, half the school going for recess at ten-thirty the rest going at eleven. Jess and Sara mingled with a group of teachers, watching out over the chaos. They stood in the sunlight just at the very edge of a blue shadow cast by the building behind them.

Jaden Van Public School was a twelve-room elementary school that taught Grades One to Four. A long, low, red-brick building that could do with a facelift. It was a smooth transition over to Alexander Heights for grades five to eight then on to Brady Byron High for most of the kids. The town's population kept growing faster than the schools could keep up. Twenty years ago Jaden Van served the whole town for Grades One through Eight. The school board had already been displaying the blueprints for a new Senior Elementary planned for about five years off.

Carol O'Neal was smoking and talking around her cigarette. She was small and mousy with brown hair that had really gone quite dark grey over the last two years. "I just hope people realize how important it is. I always try and imagine where my Becca would be if she hadn't learned piano..." she inhaled on her cigarette watching the kids play, her huge magnified eyes blinking behind her enormous Coke bottle glasses. Carol's husband was the music teacher at Brady Byron.

Jess could see Sara leaning back at the waist to catch her eye behind Carol's back. She didn't want to look, felt a laugh coming on already. She

couldn't help it, darted her eyes over to Sara, who put on an outrageous cartoonish expression of skepticism, then closed her eyes and nodded.

Jess blurted out a laugh, turned it into a cough, put her fist up over her mouth. She thought she got away with it.

Out past the chain link fence that ran the length of the grass field where the kids would play football, that separated it from the rather busy tree covered roadway, a young well-built kid on a loud low motorcycle roared past. The intense insect-whine of the bike made her insides rumble, and her heart swelled. She felt like a high school girl with a crush. Was it him?

On cue, Sara said, "Oh, is that Tyler?" to the group of girl teachers, all of them following along now.

She felt her face blush even though she could see now that it wasn't him. His build wasn't quite right, the motorcycle was the wrong colour. Good looking guy whoever he was, but his back wasn't wide enough, waist not small enough. She'd had her hands all over Tyler's back, she knew it very well, she figured.

Dawn Tilley, who taught first grade, said, "He's the only thing that makes me wish I taught High School," as her head swivelled to the right following the rider. Others nodded and someone snickered.

"My brother's friend lifts weights at the same gym as him, he said he has the biggest dick you'll ever see," Sara told them all.

"I know. Gross. You already told us," Jess said, turning up her nose.

Sara rolled her eyes, said, "Jess, you're such a prude."

A BAD GIRL

FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 30TH

Pete was going to have to fire Karla and there was no way around it. He'd spent the afternoon with it at the back of his mind, letting it hang over him. Probably somewhere in his twisted psyche he knew he was going to bail on it; ditch work, find an excuse to go home like he was doing. He was on the I75 right now doing sixty, feeling the pressure come off his shoulders the more distance he got between himself and the Save-Mart.

Karla was twenty-one, pretty, bubbly, hopeful. She had an unbelievable body too. Pete had the hardest time with her. Maybe in some way it was his fault she was going to be let go. If she was a sloppy girl, didn't have pouting lips, big doe eyes—he might have found it easier to get her some help when she needed it. Before she fucked it all up for the hundredth time. How hard is it to record the goddamn daily sales totals properly anyway? If she wasn't so pretty he might have been firmer with her, put a fear in her that steadied her hand, focussed her thought.

He loosened his tie, breathed easier. Around four he had his finger on his intercom, ready to get someone to have Karla come up. His mind raced, looked for any way out of this. Fight or flight. His stomach gurgled. And just like that he felt he was sick enough to go home early. And, Geez, what do you know, it was Friday so now he'd have to wait until Monday. He had a whole weekend to have this albatross hanging around his neck.

The thought of Karla coming in, sitting at his desk, maybe crossing one long leg over another waiting for him to say something; him knowing he was probably going to have a confrontation... She might be pretty but she was not demure. She might turn it into a yelling match.

The gurgle in his stomach was real, the nausea real. She had a boyfriend, a fiancé, they were going to be married this next summer. She would be upset, probably real mad. It might be better to tackle it first thing Monday morning, right?

He got off the highway, out of the off ramp past the Dunkin' Donuts and into his little suburb. It was beautiful out for an October day. The sun shining, the sky a brilliant blue. Deep and dark like you only see in the fall. The trees were a bright orange still, not many of them giving up and falling yet. Holding on for some final days of nice weather. His little street was busy, busy like it is in summer. Everyone getting one last nice day in for the year before the winter came. People out jogging, kids in the park playing baseball. The dog park was packed. He honked and waved at Tonya Waterhouse, his neighbour. Pushing a pram with her one-year-old, walking with her old, white-haired mother, both of them smiling back and waving in the sunlight, wearing light sweaters and turtlenecks. Her husband had left her while she was pregnant. Five months along and that asshole got cold feet and he up and split. Left her on her own. Sad, really. Her mother moved in to help out, and she was still there. How was she going to meet someone when she worked, had a newborn and lived with her mother? Must be a real tough spot. She looked happy enough though. Good for her. What else was she going to do but put her head down and get on with it?

He got to the end of the cul-de-sac, signalled for his driveway. He was feeling pretty good now. Not guilty that he'd dodged that responsibility. What's done was done. Put your head down and get on with it.

Tyler's ninja bike was in the driveway. And like that his stomach gurgled again. The sickness was real. He was clutched, his organs all at once condensing, drawn to the gravitational core of his being, compressing to a dense hot magma. Jess' minivan was parked ahead of Tyler's bike. He looked at his watch. It was four-thirty. He was home an hour early. Jess and Tyler would have been off now for an hour. He tried to swallow but he couldn't. He had to grip the wheel tight and concentrate, force the saliva down his clamped, dry throat. Do it before he choked. His heart was pounding. What were they doing? Or was that the most ridiculous question? *He knew what they were doing.*

He opened the door of the Buick, felt like he'd just want to fall on the hot black driveway, feel its heat on him, just disappear, swallowed up in its toxic bitumen. He put a foot down, stepped out. He stood next to the car,

shut the door quietly, barely latching it. He looked up at the window of their bedroom, set in the shingles of the peaked roof, reflecting the blue of the sky behind him. A seagull swept across the glass. He heard them. Faint, Jess's voice high and brittle behind the panes. *Ah, ah, ah*, over and over. A steady passionate rhythm. She was being fucked.

His shoulders and arms were heavy, a buzzing dread coursing through his veins as he walked his way up to the front door. Key in, lock turned and he slipped into the house. It was louder in here. They were in the bedroom, the door closed, but their sounds of passion, loud and uninhibited, were clear as a bell standing at the bottom of the stairs.

"Yes, yes, yes," Jess was proclaiming. She was joyous, exuberant.

One foot in front of the other, step by step, Pete forced himself up the stairs. It was louder now. They were louder and he was closer. He could hear Jess, low, growling, *Fuck me, fuck me, come on*, the headboard was rattling, banging against the drywall. The wet sounds of their bodies slapping together in rhythm with the headboard, the bed squeaking its springs. A dirty symphony. A loud slap. Like a cymbal. Tyler's big hand across her ass, maybe the back of her thigh.

"I'm coming, I'm coming, oh, yeah, I'm coming." Jess again, letting him know it was working. The pounding intensified, Tyler growled. Pete stopped near the top. Couldn't bring a foot any farther. He dropped his head and listened.

Jess's voice warbled with Tyler's thrusting, carrying out one long note that turned into a howl. She was coming. He'd never heard her like that before though. She went on, her orgasm lingering as that kid kept fucking her. Part of Pete was happy for her, part of him loved to hear her make that sound. But his normal arousal wasn't there. He was disheartened. This was a betrayal. She could fuck that guy every day and Pete would root her on, tell her to go for it. He'd sit and watch or she could tell him later all the juicy details. Because they were a couple and they had to do this wicked thing *together* or it was infidelity. A silly twist to their arrangement but true just the same. They had rules and she was breaking them. She was fucking him behind Pete's back in their marital bed. This wasn't right. How could she not see this wasn't right? She was still his wife. She should know better.

It was Tyler's turn now, his pounding reaching a crescendo, then he roared as he came. *Rah, rah*, again and again seven times, ten times, spewing his seed. Where? In a condom, on Jess's belly, splashing her face?

Jess was encouraging him, hissing, *Give me that come*, through her gritted teeth.

He turned and stepped down the stairs. Today was not the day for confrontations. Boy, he thought dealing with Karla would have been bad. He'd have been better off staying and dealing with her than coming home to this. Granddaddy of all confrontations. His wife fucking her lover before her husband got home, spreading her legs for his big tool on the very bed her husband slept in next to her. Would she lie about this? Never tell him it happened?

He got himself to the kitchen, bent over the sink, rested his elbows on the edge. He could be sick. He could throw up.

The house seemed so quiet now with those two spent in the bedroom. Where was everyone? Where were the boys? Where was Sargent? He lifted his head, a great struggle, and looked out the window. Sargent was out there, sitting in the grass watching out the chain-link. The yard backed out to a soccer field, a public park, and he was watching a big group of kids out there kicking a ball around. The sun glinted off their bikes leaning up against the fence. He could hear lawnmowers out there, kids shouting to pass the ball. Real great day.

He felt cheated, but also, strangely, something else: Left out. Like finding out a bunch of his good friends, eight of them, went to Six Flags when he was eleven and no one even asked him if he wanted to go. Everyone standing around on Monday talking about what a great time they had.

Without me. She's doing it without me?

He could hear a heavy body coming bouncing down the stairs. Making the old steps creak with his weight. Pete couldn't get out of here. He was caught. Now they'll know he knows.

Tyler strode into the kitchen. Naked, head down, his giant, plump cock still mostly hard, wagging and bouncing, sticking straight out. He was glossy with sweat, his hair hung down over his forehead. Veins bulged, standing out in his big arms and up through his shoulders.

"Oh, shit," Tyler said, looking up now. He stopped.

"Oh, shit is right."

"Hey, Pete."

Pete didn't say anything. Tyler put his hands up like, *Hey, you caught me*.

Then he shrugged, and continued on, walked right up next to Pete to stand at the counter. He reached up and opened a cupboard, brought down a drinking glass. He turned to the sink and Pete gave him some room. He watched him run the tap, test the temperature then put the glass under the stream.

“She’s a little thirsty,” Tyler said without looking over.

Pete looked him up and down. Not much taller than Pete, but voluminous. Big arms and neck and shoulders, rounded, jacked, inflated. His stomach muscles rippled while he stood there, swishing the glass while it filled. His big cock was pressed up against Pete’s kitchen cupboards, going sideways, its eye looking right at Pete. It was long enough to go past his hip, look around it, keep an eye on the husband of the woman it just fucked.

Tyler took a sip of Jess’ water and grunted something to Pete before turning to leave the kitchen. Pete went to follow, looked back and saw the long, shiny mark his cock had left on the cupboard door. He reached back, sighing, exasperated, grabbed a dishcloth and wiped it away. Was that from his own semen? It couldn’t be from Jess’s insides—he came inside a condom, right?

Pete caught up with him on the staircase, saw him at the top, his big, bare, bubble butt, his heavy balls, then he turned and stepped into the bedroom, closed the door. Pete got as far as the top of the stairs and stopped again. Couldn’t get any farther.

He heard Tyler’s low voice say something in there. Heard Jess give a little laugh. The bed squeaked, he heard a wedding ring clink on a drinking glass. Some more quiet talking, another little girl giggle. Soft footsteps.

The door opened and Jess came out, tying her white terry robe at the waist. She was bare-legged, naked under there. Her face and chest were splotchy, she was sweaty, her hair heavy, tucked behind her little ears. She was glowing.

“Hi, Pete. You’re home early.”

He didn’t know what to say. He shrugged his shoulders and shook his head at her. He couldn’t speak, he sat down heavily, four stairs from the top. Jess came down to him, sat herself a few stairs higher.

He sat silent for a while, looking at her perfect feet. Her well-formed toes, the healthy nails. He wanted to bend to them, kiss them. Let her off the

hook. But this was too much. What if the boys had witnessed what she did? She was bat-shit crazy to do this.

“Where is Andy? He’s not home is he?”

“No, Pete, he’s still at daycare.”

“Jess, it’s after four-thirty.”

“I know, I pick him up at five. It’s just an extra fifteen dollars, they don’t mind.”

“Wait, has this happened before?”

She held his gaze for a moment. She’d been caught. She said, “No.” Too quiet. Couldn’t even convince herself.

“You’re lying, Jess, I can see it. You’re the worst liar.”

She shrugged and looked down at the bottom of the stairs.

“Jess, look at me.”

She looked at him. Her expression wasn’t quite what he expected. Her lips were firm. She was mad at him. Worried that her mean old husband was going to ruin her fun. “Yes, all right,” she said, “it’s happened before.”

“How many times?”

She flicked her hand at him, exasperated, said, “I don’t know Pete. A couple...”

“Where’s Petey?”

“He’s at Noah’s place, he goes there after school, like, every day.”

“Jess he could come home and find you two.”

She scrunched her face up, shook her head at Pete—*that would never happen, Pete, you’re being an idiot.*

“It’s true Jess, he could come home unexpected.”

“He won’t.” She was still shaking her head. She was in denial.

“I came home unexpected, didn’t I?”

It stopped her head shaking, but he thought she might have rolled her eyes. “The bedroom door is locked.”

“Jess, the minute I got out of the car, what was the first thing?”

“I don’t know, Pete—the first thing what?”

“I heard you up here, screaming. I could hear you out on the street. Jess, the neighbours might have heard you.”

She raised her eyebrows, still looking away from him. “Oh,” she said.

“Yeah, *oh*. What would Petey think was happening to his mother if he came up the driveway, heard that?”

It made her smile.

“Are you fucking smiling?”

“No, Pete, come on. Look, I’m sorry. It was stupid. I shouldn’t do it. I know already.”

“Are you using condoms?”

“Of course.”

“Are you lying about that too?”

“No.”

Pete put his hand on her knee, watched it cover her thin leg, felt her warm under his touch. She put her hand over his.

“Pete, I really am sorry. I really do know how crazy this is.”

“Open your legs, Jess.”

“What?”

“Open your legs.”

“What—no, Pete. Why?”

“Prove he didn’t come in you.”

“Pete, don’t be gross. We’re using condoms.”

“Show me.”

“Pete, don’t be a pervert.”

“I’m serious. Fucking prove it to me. Show me.”

“No.”

“Jess, if you’re letting him fuck you without a condom, I swear, that’s it.”

Pete got his hand over her other knee and forced her legs apart. She resisted, but she didn’t fight him off. She was only trying to be difficult.

She rolled her eyes and looked up at the ceiling. Let him examine her.

He lowered his head to look up under her robe. Her pretty little pussy had been beaten up. She was shiny, reddened, her labia bruised and puckered. There was nothing leaking from her.

“Satisfied?”

“Thank you,” he said and let her knees go. She brought her legs together, adjusted her robe, laid it across her thighs again.

She seemed bothered. Shaking her head and bouncing her feet while they sat there not saying anything for a moment.

“We’ll talk about this later,” she said as she stood up again, holding the bottom of the robe to her so he wouldn’t see up it. She was mad at *him* now?

“Jess, you can have him over for dinner and fuck him any time in front of me. We can make arrangements, make sure the boys are—”

“Pick Andy up, please, it’s almost five.” She walked into the bedroom and closed the door behind her, left him sitting on the stairs.

He listened to her footsteps in the bedroom, he could hear Tyler say, *Uh-oh, somebody’s in trouble*, in a deep, chastising sing-song voice. Jess was laughing. *Somebody’s been a bad girl*, she said. The bed squeaked.

Jess enjoyed hurting him. The pain on this beautiful, sunny October afternoon was precise, acute. The worst, most profound humiliation she had ever delivered. Was it on purpose? A game of pain? Was she doing this for Pete? Obviously her own enjoyment—but was *any* of it for him, or was she only thinking of herself? I mean, this particular game required him coming home early. She couldn’t predict that. Was she hoping to be discovered, or was she really just fucking Tyler for sport? How did she figure her husband in this? Maybe she wasn’t.

God, he could lose her for real. He really could lose her for real.

PAS DE BOURÉE

THURSDAY, OCTOBER 6TH

Jess washed the sliding glass door with a wad of paper towels sprayed with generic window cleaner and Pete watched her carefully while he mowed the lawn. He walked slow behind the mower looking at her slim legs work. The way she moved, even just washing a window, you could tell she'd been a dancer.

She was wearing a pale blue tank top with spaghetti straps and shorts, her silky hair up in a twist. Her legs were graceful, muscular, and they worked an inadvertent sort of Pas De Bourrée while she cleaned.

What was she thinking right now? Was she thinking about the streaks she might be leaving, maybe Petey's little league in an hour... Or was it darker, dirtier? Was she thinking of all the things Tyler did to her—things that were so great she *had* to have them, even running around behind Pete's back and shunting the kids' schedules? What goes on in her head? How well can you really know someone?

Pete had given her his trust. He'd given her his darkest fears and secrets. The keys to his psyche. He'd really only known her for nine years. In the grand scheme of things how long was that really? People divorced all the time. She could go and tell all the people she knew that Pete had a little dick and he had fantasies about seeing his wife with better men. Embarrass him, how would he walk around town anymore? He'd have to move away.

Petey was pushing his little brother on the swing at the play-set, dressed and ready to go in his little league outfit. Pete shut the mower down and walked it back to the garden shed, wheeling it in and then pushing it off to

the side. He filled up the edge trimmer with the gas/oil mix, holding a cloth underneath so it wouldn't spill.

Thursday night, more nice weather, but the days were getting shorter. The sky above their well-kept house still bright but getting that deep haze as the sun started to descend. Pete Jr. had baseball in an hour. Minor 7 Fall Baseball, only two more games left in the season before it would be too dark for them to play in the evenings. Kid was no slugger but he had great fun out there, loved spending time with his friends.

Jess was watching him from the back door, standing outside on the concrete step in her bare feet. It stopped him dead. The light had crossed her glasses, put the reflection of the hazy sky across them so he couldn't see her eyes but her soft lips were spread in a gentle smile. Her hand came up and her fingers danced a little wave to him.

Jess would never hurt him for real. She would never leave him. She was his sweetheart. However it had come to be, whatever black magic he'd cast, they were meant to be together.

He'd give her what she wanted. He couldn't wait for her to get it. He moved to the back of the shed where she couldn't see him and he sat down on a squat barrel of fertilizer. He wanted to watch her again. He wanted to witness her ecstasy. He ran his hands through his hair, cradled his head, rested his elbows on his knees. God help him, he didn't know why, but he ached to watch her again with Tyler. Ached to see her small fingers and tiny nails scratch across that kid's muscular back as he fucked her.

PARTY CAKE

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 18TH

Boy, she had really messed up. It was two and a half weeks ago, but Pete was still feeling it. She had stuck a knife in him deeply that day. It was exquisite.

Jess fiddled with her glasses as she walked quickly down the busy hall of the school, headed for the staff parking, her long cardigan flowing behind her like a cape. She had a thousand things to do.

“Mom!” Petey’s little voice yelled behind her from the other end of the hall. She turned and saw him through the crowd of kids. She shook her head at him, smiling, and she put a finger up to her pursed lips to remind him not to be so loud, to be more polite in public. They met in the middle of the hall and Jess tossed her heavy school bag behind her hips so she could kneel down put her hand on his shoulder. She’d like to give him a kiss but he’d warned her about doing that to him at school. He did not like it.

“Sorry, Mom, I wanted to catch you before you got outside.”

“That’s fine, Petey. Are you going to Noah’s or are you coming home with me?”

“Noah’s mom’s here, I’m going with her...”

“Okay, Petey, but remember we’ve got dinner with your cousins tonight, so don’t be too late. You need to get cleaned up and changed before we go over. I need you home by five.”

He pulled away from her, pretty sure his mom might give him a kiss anyway, he said, “Okay, bye, Mom,” and trotted back up the hallway. She watched him disappear into the other students. He was getting so big, so grown up. She hated it.

Jess turned and got in the flow of students, hustled herself out to the parking and into her minivan. She threw her bag into the backseat and headed out into the throng of cars and buses. She needed cocoa and brown sugar to make her chocolate party cake for Pete's brother's memorial tonight. Pete and Patty held the memorial to honour their brother. Not on the day of his death but on his birthday, celebrating all the happy parties they had when they were kids. Pete and Jess and the boys would go to Patty and Russ's tonight and Jess would bring the dessert. It was always a good get-together, not usually sad, it was just a way to make sure they never forgot Michael.

Pete never really talked to her about Michael. Which was strange since she knew he suffered over it at times. One night when they were dating, just beginning to get to know each other, he'd told her when it came up in a natural conversation about siblings. He was matter of fact and the story was very sad, but he had seemed like he'd come to terms with it a long time ago. And he'd never talked about it since, never told her any details about his illness or fun stories about him when he was well. He would reference him occasionally and they had this wonderful memorial once a year, but he never discussed with her his feelings, his emotions on the loss. Sometimes she thought her Sweet-Pete kept things way too bottled up. She sometimes worried that there was a lot more pain in there that she didn't know about, that even Pete didn't realize.

Coming out of school and then turning out to the main road she got stuck in traffic, dwarfed in an armada of school buses. There were kids on her left trying to get her attention, waving their small hands in wide swaths. She smiled for them and waved back while they all waited for the light to change. She saw Kevin Campbell there, shy, behind Florencia Torres who drew her little finger across the glass in the shape of a heart. Fitting, she was going to be a real heart-breaker in a few years. Jess drew a heart for her as well then waved to them all as their bus pulled ahead a few lengths.

Pete was right. Everything he said that day he'd found her with Tyler was right. She actually couldn't be more sorry about that whole afternoon. Petey could have come home early, been a witness to something he wouldn't ever understand.

She'd sworn off Tyler. She had to. Fifteen days now without him. She'd seen him out and about, around the school, but she'd had no contact with him. She absolutely ached for him.

She knew she would fuck him again. She knew Pete would want to sit and watch them together again. No date had been set, they'd just been too busy. She was hoping for this weekend, or maybe even a day during the week. God, that could be horrible though. Having to stand and teach the following day, sit in her hard classroom chair, her little vagina throbbing. That last session had really left her hurting. It was all she could think about the next day, the pounding Tyler had given her when Pete wasn't watching, puttering around the house in soft sweatpants, her battered mound pulsing. Pete heard about it every chance she got. She had to hover over the toilet that day, couldn't put her tush down on it, and urinating was like passing liquid paper cuts. That kid fucked like a horse.

Jess went to the Kroger Marketplace on Sycamore and it was busy, she had to park near the back. She walked past Patty's Honda Odyssey, knew it by the stick figure family in the corner of the back window. There was a hold-up at the door as an elderly man backed up with an empty cart, struggling to pull it free from the long line of other carts it was filed into. His wife was in a scooter and she was blocking the way, the automatic doors still held open by her weight on the sensor. Young guy in a baseball hat in front of her was mad, looking up into the high roof, at the white metal girders, shaking his head because he couldn't believe his luck.

Jess laughed and stepped around him and she tried to help the older man pull the cart free but it was really stuck. The younger guy helped out now, seeing someone else's simple kindness, and he pulled a rock out of the cart's wheel well that had been stopping it. Jess thanked him and touched his arm and she could tell he felt better about his day now. She picked up a basket, then turned, put it back down and took a cart for herself. She might as well grab some more items while she was here. Maybe put off a big shopping for a few more days.

There had been that one and only time after school that she and Tyler had got together, made love after work. She fibbed to Pete, and she was delighted that the opportunity had fallen in her lap. She hadn't planned on fabricating other times, lying to Pete and telling him that they'd done it before, but she couldn't help it. Pete looked so weak on the stairs. So vulnerable. She got such an incredible thrill from insinuating that she and Tyler had been doing this for a while. The hurt was a palpable force in the stairwell that day. Seeing his physical reaction, the horror in him as he tried to control his emotions, made her flutter. He loved her so much, she was

everything to him. She had *all* the power. Enough power to take on a lover. *Quiet, demure Mrs. Mapplethorpe had a lover.*

Jess saw Patty standing over by the hot dogs and lunch meats. Patty looked lost, staring at the rows of processed meat, unmoving. Pete and Patty's brother Michael had died of leukaemia when he was sixteen. That was twenty-three years ago, but right now it looked like the weight of that loss was across her shoulders. It could have been something else, it could have been nothing, but Jess thought she would leave her alone, she had a lot of weird thoughts of her own on her mind. She looked down into her cart, pretended she had never seen her. They'd all be together in a few hours anyway.

Brown sugar was on sale so she grabbed a second bag. She found the cocoa and then got some more milk and cereal for the boys, some toiletries for Pete. She was pretty sure they needed lunch meat so she headed for the butcher. There was a line up there and she thought to just grab some generic pre-packs but Pete really liked his black forest ham.

Pete inspecting her that day, sitting on the stairs and having her bare legs spread open, looking for traces of Tyler's semen in her—it turned her on like she hadn't expected. She was a very naughty girl. She was being inspected for badness.

It backfired on Pete because now at night when she lay thinking about all this, she couldn't shake that idea out of her head. She wanted Tyler to come inside her. Now more than ever. Hadn't really been a thing to her until she saw Pete's sweet face, his worried brow, inspecting the injured sex of the woman he loved, hoping, praying, her big-dick lover didn't ejaculate inside her. Another man coming inside her had to be the biggest violation. What could be more forbidden than Tyler planting his seed inside Pete's wife? It would crush Pete. Tyler's young, healthy seed swimming around in his wife's belly, sprayed so deeply inside her by his incredible penis. She was obsessed with the idea—thinking of what it would feel like to have his big cock go off inside her, feel it splashing her cervix with his hot sperm. It made her weak in the knees.

She left her cart at the butcher counter, followed an arrow to the ladies' room. She got past the swinging door without touching it with her bare hands and she closed herself in the stall that was farthest from the door. There had been a woman washing her hands, she'd be gone in a minute, but there were feet on the floor in the stall next to her. She couldn't wait. She

slipped her panties down and sat on the toilet seat. She tinkled, fumbled through her purse and brought out her phone. She swiped through the menus with her thumb. Her hand was shaking. She found the image she was looking for. Tyler on his knees hovering over her in her own bedroom. She'd laid on the bed, admiring his beautiful body, and then without asking she'd reached to the bedside table lifted her phone and snapped a picture. Tyler had let her, she could see him flexing a little. He had looked so good in that afternoon light. The sun streaming through their bedroom window and lighting up all the edges of his muscle.

She dabbed herself with toilet paper, dropped it into the water. She rested the phone on her knee, pinched it with her left hand, tilted it so she could see it. Her right hand brushed her thigh, teased herself coming up the inside of it now, she waited to feel her own touch. She trembled when she found it. She was so wet. Her finger stroked up the centre, teasing it, making all her warm surfaces slippery with her excitement. She gasped, inhaled softly as she sunk her middle finger inside herself slowly. She let it go deep, felt herself kiss her own finger, swallow it up until her knuckle bumped her. She curved it forward, stroked her soft insides, listened to the squishing. How could she have got herself so wet on a weekday, 4 P.M. in the grocery store, hours before a memorial for her husband's deceased brother? When did she get so awful?

Her finger worked inside her, she knew how to please herself. She swivelled her hips in circles, working around her plunging and tickling finger. She gasped again, let it out slow and quiet. She bored a hole into the picture of her lover. His big, hard body lit up in yellow from the window, bright white painted along his shining edges; his hard ridged abdomen, his slabs of chest muscle, his dark tight nipples. Then down, looking down where a married woman with two kids shouldn't be looking, his young, rock hard cock. It was raging, seconds before he stretched a condom over it and fucked her with it. It was bare naked, crossed with thick veins that gave it life. The head of it plump, the skin pulled tight on it, aching to push into her.

"Aunghm," she blurted and then seized up, her heels dragged on the polished floor, making a loud squeak. *Oh, no*, she was going to come in here, a woman right next to her dropping a number two.

"Awaahh," she warbled, then pulled her lips into her mouth trying to shut herself up. She came hard on her finger, thrusting it into her wet

mound now in a frenzy. She shut her eyes, using her mind to recall that moment he'd taken it, pushed it into place with his thumb and then drove it inside her. Her toes scrunched up in her flats, the left one falling right off her foot, she hunched forward, seized so hard her stomach muscles cramped and she winced in pain. She had come three times that afternoon before Pete had come home. Three incredible orgasms after a long day of work. Tyler made her so happy. She needed him, needed to be with him and she didn't know if she could even make it another day without having him inside her.

TEACHER'S LOUNGE

WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 19TH

Jess drove past the high school secretly hoping she'd see Tyler out in the field and then wished she hadn't. He *was* there, he saw her, and he waved. She felt busted. And compelled.

She was on her way home from her school at 1 P.M. and thought she might take the way around past Brady Byron, *Geez, you never know, you could just catch a glimpse of someone special*. She had a half day, her kids went to a Spanish event with another class, some festival in Columbus and a lunch serving some authentic cuisine. She was going to catch up on some paperwork and thought she might as well do it at home.

Now she felt like this was going to be a big mistake. The turn signal was on before she knew it and she pulled into the parking lot. Tyler was running some boys, dressed in sweatshirts and sweatpants, but running with their football helmets on. It was pretty crisp out and she could see the clouds of their breath. She nosed the minivan into a parking spot right up against the chain link, the grassy field just on the other side.

Tyler stood and watched her, his arms folded across his broad chest. He was smiling. She smiled back for him, sitting in her car, watching. The boys ran past him again, their young bodies steaming in the cold. He encouraged them, slapped some shoulders. He was bundled up, looking massive in a tight sweatshirt with the Brady Byron Cougar, the hood bunched up around his thick neck. Still wearing shorts, even though it was late October.

The sun was shining but it wasn't warm out there. It was one of the most beautiful autumns she could remember. So many sunny days, it was hard to believe winter was just around the corner.

Tyler nodded his head to the side, towards the building. *Come inside, come see me.*

She knew she shouldn't. She shouldn't be seen with him. But she wanted to talk to him. She wanted to be near him. Frankly, she wanted to fuck him. She wouldn't of course, not here. She *should* make a date. She should go in and find out when they can meet again. With Pete. *Let's do it this weekend. We will make it happen.*

Now she was excited. This wasn't some infatuated stalking incident. She was here with a purpose. She wasn't messing around behind Pete's back, she was here to arrange something. A time where Tyler could do it to her while Pete watches. Her life had become quite strange. She laughed as she undid her seatbelt and got out of the van.

The boys were running back into the gym, heading for the locker room. Tyler marched along behind them writing something down on his clipboard.

Jess crossed the lot, went to the front doors, meant to pass through the admin offices like a visitor was supposed to then stopped short, her hand on the glass door ready to enter. The place was quiet, everyone in class at the moment. She changed her mind, walked down to the end of the building and came in through the side, into the double doors that lead to the stairwell. No one saw her. The halls were quiet, the only noises coming from the classrooms on either side of her. She felt suddenly very wicked. She tried to shake it off. She'd walked into this school a hundred times. She wasn't here for anything dirty. Just here to talk to a friend. Something within her, however, wanted her to keep this a secret.

Tyler was at the end of the hall now, he held a hand up to her, watched her come to him. She looked down at what she was wearing. Conscious of her demure garb. Was she attractive to him like this? Her hair was up in a bun, she was wearing her big, black-framed glasses. Her skirt was long, almost right to the floor. She had a cotton shirt with a Victorian collar, buttoned right up. God, she was wearing a cardigan. He watched her the whole way down the long hall.

"Hi," he said as she stepped up to him, not too close.

"Hi," she said back, she couldn't help her smile spreading wide.

Tyler held the door for her, and she walked into the teacher's lounge. He followed her in. The place was empty, they were the only ones in there. She had her back to him, bit her lower lip, this felt like a big mistake.

"How do you take your coffee?" he asked her.

“Black, one cream,” she said, getting the nerve to turn to him.

He poured two mugs full of black coffee, added a splash of cream to one. He was smiling, confident. Looking over at her then back down as he put the cream back.

“I’ve missed you,” he said.

She looked around, felt nervous even though she knew they were alone.

Tyler leaned back against the counter the coffee maker sat on. He looked really good. Too good. A cartoon ghost loomed over his shoulder, its big sad black eyes watching Jess. Reminding everyone else that there was a Halloween Dance this weekend.

She said, “I’ve missed you too.”

He brought the coffees over, set them on the table. She sat down in a swivelling chair, looped a finger through the handle.

Tyler sat next to her, the chair squeaking under his weight. “I’ve been thinking about you.”

He made her blush and she smiled, looked away. Looked into her coffee cup. “I’ve been thinking about you too.”

“You have?”

“A lot,” she said. She looked up at him, she was trembling. How honest should she be? Should she tell him she masturbated in a grocery store bathroom yesterday? That she had to run in there and get it done after thinking about what it would be like to feel him come inside her. She couldn’t—that was too embarrassing.

He sipped his coffee while he watched her play with her cup. There was a bowl of molasses candy in the centre of the table and she pulled it over, took one out and fiddled with the orange wrapper.

“Were you in trouble?” he asked her.

“Yes.”

“It’s okay?”

“Yeah, it’s fine now. We can have sex,” she said, looked up at him, reassuring him, “he was...we made him feel left out. He didn’t like that.”

She could sense him nodding next to her.

“I’d like to see you again,” she said.

“Yeah?”

“You know, have you over for dinner.”

He nodded some more. “I’d like that.”

“Can we do it this weekend?”

“I don’t know—”

“I need it this weekend,” she said, seriously, hoping to sound sexy, but she could hear desperation in her own voice. Maybe he found desperation sexy.

“Saturday?”

“I’ll make it work,” she said. She felt relieved. Relieved and then instantly anxious. Like a countdown had just been set. Happy it was going to be done but now she had to watch the seconds click dreadfully past while she was driven out of her mind waiting.

“Pete’ll be there, right?”

“Oh, yeah. He wants to keep an eye on me now. Keep an eye on us.” She smirked, still fiddling with the candy, watching it in her fingers. “You’re still okay with that?”

He looked at her over his coffee, inhaled deeply. “I’ll take you whatever way I can.”

She blushed again, looked away. She tossed the candy back in the bowl, didn’t want him to think she was a fidget. She sipped the hot coffee, swivelled her chair to face him.

Tyler was leaning back in his chair his legs stretched out in front of him, one over the other. His big tattooed fingers circled his mug, and he looked over it at her with his light blue eyes.

He got her fidgeting again, spinning her chair in circles, back and forth in tiny movements, making it creak.

“How do you hide that thing in those shorts?” she asked him. She thought his bulge would be huge the way he was sitting.

“It’s not always hard you know.”

She laughed, covered her mouth with her hand.

Tyler pulled his shorts up tight, spread his legs a bit for her. He got the front of his shorts up against his package, presented it to her, showing her his impressive shape under the fabric.

“Okay,” she said, “I’ve just never seen it when it’s not hard.”

“It’s smaller,” he said. Then he thought about it a moment, rolled his chair next to hers so that their elbows were touching, both of them with their backs to the door. He stretched out the waistband, pushed the shorts out so she could see inside.

Jess leaned into him, curious, peeked into his shorts to see what it looked like. His sleeping cock was curled up in his lap like a pale banana.

“That’s not small at all.”

“Small-*er*, I said.”

Jess put her hand into his shorts, she wanted to feel it. It was soft and surprisingly cold under her fingers.

“That’s really big,” she said. She rolled the head of his cock between her thumb and forefinger, ran the tips down his shaft, then wrapped her fingers around it, lifted it off his leg. She tried to stroke it but it wanted to slip out of her hand. She reached down between his legs and grabbed his balls. They were loose, heavy in her grip.

She looked back at the door, pulled his flaccid cock out of his shorts. She looked back down, looked at his thing in her hand. She lowered herself to it, put the head past her lips and sucked on it. It felt so funny in her mouth. Soft and squishy, squirming around, but just so darn big. She sucked it in deeper, liked the feel of it on her tongue. Tyler’s hand rubbed her back. He smelled like a powerful deodorant soap.

She used her fingers and tried to stuff as much of that soft meat in her mouth, couldn’t get it all in there. She picked a ball up and popped it in her mouth instead, sucked on it, rolled it around and let it drop, then back over the end of his cock. She thought about his cleanliness. She didn’t really know him. Didn’t know his past, kind of assumed he might have been with a lot of girls. But he wasn’t hard, nothing was going to come out of him, right? Like sucking on his finger. She sucked on him more, the soft thing starting to take some shape in her mouth, getting more workable. She gripped his balls, played with them, bobbing her head on his soft, heavy cock. She pulled off him, letting a loud suction from her lips. She had to stop, he was getting hard and she didn’t want him leaking in her mouth.

She picked it up, stroked it, using her spit. “I can’t wait for Saturday,” she said, got herself close to him.

“I can tell.”

“Tell me what you’re going to do to me.”

“I’m going to bend you over, fuck you from behind like an animal,” his voice was breathy but deep, like a rumble.

“Oh, yeah?” she gasped, she had soaked her panties, she could feel it down there.

“I’m going to make you scream, I’m going to make you come a hundred times on the end of this cock.”

“Oh, God,” she looked down at it in her hand. He was pretty hard. Too big to be real. She couldn’t believe he’d been putting this inside her. She stroked him, her fist just working his head, rolling around it, squishing it.

“I’m going to make Pete shrivel up and die when he sees what I do to you, how I make you come.”

“He’s not even a tenth of the man you are,” she whispered to him.

“Oh, stop, stop, stop,” he said. He wrapped his big hand around her little wrist, stopped her stroking him.

“I can’t hide it if you make me hard.”

“You are hard,” she said.

“Mm. I am,” he said. He held her wrist tight, fucked her fist gently, doing it with his hips. They both watched him force her little hand apart, pushing his manhood through her grip.

“I can make it go down for you,” she whispered, looked into his eyes.

Tyler chewed his lower lip. “Come on,” he said.

He stood up, pointed his cock upright on his belly, pulled the strings of his shorts, cinching it up against him, dropped his sweatshirt over it. He looked at her.

She nodded, she couldn’t see it.

He opened the door of the lounge, looked down the hall, “Okay, let’s go,” he said, waving her towards him. She took her glasses off, put them in her purse, followed him down the hall, their movement ranging from suspicious, to stealthy, to normal. Quick-stepping, slowing, ducking. He got her to the end of the hall, checked into the boys locker room. He nodded his head for her to follow him.

She couldn’t go into the boys room.

“I can’t go in the locker room,” she whispered, still standing in the hall.

“My office is through here. It’s empty. Come on.”

She looked around nervously. *This was crazy.*

“Okay,” she said, slipping in behind him.

They rushed through the locker room, the place stinking with boy smell. Open lockers, stuff strewn out, equipment, towels, she didn’t want to look around—like this was a private place even though it was empty. He stopped at the next room, some sort of conference area, tables and chairs facing a whiteboard with running plans. He looked around the corner. “Come on,” he said and he took her hand.

She could see an open office ahead, they were almost there. He got her in, closed the door behind him.

He turned to her, they were face to face. She pulled him to her, kissed him, he pushed her away, "Hold on," he said.

He crossed the small room, went behind his desk. There was a door on the other side and he opened it, looked out. Daylight out there, out onto the field probably. He looked around, watched something out there for a moment, then he shut the door said, "Okay," pulled up on the bar, locked it.

Jess grabbed the handle of the door they'd just come through.

"This door doesn't lock," she said.

"Come here," he said, standing behind the desk.

She went around behind it, let him pull her to him with his massive arms. He crushed her against him, she could feel his cock under his sweatshirt, hard against her body. He kissed her, gripped the back of her neck, pulled her tight, and forced his tongue deep into her mouth. She sucked it in.

Jess pulled her long skirt up, got her hands under it, hooked her thumbs into her panties and slid them down. She picked them up and threw them in her purse, didn't want him to see them, they were a bit worn, definitely not sexy.

His hands went up her skirt now, bunching all the extra fabric around her waist. His touch was amazing. He went straight between her legs, not time for teasing.

"Oh, shit," he said, "you are so fucking wet. Jess, you're dripping."

She had her hands under his sweatshirt her hands running over his rock hard stomach. She could feel his erection like hot steel against her wrist.

"Get a condom," she said. She had no time for teasing either.

"You don't have a condom?"

"Oh, please, no. Tyler, why would I have a condom? You don't have any condoms?"

"I don't have sex at school."

"Well, I don't either. Don't you put one in your wallet?" She was panicking.

"It's okay, Jess, sit up on the desk here, I swear I won't come inside you."

That made her tingle.

"Oh, Tyler, I can't."

“C’mon, Jess, I swear I’ll pull out.”

She didn’t want to say it was more than that, didn’t want to ruin the mood by saying she wasn’t sure where he’s been, how clean he was.

“I just can’t, Tyler.”

Tyler grabbed the back of her neck, gripped a handful of her hair that had fallen out of the bun, he said, “Jess, I have to fuck you.”

“I need you so bad right now,” she said. She stroked him, felt how ready he was in her fist. She could barely close her fingers around it. “Oh, Tyler, I need this so bad.”

He lifted her up and put her on his desk, yanked her skirt out of the way. He lifted her like she was weightless.

“I just can’t, Tyler,” she whispered into his ear.

Tyler’s big hands pushed her thighs apart and she let him do it. Her soaking wet sex was exposed to his big manhood. He kissed her again, she put her arms around his neck. His cock was hot against her thigh. It was sliding up, getting closer to her heat. Her pussy ached for him, she would risk it, he could bury that naked cock deep inside her, she could find out what it really felt like. It would feel amazing. She knew it would feel amazing. He could pull out. What was the worst that could really happen?

She felt his hot tip at her labia. She opened her legs for him, leaned back so she could watch his unprotected cock slide inside her.

“Oh, baby, we shouldn’t,” she gasped but her legs didn’t close.

He gripped it in his fist, stroked the tip against her.

“No, Tyler, don’t. We shouldn’t,” she said but still her legs stayed spread. She wanted it so bad.

“Just the tip,” he said.

“Okay, just the tip,” God she was fifteen again.

He pushed gently into her, struggling not to lose control and plunge it deep. She watched the glistening head, rosy-grey, part her lips. Heard the wet crackle as he penetrated her with his huge glans.

“Oh no, no, no,” she said. She grabbed it, stopped it from sinking into her. “I can’t, Tyler, I can’t.” She closed her thighs on him, arched her back so her sex was flat on his desk. Her fingers were working the buttons of her shirt, moving through them one after the other. She got her top open, got her arms bent behind her working under her shirt, unclasping her bra.

Tyler watched her, stroking himself. His face was taut, angry. He had one thing on his mind.

Jess plopped herself down into his chair, gave him her best sultry look. She wanted her man happy.

“Let’s make you come,” she said. Her fingers danced around her hardened nipples, thrilled them, showed him how aroused she was. She pushed her breasts together, let him know what she was thinking. “Come here,” she said.

He stepped forward, straddled her legs that she had kept closed together. His cock loomed over her, threatening. He was ready to burst. So hard his skin was stretched taut, his cock head gleaming. She put a hand over the wide top of it, guided its hot belly between her breasts. Enormous. Balls below her breasts, tip coming up past her chin. It didn’t work as well as she’d hoped. They were both dry. She worried about pleasing him. She spit on the head, took it in her fist and covered it. She squeezed him, coaxing some of his lubricant from him. He closed his eyes, let it pulse. Now she had him slippery, it was going to be okay. She pushed him down between her breasts again, pinched her nipples, closed her flesh around it. He started to thrust it between them, slowly at first, testing the feel of her.

“That’s it, baby,” she said, “fuck them.”

She had him breathing heavy now.

“Show me that body, baby,” she said. He pulled his sweatshirt over his head, threw it aside. He was gorgeous. His stomach rippled as he worked himself between her breasts. She watched the big glistening end come up to meet her, slide back down and disappear between her breasts. His huge tattooed arms came to her, his hands gripped her small shoulders, held her steady.

“You feel so good,” he moaned.

“You like fucking my tits?” she asked him.

“You’re going to make me come,” he said.

“Are you going to come in my face?” She looked up at him, her eyes expectant. Play-acting, but God, she was just so aroused too. She wanted him to come, wanted it to be huge and hot.

“Mm—yes,” he said, he was so close.

She had him in a trance now. Hard and horny.

“Do it,” she urged, “come all over my face.”

He got quicker, he was going to come.

She prayed he didn’t get it in her eyes or in her hair, but she did want him to come, wanted to hear him roar out because she had done it to him.

“Show me that come, make this big thing shoot all over me, make me—”

The door opened, three people walking in from the conference room.

Before she dove, before she threw herself flat on the floor, she was aware, not sure, but had an awareness, that it was two students and a teacher. It happened very fast.

Someone gasped, someone said, *Oh, my God.*

The door to the outside was opened, daylight hitting her in the face, making her blink. Tyler above her, shoving the door open. His shoe was kicking her in the behind, forcing her out the door. She alligator-crawled, fell outside the lip, down two steps onto concrete. The door slammed behind her. She was sitting by the football field. Her purse was still in there. Her glasses.

Then she jumped up and ran. Ran in a straight line away from the building. Towards the woods. Ran faster than she ever had in her life. Legs pumping until she thought her heart would burst. Fifty yards, across grass, students on the field, far from her, not looking. She got to the edge of the field. Houses, suburbs beyond that. Woods, trees. She launched herself onto an eight-foot-tall chain link fence, pulled herself over it, fell to the other side.

She looked back, saw the school, saw the door she'd come from. It opened. A woman. Angry, looking out and around. Jess rolled herself under a shrub. Her heart was pounding, her mind racing. *What the fuck had she just done?* Her heaving breaths became sobs as the realization came over her. This was real. This really happened.

“Oh, God,” she sobbed. “Oh, no.”

The door closed again and she jumped up. She was in someone's backyard. She ran down the side of the house, tears streaming from her. She buttoned her shirt as she ran, her breasts swinging around underneath it without a bra.

“Oh, no, oh, no,” she cried. She ran down the sidewalk, didn't even know where she was going. She was going to lose her job. What would Pete think? What about the rumours? What would the boys hear about their mother?

What was wrong with her?

OWING HIM

THURSDAY, OCTOBER 20TH

Pete knew something was wrong with his wife. Very wrong. Something had happened and it was huge. He knew since last night when he'd come home and she'd ruined dinner. No explanation, just said she wasn't paying attention, had burned it. He didn't press her. Her face was drawn, hollow. She looked ill. Maybe she was coming down with something.

Pete went out and picked up KFC for them and she didn't have a bite of anything he brought back. She said she wasn't feeling well and he said she should go lie down, told her he'd take care of the boys. She went to bed, must have been eight o'clock. He'd thought she was getting a flu.

So he stayed up with the boys and they had their chicken and they watched some TV. He took them down and they messed around with the trains for a while. Made some more sagebrushes. He put them to bed, stayed up to watch The Bachelor, the news, then packed it in around eleven.

He tiptoed around the room, trying not to disturb Jess, poor girl not feeling well. She was awake. He could see her in the dark of the room, dim light from the master bath, her eyes were open. Staring into nothing.

He asked her if she was okay, and she said, Yes, then closed her eyes. That's when he thought this was no flu. Something bad had happened.

He got a little nervous. Hated the idea that something was bothering her. He washed up and climbed in behind her, put an arm around her and hugged her. She pushed her back into him, hugged his hand over her heart. He fell asleep like that.

He didn't remember until morning, then wasn't sure if he'd dreamt it, made it up, but he could recall an idea that she had got up in the middle of

the night and had used her phone. Had talked to somebody. That's all that he was aware of.

Then it was morning and he watched her, dressed for work, shuffling around the kitchen like she was in pain. Mental anguish. He could sense she wanted to talk, wait for the boys not to be around. Pete had to get to work. He kissed her forehead before he left, she was clammy. He stopped at the door. He said, "Call me if you need me today."

She smiled at him weakly and nodded.

Now it was five and the boys were in the backyard. Jess was in the kitchen and he could tell they needed to have a talk. His heart was pounding.

"What is it, Jess?"

She sat across from him, her hands folded together resting on their kitchen table. She had her glasses on, her hair looked stringy, lifeless, her shoulders a worried slope swooping away from her thin neck. "You're going to be mad."

She was pregnant. That was what hit him. She'd been fooling around, lying about using condoms and now she'd got herself pregnant. "What is it?" he asked her. Not mad, not mean; he was worried.

She covered her mouth with her thin pale hand, struggling with a way to tell him something.

"Oh, no, Jess."

"I stopped by the high school the other day. Ran into Tyler. We were fooling around—we didn't have sex, Pete, I swear, but we were...we were messing around and we got caught."

"Oh."

"I know Pete, I didn't mean to, I wasn't thinking about it, it just happened."

"Oh no," he said, feeling the blood drain from him. His vision narrowed. This was really bad. "Who saw you?"

"I don't think anyone saw me."

"Oh, Jess. Oh, no, what's going to happen?"

"Tyler got me out without anyone seeing me. I think."

"Are you sure no one saw you?"

"Pretty sure."

"So know one knows it was you?"

"I don't think so."

It was a relief. He thought everyone would know his wife had stepped out on him, that she went around behind his back. A public cuckolding. She wasn't caught at all. "What were you doing?"

"Messing around."

"Specifically."

"I'd rather not say."

"Tell me what you were doing."

"Can we play your stupid cuckolding games another time? We're talking about my job here. Tyler's job."

She was mad at him. He wasn't looking for dirty talk, he wanted to know what someone might have witnessed. "Your job?"

"I think it's okay. I was so worried but I don't think anyone knows it was me."

"Please, tell me your job is okay."

"I was at work today and no one said a thing. And everyone was talking about what happened at the high school."

"Oh, no, Jess."

"Yeah, it's all the gossip."

"I'm sorry, Jess." He took her hand in his, held it.

"So..." There was more.

"Yes?"

She paused, exhaled. "Tyler was fired."

"That's terrible."

"He was fired and it was my fault."

"Your fault?"

"I'm sorry, Pete. I...I was the instigator, really. I'm sorry."

What had become of Jess, when had she turned into someone he hardly knew? "It's okay, Jess." He slid his chair around so he could sit next to her, put an arm around her. She leaned into him, let him squeeze her to him.

"You know, he got me out of there before they could see my face. He held a door open and he shoved me out with his foot, slammed it shut and wouldn't let them open it until I had time to run away. He wouldn't tell them who it was. He thinks they think it was a student."

"Oh, that's awful."

"He hid my purse, I'd left it there. Anyway, they let him go—fired him. He left, then snuck back, took my van and drove it out of there before

classes let out and it was the only one there. Someone might have figured who had run off with the blonde hair.”

“They know it was a blonde?”

She nodded.

He held her head to his chest and stroked her hair. “We’ll get through this,” he told her. “We’ll get through this.”

“I saw him today. Talked to him.”

“Is that a good idea?”

“It’s fine. If I act like I can’t be seen with him that would be worse.”

“Maybe.”

“I saw him. He brought my purse, my glasses,” she said, touching the arm of her glasses. “I had a coffee with him over at the Dunkin’ Donuts.”

“How’s he holding up?”

“Not good. Not good at all. He really needed that job. *Really* needed it.”

Shouldn’t have messed around with my wife then when I wasn’t there.

“Sorry to hear that.”

“Yeah, he has no savings, he was paying down some debts. He can’t even afford his rent.”

“How long does he have?”

“No time. He was already behind.”

“Well, Jess, I don’t think we have much to give him. I mean, it also sounds like he’s a terrible person to lend money to.”

“I told him he could stay here.”

“You what?”

“Told him he could stay here. Use our guest room until he’s back on his feet.”

“No way.”

“Just a few weeks, Pete. A few weeks, tops.”

“With our kids here?”

“What else can he do?”

“He could leave town.”

“He has nothing right now. No credit. Nothing. We can’t let him just...we can’t let him do that.” She was pleading with him, her eyes were tearing up.

“Jess, baby. That’s crazy.”

“Please, he saved me. Saved my job.”

“So, you’re going to be the blonde girl who helps him after he gets fired for sleeping with some mystery blonde girl on school grounds? Come on, Jess, be sensible. People will assume it’s you.”

“No, they won’t. Not me. No one will think it’s me. I’m not the type. And if I get out in front of it, unashamed, indignant, it might go a longer way to convincing people it wasn’t me.”

“They wouldn’t consider you in the first place.”

“It’s not impossible.”

“Well, no. Not impossible.”

“Pete, he’s moving in.”

“Jess...”

“Pete, he’s moving in on Saturday and he’s going to stay for a few weeks. I won’t put my hands on him. The kids won’t see that.”

“Jess.”

“Pete. 2 P.M. Saturday, I rented him a U-Haul. I have to do the right thing.”

Pete let her go, put his hands over his face, ran them over his scalp. His heart was pounding.

What the fuck was going on here?

PART IV

LETTING HIM IN

VAMPIRE

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 22ND

Pete had picked up the moving van at the U-Haul and Self-Storage Place out on East Fifth Avenue. Guy at the counter looked at his computer screen, said, “No Mr. Mapplethorpe here...wait...*Jess* Mapplethorpe—I talked to her. That your wife?”

“Sure, sure. Yeah, my wife booked it all right.” His stomach had tightened right there, hadn’t thought it could get tighter. Pictured his quiet, shy wife calling this place, booking a van to move her lover in under his roof.

He still couldn’t believe this was happening. Didn’t she see how crazy this was? He understood how she felt responsible, but couldn’t she help in another way? There was no way this was going to work, all three of them living together. This was going to be the hardest couple of weeks of his life.

The dolly he’d rented rattled around in the back as he turned onto Tyler’s street, Jess’s handwritten instructions open on the seat next to him. The dolly rolled on its wheels, bumped into the back of Pete’s seat. Shouldn’t someone there have thought of fucking strapping that down before they gave him the keys?

He saw Tyler up ahead standing at the end of a driveway, talking to some woman. This was a town-home complex, narrow units plugged into a long row of Victorian peaked roofs, grey slate shingle over light grey brick. The woman was standing next to Tyler, looking up at him, unashamed of the infatuation lighting up her face. The doe-eyed eye-batting, the smile, showing him her white teeth. He could just hear it: *Oh, Tyler, we’re going to miss you around here, you’ll have to stay in touch.* She probably watched

his window looking to see him without his shirt. Shit, they might be fucking. They probably were fucking. She was probably married too.

Pete drove past them, stopped and put it in reverse. He watched the mirror while he backed it up. Couldn't see them. He inched back. Someone slapped the side of the van and he stopped. Tyler was in the side mirror now, looking at the back of the van, holding his arm up, wagging his pointed finger, telling him to move forward—try it again. What the fuck? He was doing fine. It was a wide driveway. Pete moved it forward, then pushed the gear up again, into reverse. Watched the mirror, Tyler waving him back now looking over and chatting with the woman. Turned and said, *Whoa*, gave him a stop hand. Shook his head and pointed him to go forward again. Was he fucking with him? Pete did it again, forward then into reverse. Tyler waved him back, stepped aside, watched the wheels. Lucky he stepped aside, because if he told him to move forward again Pete might have kept going, gunned it and flattened him. Tyler shook his head like he guessed that was as good as Pete could do, he heard him yell out, *Okay*.

He put it in park and got out. Tyler was close to the woman, whispering something to her. She was pretty. Looked like she could be a mom. Looked like she could be married.

"We're really going to miss you around here," she said. *Oh, my God. Big surprise.*

They kissed cheeks and she gave him a dreamy look then went back up her driveway.

"That's my neighbour," he told Pete.

"Yeah? You all boxed up?"

"Sure," Tyler said, "come on," turning and walking up the driveway, waving for Pete to follow. Pete caught up with him at the front door. "I sold a lot of my stuff. Most of it. We just have to move the things I needed to keep." He opened the front door and followed him into the place that Tyler had been living in. It was kind of sad. He felt a bit for the kid. Looking around the space he used to come home to until his wife had ruined that. Maybe it wasn't entirely Tyler's fault. Shit, he knew that, though. It wasn't, was it? His wife had changed. She maybe had ruined this kid's life. Maybe she was right to help him. If Jess wanted it, what kind of twenty-five-year-old could keep it in his pants? If Jess made the first move was it Tyler's fault he let her?

The place was bare. About a dozen different sized boxes just inside the door. Plain white walls, bare wood floors, a cable stuck out of the wall where his TV must have been.

“This is it?”

“Yeah. I sold my TV, my kitchen stuff. Threw out a lot too. I sold my bed since I’ll be using yours.”

Our guest bed, right kid?

Sad he had to sell off his stuff like that. Sold his bed. Pete looked around the place, hands in his pockets. Did you fuck my sweet Jess on that bed you sold? He wondered if she’d ever been here before. Behind his back. She wrote out the directions in her pretty Bic cursive. She knew where Tyler lived. Had she ever come here after work, taken a session like he heard that day coming from his own bedroom?

“Hey, man, it’s really cool of you to let me move in.”

“Yeah, yeah.”

“It’s a little crazy I know. Everything I’ve done with her.”

Pete swallowed, temples aching.

“Pretty big of you.” Tyler slapped him hard on the shoulder, twice. His hand was heavy, resting on his shoulder, felt like he was trying to push Pete down to his knees. Subconsciously.

“Right, let’s just get the van loaded. Get going,” Pete said.

Tyler slapped him hard again right on his collarbone, it made his brain jostle.

They loaded the van in silence, and for every box Pete carried, Tyler carried three. There were some weights there and he left that to Tyler. Stood and watched him carry three big rubber plates at a time, carry his bar out to the van, some cannonballs with handles on them.

“That’s it all?” Pete said, standing on the driveway, hands on his hips. He wasted his money on the dolly. Tyler wasn’t even huffing, he said, “Yeah, we’re all packed up.”

“All right, I’m going to go home.” He got out the keys to the van, glad Tyler was going to be on his bike. What the fuck would they talk about sitting in the van driving across town together?

Tyler said, "I'll catch up. I wanna take a walk around. Old time's sake. Make sure I didn't miss anything."

Jess told the boys last night about Tyler coming to stay with them. Pete and Jess sitting in the family room, palms sweating, struggling through that awkward conversation.

She'd explained to them that someone was going to come and stay with them for a little while. A friend of your Mommy and Daddy's. Just for a few weeks.

Poor boys had picked up on their nervousness. Could tell something was up. This wasn't going to be some party. Not Jess's fun cousin coming in from Italy and staying, keeping up the boys all night with her hilarious stories. Pete and Jess felt weird about it and they wiped those germs right on the boys.

They bounced a ball on the driveway. A big faded yellow ball, like a melon, making that hollow sound as Petey bounced it to Andy, teaching him to catch. Being so gentle and kind to his baby brother. Jess paced the asphalt, waiting for them to show up. This was without a doubt the absolute weirdest day of her life. It put the absolute weirdest feeling in her belly too. She didn't know what it was. Jury was out. Sickness, excitement, sadness, happiness? Arousal, horniness, disgust? Maybe it was all those things rolled into one like a tense ball of rubber bands, every band a different colour. Sitting now heavy in the space below her heart.

She heard Tyler's bike. One band got tighter: excitement.

"Here he is, boys. This is Tyler." They stopped and watched the bike coming down the street, gearing down, getting louder. Petey said, *Wow*.

Tyler came up the driveway, pulled off to the side out of the way, put his foot down and turned the bike off. Her boys were mesmerized. She knew the feeling.

He took his helmet off, laid it in his lap, said, "Hey, kids," smiling down at them, his voice deep but friendly.

They both said, *Hi*. Shy and quiet. Andy looked back up at her.

"Boys, this is Tyler." She squat down with them, said, "This is Andy," ruffled his hair, "and this is Pete Junior, he's our oldest. He's Seven."

"I'm five," Andy said.

"Andy's five," Jess laughed.

Tyler got off his bike and rested the helmet on his seat. He got down knee to knee with Jess and faced her boys.

"Do you know how old I am?"

They both shook their heads, watching him with open, curious eyes.

"Can you guess?"

"Twenty?" Petey said.

"Not even close."

"Fifty-seven?" Andy said, still trying to get a handle on numbers.

"No, he can't be that old," Petey said, looking at Tyler. "Twenty-five?"

"Mmm. Add one hundred," Tyler said.

Andy looked up to his big brother to do the math.

Petey struggled with it, the math was easy for him, he just couldn't fathom how the answer could be possible. "One hundred and twenty-five?" he asked his voice high.

"Yup."

Andy's Mouth went into an O shape, still looking over at Petey. "That's old," he said.

"Well, I'm a vampire," he said, really pleasantly.

He gave Petey a half second for it to sink in then he pinched him in the collar where his neck met his shoulder.

It made her Petey flinch and he jumped, laughing, scrunching his chin down to his chest to protect his neck. "Aggh," he screamed, laughing out.

Jess covered her mouth and nose with her hands and her eyes got wet. This could work out after all. It might all be okay.

"Now you're a vampire," Tyler told him and Petey got it right away and turned and bit Andy's neck with his fingertips. Andy screamed, lifted his shoulder to his ear, then turned and ran away with Petey chasing after him.

She stayed squatting down with Tyler, their knees touching, both of them watching the boys running and pinching each other.

"Boy, you made that look so easy," she said.

"How are you, Jess?"

She looked at him, pursed her lips into a slim line, then said, "Nervous."

"Me too," Tyler said. He held his hand out to her and she put hers over it, squeezed his big fingers. He stood and helped her up. She wanted to put

her arm around his waist while they watched them play but knew she couldn't. She stepped a bit closer, could feel his body against her side.

Pete saw them on the driveway together driving in the cul-de-sac with the van full of Tyler's stuff. His boys were running and playing and the two of them watched. They looked like a fabulous young family. But that was *his* wife. Those were *his* kids. He felt himself start to cry, felt his chest heave like he wanted to sob. They looked so good together, like they were meant for each other, watching their fair-haired boys horsing around.

"Oh, God," he whispered. He moaned, heard it echo in the van.

They were knee to knee, then Tyler took his wife's hand, held it, then raised up and lifted her next to him and they stood together. Pete drove past the driveway. He put it in reverse, looked in his rearview. A tear rolled out of his eye and he stopped what he was doing. He wiped his face on the sleeve of his coat. He cleared his throat, sniffled. Wiped at his nose.

"C'mon, Pete," he heard Tyler yelling behind the van. Waving his hand to Pete again, squinting—saw him in the side mirror, Jess standing just behind him.

He backed it up, watching in the rearview. Tyler was watching the wheels, pointing to the side with his finger, saying, *Left, left*.

Then he but both hands out to stop him, said, *Whoa, whoa, how about your other left, now?* Pete put it in drive and went on to the road again.

Tyler said, "Okay, c'mon back now." He turned and was saying something to Jess and it made her laugh.

Pete came straight back, watching in the rearview and using his side mirrors, that musclebound hunk standing with his little wife, fucking with him. This was Pete's driveway, he'd backed in a thousand times.

Then he felt the wheel climb the curb. This fucking guy jinxed him, got in his fucking head.

Tyler was saying, *Easy, easy*.

Pete slammed it in drive and barked forward, made the front wheels chirp. He looked back saw Jess with the boys making sure they were safe. She pulled them to her thighs and put her arms over them holding them there. He shivered again, watching his beautiful wife. She had her car coat

on, dark grey cardigan and a long skirt. The wind was tossing her light hair around her. He ached for her. Wished he could be her man. He held his hands out, watched them shake. He clutched the wheel in one hand, put the van in reverse with the other. He backed it in, calmly, breathing heavy, his breaths a little shaky like he could still just burst out in tears. He got it in.

When Jess opened the door his forehead was resting on the steering wheel.

“Pete—you okay?”

“Yeah, yeah, fine,” he said, sitting upright, quickly dabbing his eyes. He was sure she saw that they were red, puffy. He sniffed and stepped down out of the van.

“Glad you could make it, Pete,” Tyler said, taking off his coat and throwing it next to his helmet, draping it over the seat of his bike.

“Hi, Dad,” his boys said as they hopped over.

“I passed your dad on the main street,” Tyler said, hiding his mouth behind the back of his hand like it was a secret for them. “He drives like an old man,” he said, holding an imaginary steering wheel up high close to his face, peering over it, squinting.

They laughed, “That’s Dad, all right,” Petey said.

“Look at his muscles,” Andy said.

Tyler was just in a T-shirt now, ready to move his boxes. It was tight as could be, showing off his massive yoke, his big thick arms covered entirely in tattoos.

Petey was looking at the drawings on him, getting close to see what they were. Tyler held his arms out so the boys could look at all the crazy things all over him.

“Wow.”

“Holy moly,” Andy said. “That’s so cool.”

Pete looked at Jess, smiling, her arms across her chest, looking down through her glasses at her little boys with Tyler. Pete got close to her and put his hand on her shoulder but she didn’t look over.

“Make a muscle, Tyler,” Andy asked him.

Tyler laughed, got down for them again and flexed, gave them a good bicep peak. His arm was a thick slab covered in interlocking plates of muscle that rippled. Andy put his tiny hands around Tyler’s arm, nowhere close to covering up even the peak of Tyler’s bicep.

“How strong are you?”

“Oh, pretty strong I guess.”

“Could you lift up Mom?”

“I’m not heavy, Petey,” Jess said, insulted.

“No, you’re not,” Tyler said, “You’re light as—”

“Okay, boys, beat it for a minute. Go grab us some drinks,” Pete said.

“Get your muscles ready. We’re gonna move some boxes, we’ll need your help. Turn you into He-men in no time,” Tyler called after them.

“Cool!” Andy yelled, skipping behind his brother to go get some pops for everyone.

The three of them looked at one another standing in the driveway. Pete said, “We’re going to need some ground rules.”

“Of course, Pete,” Jess said.

“Seriously, these are my kids, so, I mean, they are never, ever, ever to be compromised.”

“Yeah, Pete we know,” Tyler said.

Jess said, “Pete, we’re not idiots. And they’re *my* kids.”

“Don’t forget, I’m a teacher,” Tyler said.

Pete narrowed his eyes. *Were a teacher, Tyler.*

“I know how to act around kids.”

Did these two forget why they were here? How this came to pass? They fucked up and got caught. This was *exactly* what he was trying to explain to them.

“You’re here as a favour to you. To help you out. Not to...” he looked around, whispered, “*fuck...*my wife every day.”

Tyler and Jess nodded, looking down at the asphalt.

“Right, we’re all on the same page? Just because we’re under one roof now doesn’t mean this is one big sex party for you two,” Pete said

“When we do it, it’ll be just like it was before. Kids at your sister’s. All of us okay with it,” Jess said.

Pete chewed on a piece of skin stuck to his lower lip. He nodded. Still couldn’t believe this was happening.

BIG BREAKFAST

SUNDAY, OCTOBER 23RD

“**Y**ou don’t seem very interested. Am I boring you?”
Jess said, “Huh?” waking out of a reverie and trying to act like she’d heard everything Pete said.

Jess was sitting on the concrete stoop outside the back door of the kitchen looking out into the yard. Pete was standing below her, his back to her, hands on his hips, holding a plastic bag while he waited for Sargent to find a decent place to poop. A sharp line of shade was drawn across the lawn from the early morning light, and Pete Jr and Andy were horsing around on the lawn wearing big warm sweaters and jackets, rolling around in the wet frosted grass despite the October cold. Cold but still bright and sunny, no clouds up in the deep blue sky. How long could this nice weather last?

“Never mind. I was talking about Karla.”

She couldn’t remember who Karla was. She said, “Oh.”

She’d had trouble sleeping last night. The thought of Tyler in the house disturbed her now that he was here. Her attraction to him was, on the surface, so blatantly sexual. Having him in her intimate family space felt like a violation, even to her. She slept eventually, then, when she woke, the very first thought she had was of Tyler. How close he was. Just past two doors and she could climb into bed with him. Slip under the sheets and feel his strong arms hold her to him. She didn’t think of making love, just wondered what it would be like to wake up with him. She was getting a hint of what it would be like to live with Tyler. To be his mate. He was so close and she was so hungry.

“I’m sorry, Pete.”

Pete looked over his shoulder at her while Sargent finally found a spot good enough to squat over, his red legs and tail trembling. He smirked at her, said, “A lot on your mind?”

“Yeah, I guess so,” she said and she sipped her coffee. It had got cold.

“I’ll get breakfast started,” she told him, and got herself up and went back in the house.

Tyler had been on his best behaviour. Charming her impressionable boys with his good looks and his charm. Even Pete didn’t say a thing to her when they were in bed last night. Tyler was playing his part very well. He wasn’t swearing, or being brash and rude like he could be. He was respectful. She hoped he could keep that up.

Jess brought out the bacon and eggs and put them on the counter, wondered if Tyler had strange dietary needs. Body like his, did he eat bacon? Pete would shit his pants if she had to start doing special shopping just for him. She’d just make him the same as everyone else for now.

It was Sunday, a family day, so it wouldn’t be unusual if she were to make a nice big meal for everyone, right? But would that come off as too celebratory, like she was making a big deal about her friend staying over? Would Pete think she was going too far? Would Tyler think she was trying too hard—could she turn him off? Gosh, was all this worry necessary?

It could be. This was the most outlandish experience in her whole life. No experience in her life had taught her how to behave in a situation like this. She wanted to be in her warm terry robe and her flannel PJs, but not with a guest in the house. A guest who had made love to her a few times and with whom she wanted to go again and again. So when she woke up she’d had to get showered, cleaned, even touched her face with a bit of makeup. This was going to be an awkward few weeks. Her stomach felt so strange.

Helping Tyler like this was a necessity. It was a kindness, sure, but she *had* to help him. If she’d never stopped that day at the school, gone in and sat with him in the teacher’s lounge... Hadn’t talked about the bulge in his shorts, hadn’t peeked inside when he showed her... There were a lot of bad things she’d done that day. Thirty-five-year-old woman should know better. She’d brought this on the kid. Had he a better work history, a better relationship with his landlord, better credit—he could have survived their indiscretion, that was on him. She was still right to help him. And while she

had told herself and told Pete she would keep her hands off him, now that he was here, she couldn't help but think how close he was, how easy it would be to lock herself in the furnace room with him and peel his tight clothes off that big muscular body.

Pete was out there with the boys still, he had them working on something. He'd brought out a shovel and Andy had his plastic beach shovel ready to help old dad with whatever he was doing. She checked her reflection in the mirror in the hall, she liked what she saw. Contacts in, simple makeup, fresh face for so early in the morning, her hair was put together without looking like she'd spent time on it. She went up the stairs.

The hall at the top wasn't long, it was more rectangular, with four thin hollow doors separating it from the rooms. There was the master bedroom, the boys room, and then a washroom, and the guest room. Tyler was behind that door. The boys' new big brother who was sharing that tiny bathroom with them now. Their house wasn't big and Tyler filled it up that was for sure. The guest room he was in was very small, maybe just twelve by ten. He had a bed, a dresser, and a closet. His door was open a crack and she could see him awake and moving around in there. He was dressed, which was a relief, although she would love to see him naked—just not right now with Pete and the boys so close, ready to run up the stairs and catch her.

He had an old, beat-up suitcase open, and he was putting things away in the dresser, his big, wide, muscular back turned to her. She watched him a moment—felt so creepy doing it. Every second she enjoyed watching his body move in his tight jeans and t-shirt was also a dread-filled second where she thought he might turn and catch her. But she kept watching from the hall, ready to walk in and start talking if he turned and saw her standing in the shadows.

She knocked very lightly with a knuckle, stood in the gap of the door and pushed it wider.

"Hey," he said when he turned.

"I'm making breakfast. I want you to come down and join us. Is that okay?"

"Yeah, of course it is."

"I just don't know how we're going to go about this is all," she laughed.

He waved her in, gave her a warm smile. It felt so wrong to go into that space with him. She stepped through the threshold and closed the door quietly behind her. She wasn't here for sex, but man, she'd like to. If Pete

could keep those boys busy... She had an image of herself bent over the edge of the bed, Tyler pounding her from behind, one of his white sport socks stuffed in her mouth so her family couldn't hear her ecstasy.

Tyler sat on the edge of the twin size bed and she sat next to him. "Thanks for letting me stay here. It means a lot," he said.

"Please, Tyler, it's fine. Stay as long as you want."

"I'll get myself right soon. I'll stay out of your guy's way. But if you want me to sit with you and eat, I'd be honoured."

"Yeah, we do, of course we do. You're not going to be holed up in here while we're home. I want you around."

"And Pete?"

"I'll take care of Pete. Really, he'll be okay."

He hunched forward, his hands clasped between his thighs. He said, "I hope you don't blame yourself for getting me fired."

She bristled. She bit her lips and couldn't help wincing at him, said, "Do *you* blame me?"

"No," he said, looking down at the carpet, "We both shoulda known better, I guess." He smiled at her. "You just can't keep your hands off me, can you?"

He gave her a mischievous smile, but she could see in his eyes he didn't have the conviction. He wasn't in the mood right now, he was just going through the motions. She wondered what went through his head. How did he see this arrangement? She hoped he didn't think that he had to bang old Mrs. Mapplethorpe once a week to pay for his room and board. She hoped he didn't see her that way.

She pressed her open palm against his cheek and he put his hand over hers. She watched his face, struggled with what to say.

The sliding glass door rumbled underneath them, Pete and the boys coming back in the house. She pat his cheek and he let her hand go.

They sat a moment longer on the edge of the bed, both looking at the floor. It was odd but it did feel strangely comfortable to sit with him and be quiet.

"You'll come down for breakfast?" she said.

"Yeah, I will," he said, his hand went across her back, went in circles then up to her neck and he held her. It gave her a chill that made her nipples harden. "Thank you," he said.

“Uh-okay,” she said and she got up. She opened the door and slipped out, keeping her back to him, afraid he might see her nipples pressing out the fabric of her shirt.

Pete was on the stairs. One leg up, one leg still in the hall, leaning on the handrail like he’d been listening but afraid to come up. His face was raised, watching her come out of Tyler’s room. She felt a little charge bolt through her from his horrified expression, and as she passed him on the stairs, she let him see her nipples, couldn’t help herself—she wiped at the corners of her mouth. She could feel his anguish, feel his suffering, wondering if his wife had just gone down on her lover in their own home while he was with the boys.

She went into the kitchen and started breakfast, riding a salacious thrill that raced through her whole body.

TWISTER

MONDAY, OCTOBER 24TH

Stir-fry tonight. Carrots, onions, peppers, broccoli, and cauliflower chopped, chicken browned, sprouts in the pan. Jess was over the stove, the steam feeling good on her face but making her hair a little heavy. She tied it back in place with an elastic hairband while dinner cooked.

Maybe she'd really gotten away with it. Another day at school today, the place rippling with gossip about the dirty incident someone witnessed over at the high school. That stud PE teacher and some blonde-haired girl. Some of them saying quietly, *Wish it was me*, giggling behind their hand. Not one funny look at Jess. Not one weird exchange that made her think someone out there in this ugly world was spreading the rumour that it was Jess Mapplethorpe. No one shunned her, everything seemed like business as usual today. The other lady teachers waving her over to their little groups so they could all discuss their perverted theories. What were they caught doing? Who do you think it was?

No one thought it was her? She maybe should be a little insulted she thought, after a while. *Why couldn't it be Jess?*

The rice was done, sat now for a few minutes. She walked down the hall opened the basement door and yelled down to Pete that dinner was ready.

"Up in a minute," he yelled up from his dark little refuge. He was spending a lot of his time with those trains these last few days. Whatever it took him to get through this was fine with her. He was a saint for letting Tyler move in. They were doing the right thing. Sometimes, though, passing Tyler in their narrow hall, feeling how he filled up her living space,

brushing against his body in the kitchen—after all the dirty, dirty things they'd done together she wondered if she was kidding herself.

This had been her fault. Not entirely of course, but more her than Tyler. She knew better than to do that at his work. Knew better to even visit him given the filthy things they'd done together.

She was thirty-five. Ten years older than him—she was mature. She was everyone's sweet Jess. How was it possible that she didn't stop, tell him they needed to do this somewhere private? Even when she was a young girl she was never so crazy, so promiscuous. What was happening to her?

When she opened the door from the mudroom that led to the garage she saw Tyler with her boys, showing them how to do chin-ups. The three boys in a line, their backs to her. Tyler was hanging from the rafter, her boys gripping a bar across Tyler's squat rack.

Tyler had his shirt off and she watched those big round muscles bunched up across his back and over his shoulders bulge and dance. She stood on the top step of their garage watching the three of them. Her boys were doing well, pulling their light bodies up and watching Tyler, trying to please him, get his attention.

"That's it, dude. Do two more," Tyler said.

Petey kept at it and so did Andy, his little thin arms shaking.

"You can do it, Andy," Jess said and she stepped onto the wooden steps and sat down at the top.

Petey said, "Did you see me, Mom?"

"Yes, I did, Petey. You were doing great."

The single garage door was open to the early evening blue light, getting dark on her little cul-de-sac. What must the neighbours think, looking into their lit up garage, seeing their new tenant with her children like this? This muscular beast living with this young family. Could they ever suspect?

Andy shook his way through the last one he could possibly do and jumped down like he had just won a trophy.

"Raaah," he yelled and he flexed for his mommy, a double biceps then down into some Incredible Hulk pose.

"You're amazing, Andy," she said and she clapped for him.

Tyler jumped down and turned, his muscles rippled and she had to look away.

"Glad to see you boys are bundled up out here," she said.

Tyler had the boys in heavy sweats, towels tucked into the collar like Rocky Balboa. She watched Tyler bend at the waist, pluck his T-shirt off the squat rack between two fingers. Steam was rising up off him.

“Dinner’s ready, boys,” she said, her eyes on Tyler just behind Pete and Andy. She watched that shirt go over his head, his deep six pack sucked in as he shrugged himself into it, pulled it down that lean hard body. His arms stretched out the sleeves of his tight t-shirt. They were so thick she couldn’t come close to putting her hands around them. He was so strong, so hard, his arms felt like steel when she ran her hands over them. She would watch her pale thin hand, so light against the dark inked skin of them, her hands would claw at the dragons while he plunged in and out of her.

“What’s for dinner, Mom?”

“Stir fry, Petey,” she said. She pulled the front of his sweatshirt, snagged him into a hug, squeezed him tight.

“Agh, Mom,” he yelled, pulling his head away from her in case she might try and kiss him too.

Andy said, “Are you crying, Mom?”

She touched her cheek, felt it wet. Her eyes felt swollen and puffy.

“No, Andy, it’s just the onions,” she said.

“I hate onions,” Petey said, still held close to her.

“I know, kiddo.” She kissed him, said, “I made some without onions for you and Andy.”

“Thanks, Mom.”

She let Petey go, picked up her Andy and carried him into the kitchen, Petey and Tyler right on her heels. She put Andy in his chair, the other two finding their seats at the table.

“Hey, hey,” she said firmly to Sargent who was standing underneath the oven, his black nose checking out the pots on the stove. “Don’t you dare,” she said.

She got the boys’ plates served—no onions—and did one for Tyler. She put them on the table for them, the boys said, “Thanks, Mom,” Tyler said, “Thanks, Mrs. M.”

She didn’t like it. How did he mean that? She wasn’t his mother’s age. She was older but she was nowhere even old enough to be his mother. Not sexy, Tyler. Not sexy at all. She didn’t respond to him.

“Where is Pete?” she said under her breath.

She went to the basement door and yelled down again.

Pete yelled back, "Coming."

The last time Jess had been persuaded to take Just The Tip she was fifteen. Eddy Maxwell persuaded her to let him put the head of his skinny penis inside her when she fell for him after two weeks vacation with her parents, staying at that rental cottage up in northern Michigan. She fell for that long-haired kid with the Nirvana shirt and that was kind of technically who she lost her virginity to although he hadn't even touched her hymen. She cried for a day when she got home and she never heard from him again. Tyler would have been Andy-boy's age that same summer.

"You okay, Mom?"

"Huh, yeah, Petey, I'm fine. Just felt a little funny there."

"Hurry up, Dad, we're waiting," Andy said, his head lolling back in exasperation.

"Yeah, yeah, sorry, guys," Pete said, coming into the kitchen and going to the sink to wash his hands. "Start without me."

Tyler paused, his mouth full of food, looking around the table. He was already a good way through his dinner. His eyes stopped at Jess and she smiled at him.

"How was school today, boys?" Pete asked.

"We were working out with Tyler," Andy said.

"Oh, yeah?" Pete said, working his fork through his dinner.

Petey said, "Yeah, Dad, we did pushups and sit-ups and chin-ups—"

"Well, Tyler used to teach Gym, guys," Pete said. She knew Pete was hurting hearing this from his boys. They were really taking to the guy that their mom had been having sex with. Her weird husband was in physical pain from this. But he loved it. With Tyler in the house now she could really make him suffer even if she were trying not too.

"We know, Dad."

Don't ask him why he doesn't teach any more boys, please, not with me here at the table. I might lose it.

Pete's phone buzzed, and he slid it out of his chest pocket, looked down at it. He frowned, kept reading.

"Excuse me, everyone," he said, pushed himself from the table. He went and leaned on the counter and made a phone call. Jess kept eating, heard Pete talking behind her. It was work.

"Shoot, guys," Pete said, standing behind her, his hands on the back of her chair. "We've got a problem with the silent alarm down at the store."

Keeps going off, the police are there.”

“The police?” Andy said, excited.

“Yeah, Andy. Corporate wants me down there, gotta meet the police and the alarm company.”

“They don’t have someone there?”

“No, they—”

“Someone else?” Jess said.

“No, I’m closest anyway.”

“Pete, your dinner...”

“Sorry, Jess, I gotta go. Can you wrap it up for me? I’ll eat it when I get back. I’ll probably just be an hour.”

“An hour?” she said. She wasn’t sure how she felt being alone with Tyler like this. This was a little weird. It was nighttime now, family time. This was the time that she and Pete would spend with the boys before they went to bed. Now she was going to spend it alone with Tyler?

It was almost two and a half hours before Pete got home and it put him in a terrible mood. He’d had to grab a burger at the McDonald’s in the Save-Mart or he was going to pass out. He was filled with dread standing there in the kitchen knowing he was leaving his family with another man in the house.

Standing now in the front hall he could hear the boys laughing hysterically from the family room.

Andy was giggling so high he was squeaking. He heard Petey, saying, *Mom, Mom, Mom*, over and over trying to get her attention. He walked through the kitchen, the lights dimmed, table cleared, counters and stove cleaned.

He heard Tyler’s deep voice encouraging, “You can do it, reach.”

They were all having a lot of fun without him.

“Reach, Jess, reach,” Tyler said again, sitting on the couch. Pete was in the doorway, his heart dropped into his guts.

“You can do it, Mom,” Petey said. He was leaning against Tyler’s knee holding a square thin board with a spinning arrow on it. Both of them watching Jess and Andy on the floor.

They were playing Twister, the coffee table slid away, sheet spread on the floor. Sargent was watching through the sliding glass door, his tail wagging, lit up by the porch light. He barked when he saw Pete.

Andy was on his back, arms behind him, holding himself up, one leg stretched far, planted in a yellow circle. Jess was spread over him like a spider. She was on all fours, her butt up in the air like a yoga pose, her right leg straining to get her bare foot onto a red circle.

The tendons in her neck stood out, she was laughing, reaching, her hair tied back, her ponytail hanging over her shoulder. She'd changed into black tights and a loose sweatshirt, but putting her body like this, Pete—and Tyler—could see up her sweatshirt, see her tummy and her black bra, see the curve of her rump, her beautiful legs, thin knees. It was an awful scene.

They could have been playing Connect Four, Candyland, Operation. They could have been playing Hungry Hungry Hippos. But they were playing Twister.

What had Pete missed? Had Jess and Tyler had a turn together? He could picture his boys laughing as they flicked the spinner, encouraging Mom to play with Uncle Tyler. His kids seeing their mom have fun with another man. Her on her back, legs askew, hands and feet in coloured dots, Tyler's strong arms holding himself above her with ease, them laughing, looking into each other's eyes. Jess wouldn't have let the boys see that would she? It crushed him thinking about it.

"Mom, Mom," Petey was still trying to get her attention. "Mom, this one here, you'll never get that other one." Petey was in her line of sight now, pointing to a red dot she hadn't seen.

"Petey, I can't bend my leg like that."

"Yes, you can, Jess," Tyler laughed.

"Quiet, you," Jess said, peeking under her arm at Tyler. She saw Pete looming in the doorway.

Pete saw the guilt on her face. She knew how terrible this was. How wrong.

"Oh, hi, Pete," she said.

"Hi, Dad," Pete said.

"Hi, Dad. I'm winning," Andy said from under his mom.

"That's good, Andy-boy." Pete leaned on the archway.

Jess crossed her leg underneath her, careful not to hit Andy. She stretched it over trying to get her little toe to touch a red circle. Her leg

shook with the effort. Her butt cheek pinched a crease in her tights showing Pete and Tyler her round rump as if it were bare. Jess was laughing now, giving up, her arms shaking. She collapsed next to Andy.

“Agh, you win again, Andy,” she laughed. She lay on her back next to him with her knees up, her bare feet on the mat. Andy climbed on her and she hugged him.

“How did it go, Pete?” she asked him over Andy’s shoulder.

“Shouldn’t the boys be in bed?”

“Aw, Pete, they wanted to stay up for you,” she said.

“Yeah, well it’s late.”

Petey came to his side, grabbed the side of his palm, “Yeah, sorry you missed dinner, Dad.”

“Me too, Petey, glad you guys had fun without me. Come on, Andy,” he said and held his other hand out for his littlest boy.

“You okay, Dad?” Petey asked him.

“Yeah, no, Pete. I’m fine. Let me get you boys to bed. Tuck you in.”

He walked them down the hall. Left Jess and Tyler in the family room.

Jess went to bed some time after Pete and she was worried about him. Pete was sleeping, curled up in their bed, laying on his side, facing away from where she would lay. She tossed her sweatshirt to the floor, slid her tights off, then her panties and bra too, and she climbed under the covers and slid across to him, pressed herself against his back. He didn’t budge.

“Petey?” she whispered.

He grunted, half-asleep.

“You okay, sweetheart?”

He gave her an affirmative grunt.

She slid her hand around to his front, scratched her nails lightly on his chest. “You sure?”

He was awake now, she could see his profile, could see his eyelashes. His eyes were open, looking across the room.

“I’m sure, Jess,” he said quietly.

He didn't sound fine. Her hand scratched its way idly down his T-shirt, over his belly, lingering along the elastic waist of his briefs.

"You know how much I love you, right, Petey?"

"Yeah, I do," he said, she could see him blinking.

Her hand slipped under his waistband, found his small, hairy penis, his testicles scrunched up high underneath it. She tickled it with her fingertips, touched the tip, circled his hole with her forefinger. His legs straightened a bit, exposing it better for her. Her fingers stroked it, going up and down his shaft and she could feel it starting to stiffen.

"You know there's a big, thick cock just outside that door and a muscular boy dying to fuck me with it but I'm here stroking this little thing because I love you. You're my baby, Petey."

"Oh, fuck, Jess," he gasped, a little breathy chuckle in it. He swelled hard under her fingers and she was able to grip it now, stroke it.

"But he *is* going to fuck me again. You just have to face it. Soon. When the boys are out and we're all alone, he's going to fuck me. Are you ready for that?" Her hand was steadily jerking his short penis, her fist working under the front of his underwear.

"Y-yes, Jess."

"You want that, don't you?"

"I do."

"Look at me," she said.

He rolled over to her, lay on his back as she looked down on him, her hand still moving around inside his underwear. She dipped her lips to his and she kissed him. He surged in her hand and he was suddenly slippery. Her hand squirmed over his little tip and he gasped in her mouth.

"Let me get his little coat on for you," she said. She slipped her hand out and she leaned across him and opened the drawer of the nightstand.

"Oh, Jess," Pete said, his hands finding her body and sliding over her, "you're naked." His hands felt good going over her, his warm familiar hands that had touched her thousands of times.

"Get your pants off," she whispered as she tore open a foil condom square.

Pete pushed the bedsheets down and he slipped his briefs down his legs and lay back naked for her. She pinched the tip of the condom, and rolled it down, let it go and waited.

"What's that?" he said, his hand feeling his erection.

“What’s what?”

She watched him pull on the condom and it slid right off.

“Oh, I’m sorry, Pete. That’s one of Tyler’s condoms. I have some in there, just in case,” she laughed. She had another condom in her hand and she was opening it. “He needs special condoms for that beautiful man-cock he has,” she said.

Pete chuckled again, he was fiddling with the condom over his penis, rolling it out to see how long it was. “You really love that thing, huh?” he said.

She gripped the base of his penis with one hand and held Tyler’s XL condom out for Pete so they could both see the difference. “Yeah, Pete, it’s amazing.”

“Not too big?” he said, looking up at her as she tossed the other condom out of the way.

“No, not at all. Here’s your little condom,” she said and she slipped it on him with her fingers.

She straddled him, then put her hands on his cheeks and she kissed him again, her hair falling across his face. He kissed her, passionately, his hands coming up and squeezing her shoulders. She bit his lip, broke away from him, said, “I love your dick, Pete.”

“But his is better.”

“Yes. But I love you and I love your little dick.”

She shimmied down to his hips and sat back on him, felt his hardness, poking between her legs.

“Did you do anything with him before breakfast yesterday?” he asked her.

She felt behind her, gripped his penis and held it up, guided it to her opening. “When I was up in his room?”

“Yeah.”

She pushed her hips down on it, felt it part her and poke inside her. Pete moaned and she smiled at him. “I just sucked him off real quick,” she said.

“Jess.”

“He came in my mouth,” she said, grinding her hips in contracted circles on him.

“Did you *do* something?” Pete said, his hands sliding up her sides to cup her breasts.

“No, Petey, I was asking him if it would feel funny to have meals with us.”

“Tell me you sucked him.”

She bit her lip, her grinding getting faster, gasped, “I did. Just before breakfast. I thought I could sneak a few minutes...ah, while your back was turned.”

“You’re so bad, Jess.”

“I know. I’m the worst, I just can’t get enough of that kid.”

“Ah, Jess, tell me you fucked him.”

“He fucked *me*, Petey. I tried to stop him but he’s too strong, baby,”

“Oh, shit, Jess,” Pete gasped, his hips were straining to push his cock out as far as it would go while she squirmed on it, “did you fight him?”

“I didn’t, he just felt so good, baby. He bent me over the bed, ah, he stuffed a sport sock in my mouth so you couldn’t hear me scream from up here.”

“Did he hurt you?”

“I loved every minute of it.”

She closed her eyes and tried to picture that. Picture that kid dominating her, taking her against her will. She ground her hips against Pete, his little thing buried in her, her hard button mashed into his pubic bones and she kept an orgasm on edge, thrilled it’s shining ridges and dared it to come and get her. She thought of Tyler and all the incredibly hot things they’d done and all the things yet to do once they found the time, the privacy. Pete slipped out of her a few times but she got him back in quickly, before she lost her grip on an orgasm. Pete worked her, rubbing his hands across her slim sides, running them over her rump and sliding his fingers down underneath to tease where he was entering her.

“I’m going to make you suffer,” she whispered to him. She fell forward over him, holding herself over his face, her hair whipping forward and thrashing him.

“Do it,” he said, and he squeezed her thighs. She could feel how incredibly hard he was inside her.

“You sure you want me to?”

“I want you to be as bad as you want to be, Jess.”

She slipped off him, she gasped, “Oh, Pete, you have me so close,” and she spun herself around and backed her hot sex over Pete’s mouth. “God, Pete, please,” she pleaded, and he went after her, wanting to please her. His

tongue worked through her, penetrating and teasing, mashing against her swollen clit, then back to teasing. She closed her eyes as hard as she could and thought about Tyler. She worked against Pete, tilting and swivelling, wanting so bad to be pushed over the lip, to have that sweet swell raise her up and make her cry out. She could feel it coming, building, and Pete worked her harder, his hands squeezing her legs, his thumbs digging high up into her sensitive inner thighs. She buckled, her head whipped forward, "Oh, Pete," she warned him. It was huge. She trembled as she came, squeezed her thighs together, clutching Pete's poor balding head tightly, crushing his face into her sex, freezing him from tickling her out of it and ruining it. She croaked and squeezed, arched her back as she felt the incredible wave wash over her. Finally she let her head fall, her forehead rest on his soft, clammy belly. She felt her thighs quivering as she released him, let him breathe again.

"Wow," she whispered.

His cock was bobbing with his heartbeat, aching to be touched right in front of her. She ran a finger down it and it flexed. She took it up, his rock-hard penis, barely longer than her fist, and she stroked it with two fingers and her thumb. His arms circled her waist and he hugged her hips closer to his chest. She was going to make him suffer. She hated that it aroused her but she couldn't deny it. Tyler was sleeping in a twin bed just past her door and she could torture Pete with that stud. She'd enjoy every minute of it, the sordid pleasure as a young, hung, stud, made her come, and then the dirty secret thrill of knowing her sweet husband was dying inside, watching her get something he could never give her.

Pete let out a long low moan, and his hips thrust his penis through her circled grip. She squeezed it tighter, stroked him faster, and watched the tip of his little condom fill up with his milky seed.

HALLOWEEN PARTY

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 30TH

“He was what?”

Pete and Russ were at the side of the family room, close together having a conversation they shouldn't be having in a room full of children.

“Yeah, you know, between her breasts,” Russ leaned right in and whispered it in Pete's ear.

“Russ, come here,” Pete nodded toward the kitchen. They were at his sister's house, with Patty and Russ's kids and about a dozen others were there with their parents too. Pete and some of the other parents weren't so fond of their little ones walking the neighbourhood getting candy from strangers so they made their own party. Seven at night now and they'd been here since three in the afternoon, kids playing games, building scarecrows, donut-eating races. None of them tired yet, amped up on sugar and excitement.

Pete walked through the dark hall into the kitchen. “What did you—”

He got a string of cottony spiderweb that his sister had strung up in the dark hall caught in his open mouth as he walked into it, and he reeled back splashing beer up the front of his sport shirt. “Jesus Christ, Patty,” he cursed under his breath.

“Easy, Pete.”

“Shit, yeah, sorry, walked right into it.”

“Yeah, gotta watch where you're going, buddy.”

“What's she doing stringing that up in the dark?” he said, wiping his brand new shirt, flicking the wet off his moisture-repellant fabric.

“Ha, you know your sister.”

“She probably strung it along the top of the stairs too, try and kill me that way.”

“So you haven’t heard anything?” Russ said.

They were alone in the kitchen now, a little more free to talk. Pete could see into the family room, see the kids milling around, anticipating the next game. Jess was there, crouched down with Andy. She had her witch’s robe on, dressed all in black. She was beaming at him, listening to him over-explain something the way he would do. Nodding, lips peeled back, showing her perfect white teeth.

“No—we’ve talked with him, but I haven’t heard any of the rumours. What did you hear?”

“Just what I told you. It was old Joe Watson walked in on them, I think maybe a couple of kids too—he was with some blonde-haired girl. He was, like, naked, and he was, you know, he had his thing going between her breasts.”

Pete’s upper lip was sweating. He could see Jess now—Jacob, their nephew, Russ and Patty’s boy, had his arms around her from behind. She was looking at him sideways, talking to him.

Russ got real close even though they were the only ones in the kitchen, he whispered, “Word is he’s got a real baseball bat down there too.”

“Oh,” Pete said.

“Yeah. It better not have been a student, I can’t believe you guys would—”

“No, we’ve talked to him. It wasn’t a student at all. We believe him. If we thought otherwise we wouldn’t be helping him out.”

“For sure, for sure—what’d *he* say?”

“He won’t say who it is, Jess thinks he’s protecting someone. Like he’s doing the right thing. He’s heartfelt about the student thing—no way it was a high school kid.”

“Yeah, personally I don’t think it was a student either. Ten times more likely it was one of these moms right here.”

Pete’s sphincter tightened.

“Christ, you see the way they got when he would come around.”

“Yeah, I think you’re right,” Pete said, his voice a little tight.

“Maybe a teacher.”

Pete's heart pounded blood up his neck, forcing it painfully through him, it made him wince, he thought he might have to take a knee. The more he thought about that the worse it got until he'd convinced himself his vision was dimming. This was it. He was going to have a heart attack. *He was looking right at her.* It was so obvious. So fucking obvious to goddamn everyone. His pretty Jess, his baby girl, standing now, everyone watching her. All the kids and all their parents. She was putting her witch's hat on, telling the kids how to play the game. They were in love with her. Transfixed.

Who else would it be? *She* was one of those moms. *She* was a teacher. *She* was blonde. Tyler had moved in with *her* after he was fired.

"Shit, there she is," Russ said, "Jess is a blonde teacher."

Pete turned to Russ, his eyes were peeled in horror, his heart was in his throat, he tried to protest, his voice a creak from a coffin.

"Jesus, Pete, I'm kidding, Oh, my God, sorry, buddy." He clasped Pete on the shoulder. He looked genuinely sorry. "Oh, man, that sounded funnier in my head. I'm sorry, that was stupid. You should have seen your face."

"Yeah," he cleared his throat, took a sip of beer and struggled to swallow it. "Yeah, that wasn't funny."

"Jess is at the wrong school anyway. And besides," he shrugged, "*it's Jess.*"

Pete was stuck. What if someone found out her class was away on a field trip that afternoon? What if they found out she wasn't at school? Shit.

"I know for a fact it wasn't her."

"We all know it wasn't her, Pete. Not Jess. Plus why would you move him in if you thought it might be her?"

"Yeah, I saw her that afternoon. She was with me."

"She wasn't at school that day?"

"No, no, but she came by the Save-Mart. She was with me."

They both stood in the light of the kitchen looking out through the short dark hall at the room beyond. Watched the kids learn the rules, *Put the Mole On The Witch*. Jess was handing out sticky warts she'd made out of putty. Up late last night at the kitchen table going to the trouble to make sure each one had a fibre run through it like a big ugly hair. Everyone getting their wart put into the palms of their open hands. The inevitable booger it became in the hand of one boy dressed as a Minion who stuffed it in his nostril then blew it out on to his friend. Russ and Pete sipped their beers and watched.

“Has he found any work yet?”

“I don’t think so,” Pete said.

“How hard is he looking?”

“He’s looking,” Pete said, but he wasn’t sure he was. The last week was tough—coming home and seeing him sitting on the couch while Jess made dinner. There were things he could do around the house that would help them but he didn’t do them. Pete wouldn’t ask, neither would Jess, but it was the kind of thing that he’d hoped Tyler would feel grateful enough to want to do on his own. He’d asked Jess once what Tyler was doing about finding a new arrangement, about finding a job. Jess had shrugged, and she looked unhappy, wouldn’t look Pete in the eye so he dropped it. Quite frankly, he was afraid to ask about it again. They had a date in mind, at least Pete did, and Jess had originally acknowledged it. Tyler should be out around November 5th, 12th at the latest.

“Don’t think he’s going to find a job teaching around here,” Russ laughed. “He’ll have to pick something new or maybe move out of town.”

“He’s all right. He was probably good at what he did. He just messed up,” Pete said, then added, “And not with a kid.”

“Wonder what the conditions were on his termination?”

“Don’t know.”

Jess clapped her hands a few times, said, *Kids, kids, kids*, and then she had their attention. She told them the game was about to start, told them to be polite and respect the others. No tripping or anything else you might think was funny. There was nodding, some of the kids looked around at one tall boy dressed as the Joker. Fat kid, dyed his red hair green, just got pinged as the bully.

“Still, you’re crazy letting him in the house. I know we can trust Jess but still... Walking around the house with that body. What if she walked in on him coming out of the shower? Saw that old baseball bat? I couldn’t do it. The thought of Patty seeing something like that? How would she ever put up with this?” he said, putting his hand on his round stomach.

“Yeah, I hear you—I’m not ecstatic. But Jess wants to help him.”

“Too kind for her own good,” Russ said, swigged his beer.

Jess had knelt on the floor in the middle of the family room, all the furniture pushed off to the sides. Patty had a little Princess by the shoulders and was carefully spinning her around. She stopped then let her hands off, sent her on her way. She put her arms out in front of her, her head tilted

back like she was trying to see under the blindfold. Someone whispered, *No peeking*. Then everyone was dead silent except one boy chuckling somewhere when she stumbled. The Princess told him to shut up then everyone giggled. The little girl walked around with her hand held up, seeking Jess's face to plant her sticky wart on it.

As the girl got close Jess would make claw marks in the air near her that made the other kids' eyes go wide, pleasantly fearful. When the girl finally found her, touching her pretty face with her hands, looking for her nose, Jess scrunched her face up and held it still. The little girl plopped the wart onto Jess. Jess had drawn a spot with an eyeliner—the closest wart to her target won the prize, a big plastic pumpkin of goodies that Jess had put together. When the Princess took her blindfold off to see how close she'd come, Jess smiled then turned it to a snarl and tickled the girl all over with her clawed witchy hands. The little girl didn't even get away just collapsed in laughter and let Jess tickle her up and down until she couldn't breathe.

Andy was next and even though he knew it was his mommy he was scared of the claw hands, and the surprise tickling ending. He'd demanded to go as a vampire this year for some reason. Jess had him painted with a black widow's peak and a cape, and he loved showing everyone the fake fangs he'd stuffed in his mouth. Now he was shaking his head, and he had Jess laughing. He was so scared. She was laughing so hard no sound was coming out. She took her hat off and put her arms out to him, *awwing* him and urging him to come to her. He did, Patty with a hand between his little shoulders. She hugged him tight and rocked him back and forth, his shiny black Dracula shoes coming right up off the carpet.

She went on through the kids, playing her witch game. Getting the kids to plant their warts on her upturned face. Making creepy witch noises if they would head too far in the wrong direction. Gave them a hint that would make them giggle. Her creaky laugh even made Pete chuckle despite the pain that was in his heart. She was ridiculous. Such a wonderful person.

How could this be the same woman who opened her top for Tyler, middle of the day at school, got him to do that dirty thing to her? He pictured Tyler running that big thing between his wife's pretty breasts while she held them for him. Wanting it, doing it willingly, watching his big tool slide against her skin.

WITCH

SUNDAY, OCTOBER 31ST

Tyler had wanted to answer the door as Drax. Jess said they couldn't have kids and parents coming to the house and seeing his body like that. It would look suspicious. As much as she'd love to see that, she added. Tyler had laughed, said maybe he'd show her later.

So Pete was sitting on his recliner now watching TV with Tyler while Jess and the two boys were at the front door handing out candy to kids. Jess was in her witch's robes, Andy was a vampire, and Petey had on his Iron Man costume.

"You didn't have somewhere to go out?"

"Nah, just don't feel like it. You know..."

Yes, the incident. The shame my wife brought you...

"Mm-hmm," Pete grunted. "I'm going to make popcorn," he said.

He went into the kitchen, into the cupboard, brought down a box of the Save-Mart brand Microwave Popcorn, opened it up. Jess came in the kitchen holding a plastic pumpkin they used to hand out treats from.

"I think that might be it," she said, putting it on the counter.

"Oughtta turn out the lights," Pete said, "mostly older kids now."

"Yeah, Petey did that. You making popcorn?"

"Yeah, get them in the family room."

He put a bag in the microwave, pressed the popcorn button. Jess's arms came around his waist. He looked at her hands laced through each other draped over his belt. He looked at her face past his elbow. She was looking into the counter, distant, absent. She said, "We're going to get through this?"

“Of course we are, Jess,” he said, and he rubbed his hand over the back of hers. “Go get the boys we’ll watch a movie.”

“Yeah,” she said, and his pretty witch softly padded out of the kitchen looking for her kids.

Andy and Petey sat up on the couch with Tyler, Jess sitting on the floor below them, watching the movie. Halloween Is Grinch Night. His two boys’ faces lit up by the light of the TV, their wide-eyed expressions warming his heart. Pete sat in his recliner. Wondered why he had this chair. It kept him separate from his family. Created a physical gap between them. He sat on it now and watched a better version of his own family just ten feet from him. He could barely concentrate on the movie. His pretty wife with her handsome young husband. A very attractive couple. Their little boys eating popcorn and the two half-size candy bars their mom had allowed them. This was what Jess should be. This is how happy she could be. How fulfilled. A man in her life that filled her up and made her scream then sat next to her while they watched TV with their boys. His Jess was different when Tyler was around. Not when she was nervous about how Pete might feel or what the boys might think. When she was relaxed, not thinking how absurd this all was, she had a glow. Like a girl in love. She looked at Tyler with different eyes. She sparkled. Pete watched her when she didn’t know he was looking. It hurt him. But he still wanted this for her. How could he not want her to be so happy?

Jess put the boys to bed when it was time, carrying Andy who had fallen asleep leaning on Tyler. Petey stumbled along next to her, his hand in hers.

He went to the kitchen and poured himself a Dewar’s, ran into Jess in the hall as she returned to the family room. She didn’t even look at him. She had changed out of her witch garb. She had long pyjama pants and a snug little tank top on. He watched her turn in front of him, step down into the family room and pad over to the couch. She hopped next to Tyler, drew her legs up underneath her. Not touching him. But close enough. Tyler leaned back, put his big arms over the back of the couch. They looked at each other, held their eyes a moment. Jess smiled first, then Tyler. Pete could tell she wasn’t wearing a bra. It was obvious. Gentle swinging of her pretty breasts behind the snug fabric. Her nipples had hardened a bit, pressing the cotton out. She grabbed the remote while Pete took his place back on his recliner. He watched them. The two lovebirds sizzling with tension, pulling

a blanket over their laps, sharing it. Wanting to touch each other but knowing they couldn't, not with the boys in the house.

Just two and a half months ago Pete had sat in his chair like he was right now and he'd watched the two of them, in the same spot they were right now. He'd watched this young guy fuck his wife in all sorts of positions. Watched his Jess's pretty face turn to something resembling pain as this stud split her wide with his giant cock. Now he was living here. Sitting with his wife and kids, eating dinner, watching a horror movie. This was insane. If Pete had any sense, he knew this would not happen. Tyler would never have fucked her, he would never be living here. That would make sense. But then Jess would have missed all the wonderful things she'd experienced. He'd have deprived her of that pleasure.

"You okay, Pete?"

"Huh, yeah."

"You're staring."

"Oh, yeah? Lost in thought."

"Did you want to watch a different movie?"

Pete looked at the screen, forgot what he'd been watching. First scenes of Halloween. Michael Myers as a kid. "No, this is fine."

Jess leaned forward, reaching to the coffee table to pull the popcorn bowl over to her even though the kids had eaten most of it. Her rump came up, exposed to Tyler and his hand went between her legs.

"Ope," she yelped, and she knocked the popcorn all over the floor.

Jess looked up at Pete, big smile on her face. "He touched me where he wasn't supposed to," she whispered.

"I did not." Tyler held his two palms up.

"Oh, you didn't?" Jess said, being playful, sitting back up now, facing Tyler.

"How do you like it?" Her hands went under the blanket slowly, Tyler staring at her unflinching, smirking.

Then her hands dove in, tickling him between his legs, hidden under the blanket.

Pete looked around at the doorway, down the dark hall, worried about the kids. "Jess," he whispered.

"I know, I know," she said, her hands stopping their tickling but turning to fondling instead. "They're out cold, Pete." She watched her hands moving under the fabric. She was stroking him over his pants.

“See, how do you like it?” she said to Tyler.

“I like it.”

“Well, maybe I liked it too.”

Jess looked over at Pete, past him, down the hall. Her hands were moving still. Pete heard his button snap, his fly come down.

“Jess.”

“It’s fine, Pete,” she said. “We’re not going to do anything.”

He could tell she had brought it out, could see her holding it, thought he saw the shape of Tyler’s cock under the blanket. Tyler had his arms back over the couch again, Jess curled up next to him. Her hand was flicking now, swinging his flaccid cock up, snapping it against the blanket watching it make the fabric jump. She was making a little sound effect each time she saw it bounce.

“Jess, come on,” Pete said. She was acting like a teenager, playing with a penis for the first time.

“Pete?”

“What?”

She was looking at him over her shoulder, leaning towards Tyler, her hand was still playing under the blanket across the two of them. “Tyler got a blood test. We got his results back. I want to have unprotected sex with him.”

Pete’s arms trembled, he saw the waves build in his whisky. “Oh?” he managed.

“Yeah, I really, really want that.”

“I know,” Pete said. “I don’t like it.” He had to put his glass down.

“I know. You can watch. Don’t you want to see that? See him slide inside me without a condom?”

“Yes.” He did. He really did want to see that. What was wrong with him?

“What’s the big guy think of that?” she said up to Tyler, her hand working between his legs.

“He’s letting you know right now, isn’t he?”

“He sure is. I can’t wait to feel his bare skin inside me. Pete’s right, though. I gotta put him away.”

“You sure? They’re sleeping.”

“I’m sure. We’ll get our chance.” Her hands were putting him back inside his pants. “Wow, he was easier to get out than to put back in.” Tyler

laughed at her struggling. “You zip him up, I don’t want to snag him,” she said.

“You’re not on the pill, Jess,” Pete said.

“I know. We’ll be careful, I know my cycle,” she said, looking over again. Tyler was zipping himself up under the blanket.

SWALLOWING

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 3RD

Jess looked out the window from the master bathroom and down the street. No sign of Pete yet.

“Come on, Tyler,” she said.

Tyler was in the shower, the room steaming up from the heat. She had him in there, scrubbing himself clean. She stood by the window in her bare feet, naked but she had her white terry robe on, tied around her waist.

The knob squeaked as he twisted it, shutting the water off, then the shudder of the pipes somewhere behind the tiles, hammering away. He whisked the shower curtain aside and she blushed. It was still such a dirty thrill to see him naked in the daylight.

He stepped out onto the bathmat and she handed him a towel. He dried himself, and she watched the muscles in his shoulders squirm while he scrubbed the towel over his chest. The big slabs of muscle in the side of his hips bulging as he bent over. His skin was so tight his middle bunched up into a hundred folds when he bent to dry his feet and ankles. Then he stood up, smiled at her, let her take him in a moment. She looked down at that big thing swinging between his legs, reddened by the heat of the shower. He put the towel over it, scrubbed it dry, all his big man-parts bouncing around. He threw the towel over the toilet seat, manhood slapping against his thigh when he let it go.

“Where do you want me?” he asked her.

“Just sit on this stool,” she said, patting it with her palms. He got himself turned around in the tight space and sat back on it. “Now what?”

Jess clutched the collar of her robe, looked down at him sitting before her. His legs were open, his huge cock and balls hanging heavy over the edge of the stool. Hanging down more than half a foot.

“What?”

“Oh. You just look incredibly good right now.”

Tyler leaned back, put his elbows on the counter behind him. “Hot water makes it hang,” he said.

“I’ll say.” She stepped between his legs, ran her hands over his muscles, over his stomach. “You are the hottest thing ever.”

“You are too,” he said, and he kissed her chin, up to her lip, pulled it between his.

“Whoa, whoa,” she said, shaking it off, pushing away from him. “We’ve got work to do here.”

He smiled at her, a little too devilish. Made her want to climb on him and eat him alive.

She couldn’t believe this perfection was here with her in her bathroom. Same boring, small space she used every morning for the last six years. Showering, pooping, peeing, makeup, hair. *Now, look at this.* Look at what was sitting here right in front of her. She was so lucky she could spend time with a physical being so perfect. Couldn’t believe she could pull something so hot, so young.

“Whew,” she said, cleared her throat, “okay.”

Her glasses had fogged up again so she cleaned them on a flap of her robe. She got her scissors and started clipping at the long strands of pubic hair around his penis. Pinched clumps in between her fingers then clipped them away, sprinkled them on the floor next to her. She kept going around, pulling and snipping. When she started clipping the long hairs coming out of his scrotum, it shrivelled up, pulled his big balls up high, right in front of her eyes. “Oh, my,” she said.

“What?”

“Your balls are really afraid of scissors,” she laughed.

“I don’t think they trust you.”

“Aww, they don’t? After I’ve been so good to them?”

She blasted a few blueberry-pomegranate lines into her hand from the Lady Shave gel can. Knelt down between his legs in front of his pendulous genitals. The sun was bright through the window and she was up close in front of this thing, seeing it in dirty, dirty high-definition. It was

magnificent. She worked the gel on him starting on his belly, working it into the patchy scruff she'd left on him. She stroked it partway down his shaft, feeling an incredible horny surge rush through her that almost made her shudder. His penis was so soft, so big and slippery in her hand. Her heart was starting to beat in her eardrums.

"Don't get it in my hole."

"Yeah, okay," she said.

Jess wiped her hands off on the towel, brought her pasta bowl down, already filled with hot water. Fresh pink lady razor right out of the wrapper, popped the cap off it. Her left hand cradled his cock, held it out, but when she brought the razor to it her hand was shaking like mad.

"Oh, no, you're sure you can do this?"

"Yeah, yeah, you've just got my heart racing is all." She shook her arm out, rotated her hand on a swivel at the end of her wrist. It was steadier when she brought it back. She worked down his belly, scratching his hair away one swath at a time. She got his belly cleared, right to where his penis came out of his body. She swished the blade in the pasta bowl, rinsed it off. The razor worked down his shaft, starting at the base and coming down halfway. He had some hairs there she wanted to get rid of.

"You're getting hard," she warned him.

"Blame me? Open your robe for me."

"No way. We'll be on the floor in no time, this thing buried in me."

"You're right. That sounds terrible."

"This is for Pete today. We're going to make him suffer. Okay?"

"I'm game."

"Gosh, Tyler, don't get hard, I can't control myself."

"That's making me harder."

She laughed, the blade shaking on his slippery penis.

"Careful."

"There," she said, squinting through her glasses at his bald tool. "Now I have to do your balls."

She rinsed the blade off again, swished it around, got it clean and hot. She held his penis off to the side, up against his thigh. It was blocking her light, they should probably turn around, but Pete could be home any minute and they didn't have much time. She went over it and over it, swiping the front then the back, but every time she'd check she'd find another long hair there and then she'd do it all over again.

Finally, she thought she was done. “Bald as can be,” she proclaimed, holding it in her hand and flipping it from side to side.

“Did it make it look bigger?”

She laughed at that one, made her toss her head back. “It sure did,” she said.

She lifted the bowl up and let his penis and scrotum sink into it. She used the water from the bowl, splashing it up his shaft and onto his belly. “That’s good,” she said, picked her towel up and dried him off.

“There we go,” she said, stood up and grabbed her cocoa butter, shook the bottle.

“What’s that?”

“Probably your favourite part,” she said, squirting it into her hand. “Stand up.”

He stood up and got himself right in front of her. She looked up at him, his blue eyes sparkling in the light from the bathroom window. She sucked her lower lip right into her mouth. She rubbed the lotion into his balls, starting at the back, then the front pulling them down, then she worked his cock, rubbing it up and down. It made him groan, and she could see he wanted to bend down and kiss her. Her hands went up and down him, her eyes locked on his. He was pretty hard. It was getting a little uncomfortable. She was about to lose her control and spread her legs for him. She undid her robe, let it hang open. She pushed her bare body against him, his cock sticking up flat on her belly, sliding in between her breasts. She rubbed her body against it, felt it hard against her ribs, against her stomach, pressing it between them. She looked up into his eyes, felt his big hands work over her back under her robe.

A car door slammed out front and she darted to the window, tying her robe up. Pete was home.

“Okay, he’s here, he’s here,” she said. “Quick, go jump into the bed.”

Well, it was done. It was done and it was horrible.
He’d managed to put it off for four weeks now. A month and three days.

He'd fired Karla. She didn't take it well. She threw a tantrum, knocked a paperweight from his desk. Then she cried and he'd looked around his office, didn't know what to do. He watched her sob into her hands in the chair across from his desk and, when he stood up to see if he could find the nerve to put his hand on her back, she called him a fucking asshole. When she left she slammed the door so hard the little sign with his name had flown right off it. It took them a few minutes to find it, him and Tamicka going around on their hands and knees until she found it under a desk leaning up against a waste basket.

After it was over he left, got out of the office. He went and sat in the crapper for fifteen minutes. Sat there talking to himself quietly with his pants still buttoned up.

He was very glad to be home.

His front door was yanked open, pulled inwards as his hands came a breath from the handle. He jumped.

"Pete, get in here, quick."

Jess was standing there holding the door. She was wearing her short cotton robe, her legs bare, nothing on her feet.

"Jess, what is it, what's wrong?"

"Come in, it's good. Something I want to show you."

He stepped in, still a bit slow for her liking and she pulled the arm of his coat.

"Come on, it's cold out there." She pulled his briefcase from him, tossed it into the closet.

"What is it?"

She was on the stairs already. "Pete the boys are at your sister's for dinner, I said you'd pick them up. Please come on, we only have an hour."

He watched her legs as she went up the stairs, felt himself get a little aroused. What was this?

He followed her up, watching the flex of her calf, her perfect toes.

"Baby, what are you going to do?" he asked her.

"I'll show you. I can't wait, Pete, I've been absolutely dying to do this."

"You've got me excited, Jess," he was rushing up behind her.

"Yeah, look," she held the door open for him and he went into the bedroom, loosening his tie.

Tyler was stretched across their queen size bed absolutely naked. He lay his huge body corner to corner, his head on the pillow that Pete would rest

his head on tonight.

He was beautiful, Pete had to admit. The lacy curtains were drawn and the afternoon light played across all the deep peaks and valleys of his abs, his chest. He was the kind of dirty thing you would see on cards girls would give each other at Bachelorettes then giggle, cover their mouths. He had both his hands laced behind his head.

“Hey, Pete.”

“Hey,” Pete said.

Jess locked the bedroom door behind her, said, “Okay, Pete, I want you to sit up on the pillow. My pillow.”

“What?”

She moved past him, patted her pillow. *Sit right next to Tyler?*

“Jess, I don’t know...”

“Please, Pete, just do it. Hurry.”

Pete went to the bed and sat himself down, tucked one leg under the other, kept his other foot on the floor. He looked awkwardly at Tyler, so close to him. Tyler nodded to him, and he nodded back.

“Pete, look,” she said. She was standing at the foot of the bed, one knee on it now in between Tyler’s feet. She got down and ran her hand over Tyler’s penis. It was hanging straight down, resting on the bed and he couldn’t see it. “See?” Jess picked it up and let it fall across his hip. “And...” she held his balls up now, “I shaved him.”

“You did?”

“Yeah, just now. You should feel how smooth it is.” She was running her fingers over it, petting it.

“Jess, it was a really bad day.”

“Pete, don’t ruin this. Don’t be the party-pooper. Okay? I want you to watch something.”

He did feel aroused. She was being so weird, so dirty, it was doing something to him. More to his heart and soul, to the pit of his stomach, than his penis, but he had to admit she had his attention.

“All right, Jess. I’ll watch. Show me.”

“Okay, baby,” she said.

She stood up and undid the belt of her robe. He felt a sudden urge within him again, to stand up and stop this. Whatever it was it was going to be it was wrong, it was bad.

She opened her robe, shrugged her shoulders out and let it fall onto the floor.

“You’re so beautiful,” Pete said. She was watching Tyler. She put her knee back on the bed. Her body was amazing. So perfectly feminine, so soft and smooth. Her breasts swayed as she got down on her hands and knees and crawled up Tyler’s body. She got herself right over him face to face, kissed him, looked into his eyes. “Remember, don’t move,” she said to him.

“Yeah,” he said.

She buried her face in the crook of his neck, kissing him, hidden in the tangle of her white-blond hair. She worked away in there, Tyler lifting his head to let her do it. She kissed down his collar, then into his armpits. Pete could see her tongue out, flattened against his thick hair there, licking him. She bit at his arms, drew the lines of a dragon tattoo with the tip of her tongue. Then she was on his chest, kissing him, pulling on his nipples, biting and plucking them. Her hands scratched at his rock hard belly, pulled at his tight skin with her tiny fingernails. She got lower, her face over his big shaved penis. It had got a bit hard, stuck on the skin of his hip and had gone U-shaped like a diver doing the jack-knife. She kept her mouth off it, only let him feel her breath, then she was down his thigh, biting his knee. Kissing down to his feet, then getting on her knees at the foot of the bed. She licked the sole of his foot and Tyler shivered. Her mouth went over his big toe and she sucked on it.

“For Christ’s sake, Jess,” Pete said.

She smiled, her lips still wrapped around his toe, knowing she was killing her husband. She sucked on his toe, her eyes on Pete, her lips wrapped around it purposely making it look like a blowjob. Then she was pulling his toes apart and licking in between them, her soft wet tongue squishing in between and sliding through to the top side.

“Jesus,” Pete whispered, shaking his head.

Jess got back on the bed, walked on her knees in between his legs, stopping at his thighs. Her hand straightened out his penis, watched it move on its own as it started to stretch out of its wrinkled skin right in front of her. Then she bent in between his legs, her right hand circled his scrotum and pinched it, held his balls off to the side, against his thigh and out of the way. She licked below his sack, pushing her tongue hard against him there. Tyler moaned next to him and Pete looked at him. The King. Laying back receiving this pleasure from his wife, hands behind his head like he was on

a hammock after he'd mowed the lawn. His eyes were closed, his lips parted.

Tyler brought his knees up, spread his legs and Jess worked deeper, going lower.

"Aungh," Tyler groaned. He lifted his butt off the bed, planting his heels and curling his toes up.

Jess drove her tongue between his cheeks, still holding the kid's big balls off to the side.

"For fuck's sake, Jess."

He could see her back shaking with a laugh. She thought this was funny.

She pulled his balls straight up now so she could fit her head under them. She got her tongue right into his anus, he figured, given Tyler's reaction. She was still laughing, he could hear it in the moan she gave as she washed him up and down.

Then she was back up and she bit at the taut flesh of his scrotum, her bared teeth running over his testicles. Tyler dropped himself back down.

"Agh," he said, sounding pained. She smoothed her pouted lips over them, running their soft plumped shape across his sensitive parts. Her hand let them down gently.

"Don't you like his cock when it's shaved?"

Pete didn't answer, just watched her.

"I do," she said, sounding disappointed that he wasn't playing along.

She was stroking it now, looking at it in her hand, looking almost cross-eyed, sleepy. Tyler wasn't hard really, but he was getting there, filling up his wife's hand with his big soft tool. She pushed the fat head of his cock past her pouted lips with her index finger. He was soft enough that she could suck it in, his penis squishing past her lips. She sucked on it, her eyes closed, her fingers working his thick bald shaft.

"Ahh, that feels incredible," Tyler moaned next to him.

Jess kept at it, sucking and stroking, the kid's cock getting thicker and stiffer in his wife's hand. When she pulled him out of her mouth, letting it go with a satisfying pop, his wet cock head was full and plump.

"It's so big, Petey," she said.

She held it in her hand, swiping the underside of it with her outstretched tongue watching Pete's reaction.

He was dying. He felt like he was eroding right here in front of these two lovers. Like a good stiff breeze could come along and blow his dusty

body away forever.

“It’s kind of hard to suck him off,” she said. She was tapping his stiffened cock on her cheek. “But I’m going to do my best.” She gripped him by the base and ran him across her cheek over her pointed tongue then the other cheek.

“I’ve thought a lot about putting his bare cock in my mouth. I couldn’t wait for this.” She ran her pink tongue up the underside then plunged her mouth over the top, stuffing his fat end past her lips. She couldn’t get him very deep in her mouth. The skin of Tyler’s cock was bunching up along his shaft between his wife’s grip and her stretched out lips.

Then she started working her head on him, bobbing up and down on it, giving it a slight twist, rolling her head on her thin pretty neck. It was making Tyler moan, and his breath was heavy and slow.

Pete watched her pleasure him. She took her time with it, going very slow, then suddenly very fast. She would run a hand up him, then slide her delicate fingertips back down, then grip his balls quickly making him buckle and grunt. She never took her lips off the end of his cock. She dragged it out, making Tyler suffer. Pete looked at the clock by the bedside. She’d had this kid on the edge for almost half an hour. Half an hour with this guy’s cock inside her mouth and she hadn’t once taken a break, come up for air.

She had him close a few times, Pete could tell, his legs trembled and shook the bed. Tyler wanted to come but his wife wouldn’t let him. She backed off her stroking, backed off her sucking, let it subside and it would make him whimper. For a few minutes, she had let his cock go, held it only in her mouth, her arms stretched up his torso, her little hands raking across the muscles of his stomach. That had *her* moaning. Jess really loved this boy’s body. Tyler arched his back a few times like he was in pain, his face contorted and his hands covered his own face, his arms flexing and shaking.

She slowed, after what seemed like an impossible amount of time to suck a cock, she brought her knees up closer to him, got herself kneeling over him. She wrapped both her hands around his shaft, kept them together, her mouth was still over the end of him. He looked so incredibly huge in his wife’s hands. How could he be so big?

Then Jess’s head was bobbing and her hands stroked him in unison. It was on now. Even Tyler sensed it. His body relaxed as he focused everything he had on getting some release, on finally coming. His hands

went back behind his head, his eyes were closed again, and he grunted with every thrust of Jess's mouth down his cock.

"Oh, my God," Pete heard him whisper.

Jess's hands were stroking him vigorously now. She was going to let him come. She was going to make him come.

Pete saw her eyes were open, she was looking at Tyler, her mouth was pushed wide by his big thing stuffed in it. Tyler was watching her now too.

He heard Jess say, *Uh-huh*, like a question, a high girl-sound trapped in her throat.

Tyler said, "Yeah, oh yeah, don't stop."

Pete said, "Jess, what are you doing?"

Jess kept going, plunging and stroking, encouraging noises coming from her.

"Jess, he's going to come in your mouth."

She nodded, her eyes were locked on Tyler's.

"Jess, please, don't."

Her hands were stroking him furiously, her lips clamped over his glans.

"Tyler, please don't come in her mouth."

"Fuck, fuck, I can't help it, shit, she's so fucking good at this, Pete."

Uh-huh, uh-huh, Jess wanted it, still encouraging him.

"Raaah," Tyler roared out loud, his abs tightening as his body lifted up off the bed like he was trying to do a sit-up.

He was coming in Jess's mouth.

Pete could look away but he didn't, he watched it. Let the image burn in his mind, felt the horror, the pain, the agony it produced, the ball of hurt and contempt for himself that swirled like a dark sun in his heart. He watched his wife's hand milk it into her mouth, her little finger not even as wide as the base of her lover's cock. He saw the tendons that connected Tyler's huge dick to his body flex, stand out, cables bulging as he spewed into Jess's mouth.

Jess's eyes were locked on Tyler. She was beautiful. Dark. Dirty. More dirty than he could ever have imagined. She snorted through her nose, trying to breathe with her mouth stuffed full of Tyler's hard flesh. Her eyes trembled, the cords of her neck stood out, she was trying not to gag. She held it together and drank Tyler's semen. Her hands kept pumping and twisting, Tyler kept roaring, and the whole time she kept the head of his cock clamped in her mouth.

“Oh, shit, Jess, oh angel, baby...” Tyler’s head came back, and Pete could see his expression, see what his wife was doing to this kid.

Tyler kept pumping and pumping, Jess’s strokes were more careful now, in rhythm with her lover’s pulses. He was still coming and she was still swallowing. Tyler’s chest was heaving, he was sweaty. Pete could see Jess was sweaty too. Tyler was groaning, his breaths shuddering on the exhale.

Jess took her lips off him, sliding them up his big fat cock head, right up over the tip, forming a pout making sure not one drop of his seed escaped. His cock dropped back on his belly, glistening, emptied.

“Mmm,” Jess said, and she ran her hands up his length. “What did you think of that, Petey?”

“You’re breaking my heart.”

Jess opened her mouth to Pete, showed him her white molars, her pink tongue. She stuck it out as far as it would go. Like proving a magic trick. Nothing up my sleeve. *Yes, Jess, I see you swallowed every drop.*

“Hey, Petey, now I know what he tastes like.”

“Yeah, I guess you do, Jess.”

“Uh-oh, he’s mad,” Tyler said.

“Disappointed, maybe,” Pete said.

“I’m not.” She lay on her belly still between his legs, her feet were brought up behind her and he could see the soles as she crossed them over each other, scissoring them. She was smoothing the underside of Tyler’s cock, watching it under her fingers as she went up and down it.

“Do I taste good?” Tyler asked her. He put his hand down, brushed some hair out of her wet eyes, then held the side of her face. She looked up into his eyes and smiled at him, rested her head in his big palm.

“Mm-hmm,” she said. “Like...like a salty orange rind.”

“Oh, God, Jess. You’re disgusting,” Pete told her.

Jess laughed out loud, afternoon sun glinting on her wet lips. “Pete’s little double-a battery just spits acid,” she said, laughing at her own joke, closing her eyes and shaking, her head falling and resting on Tyler’s thigh.

“That’s really shitty, Jess.”

“I’m joking, Pete.” Then to Tyler, “But he is *really* bitter.”

“Like his personality.”

Jess laughed, said, “How did it make you feel, watching me suck this beautiful cock?”

“Horrible.”

Tyler said, “How do you do that, Pete? Sit there and watch that? What’s wrong with you?”

“He likes it,” Jess said.

“That is insane. I wouldn’t let anyone touch you.” Tyler reached down and brushed Jess's cheek with his big thumb.

“You should stop Petey from touching me. Climbing on me in the middle of the night and humping my leg with his tiny pecker.”

“Pete, stop touching my girlfriend, okay?”

“I’ll be downstairs.”

“Hey, Pete, come on. We’re only joking,” Jess said, mad he wasn’t playing along.

Pete got up, very aware of his erection poking out the front of his suit pants. Jess saw it too. He closed the front of his suit jacket over to hide it. He walked to the bedroom door.

Jess got up and came after him, stopped him while his hand was on the knob.

“Petey, Petey, baby, come here. I’m only kidding, honey.” She put her arms around his neck and hugged him to her.

Pete put his arms around her, felt the warm slim body of his naked wife. Used to be his wife.

“Pete we talked about this the other night.”

“Not in your mouth. That’s not what we were talking about.”

“C’mon Pete, we’ve talked about it before. Remember you said he would taste like steroids?”

“That was dirty talk. I didn’t—”

“We’re still on? For the other thing?”

“Yeah, I guess.”

“Are you okay?”

“I’m fine.”

“I thought you liked this.”

“I do. I don’t know. I don’t know what to think anymore. You’re making me crazy.”

She squeezed him, put her mouth over his and kissed him, holding his lips with hers. She pulled back, said, “I like making you crazy.”

He looked at her, trying not to show her the sadness and hurt that he felt. His stunning little lady, naked, her arms around him.

The thing was that watching her do that, while it made him want to scream, cry, slap the cock out of her mouth—it aroused him in a way he could never describe, never put into words. His belly ached. His loins really, if he were a romance writer. He couldn't explain it. He loved Jess. He hated to see her like this. So dirty and sexual, and more of a woman than she was when she was with him. He could never arouse her like that. He could never put a thrill up between her legs like Tyler did. Why did seeing her like this—when he hated it—make him so hard? He was aching for her right now. He wished he was Tyler. Wished that he could do that to his wife, turn her into the horny little teenager she'd become. He loved seeing her like this, just wished he had the equipment, the appeal, to be the one to do it. Ultimately, he guessed, he wanted it done. Wanted her pleased and it didn't matter who did it or how it got done.

Pete left her in the bedroom and headed for the stairs. Left his wife naked with her lover stretched out in their own bed. He had to go and pick up the boys. Patty was expecting him.

Shaking his head as he went down, cursing his life that it had to come to this, he smelled bleach in the hall. Thought Sargent had been peeing in the house again, Jess cleaning it up. That's when he'd realized what she'd done. It was his own mouth. Tyler's semen from his wife's lips when she'd kissed him.

"Ah, shit," he spit out the front door, scrubbed at his mouth and tongue with the sleeve of his suit jacket.

Had she done that on purpose? Put her semen-coated lips over his?

PART V

L A I D B A R E

LITTLE BABY

FRIDAY, NOVEMBER 4TH

“**W**hat’s this bowl?” Petey said.
“Yeah, what’s this bowl?” Andy imitating his brother.
“What do you mean?” Jess said, knowing what they meant.
“Where’s our favourite bowls?”

It was pasta night tonight. Spaghetti for the boys, fettucine for Tyler and Jess and Pete.

Jess looked over from the stove, saw Petey and Andy looking at the new bowls she’d bought. They weren’t happy. Practically the same bowls, maybe a little smaller and a different colour.

“I threw them out, boys, I bought you better ones.”

“Threw them out? Why?”

“It was just time for new bowls, okay?” she said, dropping fettucine into the new bowls for the rest of them. She’d put the old bowl back after she’d shaved Tyler, cleaned it with bleach. Then standing at recess today she’d had a virtual panic attack. She could let them sit in bleach for a year it couldn’t erase the image of Tyler’s big slippery cock and his heavy balls practically filling the bowl up. It was one bowl out of six. Russian Roulette. Who was going to be eating from the cock bowl?

So she stopped at the Save-Mart on the way home, frantic, bought the best ones she could. She’d taken the old ones from the cupboard and put them in the garbage. Then she’d tied it up, and dropped it on the garage floor a few times, made sure they were cracked and broken in there.

“I like these bowls better, all right?” she said, and she brought dinner over for Tyler and Pete. Both of them oblivious to this conversation, to the

implication. Tyler might have figured it out but he wasn't paying attention.

The boys dropped it and she was thankful. She had too much on her mind. She couldn't even eat. She'd nibbled while she cooked and that was going to be enough. She watched the four men in her life gulp their food down, resting her elbows on the counter.

"You're not eating, Mom?" Petey asked her. He was so attentive. So in tune with how other people felt. He was the greatest kid.

"No, Petey, I think I ate too much already while I was cooking." She wouldn't tell him about the butterflies in her stomach. How his mommy was going to pull the craziest stunt of her life tonight. She wasn't going to mention that her belly was so tight in anticipation that food could not pass. It would fall right back out of her mouth.

"You looking forward to staying at your Auntie Patty's tonight?"

"Mmm," Petey hummed, brow furrowed. He looked nervous.

She sensed that there had been some sort of falling out between Petey and Jacob. Little boy stuff. They would work it out.

"Do I have to go, Mom?"

"Yes, Petey. You always have such a good time."

"Why can't I stay here? Where are you going?"

Jess turned to the table, bit the inside of her lower lip. She could see the beaten slope of her husband's shoulders as he slumped over the table eating his dinner, his back to her. He wasn't helping. Tyler had checked out. Either really disinterested in the whole thing or worried that this family stuff could kill the mood, stifle an erection.

He was as hard to figure sometimes as her husband. What was he doing here? Why was he still here? He was young and handsome. Incredibly fit. Obscenely hung. Shouldn't he be out all the time, meeting people his own age? He never talked about being fired. Not seriously. Only to defend himself, say they were in the wrong. Was he really hurting from this? She had started to suspect that he was. That he was getting some sort of spiritual nourishment living with her family.

"Petey, we just have some grown up things to do tonight. Obligations. We won't be here for you, kiddo. It's almost near bedtime anyway. You'll get there and before you know it you'll be asleep, okay? Then I'll pick you up first thing in the morning."

He didn't answer. He kept eating. A little more slowly, pensively. He nodded.

Andy watched his brother. Whatever he would do Andy would do. Ultimately it didn't matter what they wanted. They couldn't be here. She needed one night for herself. Needed things to not be difficult. Everyone play their parts.

This had been a tough week. They were getting close to the time that Tyler should be leaving and she hadn't had a real chance to be with him. She brought him in because it was the right thing to do but she wanted more. She had an ulterior motive. It wasn't hidden, Tyler knew it and Pete definitely knew it. It hadn't happened though. And being so close, so familiar with Tyler, had put a real fire between her legs. To sit on the couch with him, see him in the morning in his tight T-shirt, watching him work out, running into him in their narrow halls, wishing she would get a chance to be with him... But it never happened. Not until yesterday. Shaving him had been incredibly erotic. More exciting than she'd anticipated. And the blowjob? Well, that was almost entirely for Pete. She enjoyed every minute of it but tonight was what she really wanted. Ached for. She wanted to be pounded. To feel him hurt her between her legs, punish her girl parts. Feel his hot, hard cock naked inside her. Feel his muscle under her fingers, taste his lips—feel his seed.

"Come on, boys. Let's get your things together, grab your gear."

"All right, Mom," Petey said. He was going to go even if he didn't want to. He hung his head while she walked him and Andy down the hall.

She couldn't believe her luck when Patty took her aside at the Halloween Party. She wanted to know if Jess could take Jacob and Tammy for an overnight on the weekend of the twelfth. *Of course, Patty* she told her, then without the slightest hesitation, asked, Would you take mine on the Fourth? Patty said, This Friday? Yeah, sure, why? Jess gave her a pained expression, said, Don't ask—it's just a lot, you know... She shook her head, acted like it was too hard to explain. Patty said, Yeah, I can't imagine.

Pete couldn't shake the worried look his sister had given him when he'd dropped the boys off. The guilt he felt about all of this was enormous. It was just a sleepover to the boys but it was bigger than that for Pete. He needed them out of the house so he could watch his wife with her

lover. It was a terrible thing. Could Patty read it on his face? Suspect that something strange was up? What would she think? More likely she would assume there was trouble between Pete and Jess. That they needed some house-time to have a real shouting match. Didn't want the kids to hear that. After all, Pete's wife had invited another man into their home—it would seem natural that her husband would find it too much. Were there holes in his game? Was it possible that his sister could figure out what was really happening? Had Pete let something slip somewhere along the way, had Jess ever let something slip? What would his sister think of him? How mad would she be at him? He would be mortified.

Pete got out of his Buick, looked up at the eighteen-hundred square-foot two-storey he and Jess had been living in since they were married. Could see his bedroom was dark but the light in the master bathroom was on. Jess was getting ready.

The light was on in the garage, two pill-shaped windows in the grey painted roll-up bright white in the dark. When he walked up the path to the door he could see into the garage through the narrow windows in the brick wall. Tyler was in there, working up a sweat. Pete watched him, one of those cannonballs with the handles in each hand, curling them, alternating right, then left. He shone with sweat, his arms were pumped, glistening, bulging—his veins stood out, crisscrossing under the dark lines of his tattoos.

He didn't know if he could ever get rid of the image of his sweet Jess sucking that big cock of his until it came inside her mouth. She just seemed to enjoy it so much. He knew she got off on teasing him, he could tell that there was a piece of her that was thrilled knowing that Pete wanted her to do it, wanted to watch her perform, but that mostly it wounded him deeply. She performed it perfectly too. Surgical precision, slicing her blade right through the tough meat of his leathery heart. She had prepared Tyler, shaved him. Slice. She teased Tyler, kept his orgasm from him, playful, devious. Slice. She had a surprise ending, she let him defile her mouth. Slice. Another surprise, she liked his taste. Slice. She turned Tyler into a high school bully and herself into the pretty cheerleader. Slice. She kissed Pete on his lips, leaving the traces of her lover's seed on him. Slice, slice, slice. She'd dissected him.

When he had made this arrangement with her, confessed to the woman he loved—the mother of his children—his deepest, darkest desires he had

no way to expect she would be so good at tuning into his hurt, his pain. She had twisted his knob, found the frequency, and the signal was loud and clear. She got it. She either loved him so much she wanted this for him, or he was finding out that part of Jess really did hate him.

He poured himself a whisky once he was in the house, shoes off, Sargent put out in the yard. He took a sip and looked around the dark kitchen. He smiled. He couldn't feel the dread. It wasn't there right now. It could, of course, jump out of the shadows at any moment but right now when he concentrated he realized all he could feel was excitement. Anticipation. He felt like tonight Jess had brought him back into the fold. They were a couple again. This was for them both. Tonight he was going to watch the woman he loved receive pleasure. He couldn't wait to hear her make those noises again. That kid in the garage with the big biceps was going to fuck his wife, make her scream, make her come. He was happy for her.

He went upstairs to the bedroom, heard the hiss of the shower. He leaned in the doorway of the bathroom, pushed the door open wider with his middle finger. He could see the flesh-coloured shape of his wife behind the frosted vinyl curtain. Could see her head must have been turned up, facing the shower head, could see the movement of her arms as she scrubbed herself, one leg slightly bent. He felt aroused watching her even though he couldn't make out a single detail. But he knew all those details, didn't need to see them. He knew what she felt like under his hands, knew what she smelled like, how she liked his tongue between her legs. She hadn't been with him now for almost two weeks. Part of her game. He knew it. The message: *Why fuck you when I have a big dick stud? Don't waste my time.* The torture was exquisite. He didn't deserve her. Tyler did. Or she deserved Tyler, more accurately.

Pete sat in the dark bedroom in a chair he'd placed where he would get the best view of the action. He sat with his whisky, sipping and staring at their bed, comforted by the whine of Jess' hair dryer. He'd laid out lingerie for her, the pieces organized on the bed for her when she was ready. Black lace and stockings, a thong panty, brought home from the Save-Mart.

She was doing her makeup now and his heart pounded—they were so close to it happening. He couldn't wait.

"Pete?" she called him from the bathroom.

He got up and went in, saw her in all her glory. She was standing in the bathroom completely naked. Her hair was done, clean, shining, styled down over her shoulders. Her makeup was ready, red on her lips just a little black on her eyes, she smelled of lemony perfume. He took her in, her slim bare shoulders, her thin waist and the swell of her hips. Her full breasts swayed slightly, her rosy nipples swollen and gently pointed but not quite hard yet.

"Jess." He was stunned. "Oh, Jess, honey, you look so beautiful." He could feel his eyes well up with tears. How was he so lucky to be with her?

"Thank you, baby," she said, smiled at him, broke his heart. "Could you do my toenails for me?"

"Yeah, of course," he said, put his drink on the shelf above the sink.

Jess climbed up on the counter, brought her legs up, heels resting on the edge. She hugged her knees to her, shook her hair behind her. Her eyes watched Pete, watched him as he took her in. His pretty wife, strangely naked, perched up on the bathroom sink. She knew how odd this looked, how crazy every bit of this was. He could see it in her face. She could see it in his. Pete could tell she was committed. There were no second thoughts. She might be quiet but it wasn't some epic struggle going on between those teeny, well-shaped ears. She was going to do this. Her silence was meditative. Reflective.

Pete shook her bottle of polish, taking in the smooth skin of her knees and her calves as he did. He dragged a stool to sit below her, her feet at his chest.

He could see her smooth pretty mound peeking at him between the backs of her milky thighs, the slightest ruffle of her darker folds in the middle. That was his. Was supposed to be his. His wife should like it if he were to reach out and gently stroke her but tonight he felt he couldn't do that. If he were to reach out she would resist. Tonight she *wasn't* his. Tonight she belonged to a better man. A masculine man who put a tingle in her dirty spots. He made her a woman. Pete made her a mom. Pete gave her the responsibilities, the burdens of life. While she cherished those boys there was nothing wrong with forgetting it all. Taking her lover and escaping. Going back to the time when she was a young woman and almost

anything was possible. That's what he delivered with that big dick she was crazy about. Youth.

Even the way she was sitting like this was so different than the Jess he knew as his wife. Sitting with her legs drawn up, completely bare, exposing her dirtiest part to him. Shameless in a way that was not like the woman he knew. Sexually confident now, letting her sex be seen, knowing what it was doing to her husband. Knowing she wasn't going to allow him to touch it. She was the queen and he was the servant in this moment. And you wouldn't dare touch the queen.

"Are you excited?" she asked him as he brushed the clear polish onto her tiny toenails.

"I am."

"Do you remember our first time?"

Of course he did. He wasn't proud of it. They'd both had too much to drink. They made love on her couch in her apartment and Pete didn't pull out. He came inside her. It was an accident. She didn't even realize it, both of them falling asleep. Nine months later they had a son.

"Yes."

She didn't answer. This was punishment. She didn't remember their first time. This was a symbolic coupling tonight. Tonight a man was going to come inside her and she knew it. She was prepared for it. Mentally, physically. There was a lot of meaning behind tonight's events and Jess was making sure Pete didn't miss it. Tyler was the type of man who should have come inside her. Who should have given her a baby. He was the better man.

"I want this for you, Jess," he said, and he kissed her knee. He inhaled deeply, his heart feeling a little heavy now, the dread finding him, lurking still but getting closer. He smelled her soap and perfume, but something else under it. Her musk, her desire. Jess was so aroused with the anticipation of what Tyler was going to do to her tonight Pete could see she was damp, glistening.

Jess let Pete watch her get dressed. He sat in his chair poring over every movement she made, lit up by a lone table lamp by the bed. She turned, showed him her rump as she slid the panties up her thighs, the string

back of the thong pinching up between her cheeks. She posed for him, let him see her with her hands on her hips, wearing the tight little panties while she checked herself out in the mirror over the dresser. Then the lacy corset, still showing him her back while her slim wrist came up behind her and zipped it up. Then she turned, let him watch her scoop her breasts out and up, sit them properly in the tight bustier of the lingerie. She turned herself in the mirror, Pete's eyes like lasers on her. Then she sat herself on the bed, pulled the fishnet stockings up her leg, snapped into the garter. She stepped into the heels he'd left by the side of the bed. Black patent pumps, the same shoes she wore that night she'd convinced Tyler to come out to the minivan for a quickie.

She was ready now. She sat on the edge of the bed, her feet together, shoulders up to her ears, hands gripping the edge of the mattress. Where was he? Where was the man of the house? What if he didn't show? Went out to do something or someone better. What if he'd left her dejected, alone and embarrassed with her cuckold husband? What if she wasn't really the one in charge here? Couldn't Tyler fuck better girls than her? Younger?

She looked at the red digital readout on the clock radio. It was after 8 P.M., he should have been here by now. Jess looked to Pete, she could feel her courage waning.

Then they both heard his bedroom door across the hall. Her heart jumped. Pete stood up and she stood too, both of them facing the bedroom door. He knocked twice, loud, making her flinch.

"Come in," Pete said.

She said it too, a beat behind him, "Come in."

The door opened and Tyler came through, closed the door behind him. He was naked.

She felt herself shudder at the sight of him. Her shoulders literally trembled. He looked so beautiful, so crazily out of place in her tiny suburban bedroom. He seemed to fill up the whole room with his presence.

"You look amazing," he said.

She felt herself blush, said, "Thank you. You look... Yeah..." she laughed. Smooth, Jess, smooth.

Pete sat back down in his chair, got himself out of their way, out of their minds. He pulled the chain, turned off the lamp next to him.

Tyler walked to her. She watched the ripple of his muscle, the deep lines in his thighs as he came to her. She could hear the soft damp sound of his

cock bouncing from thigh to thigh in the three steps it took him.

“Let me look at you,” he said. He held his hand out and she took it, and he held it up while she turned for him, showed him her backside.

“Unbelievable,” he said.

He sat himself on the edge of her bed and put a hand on either side of her waist, she put her hands on his enormous shoulders. They stared at each other for a moment, looking into one another’s eyes. She had to look away, it was too intense. She felt a burning in her belly. An incredible desire. She felt like a live-wire between her legs now. A single touch could set her off. She wanted his cock inside her so badly. Hard as steel, buried deep in her body, thrusting and thrusting, urgently building to incredible release. She craved that release, she was dying to find out what a man with a real cock felt like when he came inside her. She wanted it so bad it extinguished her nerves, her fears. So what if he came in her, what was the worst? She was prepared. So what if she got pregnant. Would it be that bad? They could have another kid. She wanted one. She’d love another little baby.

Pete watched Tyler’s big tattooed hands caress Jess’s ass. He squeezed and lifted her cheeks, his fingers sliding delicately between them, and he could see it gave Jess goosebumps across her upper arms. Her hands were feeling his shoulders, looking so small on his massive frame. Jess’s back was to Pete and he could hear Tyler sucking at her flesh, her belly maybe, her chest.

“Mmm,” she said, “I still can’t get used to how good you feel.” She grabbed at his thick traps, her hands barely denting his flesh. “You’re so powerful,” she whispered.

Tyler’s right hand swept across her ass, his middle finger slowly diving into the space where her cheeks curled to the tops of her thighs.

“Ohh,” she gasped and Pete could see his wife’s legs shake. “Oh, God, I am so ready,” she said.

“I can feel how ready you are.” The muscles of his forearm rippled as his finger worked into that warm space that Pete loved. He knew what Tyler was feeling right now, the softness of the inside of her thighs, her heat, the

moist fabric of her panties when she was aroused. He was as hard as a bone in his pants now.

Jess's hips swayed as she stepped her feet out a little wider, let Tyler have some room. Her legs so shapely in her fishnet stockings, her calves flexed in the heels, her toes pointed. He had never known she could look so sexual.

Tyler ran his hand up her ass, his finger sliding under the thong strap then back down, pulling it out from between her cheeks, twisting it and pulling it aside. He swiped gently at her bare sex. Pete knew the feel of it, the damp flesh, wrinkled dry edges turning hot pink and slippery as she got engorged.

"Ah," Jess whispered, her head came back, her pale blonde hair tickling the smooth skin of her back. "Put your finger inside me."

Pete watched Tyler's hand curl up between her legs now, that big, thick middle finger of his was sliding up inside his wife.

"Oh," she gasped and she whipped forward, her head coming to rest in his collar. She was bent at the waist now, her sex exposed to Pete. He watched Tyler plunge his finger in and out of his wife, being gentle but firm. Her sex made wet squishing noises, Tyler's hand shone in the light from her wetness.

"Don't stop," she whispered into his neck.

"I can't believe how wet you are," he said.

"I've been thinking about this every minute you've been in the house, every time I've served you dinner, passed you in the hall, this is what I've wanted."

"If we didn't have rules I would fuck you every day. Fuck you on every surface of this little house."

He pushed his finger inside her as deeply as he could get it, wriggled his hand, making her cry out.

"Aow," she gasped and she slapped at his shoulders, clawed at them, stood up straight again. He kept at it, his hand a frenzied blur as he drove his wife wild.

"Oh, no, oh, no," she gasped. She stood right up straight, her cheeks clamping down on his hand, her soft flesh folding over his knuckles. He kept his pace, buzzing that finger around inside her. Jess's legs were trembling, he had her on the edge, she was gulping whisper breaths, slowly filling her lungs while he made her come.

“Aungh,” she collapsed into him, her arms going around his neck to support herself as she fell over him. Her knees buckled and she fell in his lap.

“Oh,” she said, “oh, I’m on fire right now... You’re going to make me come a thousand times tonight.”

He put his lips over hers, bit her lower lip and pulled it. Pete saw him pull it right out let it go, saw his wife’s plump lip hang until she pulled it back into her mouth, bit it with her own teeth. She smiled at Tyler, looking into his eyes.

“Let’s get you hard,” she said. “I need you inside me so bad right now.” She kissed her way down his chest, over his stomach. Tyler leaned back, put his hands out behind him on the bed.

She looked so amazing. Crouching down between his legs in her heels and lingerie. It accentuated her beautiful female form. Her ample bottom, her tiny waist, Pete ached for her. Wished he had the big cock she was stroking right now. Jess was showing him, letting him see her get her hung lover hard. She stroked him, milked him down, cradled his balls. Then she was running her tongue up the side.

“God, Pete. This dick...” she said, squeezing it in her fist and admiring it, showing it to Pete. Tyler was getting aroused, firmer in her hand. She put her mouth over his head, sucked it in, then worked her way down his shaft getting as much in her mouth as she could. Her hands dug into his thighs now, her nails scratching at his skin.

“Oh, yeah, Jess,” Tyler whispered to her.

Then she pulled her head back, his penis fell and bounced off the side of the bed. She held the base of him, slapped him against his own thigh. Her other hand went over the end and she stroked it hard and fast, pinching and gripping with one hand jerking him with the other.

“Oh, yeah,” he said, his head went back. He was straining from the pleasure Jess was giving him. Jess was watching his flexing abs as she got him hard. “Ah, stop,” he said, buckling.

She let him go, his big cock erect now, wagging and bobbing between his thighs. Jess straddled him, got her knees on the bed on either side of him and reached back between her legs to pull her thong aside.

Tyler gripped his manhood at the base, lifted it up between her legs, found her heat. He tapped the top of the big head of his cock against her wet sex and it made her moan.

“Oh, Tyler,” she said. He did it harder, making wet slaps against Jess, slapping the top of his cock, teasing her with it.

“Ah, put it in me,” she said.

He leaned back to get his hand angled, stroked the tip back over her sex a few times then drove his hips up gently until his cock started to pierce her.

“Ow,” she whispered, “ow, do it.”

He backed off then thrust forward again, Pete could see it sink into his wife.

She moaned as he slowly forced his thick tool inside her. He worked it in and out until he had himself coated with her wetness.

“God, Tyler, your bare cock feels so good.”

“You feel so hot inside,” he whispered.

“I can feel every detail of that perfect cock, every wrinkle, ah...go slower.”

Tyler slowed down, his cock disappearing inside her at a snail’s pace, Jess’s head was turned up, her mouth open in a permanent gasp. She squeaked once, shuddered. He sunk it deeper, his wife intent on the experience of feeling his cock without a condom. Getting to experience the naked sex with him she’d dreamed of. Every bit of Jess was tuned into the feel of this big invader sliding into her hot wet hole. Pete could see her slowly get filled up, slowly get stretched wide. Tyler was getting harder, thicker while he was inside her. Pete still couldn’t believe Jess found that size pleasurable, it looked like it was injuring her.

Then Jess was in control, raising her hips, bringing her stretched pink insides up, getting some relief, then plopping back down on him, getting him stuffed back inside her.

“Mm,” she whispered, biting her lips inside her mouth. She worked up and down, making a steady rhythm on him, sliding her skewered sex over his pole, she would thrust and bounce up and down, change direction, forward and back, making Tyler’s balls swing.

She got herself sweating, her hands clawed at his shoulders, then they gripped his big biceps, then her head was right back and her fists rested on his traps. She went on for almost twenty minutes, rising and falling, bringing herself to orgasm, her cries getting high, breathy, almost an imperceptible squeak. Pete was sure she had come twice. Tyler was rock hard now, the skin of his wide cock tight and shining with Jess’ fluids.

She stopped, lifted herself off of his cock and it fell from her insides and slapped against his leg.

“I don’t want to make you come like this,” she said. She got on the bed next to him, lay on her side. “I don’t want to be in control—do you understand?” Tyler turned and she lay on her back and spread her legs for him. “I want to be out of control. Wait, look at me...”

Tyler was up on his knees, getting himself between her legs.

“Do you understand me? I want you to be out of control, too. I want you to fuck me with no inhibition. Urgent, desperate, I want you to take me, claim me, plant your seed deep inside me.”

“You want me to come inside you?”

“Yes, I need you to.”

“Are you on the pill?”

“No. But it’s okay. Today is the day. You can do it today.”

“Are you sure?”

“I’m positive, baby. Come inside me. Give it to me.” Her hand was stroking him, stroking and pulling him to her heat. He didn’t stand a chance.

He plunged himself deep inside Jess in one quick motion, making her yell out. Pete could see her bite her lip and she wrapped one arm around his massive neck and pulled herself up to him, hugged herself to him.

Tyler fucked her like she wanted. He gave her every hard thick inch with each thrust, plunging into her until Pete could see his damp balls sticking to her.

“Oh my God, Pete, he gets so deep, you have no idea how good he feels.” She yelled over Tyler’s shoulder.

She had Tyler grunting.

“Tell me Jess, tell me how good it feels.”

“Ah, Pete, he’s right up in my uterus, baby.” Her heels came around his waist, locked him into place as he pounded into his wife. She looked so small underneath his huge frame. Her little fists were clenched over his massive shoulders, her high heels dangled above his big round rump. They had Pete sweating, he had to wipe his brow and his eyes stung. The room was filled with a humid musk, he could smell the familiar sex smell of his pretty wife but it was being dominated by Tyler’s heavy pheromones. She was like a smooth little plaything under all his rippling muscle and tattoos. He looked like he was hurting her. He was hurting her but she loved it, she wanted it.

“Fuck me, Tyler, fuck me harder.”

The bed frame was rattling against the drywall now, and the light in the room warbled as the lampshade vibrated from their passion.

“Ah, shit,” she screamed, “ah, you’re so big, give it to me, give it to me.”

Tyler was wordless, he was growling and grunting, he was what she wanted: desperate. He had something inside him that biology demanded he deliver and every hormone in his body was firing off green lights. *Give it to her, give it to that bitch.* His muscles bulged and glistened, the veins stood out like hoses on his arms, his big round ass flexed and tightened with every thrust. Every fibre of his being wanted to deliver his seed inside Pete’s wife. This was dirty animal sex, copulation, procreation, sheer animal lust, husbandry, breeding. It was beyond passion, it was biological necessity, two ideally matched mates about to create a life, their progeny.

“Ah, fuck, fuck, fuck,” Tyler was yelling now, his voice hoarse and dry.

Jess pounded on his shoulders, her hands curled up into tiny white fists, “Fuck me baby, fuck me,” she shouted. Her head whipped from side to side, her pretty blonde hair twisting around her. They had both gone out of their minds.

“Ah, fuck, I’m coming, ah, fuck,” Tyler screamed, the tendons in his neck bursting from his skin.

“He’s going to give me a baby, Petey,”

“Ah, fuck—”

“He’s going to, ah, plant a little Tyler inside me, ah, oh... We’re going to run off to Mexico together—”

“Fuck—”

“Give me that come, baby, give it.”

Tyler’s head flew back as he shot his semen into Jess. Pete watched his balls disappear, climb right up inside his body.

“Oh, God, that feels so good,” Jess screamed as Tyler buried his huge cock inside her and held it.

Jess had never felt anything like it. First when he was stabbing into her she thought she might not be able to take it. She thought she was

going to have to stop. She felt the uncomfortable thudding against her cervix, his hard knotty head mashing against her farthest, deepest wall. But something came over her and she started to enjoy it. Enjoyed her lover's tip spreading her farthest reaches, so big he was going into places he shouldn't go. That dark thought turned the discomfort to dirty passion. She encouraged him, wanted him to penetrate her deeper.

And when he came she felt his fiery hot seed splashing her more deeply than she could ever feel a man. She felt his forceful streams, like jets, tickling her insides. It set her off and she quivered, cried out, an orgasm starting somewhere in her sides, in her waist, then spreading up through her back. She cried out again as he shot hot pulse after hot pulse inside her, still thrusting, coating her insides, pumping his semen, spreading it over every bit of her soft insides.

Now he was still plunging, still thrusting deep and holding, she could feel him still flexing inside her, still pulsing the last of his semen inside her. His roars had turned to shuddering groans as his body demanded that he plant his offspring deep inside her, every last drop he had, ensuring his species' survival.

"Holy fuck, Jess," he whispered into the crook of her neck. She scratched lightly at his hard back. "Fuck, I have never, ever, come like that, oh, my God."

She could feel his body trembling. He was slick with sweat.

She milked his cock with her muscles, pulling him softly and squeezing him, emptying him inside her. She rotated her hips, swivelled, felt how slippery he was, how full he'd filled her. She held him to her, wrapped her arms around him, wanted this moment to last a while.

Then he was sliding himself out of her and she felt the sting. "Ooh, ow, careful," she said.

He pulled it out, then lay it across her mound up on her belly. He was slick, slimy, his erection fading but still monstrously large. He rubbed it through her folds, up her mound into her belly button, making her shiny. She watched his dark red skin against her pale soft belly.

"I can't believe you wanted that," he whispered.

She nodded.

"That was fucking incredible," he said. He was glowing. He rolled off of her, collapsed on the bed next to her, laying flat on his back.

Her hand went between her legs, an urge to touch herself. She felt how wet he'd left her, how stretched and puckered she was. He'd left her gaping. She stung and ached. His semen leaked from her, she could feel it, getting cold now, running from her insides, in between her cheeks down to the bed. She sat up and looked between her legs, covered herself up with her fingers. She was sitting in a pool of his semen, could see spots on the comforter, dark, white blobs in the centre. She closed her legs up.

Pete was watching her, sitting in the dark corner in his arm chair. His face was grim. He wasn't mad but she'd given him a show. That had done something to him. She didn't know what yet but she would find out she supposed. How did that look from his angle? How did she look to him? What must he think of her?

"Jess?" Pete's voice, worried.

She brought her knees up, put her arms around them. She touched her forehead to them, shook her hair so it would cover her face. She wanted to be alone right now.

Pete came to her, sat on the other side of her on the bed and when she felt his hand on her back, she started to sob. She was dry, she had no tears, but she was racked with shame.

"Jess, it's okay, baby."

Tyler sat up too, moved next to her. "What's wrong? Jess, did I hurt you?"

"I'm fine," she said into her lap, hiding her face from them.

"C'mon, baby, Jess, that was fantastic, you wanted that," Pete said.

"I know, I know. It was a lot."

Tyler's hand was on her, big and warm taking up the entire flat of her lower back. "That was amazing, Jess. The best sex I've ever had."

"Really?" she said, quiet.

"Oh, fuck, Jess. Come here, girl." He pulled her into his chest and hugged her to him. She put a small hand over his upper arm, felt how hard he was, how strong.

She looked over at Pete, watching the two of them, his face was blank, beaten.

"Pete, it was really amazing. He is so incredible."

BUCCANEER BAY

MONDAY, NOVEMBER 7TH

Things had changed around the old Mapplethorpe household in the last few days and Pete could feel it. There was an electricity in the air. Not something dry and static, quickly discharged if you touched a door knob. Something was building, something huge, like a storm on the horizon. The air would sometimes sizzle.

There was something between Jess and Tyler. He thought it had been fading but their exchange on Friday seemed to have sparked something new. Tyler had already transformed his wife into a horny sixteen-year-old, but since Friday she had regressed. Fourteen? Like if she had a locker at high school she would have a dozen pictures of Tyler in it. Smitten.

Nothing she said, nothing she overtly did, it was subtle. She had handed Tyler his dinner last night, made eye contact with him, smiled, looked down, blushed, looked away. Like a kid. Pete loved it. Loved to see her like that but he would be a fool to ignore the danger. This game had consequences. As happy as he might be for his rejuvenated fresh-faced little Jess, he had a family to defend. And the object of her affections was so large a presence in their home Pete could be pushed right out a window by his big broad shoulders.

Standing in the kitchen now, 5:47 P.M., the house empty, he felt that danger like a presence.

Where was his family? Where were they all?

Pete went upstairs to get changed, get out of his suit and tie. He got his comfortable pants on and a light sweatshirt, stood looking over the bed. It was a PD day at school. Jess had the day off, she would have been all alone

all day with the boys and with Tyler. There was work she was supposed to catch up on, required to. She was up late last night, marking tests, drawing happy faces on some of them with a pink marker.

Alone in the house all day.

Petey and Andy were home of course, they wouldn't be completely alone together. But still. Jess was like a different person. Sometimes he couldn't believe her behaviour. Some of the things she did seemed to be for Pete's benefit, to get him going, to make him suffer the way he enjoyed. But some of that was a charade. She did the dirty things she wanted to do then blamed it on Pete.

He got on the bed, smoothed the sheets out with his palms. Looking for semen stains, something. Please stay with me, Jess. Don't let me lose you. I couldn't bear it for real.

He heard a car door from the driveway.

They were all home, he could see them getting out of the minivan. Tyler out of the driver's side, Jess smiling in the passenger seat, unbuckling her seatbelt. He gripped the curtain as he watched them. Jess opened the sliding door and worked on Andy's car seat. Tyler had the hatch open getting things out of the back. Had they gone shopping?

Petey was in there too, talking to his mom a mile a minute. Jess was laughing with him about something. Jess hefted heavy Andy out and set his feet on the asphalt and he was already on the go, heading for the front door. Petey jumped down out of the van, excited, and followed behind his little brother. Jess closed it up and waited for Tyler. Tyler came around from the back, a sports bag slung over his shoulder, a couple of their big towels draped over it. Jess was watching him. When he was up next to her, he put his hand around her waist and they were talking. They looked a little worried. Pete thought they might kiss. His heart stopped beating while he watched their little intimate exchange out there. This man with his kids, touching his wife—God, the way she looked into his eyes. They were close, but they stopped themselves from bringing their mouths together. Then Tyler walked his wife up the driveway with his hand on the small of her back. He watched, dying inside until they passed below the window where he couldn't see them. He took a quavering breath then went downstairs.

"Dad, Dad?" Petey was hollering for him when he got down to the kitchen.

"I'm here, Petey," he said as he came through to the hall.

“Oh man, Dad, we went to Buccaneer Bay, it was so awesome.”

Pete bent down and picked him up and hugged him.

“Buccaneer Bay?”

“Hi, Dad,” Andy yelled, also very excited. Jess came in to the kitchen, Tyler right behind her. Jess looked a little concerned.

“It’s a water park, Dad. It’s indoors, like, in this huge building, there’s palm trees and water slides, and, like, Hula dancers.” Hula dancers said as a question, unsure of the word.

“Hula dancers,” Pete confirmed. “Where was this?” he asked. Petey wouldn’t know.

“Sandusky,” Jess said, quietly, not looking him in the eye.

“That’s pretty far,” Pete said to Pete Jr. held close to him up on his hip, his arms hugging him.

“Yeah, it was a long drive but we had fun, we played road games.”

“Gosh, Petey, Andy, that sounds like a great day. Wish I could have gone with you guys.”

“Yeah, you would have had so much fun. Tyler and I went down the water slide, like, a hundred times.”

Jess lifted Andy up and sat him on the counter, licked her thumb and wiped around his mouth. Tyler stood for a moment, didn’t say anything, then walked through and into the laundry room, threw the towels into the hamper in there.

Pete put Petey down, sat him next to Andy on the counter. “It sure sounds like a great way to spend the day, guys. What a treat, Jess.”

“Okay, boys,” she said, “let’s go get washed up for dinner.” She helped Andy down to the floor. “Petey, take your brother.” Petey came and he took Andy’s hand and headed for the stairs with them.

“Look, Pete,” she said, watching them disappear, turning to go up the stairs, “I hope you’re not mad.”

“Mad? Because you and Tyler went and took my boys for a family fun day? That would be so crazy of me. What a silly thing to be mad about.”

“I know, Pete. I know. It was for the boys, I swear.”

“Sure it was, Jess.”

Tyler passed by, heading upstairs.

“Did he drop off a job application at the Water Park?”

“Come on, Pete—”

“You’re making it too comfortable for him here, you know.”

“Pete.”

“He’s supposed to be looking for a way to get back on his feet, get himself out of here. You spread your legs for him, take him out on field trips with my family. Why would he ever want to leave? He’s got you and now my boys.”

“Pete, don’t be ridiculous, we had to do something with the boys today.”

“We?”

“Well, why not?”

“You don’t think it would be a little outrageous—you know, given the circumstances—to be seen with another man at a water park? I know you recognize it’s crazy. I know you know how that would look, how obvious it would be to any of our friends or co-workers who saw it. You know how I know?”

“Pete—”

“You went to fucking Sandusky. Great Wolf Lodge right around the corner, you went all the way to Sandusky so no one would see you two together.”

Jess couldn’t answer him. He knew he was right. Maybe she didn’t think that doing that was such a big deal, but it fucking was.

“You went to great lengths to accommodate him,” Pete said. “You say it was for the boys but you know that’s not entirely true.” He left her, let her think about it, went into the family room.

W as it really that wrong to include Tyler, Jess wondered. She knew what Pete had meant, but it wasn’t entirely true. Was she going to walk past Tyler with the boys and go have fun at a water park, not even ask him if he wanted to come along? Plus she really appreciated his help today. It was easier with another person helping out. Jess spent most of her time with Andy, the two of them lounging around, playing in Mango Cove. Right next to that, and circling above them, were the Tropical Tube slides and Tyler and Petey spent most of their time going down that crazy thing over and over. It was perfect, she could wave to them as they went, Petey calling out to her to make sure she saw him.

What was the harm? She went where no one would see them—no one who knew them. Everyone had a great time. The boys really had a blast. Mission accomplished, right?

“When’s dinner, Mom?”

“Soon, Petey, soon, go in with your dad please, keep him company while I cook.”

“I’m hungry, Mom,” Andy said.

“I know, baby,” Jess answered as Petey and Andy both ran through to the family room. She leaned an arm on the open fridge door, looking for something quick to make.

Did she get something from it? Sure, it was kind of exciting. Going away somewhere new for the day practically felt like she was someone else. And, yes, she got to see Tyler with his shirt off all day long. He had a perfect body, a dream body. It was natural to want to see it, she saw a lot of the other moms out there today watching him. She saw their jaws drop. Quite literally. Gosh, that felt amazing too. Being seen with him. People knowing he was with you, that he was your man, that you were his girl. At lunch they were standing in line waiting for a table right next to a long mirror. She saw herself with him and it just looked so good. *They looked like a couple*. She felt like a million dollars when she was with him. Sitting and eating, Tyler helping with her boys, people watching this lucky woman—it did occur to her what a family they would make. She knew that was crazy, impossible. He was so young. He would be moving on soon.

But what if? That was a scary, scary thought. Uh-oh. *What if what, Jess?*

It didn’t matter. It could never be. As exciting as it was to consider, it would never be. She just had to enjoy this while it lasted. She just had to enjoy the little fantasies, the little perks that came with living with this young stud. And seeing him today, with his shirt off, being so good with her boys, spending time as a couple—it had made her so incredibly horny.

“Yeah, oh, Dad, that’s the Castaway Wave Pool, Dad,” Petey was shouting from the family room. “You go in and then these waves come and they pick you up, or they can knock you over. Tyler and I were... We had a boogie board and I could stand on it...when the wave came...and I didn’t fall off.”

Jess left the fridge, moved over to the archway that went down to the family room. Pete was sitting in his chair, Petey standing next to him, practically jumping up and down, pulling on the arm of Pete’s chair. On the

screen of their TV was a picture she'd taken of Petey in the wave pool today.

Pete lifted the remote, pressed a button, and now it was Tyler holding Petey's hand as he tried to balance on a blue foam boogie board.

"Pete, what are you doing?"

"What? The boys are showing me the pictures from today."

She looked back into the kitchen at her phone sitting on the counter. Pete was in the cloud. Looking through every picture she'd taken today, doing it with the boys while they told him what a great time they had.

“Oh, look at this. You guys had a great day,” Pete said. He knew it was a violation. But he'd been bruised, slighted. And he wanted to see what they did. Wanted to see with his own eyes if it was as bad as he imagined.

He clicked for the next picture. A pool surrounded by palm trees, a rope-bridge prop strung over it, Petey climbing across it like monkey bars, floating barrels and pirate chests bobbing underneath him. Tyler waist deep in the water below, watching, muscles glistening wetly.

"That looks like fun, Petey."

Another click.

Jess crouching down, posing next to little Andy. Pirate ship behind them, cannons peeking out over her slim shoulder. Sunglasses up in her wet hair. She was wearing a black bikini. Her perfect soft flesh on display. Tyler had looked at the screen—saw this angel—and pressed the red circle. He saw her, really saw her, when she was Jess—when she was Petey and Andy's pretty mom. Not some man's wife looking for a good fuck.

"Oh, I like that picture. Tyler took that one?"

"I guess so, Dad," Petey said.

Jess said, "Pete, why don't you come and—"

"Hold on, Jess, we're just looking through these pictures," he said.

Another one.

Ah, look at this one. Feel the burn. Tyler with his arm around Petey. His other arm flexed in a huge muscular display, abs crunched. Petey doing the same with his skinny little seven-year-old arm.

“Tyler’s so strong, Dad, we went—”

“I know he is, Petey, I know.”

Click.

Aw, she snapped a picture of Tyler when he wasn’t looking. Jess taking the picture when Tyler was turned away from her, three quarter profile. Yes, he was a stud. Yes, she should take a picture. His big tattooed shoulder, his eyes cast down, pensive. Taking this picture just for herself.

“Hey, Jess, there’s nothing here, you know, coming up, maybe the boys shouldn’t see?”

“What? No, Pete.”

He turned and saw her blushing. He had her sweating. This was wrong. He looked at Petey, he was just wanting to see pictures of the fun he had at the water park. Pete looked back at Jess, saw she was mad. Her lips clenched, her eyes a little wet but squinted.

Maybe one more.

Click.

There it was. The knife in his heart.

A selfie, Jess’s hand holding her phone to take a picture of herself with Tyler. Their attractive faces filling up the frame, beaming. Her cheek pressed firmly against his, their flesh flattening into each other. Big white smiles on both of them. She looked so happy.

“Ungh,” he groaned out loud. “Ah, don’t they look good together?”

Petey said, “Yeah.”

“Oh, boy,” Pete said.

“What’s wrong, Dad?”

“I’m fine, Petey,” he said, his voice breathy, hoarse. “I think I’ve seen...here, Petey, take the remote, you can flip through.”

Pete got himself off the couch, headed up to the kitchen. Jess watched him, watched him as he walked right past her. She followed him into the kitchen and stood behind him as he leaned on the counter, trying to catch his breath.

“You’re such an asshole doing that to me.”

“*I’m the asshole?*” he said quietly. “*I’m the asshole?* For doing this to *you*?”

“Doing that in front of the boys, Pete? Don’t drag them into this.”

“Jess, I looked at pictures of you and the boys and what you did together today. Things *you* did today...” He turned, said, “Things *you* did in

front of them.” Raising his voice a little.

She watched him, her arms folded across her chest.

“I don’t want to fight, Jess, and I don’t want to do anything in front of the boys. It’s just killing me that you’re not seeing what you’re doing.”

“I’m not using the boys against you, Pete, not like you just did.”

“Yes, Jess, you are. That’s why we’re in this...” he threw his arms up, “...this mess. I like you to hurt me and you’re getting better and better at it. Now you can’t even see it when you do it.”

He wasn’t getting through to her, he knew it. Could see it in her tense face. She didn’t like the humiliation going her way. It only went one way around here. That was fair enough. He wanted it, asked for it. Even now, part of him loved this. But another cold, shivering piece of him, cowering in the dark, was feeling very, very scared. He didn’t like where this could go. Where it was going. It was more fun when he had his arm around her, when she was his Jess and his Jess alone. When it was a superficial humiliation, a safe fun game that tickled his emotions. But every minute Jess’s big boyfriend stayed this was getting more and more real.

PART VI

ALWAYS HUNGRY

ADMISSION

WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 9TH

Jess wasn't really talking to him and it was breaking his heart. Maybe he'd gone too far trying to make his point. Not speaking to him was punishment he couldn't take. She could do any dirty thing to another man she wanted but if she shut him out—for thirty-six hours now—it would kill him.

He watched her as she worked at the kitchen counter. The boys were sitting with Pete finishing their breakfast at the kitchen table. Andy was giving Sargent the crusts of his toast. Jess was beautiful even at her worst. She had her glasses on, she was worn looking, tired, her hair clipped up on the top of her head in a messy nest of jagged hair ends. He wanted so badly to put his arms around her right now. To come up behind her and hug her, feel her warm body against his, the soft flannel cotton of her nightdress under the palms of his hands as he ran them over her waist.

She'd been cold with him all day yesterday. Just like this morning. Then at night everyone could tell she was mad about something. She didn't really talk at the table. After dinner she sat at her desk in the living room and graded papers. She came in to the family room at around nine and sat next to Tyler. She wasn't mad at him, they seemed fine for the most part. It was like he understood what was going on. Pete wondered if she'd discussed it with him. Tyler had stayed out of the way and Pete was thankful for that. He wasn't mad anymore about them spending the day together but he was still a little stung. It was nice of him not to rub his face in it.

Here they were this morning, and Jess was still as distant. He couldn't take it. He couldn't bear the thought of going to work all day today without

knowing she was okay again. Jess had the loaf of bread out, eight slices laid out on the counter. Four ham sandwiches for her family. She spread out the mayonnaise on three slices, plopped down sheets of meat, then unwrapped the cheese singles. Her face was blank, distant. She got them put together, wrapped each one in a sheet of wax paper. The boys' into their colourful lunch boxes with a banana and a juice box, Pete's into a brown bag with an apple. Then she cut up a cooked chicken breast and tossed it into a Tupperware filled with vegetables for Tyler he figured. Too much food for Jess to consume at one sitting that was for sure.

What was Tyler doing today? Why would she make his lunch? Maybe she made it for him every day and Pete was just noticing for the first time. Tyler ate specific things, he could at least go to the trouble of making his own meals. The last thing Pete would do this morning would be to mention that. It would not go over well. He would just let Jess do whatever she wanted. Make him a three-course-meal for all he cared. *Just goddamn talk to me, baby.*

"Lunch is in the fridge," she mumbled to him coldly as she passed by, heading to the laundry room.

A wave of regret, dread, unhappiness came over him, weighed across his shoulders, made him hunch. This was something he couldn't stand.

He got up, pushed his stool back, swigged his coffee, finished it.

"Hey boys, you should get out now, go wait for the bus, I'll be out in a minute."

"Okay, Dad."

"Petey, you hold your brother's hand."

"I know, Dad."

He watched Petey in the hall, helping Andy get his coat on. Then they went out into the cold.

Pete stepped into the doorway of the laundry room and watched Jess from behind as she pulled laundry out of the dryer and laid it across the top.

"Hey, Jess?"

"What?" she said, head still in the dryer.

"Uh, Jacob and Tammy are staying on Friday, I was wondering—do you want to do something special with them and the boys? Should we, I don't know, have a theme night or something?"

"Like what?" she said, grabbing a pair of jeans from the top of the pile and folding them.

“I don’t know...” This wasn’t going as smoothly as he’d hoped.

“Whatever you want, Pete.”

“Maybe we could do a movie night, order some pizzas, throw a mini-party... Just have fun, some family time. I think we need that right now.”

Jess had a pair of Tyler’s jeans flattened out on her table, smoothing out the crotch of his pants.

“I want Tyler to be there too. He’s welcome, I mean.”

She chuckled, shook her head a little then folded up the pants.

Petey and Andy were outside yelling like monsters or something and they both looked out and saw them next to the swing set, Andy chasing his bigger brother.

“Why are they out playing in the yard? It’s so cold out there.”

“They’re supposed to be waiting for the bus.”

“It’s a little early for the bus, Pete.”

“I was worried you might yell at me so I told them to go out.”

“When have I ever yelled at you, Pete?”

“I know, we’re just in a weird place.”

“What makes you say that?” she said. She was smirking. They were in the most ridiculous place a couple could find themselves. He still couldn’t believe this was happening. He was caught in some cuckold nightmare where every dirty fantasy was a bedroom door away but he was so scared now to engage with it, so frightened to let it happen in case he got swept away. But every part of him ached to see his wife with Tyler again. Just naked, just sex, seeing her in ecstasy.

“I’m sorry, Jess. Sorry I went through the pictures off your phone. Sorry I did it. And I’m sorry I did it with the boys there.”

“Look Pete, we’re in a crazy spot, all right? I know that. Believe me, I know that. But you’re saying I did something to hurt the boys and that makes me mad. The boys had a great day, they really did. It was no big deal. I know the pictures... Look, I just know, okay? But what you did was dangerous.”

“Jess.”

“You tried to use my boys against me...” She could feel her eyes well up, she pushed it away.

“Jess, I couldn’t be more sorry.”

There was more but she didn’t know how to tell him. Something she felt guilty about. It wasn’t that she’d taken the boys, brought Tyler along; there

was something else that could have happened, could have hurt the boys and it would have been her fault. Pete would have done it and she could yell at him all she wanted but the truth was that she was responsible. If Pete went far back enough in her photos he would have found something. The boys could have seen it. The picture she'd taken laying in bed with Tyler that amazing afternoon. Before Pete came home early and discovered them. Tyler hovering over her, beautiful in the afternoon sun, that muscular body looked like a painting the way the light danced on his hard edges. There was more than his body in that picture. God, she would have died. She would have killed Pete first, but she would never have recovered from that. It didn't happen, not even really close, the photo was weeks old now. But it *could* have.

She felt her lips tremble and the more she struggled to keep it together the more they wriggled and twisted.

"Oh, please, Jess, don't ever cry, honey. Please, I can't take it." He moved around to her and he hugged her. She let him. She left her arms at her sides but she let him hold her and it felt good.

"We can have a fun night with Tammy and Jacob," she whispered.

"Yeah?"

She could be mad at him all she wanted but she had to realize he wasn't wrong. And there was a lot she had to be held accountable for as well. She had to let him off the hook. It just wasn't fair to put it all on him. They both had some growing up to do.

"Yeah. Let's make our own pizzas though, okay? We can get a bunch of ingredients and the kids can make their own disgusting combinations. We'll watch some movies..."

He hugged her to him, she could feel his elation at her letting it go and it made her feel better too. He said, "I mean it, I want Tyler there as well, okay? I do mean it."

"Yeah, I know. He'll be there, Petey. He lives here, come on, we can't exclude him."

He stepped back from her, nodded. She could see his eyes were a little puffy and red looking too. He held her hands in his and looked at her. "I'm glad, Jess, I'm glad."

"Glad for what, Petey?"

"For you. For everything."

"Are you happy?"

“Yeah,” he said a little too quickly, a little too desperate to let her know. “I am. I’m happy for you.”

Jess had her head in the dryer, was looking for one of Pete’s black dress socks that didn’t seem to have made it out to the hamper, when she thought he’d come up behind her again. She snagged the missing sock between her index and middle finger, pulled it out of the seam of one of the dryer’s tumblers and stood up.

It was Tyler.

She couldn’t stop a little smile despite how bothered she felt this morning. He looked so good even first thing in the morning. His young tight face, his thick brown hair sticking up, tousled, messy, like she’d just made love with him. You could see blonde bits in it when the light hit it right. He was sleepy looking, devilish.

“Good morning,” she smiled, lowered her eyes and turned her back to him, got back to folding on the top of the washing machine.

He put his thick arms around her and hugged her to his chest

“What are you doing?” she said.

“Mm. Good morning,” he said and she felt him kiss her neck and breathe her in.

“Tyler, don’t. I haven’t even showered,” she said.

“You look fucking amazing.”

“Oh my God, is that your cock?” she laughed, looking down to see what was so hard pressing into the small of her back. “You’re hard as a rock.” She looked up at him smiling, bewildered.

“What do you expect, you walking around in the mornings without a bra? Makes me think bad things,” he said, hugging her tight, his hands grasping at her bare breasts under her flannel nightie.

“We can’t, Tyler, the boys are right here,” she said, nodding to the window where they could see Andy and Petey outside bundled up in their jackets.

“They’re outside. They’re not coming back in. Andy’ll stay with Petey until the bus comes. We can see them,” he said, kissing at her neck and her collar. His right hand went up under her nightshirt and his fingers started to

pull her panties down. He pressed his hardness into her, she could feel its wide belly push between her cheeks, the firm tip scraping up her lower back.

“Pete’s still home.”

“We’ll put on a show for him. He’d beg to watch what I’m about to do to you.”

His hand peeled her panties down, pinching the soft flesh of her thighs, then slid between her cheeks and across to her front.

“Oh,” she gasped, “Tyler, we can’t. Stop it.”

His thick fingers forced her apart, pushing her soft mound wide and digging into her sensitive sex.

“Tyler, don’t.” She didn’t want to, not like this. Not with the boys right there and not in the mood she was in. But she leaned forward and she put her elbows on the top of the washing machine.

He worked through her sex roughly, spreading and rubbing until she heard her own wet sounds. His fingers slipped across her slick lips and found her little soft button. It made her gasp.

“You’re awfully wet for a woman who doesn’t want it.”

She groaned and closed her eyes. She felt his erection pressing against her.

“Why are you so hard?”

“I told you. I can’t live in a house where there’s a hot little fuck machine, not wake up throbbing, looking to sink it inside her. I’ve been laying in bed thinking about you.” His fingers worked along her, sliding up and down her wet opening, she felt his thumb probing higher, up near a place she wasn’t sure she wanted him to go. “You know how incredible you are? How incredible you look? Walking around with these bare fucking legs. Asking for it.”

His middle finger sunk slowly inside her and she inhaled, her eyebrows lifting right up into her hairline. He had her up onto her tippy toes, tilting her little rump out to him, wanting it. “Oh, T-Tyler,” she whispered.

The tip of his big thumb was probing again, touching her and prodding, testing to see if she would let it pass into her dirty spot.

“No, don’t,” she said, “not there.”

Her hand came up and clawed clumsily at the vertical blinds on the small laundry room window that looked out onto the side yard. She could

see the boys out there, still horsing around on the swing set. “Just give me that big cock,” she said.

“That’s my girl,” he said.

He spit in his hand, stroked himself, bent at the knees and lined himself up. She bent herself over. Got higher on her toes and spread her legs. His hands pulled her nightshirt up, exposed her, bunched it up around her waist. His glans was firmly inside her ring, she gripped it and waited for his plunge. He adjusted his feet and she felt his swollen round cock head swirl around and it gave her a crazy thrill, her heart skipped a beat and before she could recover he sunk his long thick shaft deep inside her and she couldn’t stifle the awkward painful breathy moan that escaped her. Her hands came up and clawed at the cupboards where she kept the extra detergent and fabric softener. His huge cock slid in, stretching and burning, ripping her sleep-tightened sex wide apart. “Ah, oh, Tyler,” she cried, “oh, fuck.”

“You like that?” he hissed into her ear as he buried it in her.

“You feel like hot steel, baby—what’s got into you?”

“I just can’t stop thinking about you, Jess.”

“Fuck me,” she whispered.

He was slow, working it in and out of her and letting her get herself accustomed, let her tight insides relax on him, accept him. She pushed her thighs and hips into the metal of the washing machine, felt the handle press into her soft flesh. She squeezed herself against it and let him find a good pace.

“You are one goddamn amazing woman, you know that?” he had himself wet from her now and he wasn’t interested in going slow. He was here in this room to fuck her.

“Ah,” she gasped and she braced herself to him, let him take her little hole by force, plunge it deep into her and then right back out.

“Look at all you’ve got, all you do. Look who you are. You’re so fucking perfect, Jess.”

His strong hands clawed at her chest while he pounded her, her nipples strained against the fabric. She could see their thick, hard shape pressing tightly against the cotton, stretching through it as Tyler’s grip tightened on her. Her small hands went over the backs of his, helped him find her erect nipples, she used his hands to squeeze them.

“Oh, yes,” she hissed, tossed her hair around for him while he fucked her wildly.

“You’re so beautiful, you’re so kind—”

“Yeah, ah—”

“Oh, shit, ah, and the fucking body on you,” he growled to her.

“Oh, Jesus, Tyler, you’re so big, so fucking hard, ah—”

“You’ve got the sweetest, tightest little pussy.”

She clawed her hands frantically along his arm, scratched at him while she gripped his wrist, pulled his big hand up to her neck.

“Don’t, uh, don’t come inside me,” she said and she pulled his hand up to cover her mouth.

He squeezed her tightly, covered her up, pulled her head back roughly and pounded her so hard it rocked the washing machine, banging it loudly against the wall, making a huge hollow metal sound like it had an off-balance load. He grunted like an animal with each powerful thrust, and she squinted, watched through her wet eyes, could see the boys still in the yard, Petey looking to the window at all the racket. She struggled, her shaky hand came up as quick as it could and twisted the rod that closed up the blinds.

She screamed in pain into Tyler’s huge warm hand, cried out with each terrible thrust. He was ruining her, tearing her little sex to shreds, she was sure of it.

Then he was out, leaving her feeling icy and deep and hollow between her legs. He let her go and she gulped for desperate air.

She could feel his seed, huge and hot, splashing across her back. Stream after wet stream, stinging her with its heat, tapping her upper back where it went up high and landed on the black watch plaid of her flannel nightshirt. Tyler grabbed her hips roughly and shoved his tool between her ass cheeks, squishing himself between them as he kept thrusting and spurting onto her.

He groaned deep and gravelly and his enormous weight fell across her back, pressed her against the machine.

“Oh, Jess,” he said and he rolled off her, slumped next to her supporting himself on his elbows. He was flushed, sleepy-eyed, he looked like he was punch drunk.

“Holy... Wow,” she laughed as she quickly pulled her panties up, shimmied her nightie down and covered her rump before someone came in.

He laughed too, he held her face in his palm, looked into her eyes and then kissed her lips.

“Better put that away before someone sees it,” she said, darting her eyes down between his legs. He slowly pulled his sweatpants up, his big arms

having trouble recovering from his very productive orgasm. His cock was still hard, pressing out the front of his pants.

She screwed up her face at him, said, “Did you come in my hair?”

“I definitely did, sorry,” he said. He touched her cheek, said, “You’re making me so crazy.” He took a folded t-shirt out of her clean laundry and wadded it up, “Don’t turn around,” he said and he wiped at her back, then through her hair, down and underneath her nightie, drying her lower back and her cheeks. She could feel how wet he’d left her. She leaned forward and rested her head on the washing machine, enjoyed the feeling of his strong hands on her while he cleaned her.

“I have to go jump in the shower anyway,” she sighed to him over her shoulder.

Tyler threw the dirtied shirt into the hamper and Jess twisted the white plastic rod, opened the blinds with it again and saw the boys still out there.

“We get away with it?”

She laughed, said, “I think so.” She looked at him standing there, looking so perfect—his young face and his thick honey hair, his hard body and that cock pushing his pants out—and felt her face fall. She shouldn’t have done that. That was against the rules.

“We can’t do that again,” she said, her face serious now.

“That was a one time deal,” he nodded. He grabbed his dick through his pants, said, “You saw what I was like though.”

She bit her lip and nodded as well.

Tyler walked out into the hall, said, “Hey, Pete,” looking up the stairs.

Pete came bouncing down said, “Hey.” He passed the laundry room, then ducked back and caught her eye.

He tapped his watch, said, “Don’t you have to get in the shower?”

“Are you okay?” Sara asked her as she walked into the teacher’s lounge at lunch time.

“Yeah,” she said, “just twisted my ankle.”

She was sore between her legs. Tyler had been a little too rough, a little too hard, this morning. Walking was a bit uncomfortable but taking short steps stopped it from stinging.

Jess went to the fridge and got her lunch bag out, Sara said, "Come and put your feet up." She pulled a chair out for her, patted her lap for Jess.

The teacher's lounge at Jaden Van was a low fluorescent rectangle with a window that looked out on to the field where the kids would play. A cinderblock room about twelve by fifteen with crooked shades, a chipped formica faux-wood table, a fridge and a coffee maker. Sara was leaning back in a tweed office chair, her tuna sandwich and a pickle with a bite out of it sitting on wax paper at her elbow.

Jess sat down carefully in the chair and she lifted one foot at a time and lay them on Sara's lap. Sara pulled her leather loafers off for her, lay them on the floor next to them. She ran her hands down her calves then back up trying to snug her tights up against her skin. She was looking at her ankles then she ran her hands over them both, said, "Doesn't look swollen, doesn't feel swollen."

"That's a relief," Jess said. "I'll be fine. Just smarts a little."

"Which ankle was it?"

Jess tried to quickly figure which ankle she'd prefer to have rubbed right now. She said, "The left one. My left," and she wriggled her foot a little for her.

"Just twisted it coming off a curb in the parking lot this morning," she said. Sara nodded and she held Jess's foot and rubbed her thin ankle with her other hand.

Jess unwrapped her ham sandwich from her wax paper, took a bite. She closed her eyes and felt Sara's fingers massaging the tendons of her calf.

Jess said, "Where is everyone?"

"Carol and Dawn already ate, Dawn had to take Carol up to the DMV."

"Mm, how terrible," she said. "It's so quiet in here. It's weird."

Jess chewed quietly while Sara kept rubbing. She could still feel the slight dry sting between her legs that Tyler had left her with, even sitting and doing nothing. He was so hard this morning, she'd never seen anything like it. Felt anything like it. She couldn't believe a penis so incredibly large could get like that, so throbbingly erect it stood upright despite its length, its weight. Normally he was firm; big and kind of spongy. But she had done that to him. Made him like that. He'd lay in bed when he woke up thinking of her and she had made him that hard. That was so arousing.

And that body, the feel of his touch on her. Her touch on him. He felt like he was made of something different than Pete. Like different materials.

Were they even the same species? Even at rest he exuded power. His heavy hands, his big joints, his massive weight. He was like an immovable object. She was powerless against him.

“Excited about your award on Friday?”

“Huh?” Jess said, holding her sandwich up next to her face, slowly chewing, lost in the deep, dark, and dirty forest of her thoughts.

“Your award?”

“Friday?”

“Yeah.”

“I am, I’m excited. It’s next Friday though, not this Friday.”

“Oh,” Sara laughed, “what do I know, I’m not up for one.”

Jess laughed, rolled her eyes at her friend. She said, “I hope you’ll be there.”

“I will.”

Jess watched Sara’s hands on her.

“Can I tell you something?”

Sara said, “Sure,” looking up now.

“After Tyler was fired, Pete and I... We heard he was in some trouble.”

“Yeah?” Sara smirked.

“No... Financially.”

“You didn’t lend him money did you?”

“No, no. He had to leave his apartment.” Jess looked around, made sure the coast was clear, said, “He has no credit, you know, no savings...nothing.”

“Holy shit.”

Jess twisted her mouth around, regarding her friend, building up the nerve. She had to tell someone. She should have told Sara this a long time ago but she kept chickening out. She had to tell someone so it didn’t get found out the wrong way, make her look like she had something to hide.

“He’s been staying with us. Pete and I.”

“Shut. The. Front. Door.” Sara sat up straight, electrified.

“Hey,” Jess put her palms up, said, “don’t make a big deal out of it, it—”

Sara was smiling from ear to ear, her eyes wide.

“—It’ll be just for a little bit. And it’s nothing.”

“You have got to be kidding me.”

“No. It’s real.”

“Oh my God. What’s he like?”

“He’s fine,” Jess said, and she felt like she might have started to blush. “It’s just for a short time...until he gets back on his feet.”

Sara was bubbly, glassy-eyed, lost in the prospect of her friend living in close quarters with Tyler. “God, I bet you’re hoping he never does,” she said.

“What? No, of course not. Look, we’re just helping out a friend.”

Sara nodded, coming back down to earth.

Jess added, “It’s not all sunshine and roses.”

“If you get tired of him send him over to my place for a while.”

“Who’s that guy you’ve been seeing?” Jess said.

“Frank?”

“Yeah, Frank would not like that.”

“No, Frank might shoot him.”

Sara was still smiling, looking in Jess’s eyes and shaking her head slowly. She said, “Have you seen him with his shirt off?”

“Yes,” Jess said slyly. *God, why did she say that?*

“You did? Oh my God. What did he look like?”

She raised her eyebrows and shrugged, could feel herself blushing.

“Look at you blush.” Sara was smirking, having trouble getting over this. “Can you imagine walking into the bathroom and he’s coming out of the shower? You know he’s supposed to have a real big ding dong down there.”

“I know, you’ve told me.” She rolled her eyes. “I haven’t seen it. I have my own bathroom you know.”

“All right, all right,” Sara laughed, and put her hands up telling Jess to calm down.

“Better hope Pete doesn’t see it. He’ll be out on his ear. How did you convince Pete?”

“It was—it was his idea, really.”

“Pete?”

“Yeah, I mean, maybe I suggested it,” she frowned, trying to recall something that never actually happened, “well, whatever, he was the one said we should offer him some help.”

“Doesn’t sound like the Pete I know.”

“He’s okay with it. Not jumping for joy, but he knows it won’t be for much longer.”

“When’s he leaving?”

“Soon. We’ll have to see though. He’s not having much luck yet finding work.”

Sara nodded, looking Jess up and down. “Do you think it’s a good idea?”

“How do you mean?”

Sara pulled at a lock of her brown hair held it out, said, “You’re blonde. We’ve all been wondering who this mystery blonde girl is.”

“Sara.”

“What?”

“How could you think that?”

“Not me. People,” she said, shrugging.

“Well, it wasn’t me.”

“Is that why you’ve kept it quiet?”

Now Jess shrugged. “He just seems like the bad guy around here now. But he’s not. I know he’s not.”

“How long’s he been with you?”

“Few weeks now. Pete is in on this, you know.”

“He got kicked out so fast?”

“Yeah, he was behind in...he’s just in a bad spot, you know?”

Sara held Jess’s ankles, looking down over her half-eaten lunch on the table next to her. She was chewing the inside of her lower lip. She was troubled. She said, “I won’t tell anyone. Neither should you. The world is made up of assholes. There’s very few nice people like you. And you’re usually the ones that get chewed up and spit out.”

Late in the afternoon Jess called Kevin Campbell's mom and told her she'd have to cancel their meeting this afternoon. Jess was the one who'd arranged the appointment, had wanted to talk face to face, then she was calling her and giving her a made up excuse so she could get out of it.

“No, it's just a family emergency,” she’d said, standing in a busy school hall with her phone pressed to her ear, her free hand cupped over her other ear.

“I hope everything is okay,” Kevin’s mom, Abby, said.

“Everything is fine, it’s just an obligation I won’t be able to get out of.”

Abby was okay with it. Probably felt relief not having to come into the school now.

She had felt enormously guilty.

Now it was 3:10 and she was looking for Petey. She went out to the car park, stood with the middle-aged traffic marshal with her whistle and her reflective vest. Jess was looking for Noah’s mom’s car. It was a silver crossover, she wasn’t sure of the make. There were so many out there she’d never figure it out.

She saw a fair-haired kid and a black-haired kid walking together across the crowd. Just the tops of their heads, not enough to be sure. She waded through with her fingers crossed.

As she got closer, worried that she could lose them, she called out, “Petey, Petey,” yelling to the two heads of hair over the tops of the other children. The fair-haired kid turned; Petey’s puzzled face looking out to see where his mom’s voice was coming from.

She caught his eye with a wave and pierced through the kids, worked her way to him.

“Hi Petey, hi Noah,” she said, kneeling to them.

“Hi, Mrs. Mapplethorpe.”

“Mom, you’re not supposed to yell,” Petey said.

“I know, sweetie, I just wanted to catch you before I went home. You’re heading to Noah’s?”

“Yeah, Mom, I told you already.”

“Okay, I know, I just wanted to know when you’d be home—”

“I don’t know, Mom...before dinner.”

“Okay. Five o’clock?”

“Yeah, Mom.”

“Good, Petey. That’s good, okay, just wanted to be sure,” she said, standing up, running her hand through his thick hair. “Okay, baby,” she said.

She turned and walked back the way she’d come, turned and called to him, “You boys have fun, okay?”

She heard him say, *We will.*

Jess got to her van, started it with a shaky hand that slid the key all around the slot before she found it. She got on the main street and headed for home but she stopped at the Walgreens first and bought a bottle of lube.

Even though she had ached all morning, right past her lunch time, it hadn't stopped her from wanting more. While the sting had subsided, her dirty thoughts had not. They'd grown stronger.

Tyler fucked her from behind this morning, did it hard with his hand clamped over her mouth, came on her back and then left her. She'd gone up and showered, got dressed and put the boys in the van and went off to work. She'd thought about it a little, more bewildered than anything. It wasn't until after lunch she started to realize how hot it was. It was like one of her dirty fantasies. Like something she might have thought about when being with another man was just something naughty to whisper in Pete's ear while they made love. But this morning was very real. Incredibly, wonderfully real.

So she pulled the van into the driveway and marched up the brick walkway to the front door and opened it. Tyler had put his bike away in storage in the garage for the winter and she knew he would be home. She closed the door behind her with her purse tightly held to her, her heart pounding; then she walked to the kitchen.

Tyler was there. He had paperwork spread out on the kitchen island and he was making himself a sandwich, cutting board with tomatoes and lettuce and a butcher knife and a loaf of bread. He turned, look surprised to see her, his face was happy.

"Hey, Jess—"

"Tyler."

"—I have some news for you."

"Fuck your news," she said and she firmly walked the three steps it took her to come face-to-face with him and she wrapped her arms around his waist, reached up, craned her neck so that she could press her lips against his. He bent to her and his arms came around her and it felt wonderful. She kissed him, moved her tongue around his lips, parted them, found his tongue.

Her hand came down, went between his legs and squeezed his big man-parts through his denim. She gripped it and kneaded it, the whole time she kissed him, pressed herself in to him until his back was against the counter. She broke away, her mouth agape, her lips swollen, and she watched his expression. He was breathing heavy, he watched her, his eyes darting back and forth over hers. He said, "You didn't get enough this morning?"

She shoved a hand down the front of his pants and grabbed his bare cock. "Take your shirt off," she said.

He pulled his shirt up over his head and she looked at that beautiful body. She said, "You were hard on me this morning. Hurt me. Made me ache. But you didn't make me come."

He smiled at her as her little hand stroked his big thing inside his tight jeans. His smile made her shudder.

She said, "I need it again. I've been wanting it all afternoon."

He kissed her, his strong hands moving across her waist, then down, cupping her cheeks, lifting her up to him, pulling her lips tighter against his. She raised her legs, let them climb up his hips as he supported her easily with his strong hands, and she locked herself around him, squeezed herself into him, felt his hardness between her legs. Her fingers explored his bare chest, wandered around and squeezed his thick hard neck and traps. She bit at his lip, pulled it with her teeth. She whispered, "Take me to your room."

So he walked her up the stairs like she weighed nothing, just a little girl clinging to him, her lips kissing his mouth, his neck. She was clothed he was shirtless and hard inside his pants, her purse was around her shoulder, her boots were still on.

This was her second violation. In just one day. She knew she shouldn't do this. She knew how bad it was. Tyler didn't say a thing and that was hot as could be. He didn't care about the right thing. He didn't respect her marriage, he just wanted her. Wanted to fuck her. It was so hot.

He walked her into his small bedroom and he lay her on her back on his bed, then his hands were working her buttons, opening her shirt. She put her hands over his, moved them and took over, she said, "Get my skirt."

He slipped down her, his hands undoing the zip at the side of her long skirt. He pulled it down slowly, his hands tucked into the waist, bringing her panties and cable knit tights with it while she opened her shirt for him. He pulled her boots off, threw them on the floor and then peeled her

bottoms right off, her tights turning inside out as they came off the tips of her pointed toes.

Jess sat up and opened her shirt and cardigan, pulled her arms out of them, threw them on the floor then unclasped her bra, felt the release of tension as the weight of them dropped. She flung it aside; she was completely naked now.

She lay back, felt her heart pounding with Tyler's eyes on her. Seeing her naked in the daylight. She took her glasses off and put them on the table at the side of the bed, turned back to him and put her arms up over her head, exposed herself to him. She sucked her lips into her mouth and her legs rubbed together, her knees tightly pressed. His eyes on her felt like his touch and he had her little pussy sweating just standing there undoing his pants and looking down on her.

She lifted her knees as he dropped his pants, stepped out of them, that big thing of his bobbing between his legs, reaching out to her, the rounded flanged end of it plump and engorged, seeking out her wet interior. She let her knees part, fall to the side and she let him see her sex.

He got down on his hands and knees over her, his head dropped to her and she held his face gently between her palms, pulled his lips into her mouth, kissed him deeply and passionately.

She broke away, looked in his eyes, she said, "*Wait.*"

She pulled her purse over and brought out the bottle of lube she had bought. It was a weird moment, somehow strangely hot in its awkwardness. She opened the box, while he held himself over her, her eyes holding his gaze, her hands fumbling blindly, taking the bottle out, popping the cap open and then the flatulent sound of lubricant being squirted into her open palm.

She could see in Tyler's face he wanted to say something but he just couldn't find the words. She knew the feeling. There was so much she wanted to say to him. To tell him about how he made her feel. So many good things she'd like to tell him but she just didn't have the nerve.

Her hand spread the lube on his hanging cock. She worked it gently up and down making him shudder and smile. She coated him, squirted another handful and then did it again getting right down to his thick base, even coating his scrotum, just in case.

"Be gentle," she whispered as she smoothed the rest off her hand, spreading it across her mound, her fingers working through her own hot wet

folds, pinching at her labia to make sure there wasn't one tiny millimetre that was dry and unprepared.

"I will," he said.

She said, "Seriously, be gentle, I mean it."

"I will. I swear I will."

"You hurt me."

He kissed her, his hand grabbing at her neck and pulling her back, exposing her neck to his teeth. He bit her, sucked her, from her chin to her collar. His cock sunk into her ever so slowly, ever so good and slippery, her fingers holding his girth and gently guiding it inside her. He felt so amazing even though it stung like hell.

"Ah," she gasped.

They made love so slowly, so quietly. He took her hands in his and pushed his big fingers through hers, laced them and held them up over her head while he kissed her collar, her chest, then down to the tips of her breasts. His warm mouth went over her hardened nipples and he pulled them gently with his lips while he made love to her.

He was true to his word. He was careful and deliberate. She told him, begged him to make her come and he did. He kissed her and held her, ran his hands through her hair and looked in her eyes. When she whimpered he would slow and let her do the work, let her move herself on the hardness he'd put deep inside her. That was how she did it. He looked in her eyes while they lay on their sides and she worked against him, felt him hold that thing for her, flex it and make it rigid, and she rocked on it until she felt something coming up inside her. She rocked harder and faster, pushing the pain away and finding that hard pleasurable lump buried in there somewhere and she held it in her mind, crushed it, squinting, like she wanted to turn it to diamond and then she exploded on him, looking deep in his eyes and gasping out, crying in pain and pleasure.

Tyler's face trembled while he watched her come and he said, "Oh Jess, I'm going to come too," and she said, "Come inside me," and he did, that big cock shooting its hot seed all over her insides while she rode the edge of a fading but beautiful orgasm. She put her hand on his smooth young cheek and kissed him.

Jess asked Tyler, "What was your good news?"

They both lay naked on the twin bed in her guest room. Tyler was on his back, one hand behind his head laying on the pillow, his other arm wrapped right around her making her feel so safe, his big hand was draped over her waist. She felt so good pressed to him naked like that, she felt as young as he was. She felt like his girl. She had her face and her hands pressed against his muscular chest and had been watching the clock on his night table, counting down until she would have to leave and go pick up Andy.

He said, "I got a job today."

She felt a dull dread, a blunt object stabbing into her insides. She had a sudden fear she would lose him.

"Oh, you did?" she said, still looking away from him. "Where?"

"Well, here for now. Online teaching. I can do it from my laptop."

"Is that enough money?"

"Not yet. It's not full time. It'll lead somewhere."

He wasn't gone yet. She looked up at him, patted his chest, said, "You can stay here until you're ready, don't worry about that. If it takes longer it takes longer, right?"

"Pete would agree?"

"I'll handle Pete. Just don't worry about it, okay?"

"Okay."

Her hand stroked his skin gently, her fingers tracing along the muscles of his chest and down his sternum. She felt guilty doing this. She was enjoying this too much.

"Do you think we could include Pete sometime. Would you be okay with that?"

He saw through her. "Somebody's feeling a little guilty..."

"Maybe."

"Maybe?" he laughed, he shook her in his arm, shook her until she couldn't help but smile. "You are such a bad girl, aren't you?"

"Tell me I'm bad."

"You're so fucking bad," he said, looking in her eyes.

He held her close and kissed her. Her hands went over him again, around his slim hard waist.

"You're getting hard again," she said.

"I could fuck you twenty-four-seven."

She climbed up his hard body, threw a leg over him and straddled his hips. He felt like a horse underneath her. "You like fucking me?"

He looked up at her through half-lidded eyes, bit at his lower lip, said, "You are the hottest thing I've ever seen. Let me look at you. Pete is insane to let me do this. I don't ever want to stop."

"Would you watch me fuck my husband?"

"No, I don't want to."

"You don't think that would be hot?"

"I don't like the idea of him with you."

"He's my husband."

"I like these times with you," he said and his hands went up her thighs until they touched her hips.

"Ohh," she gasped. "I want you to share me."

"Share you with your husband?"

She laughed, "Yeah, I want that."

"If I'm there what do we need him for?"

"Please."

His hands went up over her belly, up her ribs and he covered her hanging breasts. "You want two men at once?"

"Oh, ah, yes." He was hard again. She could feel his hot tool tapping the back of her thigh.

"Are you going to tell him about this afternoon?"

"Maybe we should keep this a secret."

Tyler said, "This is just for us?"

"Don't tell him."

"I thought he didn't care if we fucked?"

"He doesn't. As long as I tell him. But not this way. Andy's at Daycare, I should have picked him up already. He wouldn't like that, so I can't tell him. And this morning? ...With the boys home? ...Hoo boy."

"What if we met in the middle of the night, down in the basement or something?"

She wagged her butt, felt her flesh pressing against his cock behind her. "Not when the boys are home. Ever. Ever again." She reached behind her, stroked her hand down the wide underside of his sticky cock. "Fuck," she exclaimed laughing, whipping her hair forward.

He laughed too, said, "What?"

“I want to go again so bad, but I’m hurting.” She let her head fall forward and touch his chest. Her hand still worked along his cock, pressing it along the back of her leg while she stroked it.

He kissed her, gently slapped her thigh, said very quietly, “Go on and pick up Andy.”

She sat back on him, let her hands run down his hard body, watched her small fingertips rake across his velvety skin. She bit her lip, she groaned, looked at the clock. “Ahh, shit. You’re right. I better go.” She slid herself off him and stood for a moment watching him as he lay there.

She shook her head then, searched around the floor for her clothes. She liked the way he watched her get dressed. She felt good about her body, felt pretty darn good about a lot of things right now. He watched her, didn’t say anything, watched her stand with her bare legs, turn her tights right side out, push her legs through them. She said, “Sorry, baby, you’re just so big.” Feeling a little guilty looking at him laying there, his cock hard, flopped across his hip. She got dressed, looked how late she was on the clock. She couldn’t leave him like that. She sat on the edge of the bed and put lube in her hand and she stroked him. He closed his eyes and she watched his body flex and strain as she pleased him. She held him low with one hand then just quickly stroked his huge glans with her other shiny fist. She said, *Tell me when you’re going to come*. She didn’t want to have to change her clothes again. It didn’t take long and she pointed it up his chest and let him shoot another big wet load up across his own stomach. She kissed him, feeling much better for having done that. She made it to the daycare and she was only seven minutes late, but her heart was pounding in her chest and she’d ruined her panties with how wet she was.

TEACHER OF THE YEAR

FRIDAY, NOVEMBER 18TH

Pete worked alone, twisting wire into tree shapes that he was going to put behind the General Store next to the train yard. Like the elderly owner of the place had decided last spring he was going to grow a little orchard in his backyard. He and his wife could pick them in the fall, fill up some baskets, maybe make some pies for their kids and their friends. He'd have to figure out how to make the baskets and how to make little convincing apples to put inside them.

Pete could hear the boys upstairs. Tyler was cheering loudly, yelling, Petey yelling with him, playing some game on the Xbox. Andy was up there too, watching them, yelling out questions every once in a while. Little Petey would take the time to answer them, tell him how it worked.

He lifted his arms and let the Pennsylvania Legacy pass under them. It had a boom car and was pulling four coal carts along behind it. He'd left a few trains running on different tracks, just to keep himself company while he worked. He had the sleeves of his dress shirt rolled up, his suit jacket carefully laid over the arm of a chair on the far side of the room.

Big night tonight for the love of his life. Her third Teacher of the Year Award. Jess always passed it off like she was just popular. But it wasn't that at all. He knew most of her friends, the teachers she worked with. She was different than them. Deep inside her, she had a true love for those kids and for her job. She, one hundred percent, believed in what she did; absolutely thought it was one of the most important things in the world. She was upstairs now, getting herself dressed, already worried and anxious. More so than he would have expected given this was her third time accepting one.

The last week had been strange. He suspected Jess had been breaking the rules again. Doing things she shouldn't behind his back. That was so frustrating. She knew she was allowed—knew that if they had an opportunity it was okay, that she could fuck him—but she had to tell Pete all about it. Tell him every detail while they were alone and naked together.

The fact that he felt like she'd been with Tyler but hadn't told him made him feel like she was making bad choices again. Being risky around the house. He hoped that didn't mean that she was compromising the boys somehow. She wouldn't do that though, right? Not his Jess. But she was so different now, wasn't she? It was like he was a single dad trying to raise an unruly teenage girl. Was this what Jess was like when she was young? Was she bubbling; vibrating with sexuality? Or was his own inability to satisfy her all these seven years responsible for this sudden explosion?

He'd tried last week to be intimate with her but she shooed him off. He persisted, laying in bed at night, everyone in the house asleep. He slid his hand along her side and tried to get her in the mood. He went over her rump and scooped underneath headed for her warm sex but she hissed and it made her jump. She told him not to. Pete was convinced she was sore down there. He could guess what that meant. Just didn't know why she couldn't tell him about it.

It was absolutely crazy that Tyler was still there. It was the fucking 18th of November. Sure he's got a job. Using their internet to teach online. Not enough money to strike out on his own yet. *Oh it will, it will soon*, whatever. Fucking Tyler. At least he was being useful tonight, offering to watch the boys while they were out.

Pete checked his watch, saw that it was getting close to the time they should be leaving. He was excited for his Jess. This really was a big deal. The Superintendent there to present the award to her and three others, maybe four hundred in the audience. The first year she won, the Governor had even shown up, shook her hand and everything. It was semi-formal, they served wine and cheese. It wasn't nothing, that's for sure.

Pete shut it down, turning off some of the table lamps that lit up his little recreation of a better time. He watched the Pennsylvania Legacy chug along, heading for the tunnel that passed under his main line that would bring it to the switchyard. It had five wide squat cars with it, hogging the rail, passing along with tremendous power. He was bringing all the trains home for the night, putting them back in their yards. A quick slender

American Flyer engine car bearing no load was crossing paths with the Legacy. He could have let it dart across, see if it would make it to the tunnel first, but he turned the dial, slowed it down. The Legacy powered past while the Flyer watched. The big coal trucks practically scraped the sides of the tunnel. Bet that was one happy tunnel. He kind of felt bad for that balding little Flyer.

Jess laid out a few towels on the bathroom floor. Had herself locked in again. Double locked; bedroom door and bathroom door. She was in her terry robe, naked underneath. It was so cold outside but she'd turned up the heat and brought a small space heater in with her, had it running for a half an hour.

She looked out the window at the grey street. Leaves gone now, the trees she loved so much in the summer were bare and dark, their jagged arms reaching up to scratch the sky. She pulled the curtain closed.

She had everything arranged, she figured. Had read the directions twice. Good old Walgreens again, the one out on North High Street, her one stop shop for embarrassing items.

On the edge of the bathtub she had: distilled water she had heated in the microwave, a bottle of olive oil and a bottle of apple cider vinegar, a few feet of clear tubing (why was it clear?), a blue rubber bag that looked like a hot water bottle, a hook, a clamp, an Erica Jong paperback, and... oh, and an anal insert.

Her stomach growled long and low, creaking at the end, going up high like it was asking her a question. She hadn't eaten all day. She'd also skipped dinner last night. She was empty, the lining of her stomach dry and sticking to itself. She couldn't stop thinking about food. But she had to. There wouldn't be anything worse than having an accident. She would be horrified. She would never recover.

She knelt next to the tub and she opened the bottle of vinegar and added a few shots to the distilled water and stirred it with the end of the tube. The mix went into the hot water bottle and it hooked on to one of the knobs for the shower. Then she popped an end of the tube into the bag, made sure the tube was clamped and... well, now the fun begins.

She untied her robe, shrugged herself out of it then tossed it up on to the sink. She was stark naked. She put the anal insert on to the end of the tube, dipped that into the olive oil then ran her middle finger along it, getting her finger nicely coated. Then that finger went behind her, between her cheeks and she soothed it around her sensitive little sphincter. She winced as she dared to pierce her tight ring, probe her finger inside her just a touch. *Man, and that was just her finger.*

She lay her back against the floor, on to the warm towels fresh from the laundry, smelling of soap. She brought her knees up to her chest and hugged them to her with an arm. She felt around down there, her eyes rolled up looking at the ceiling. She felt around, then pushed gently with the insert.

She bit her lower lip and snarled, felt the very odd sensation of being penetrated down there as the insert slid a few inches inside her. She let it go carefully, her hand hovering, but it stayed in place. The clamp was near the end of the tubing and she fumbled around to find it, then opened it very slowly, releasing the liquid into the tube.

She exhaled, her face frowning, but stifling a laugh as she felt another strange sensation as her insides started to slowly fill with the warm water/vinegar mix. She opened the clamp a little wider once she got used to it and let herself get filled up a little more. When she felt like she'd had enough, like she just didn't want any more inside her, she shut it off then carefully removed the tube. As the very tip left her, squeezed out of her, it gave her a funny tickle and her belly trembled—she could see it happen. She wanted to expel it; like a not-so-funny spit take. Or *very* funny, depending on who had to clean it up. She got it under control, felt around her for her book then held it up to read while she let all that fluid sit inside her and clean her out.

She couldn't concentrate. She snickered. Then went to laughing at the thought of someone walking in right now—what they would see? Her on the bathmat, knees up to her chest, and a tube up her buttohole. Reading a book, looking up at whoever caught her, her face upside down to them. She couldn't help shaking, laughing at that image, her looking up at them. Caught. The laughing made her stomach feel funny with all that liquid sloshing around in her. *God, what would her expression be?* Would she start to laugh and then shoot jets of water out of her butt? Once it started it wouldn't stop. Would Pete see the humour in it at all? Would he laugh?

She lay in silence for a little while, concentrated on her breathing, gently kneaded her tummy. Then when enough time had passed she carefully rolled to her side and got herself up and then backed to the toilet bowl. She sat down and let it all go. It was a horrendous cascade, splashing and belching. Truly embarrassing. But better now than later, all over Tyler's lap while Pete watched.

At the start of the evening Pete had sat next to Jess in the comfortable, modern, elegantly lit, five-hundred-and-twenty-seat theatre attached to the new high school out in Limerick. He was flipping through the agenda for the evening. He flicked the glossy pages, disinterested, until he found what he was looking for. A half page picture of Jess, smiling for the camera; a professional shot, her hair done up, her contacts in so she wasn't wearing her glasses. She had a wool jacket on with a stiff lapel, just the shoulders visible, and the edge of a black collarless shirt buttoned right up.

She was nervous that day, asked Pete a hundred times what she should wear; the photographer sent by the Board of Education coming in to snap this picture of her on her lunch break just for this booklet. Pete picked that shirt, her pretty Victorian one with the tiny roses printed on the fabric. Couldn't even see them in the picture.

Pete held up the opened page to her, showed her the photo and smiled. She nodded, nervous and tight, her hands folded across her stomach.

Underneath her picture, in two narrow columns, the text read:

JESS MAPPLETHORPE, B.A., M.Ed, Grade Three, Jaden Van Public School, Hudsonville, Ohio.

"As an educator I believe in inspiration. We work to prepare our babies for State testing, for the common core; that is fundamental. But we need a framework of creativity, of flexibility within our principles. We need to water the thirst for knowledge, to create minds that are always desperate to grow. We find it through discipline and organization. Not discipline as it's come to be known

as a negative, but discipline in a certain accountability. A desire to be recognized for our achievements and also accepted for our attempts that may not always hit the mark. We must always be trying, and always be unafraid to try. I know that as a mother of two absolutely wonderful boys that I want for these kids what I want for my own—an education that prepares but also nourishes.

At one time I believed I would be a famous dancer. I had everything I needed, I thought. I was dedicated, disciplined, and prepared. But at eighteen I completely ruptured my ACL and it took years for me to properly recover. Life is long and you need to be prepared. When dance was no longer an option I didn't know what I would do. But teaching has helped me find my way. My parents and the school I went to had instilled a desire for learning in me, an obsession with education and discovery. Without that early indoctrination I may have floundered when life offered me that challenge. But I was always hungry to learn. I graduated from Ohio State, then went back for my Masters nine years ago.

I've lived in Hudsonville for seven years now, as long as I've been teaching. Hudsonville is my home. I have a wonderful husband who is everything to me, and we raise our family proudly; we couldn't imagine being anywhere else than this wonderful State, in this wonderful community."

"I sound obtuse," she'd said and groaned. She leaned forward in her chair her hands clasped together, lowered her head, her face was anxious. Chewing gum like crazy. Manic.

People were filing into the auditorium, everyone dressed up, smiling, shaking hands. Jess's stomach gurgled loudly. Pete rubbed her back.

hen the announcer called Jess's name to come up to the podium, everyone cheered like they had for the previous recipients. Someone in the back let

W out a loud piercing whistle blasted out around fingers stuffed in their mouth and it made Pete jump. Jess had some serious fans. Pete thought of Tyler, but it couldn't be him. Tyler couldn't show his face around here. So Pete clapped and watched his wonderful wife as she made her way along the aisle reaching out and giving soft high-fives to some of her friends' hands held out for her as she passed. She was so beautiful. Her light blonde hair tied back and up into a bun. She'd worn her glasses tonight, trying to look like her regular old studious self. Hardly any makeup but for some orangey-red on her perfect lips. She held her long skirt close to her legs as she bounced up the steps onto the stage so she wouldn't trip on it.

Pete felt someone watching him, in his periphery there was a white shape of a face turned to him when everyone was looking up at the stage. He looked to his right, saw Sara Bridge briefly, before she turned quickly away. She'd had a strange expression in the moment before she looked back up at Jess on the stage, still clapping for her. What was that about?

Jess shook the Superintendent's hand, he was a big black guy in a silvery glen plaid suit. He was all politician smiles, putting one of his huge hands on her back and escorting her to the podium.

He stepped next to her and leaned to the mic clipped to the edge of the stand, said, "Each year Hudsonville and District awards Teacher of the Year to four teachers who exemplify excellence in creativity, innovation, and initiative. We want to present one of these awards to Jess Mapplethorpe for all she has done for the educational community both in and out of the classroom. She has always been an educator that energizes and mobilizes her students and her fellow faculty."

Jess was blushing and watery-eyed and everyone resumed their clapping. Clapping harder now like they purposely wanted to make her cry.

Pete had to wipe at his own eyes. They didn't get to Jess, but they got to him, he laughed. He watched her as the superintendent handed her a plaque, much like the two she already had put away in her keepsake box in the top shelf of their closet. He also gave her another cheque for a thousand dollars that he knew she'd put right into the college fund.

Jess gave a short little speech, reiterating what was written under her profile. He thought he heard her stomach growl, surprised the mic would pick that up. No one seemed to notice so she got away with it.

He watched her face as she smiled out at all her friends, struggling not to let them see her tear up, even though they could probably all see her lips and chin trembling. He was so in love with that girl up there. She had so much to give. She waved and bowed, she twinkled her fingers and gave a silent *Hi* to someone sitting up front.

Was she missing her new favourite face in the crowd? Did she want to look out here and see her handsome boyfriend cheering her on? That might make her life complete. She had everything she wanted, but there was something that could be improved. This 170 pound balding lump could be a 240 pound stud with abs and a nine inch cock. She would like that, wouldn't she? Of course she would. Looking out here and seeing the man of her dreams, her two boys, maybe a couple more, another one growing in her belly. Her handsome man turning all the other mom's heads, making their eyes go dreamy. She could pull that stud. She was hot enough to keep his feet warm. What the fuck was she doing with Pete? He was a one-hour visit to a cheap lawyer away from losing it all. She could get it all done in her lunch break if she decided. Fine one day, served papers the next. Bye, Pete. Take your little pecker with you. Have a nice life. Tyler's stepping in. Don't worry, he'll raise the boys, make me come each and every night. We won't even miss you.

“Just pull over up here,” she said, pointing ahead of them, waving at the side of the road. They were on Tullyfield heading north towards home. It was a broad four-lane drive with a brick paved island separating northbound from southbound, completely quiet now this time of night. It had wide shoulders and they were snow-covered, a light dusting, just like the conifers that lined the long drive. Pete and Jess were on their way home in the minivan. Jess had seemed tense and uptight. Her stomach had been making more noises.

“Are you okay? Are you going to be sick?”

“What? No, I'm fine Pete. Just pull over up ahead. Where that guy is standing.”

There was a dull green Hydro box ahead on the right, set back a dozen feet from the road. There was a big guy standing next to it with a steaming

tall coffee cup in his hand, shifting from foot to foot.

"Pull up here?" Pete asked her.

Jess laughed, "Yeah, Pete, come on."

The guy was tall, bulky, a Carhartt work jacket on, a hooded sweatshirt underneath with the hood pulled right up over his head. He had baggy jeans and work boots on his big feet.

Come on, what? he thought. She was laughing like he was missing something obvious.

Pete pulled to the side, towards the curb, stopping yards short of the man standing there. He was looking over at them and it made Pete worried. He kept the van in drive.

"Jess?" he said, turning to her but keeping his eye on the stranger, watching this guy walking towards them now. She was watching him too.

The guy looked around suspiciously, threw his coffee cup in the bushes. He looked like he was heading right to their van.

Pete let his foot off the brake and the van started to roll forward.

"Petey, Petey," Jess was laughing. She put her hand on him, gripped his forearm. "It's Tyler," she said, her voice high and bright, getting a kick out of this.

The side door slid open and Tyler threw himself into the bench right behind them, bringing the stinging cold in with him.

"Hoo," he exclaimed loudly, "freezing out there," clapping his gloved hands together, frost from his breath still. "I thought you weren't going to show up," he said, slamming the door closed, hard, making the van shake.

"We wouldn't do that to you," Jess said.

"What the hell is this?" Pete said.

Jess looked at him, her mouth eased into a wide toothy red-lipstick smile. She said, "Just a little fun."

Jess was turned sideways in her seat, her back against the passenger door. Pete looked back at Tyler, sitting behind on the bench, taking his gloves off.

Pete said, "Who's got the kids?"

"Ashley's there, Pete, don't worry," Jess said.

"Ashley? But—"

"It's all right. Everything is fine, they're with the sitter," she said in a soothing but condescending tone.

He looked back at Tyler who gave him a big smile, raised his eyebrows high, enjoying this as much as Jess.

The van filled up with white light as a car came up behind them. Pete put his hazards on.

Jess said, "Let's get going."

"Where?" Pete said as he looked in his side mirror and pulled back onto the road after the car passed.

"Head out to the main street."

"Where are we going?"

"Pete, remember when you turned thirty-five I sent you out to do a bunch of dumb errands and you scoffed, said, *Why do I have to do all this shit on my birthday?* When you came back I had all those people hiding in the house for a surprise party? You told me how much you liked that."

"Surprise party? Yeah, I remember—"

"Well, surpri-ise," she said, pointed two index fingers up in the air and spun them in celebratory circles.

Tyler laughed out loud and deep behind them. He reached in his coat and took out a pewter flask and unscrewed the top. "You're so crazy, Jessy-baby," he said.

He took a long drink from it and handed it to Pete, but Pete held up his palm, refused it. Tyler shrugged and passed it to Jess and she took it. She tipped it back and took a few deep gulps from it. She screwed up her face like a little kid and shuddered, handed it back to Tyler.

Pete said, "Jess, you don't drink."

She was still grimacing, held the back of her hand to her mouth for a moment, squinting, then with a hoarse voice said, "I also don't fuck men in my minivan in the winter while my husband watches. Look at me now."

Pete swallowed.

She held his gaze, cleared her throat, said, "I also don't accept a teacher award, stand up in front of all my friends and coworkers, smile and hold the plaque and the whole time my panties are at home in their drawer."

Tyler laughed out loud again.

Pete said, "You mean..."

"Look at me now." She raised her skirt up slowly, holding the delicate light cotton in her long fingers, smiling at him while she did it, watching his face. His heart hammered in his chest. He watched those sweet bare legs get revealed one slow inch at a time, aching to see if she was lying. She wasn't.

She raised it right up to her hips, her legs bare, pressed together, no sign of her panties where they creased at her hip; she let her legs fall wide open and he saw her bare sex. Freshly shaved and shining, healthy and happy as could be. She looked a little aroused already.

Tyler hung over the edge of her seat and looked down between her legs.

“Isn’t she so bad?” he said, more to Jess than to Pete. He swapped his pewter flask to his other hand and then reached down between her legs and she giggled as he stroked her.

“You’re not wearing any undies either, I hope,” she said to Tyler. She had hooked her little finger between her lips, the nail pressed between her white teeth.

Tyler laughed and he fell back onto the bench and Pete could hear him messing around back there, fabric brushing on fabric, a zipper pulled. Jess covered herself, leaned forward to peer into the back seat.

“Oh, God, look at you,” Jess whispered. She got farther between the front seats and reached back, probably grabbing at Tyler’s penis.

“Jess, come on, put your seatbelt on,” Pete said.

Jess sat back down, beaming, biting her lower lip. “Take us to the Costco,” she said, bouncing in the front seat as she clicked herself in.

“To the Costco?”

“Yeah. Park there. It’s closed—not a twenty-four hour. It’s quiet, empty. I want you to watch something.”

Pete exhaled, pushed all the air out of his lungs. The road ahead got very narrow, suddenly extended deep into infinity, “O-okay, Jess,” he said. He narrowed his eyes. His lips were dry and he licked them.

Pete pulled the van off the nighttime quiet road and into the empty parking lot of the Costco on Bowers Avenue. He drove into the centre of the lot, stopped just at the edge of the circle of bright pink-yellow light cast by a pole thirty feet above them.

Jess turned up the heater, twisted the knob into the red zone. She slipped out of her coat.

“Keep it running, Pete,” she said, and she sat forward, looking between the front seats to Tyler sitting behind him. She was anxious looking, but he

saw her tense face ease into a smile.

“What are you going to do?” Pete asked her, his voice was low and quiet.

“I’m going to give Tyler something. For all the things he’s given me.”

Pete wondered what that meant.

Jess climbed over the console and into the back seat and Tyler helped her. Pete turned in his seat to watch them. Tyler pulled Jess to curl up in his lap. She had her legs tucked up under her, hidden under her long skirt. They were looking into each other’s eyes and then they started to kiss. Gently, Jess pulling at his lips with hers, biting him softly. She brought her hand up and rested it on his cheek. Tyler’s hands searched for the bottom of her skirt, then disappeared up underneath. Jess let her legs part, opened herself so he could find her hot opening.

“What are you going to give him, Jess?” Pete asked.

Jess's face broke into a smile and she laughed while she kept kissing Tyler. Tyler’s eyes opened. He said, “No way,” and now he was smiling too.

“Pete’s never been back there. I’ve never had anyone back there,” she said to Tyler.

“Really? Pete’s little dick is good for anal.”

Jess laughed, said, “This is my first time.”

“Jess, you’ve never done that with me.” He was her husband. Shouldn’t he be first?

“I want Tyler to be my first. Don’t you think that’s sexy?”

He nodded.

“Petey?” she said.

“Yes.”

Jess went back to kissing with Tyler, the two of them with their eyes closed, sucking on each others’ lips. Pete put the van in gear and let it roll forward until some of the light spilled in and brightened up the action on the bench behind him.

Jess got off Tyler’s lap, her lips still pressed to him and she knelt next to him on the bench. Tyler’s other hand went up her skirt now and he slipped it between her legs from behind and it made Jess moan.

Tyler’s jeans were unbuttoned and unzipped and Jess's hand travelled down between his legs and slipped between the open denim V. She pulled his cock out, half hard but big in her little hand. She gently stroked it and squeezed it and Pete watched. He could see it grow while she worked it.

“Hold on,” Jess said, and she leaned forward, came right up to Pete between the two front seats and she pulled her coat to her, tried to find her pockets. She pulled out a bottle Pete figured was lube.

“Oh,” Jess gasped and stopped what she was doing. Her eyes closed and her mouth fell open. Pete looked back and saw that Tyler had his head under her hiked up skirt and he was in her sex, probably had his tongue buried in her. Jess let him, she hung her head next to Pete and let Tyler work his tongue through her. She was gasping and hissing.

She pulled herself away from him, swayed her hips away and she growled, climbed back with him. He kissed her neck and she tilted her head to him while she opened the lube, popped the top and squirted a lot into her open palm. Then she was on her knees again and she was stroking his cock, hard and sticking up now. She watched her own hand go up and down it, making it shine in the light.

Pete couldn't believe they were going to do this, He said, “Jess, isn't he too big? He's going to hurt you.”

“We've got lots of lube, Petey. Tyler will be careful.”

“Pete, man,” Tyler said, “it's not like I've never done anal before. I've never hurt a girl.”

Pete could see Jess's face, see her expression.

“Oh, she didn't like that, Tyler. She doesn't want to hear about your other girlfriends,” Pete laughed.

“Shut up, Pete,” Jess said, she was frowning.

She lifted her long skirt up, bunched it around her waist and she put a leg over Tyler's lap. She had her back to him, facing Pete, and he could see her wet mound.

“Are you watching, Pete?” she said.

“Yeah, Jess. Show me.”

Tyler gripped her waist, she was bent, her head tucked forward under the low velour ceiling of the van. Then she lay back on Tyler, her silky blonde head in the crook of his neck. She spread her legs, lay them over his open thighs.

“Can you see okay?”

“It's kind of dark,” Pete said.

Tyler took his cock and he was stroking it along her mound, arching his hips so he could pull that big thing back far enough that the tip would get behind her, slide up between her spread cheeks.

“Watch, Pete,” Jess said, “use the light on your phone.”

Pete reached for his phone in the inside pocket of his suit jacket.

“Oh, ow, oh,” Jess gasped out. He could hear wet flesh being forced apart.

He flicked through his menus, his hands shaking until he found his flashlight app and started it.

Jess was squeaking and complaining, there were sticky wet noises and the sound of air being forced out of her body around his big girth.

He got the light on them, lit up their dirty pornographic fusing. Jess had her legs open wide, her sex was untouched, wet and slippery looking, aroused. Tyler’s enormous manhood stretched out from his unzipped jeans and the tip of it was skewering his wife’s tiny anus. He was so thick he was pushing her own flesh into her hole, her skin tightening around where she was being penetrated. He shone the light on Jess's face. She was in pain.

“Are you okay, baby?” Pete said.

“Mm. He’s, ah, so big, Petey. Can you see?”

“I can, Jess.”

Tyler was dragging it out now, giving her some relief. Jess squirted more lube on her hand and then she put it between her legs, rubbed it on Tyler’s cock and her own soft flesh where it was piercing her.

“Pete? Do not take a picture, okay? I will kill you if you take a picture,” she said.

“I won’t, Jess,” Pete said from behind his phone.

Tyler was breaching her again, making her cry out. He was slipping it in though, he was making progress now, the lube was helping that big thing spread her wide. Jess pressed her back into his chest, she was humming, going up high to a squeak when his size hurt her a bit too much. She turned her head and closed her eyes and they kept kissing while he gradually let that amazing cock of his sink into Jess. She would stop kissing once in a while and frown, her wet mouth held agape, then get back to kissing. She put her hands up her own shirt and she fiddled around, working at the front clasp of her bra he figured. Her hand went over one of his, her little fingers squeezing between his big fingers. She pulled that hand up under her shirt and put it over her breast. Her hips started to move on him, she started to get the feel of it, swivelling in the tiniest contracted circles while that cock sought to probe deeper.

“Do you like it?” Tyler whispered to her, looking into her eyes.

She nodded and bit her lip. She said, "It hurts."

"I can go slower," he said, and she nodded to that.

Pete shone his light closer on them, lit up their connected sexes. Tyler's cock was about halfway inside her little bottom. Jess's pretty pussy was practically throbbing. She was bright and engorged, damp—she was absolutely aching to be touched. Could he get away with touching her? He wondered if it would be all right if he just reached out and stroked that slippery pink slit that he loved so much. Or climbed back there and put his mouth over her hot wet flesh. What would Tyler do though, feeling Pete's breath on his balls?

Tyler's hand enters frame and wipes his thoughts away; the moment was gone. Tyler's big tattooed hand swept across her hip and the second he touched her hungry yearning lips she inhaled sharply, making her tummy bounce, "Ah," she gasped then.

Jess changed the moment she was aroused, her breaths came in heaves, her little body wriggled on Tyler's big body, her hips gyrating to accommodate this thick thing sliding up inside her where it shouldn't go. She sucked on Tyler's tongue, kissed at his lips wetly. They both had a hand up her shirt, moving around under there, toying with her hardened nipples.

Tyler moaned, said, "Mm, I think you like it now, don't you?"

She nodded for him, closed her eyes and bit her lip. "How do I feel?"

"You're so fucking tight back there, Jess. You feel so good, baby, I wanna fuck you like this all night."

"Yeah, fuck me all night," Jess breathed, then she locked her lips over his again.

Tyler had his middle finger hooked inside her and she liked it, there was no denying it. Maybe at first this anal experiment had seemed like it wasn't going to work but once that kid had his hand on her sensitive swollen sex she was on board. His size had to be uncomfortable sliding up where it was. It had to be. Then again now that he had her breathing heavy she seemed to be having no trouble accepting that thing back there. Tyler's bare shiny cock was an angry sort of red. Pete wondered if it hurt being so big if what you had it inside was as tight as his sweet Jess's bottom. It must feel so good to make a woman do that blissful/pained face that his wife was making while he fucked her.

Something happened to his app when he tried to move his phone closer, tried to make that dirty point of contact brighter; he fumbled it, didn't drop

it, but now it had gone off on a crazy tangent, flashing some kind of emergency strobe. The inside of the van turned into a Euro dance club, flashing bright white in pulses to electronic music that wasn't playing.

Tyler was laughing.

Pete fiddled with it, slid a graphic slider on the screen but that just made it pulse quicker.

"Sorry," he whispered to them.

Jess groaned and in the bright flashes he saw of her face she looked irritated. She looked like a woman who had been having a great time, was about to have a wonderful orgasm, but her bumbling husband ruined it.

"What are you doing, Pete?" she said.

He looked at her face squinting in the bright light, frowning at him.

He closed it and the van went black. Everyone's rods and cones were all messed up. It seemed ten times as dark as it should be. He could hear Tyler laughing.

He opened the app again, went through his menus, heard them kissing which was good. He got it back on in a normal mode and tilted the light to them again.

Whatever kind of magician Tyler was he had a real trick of getting Jess in the mood, because she was lost in his kisses again, her eyes closed but her eyebrows held up high like someone getting the best massage at the best fucking spa. His hand was working between her legs again and she was wriggling on his fat organ buried up her ass. Pete's fuck-up was in the past.

Pete stopped trying to be fancy, stopped holding the light close, he just held it at his shoulder and watched them quietly for a good long while. Jess looked so happy with her back against him, her mouth locked on his. It looked like the anal sex was a bit difficult because he wasn't thrusting, just letting it sit inside her and he let her move herself on it the way she wanted. Tyler worked her between her legs with his big fingers, plunging, stroking and tickling. Pete felt swelled with happiness for his baby girl—it looked like it felt so good.

Tyler said, "Pete watch this." Jess's legs were draped over his thighs and he pushed himself deep inside her lifting her up so that Pete could get a better look at Tyler's cock shoved deep in her hole.

"Oh Jess," Pete sighed.

Jess gasped out, high, a squeak. "How does it look, Petey?" she said.

“You look so hot, sweetheart.” He wanted a picture so bad. His finger hovered over the symbol. One tap and it was his. She would hear the shutter sound. “I can take a picture for you, baby,” he said.

“Mm,” she moaned as Tyler kissed her mouth.

“Please, Jess.”

“Not my face, right?” she gasped, pulling herself for a moment from Tyler’s lips. She was drunk with passion.

“Yeah, take it, Pete,” Tyler said, and he spread her lips wide, his two big fingers with the tattoos pinned her lips far back like a bright pink butterfly. It looked way too *Hustler*. He didn’t like seeing his wife like that. She was the mother of his kids.

Jess was mad. Her hand came down and covered herself up, she said, “Don’t do that.”

Pete’s finger came away from the button.

“Take it, Pete,” Tyler said.

“You look so good, Jess,” he encouraged her. He put his phone down, tapped the flashlight closed and sat listening to them.

They made sounds in the dark. Ahhs, oh yeahs, ows. There was the slick wet sound of Tyler’s hand buzzing and shaking her dripping mound, the crackle of his thick fingers working through his wife’s labia. Jess gasping and then squeaking, the sounds getting quicker and higher. He could feel her breath as she moaned a breathy spearmint gasp from the backseat. He felt its warm caress on his cheek and he shut his eyes and breathed it in, consumed that piece of her. He tightened even harder between his legs, felt a sudden surge, could feel himself so intensely aroused that he was leaking. He wanted to touch himself but knew he would come in an instant.

“God, Jess, this is so hot,” he whispered.

Then she was leaning forward, he could sense her face just a breath away from his. She was bending forward, letting Tyler grip her hips and thrust himself inside her now.

“Are you going to watch me come, Petey?”

He scrambled to hug her. Didn’t want to lose her. He put his arms around her. He could feel Tyler thrusting himself into Jess’s ass, could see his arms wrapped around her, his hand probably reaching around to the front and driving his wife wild with a finger or two slipped up inside her.

“Kiss me, please, baby,” she whispered to him.

He couldn't believe it. He searched in the dark for her lips. He found her cheek and kissed it clumsily, worked his way towards her lips. He felt her hands grip him. One holding his wrist, the other digging into his knee. Their lips met and he pulled hers into his own, thrust his tongue inside her mouth and searched every corner, pulled her slippery little tongue into his mouth. She tasted foreign, tainted. She tasted like Tyler.

She pulled away, gasped, "Oh, my God, that's so ho-ot, ah—"

She cried out, bright and sharp and piercing. Tyler was giving her one incredible orgasm. Pete would like to think it was the touch of his lips on hers that put her over but he knew the reality.

He watched her thrash, watched her shake her head and cry out and throw her hair around her. Her hand on his knee turned to a deadly claw and she squeezed him so hard he thought he'd have to yell out. He put his hand on her slim back, felt the tremble between her shoulder blades as she came again and again. Tyler was holding himself steady inside her but whatever he was doing with his hands had Jess going out of her mind.

"Ah, Jess, yeah," Tyler roared behind her. He dug himself deeper and held her, his hands slowed and he growled, "Come on that big cock."

"Oh, God, I am, I am..."

Pete kept rubbing her back until she had rode it out, stopped trembling. "Oh wow, oh holy..." she whispered underneath him.

"Was that good, baby?" Pete whispered.

Jess held his hand, she said, "Oh, Petey, you have no idea. He's from another planet than you."

He squeezed her hand back, said, "I love you, I'm so happy for you."

Tyler said, "Where do you want me to come?" He had resumed his stroking into her interior, Pete could hear the now-familiar sound of his wife's anus being parted and stretched.

Jess told him over her shoulder, "Inside me. I brought towels."

That made Tyler groan with excitement and now he held her haunches firmly, raised himself up so that he was fucking her little bottom doggy-style.

"He's going to come in my ass, Petey," she whispered to him.

"Does it feel good?"

"It feels so *bad*, baby."

"Does it hurt?"

"Yes. Ah, it's okay though."

Jess's hand touched him between his legs and he almost jumped out of his skin. He felt her fingers going over the little outline of his cock as it pressed so hard against the front of his suit pants. In that moment he knew there could be no other woman in his life but his Jess. He felt consumed by his love for her—it was too much for him.

“Oh, baby,” he cried.

“Is this your tiny dick? It’s smaller than my hand.” Her hand went up and down the front of his pants, the heel of her hand digging into the underside of his painfully hard erection.

“Oh, Petey. You’re so small.”

She rubbed him hard, her hand rocking up and down, pressing him against his pubic pad under his pants. She moaned, and grunted while Tyler slid himself in and out of her. Her head went up and then back and down, her eyes closed.

She said, “Are these your little balls?” She squeezed them with her fingertips.

He’d seen her hand on Tyler. He never felt smaller than right now as she rubbed him through his pants. He was as hard and as big as he’d ever be but Jess's fingers were cupping his balls and the tip of his dick was running between the pads of her clenched hand where it met her wrist.

Tyler was grunting with his thrusts, a steady slap of his skin against Jess's soft cheeks. Her body swayed against Pete with his movements, moving her hand on his cock with the thrusts of her big lover.

Tyler was hunched over her back, his big hands gripping Jess's smooth haunches, her flesh pressing down under the fingertips of his strong grip.

Pete put his arms around Jess's shoulders, hugged her head against his chest. Her hand was still pushing against the tip of his little hard on. Pete spread his legs a bit, held her tighter, he could feel his balls jiggling in his loose underwear. Couldn’t even fill out a pair of briefs with his little manhood. He watched out the window, the wintry dark night so lonely except for one set of headlights slowly passing along the quiet street. Heavy snowflakes drifted across the parking lot, fat and wet, drifting sideways lazily.

He buckled, his body shuddered three times and he thought he might pass out. He snorted through his nose, grunted high, like a crying whimper; he was shooting semen into his pants, hard jets trapped in the fabric, his

wife's wrist pressing against him. He could feel his underwear filling, wet and hot, streams running through the creases of his thighs.

Jess knew and she stopped her movement, pressed him tightly against her arm and let him hump himself against her as he kept coming. His whimpers turned to sobs and he let her go, folded up in the driver's seat in front of her. He squeezed his little cock through his pants, felt the wetness right through the fabric and Jess rubbed his back slowly, going around in circles, feeling so good.

Tyler kept slowly, steadily, fucking her anus, but even Pete could sense a tremble in him, a ragged, urgent quality to his breathing. Jess rubbed and Tyler fucked and he could feel that through Jess's little warm hand over his back. His breaths turned to quiet dry sobs. He was so overwhelmed. So happy but so profoundly devastated, lost and alone, too.

Tyler roared low and clenched, he was coming, and Jess pressed into Pete with Tyler's weight on her back as he lost control and was ejaculating inside her.

"Oh, my God," Jess whispered, "I can feel you coming."

Tyler kept pushing into her, pressing her over and over again into Pete's back. His roar turned to groans and grunts as he shot shorter and shorter pulses. Pete could smell the vodka on his breath.

"Aah, fuck," he said, finally. He sounded spent. Pete could feel movement, jostling through Jess, the sound of movement above him, the clink of a belt buckle.

"Ow, careful," Jess hissed. Pete could hear the wet sound of Tyler's weapon being unsheathed from his wife's bottom. Jess gasped and sighed in pain.

Tyler collapsed back on the bench seat, making all sorts of satisfied, approving sounds. There was a quiet slap as he must have put his hand on her bare bottom, probably laying there looking at her naked rump, her dirty sex opened wide for him. There was a faint perfumey smell of Jess's ass now.

"What's wrong with him?" he heard Tyler's low rumble.

Her hand still smoothed Pete's back, warm and small, so friendly, so needed right now. "He's fine," she said.

Pete said, "I'm fine." He lay there bewildered at what this weird thing had become. Feeling distant from Jess but at the same time so loved and so outrageously in love with her.

Jess whispered, "I love you, Petey."

Then she was pulled from him roughly. She yelped and giggled, Tyler said, "Get over here."

Pete could hear them kissing behind him, the ruffling of clothing, lips smacking and sucking. Then Jess said, "Ew, no, I'm not going to touch it."

"Come on," Tyler said, laughing, "you know where it's been."

Jess laughed too, and then she was moving around back there. "Exactly," she said, her voice projected to the back of the van.

Pete sat up. His eyes felt red and puffy like he'd been crying but he hadn't shed a single tear; as much as he'd have liked to.

Jess was next to Tyler, bent over the bench, her arms working at something in the seat behind the one they were sitting on. Tyler sat next to her, his eyes lowered, watching her rump even though her long skirt had come down and covered her again, just her bare calves tucked under her the only skin visible.

Jess turned back with an armful of different coloured bath towels. All fresh from the laundry and neatly folded. She handed one to Tyler then bent over to give one to Petey.

She whispered, "You have to wipe down that little guy, don't you?"

"Yes," he said and smiled.

"Wasn't that incredible?"

"It really was, Jess."

Tyler said, "You've got the sexiest ass I've ever seen."

Jess looked over her shoulder at Tyler. "Stop it," she said in a way that definitely meant, *don't ever stop it; keep it coming*.

Pete took his towel and stuffed a corner down his pants, tucked it into his underwear and he dried with the other corner, dabbing at the dark stains all over the front.

Jess climbed into the front and sat herself down very carefully, wincing as she did it.

"Anybody else hungry?" she said.

“A Dave's Hot and Juicy, the quarter-pound,” Jess whispered to Pete.

Pete told the speaker box, "One Dave's Hot and Juicy, quarter-pound..."

Tyler snickered in the back seat and it made her smile. She looked between the seats to see him sitting behind Pete with a mischievous smirk on his handsome face.

"Hot and Juicy?" she said to him, wry smile with an eyebrow raised.

"No, I just think you could try the three-quarter-pounder."

"Jess?" Pete said, waiting for the rest of her order.

"Uhh—"

"You can take a lot more meat than you look like you could is all," Tyler said from the backseat.

She laughed, held Pete's arm, while she still looked at the menu. She hummed again and could see that it was making Pete mad since he was trying to place the order and then that made her laugh even harder.

"That everything?" the speaker said.

"Get me fries," she whispered.

"One small fry," Pete said out the window, rubbing his tense chin now.

"Get a large fry, we'll split it," Tyler said to Jess.

"Large fry, large fry," she whispered to Pete, poking at his upper arm.

"Make that a large fry," Pete said.

"Small fry and a large fry?" the box said.

Pete looked at Jess, shook his head at her, and it made her laugh. She leaned over and kissed his cheek.

"Just one fry. A large fry," Pete said.

Tyler got a large chilli but Pete just ordered himself a Frosty. They sat and talked a while in the parking lot of the Wendy's, Jess ate her hamburger and her fries, and it was somehow nowhere near as awkward as it should have been.

"Oh wow, I was so hungry I was dizzy," Jess said, holding her burger in one hand, four fries bunched in the fingers of her other hand. She was chewing quickly, breathing deeply, her eyes rolling up.

"Somebody worked up their appetite," Tyler said.

Jess laughed, said, "No, I just wanted...to be empty down there if you know what I mean."

Pete was spooning Frosty into his mouth, he said, "Did you like it?"

She didn't know. She shrugged. "It was hot having you watch him do that to me."

"You like when I watch?"

She nodded.

“Show me that picture,” Tyler said, leaning forward, his hand out to take Pete’s phone.

“I didn’t take one.”

“Dude,” Tyler said, disappointed, falling back in the bench, going back to his chilli.

It was beautiful out, a bit too cold to be out in it, but there was fresh wet snow and it made everything look pretty, even the concrete and asphalt of a suburban fast food joint. It made everything look safe. Jess ate and watched the fat flakes fall, drift sort of aimlessly before they settled down on the ones that had come before.

She was sitting on a towel folded underneath her bottom. She had her skirt pulled up and tucked behind her so her bare parts were on the terry should anything want to leak out of her. It felt like there was an enormous phantom cock stuck up her bottom—like her stinging asshole was still wide open. She smiled. This was so crazy.

They drove home and Jess told Tyler to hide in the van until they’d sent Ashley home. She paid the sitter and watched her walk across the street to her house. Tyler came in the back door and startled them and she laughed that she could be so edgy considering how good she felt tonight after the dirty and satisfying thing they’d done. Tyler was going to stay up and watch some TV and she kissed him Good Night on the lips. He clapped Pete warmly on the back before they headed up to the bedroom and it made her feel so strange and she couldn’t stop thinking about it.

Pete wanted to have sex but she was just too worn out. She let him spoon her and he fell asleep hugging her back with his little erection poking into her butt cheek.

She was so tired but she lay awake for a while staring at the night sky out past the sheer curtain. She couldn’t tell Pete but she was going to find a way to keep Tyler here as long as she could. There was just no way she could deal with him leaving right now.

PART VII

STUFFED

BEEP BEEP

SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 20TH

Jess didn't know why but she couldn't get it out of her head that she didn't want Pete excluded. It was the strangest thing.

She was brushing her teeth, Pete next to her doing the same, like most nights the two of them standing together sharing the sink. He'd always let her spit first then he'd bow his head and cover his mouth and spit. She watched him, watched the side of his head as his hand came up and covered his mouth so she couldn't see him spit into the sink—what was he afraid she would see?

He felt like a stranger in a way. Such a familiar reflection to her in the mirror, his narrow shoulders, his long chest hairs sticking up out of the v-neck of the t-shirt he slept in, the mark his watch had left in his wrist. She knew he'd taken it off and put it on his bedside table. Hadn't seen him do it, but knew he did it. Familiar with a capital F. But then what was it that was nagging at her?

It was like he made her uncomfortable. Like when it was late at night and you had to be out somewhere by yourself, maybe you were on an elevator and some man got on and the way the two of you were alone in a tight quiet space just gave you an odd feeling. A bad feeling. Why would her husband make her feel that way?

Truth was, if she confronted it, which was rare because it was so scary, she was worried that she didn't care anymore. She could taste it. This funny bad flavour. She wanted to have sex with Tyler and not be obligated to have to stroke Pete's little dick and tell him all the stupid details. She wanted to make love with Tyler and not have Pete lurking in a dark corner clinking his

ice cubes in his stupid whisky glass. But that meant she was done with him, didn't it? That shook her to her core. She couldn't accept that. That cannot be. Pete was her husband and most importantly he was the father of their two beautiful boys. This was just a game, wasn't it? It was supposed to be fun and crazy. Pete set the board up, handed out all the pieces, the pretend money, the cards, the dice, he read out the rules. But this wasn't a game anymore. This had become too real.

Pete's eyes were trying to catch hers in the mirror, she could sense it. His pupils darting around in her periphery when she was looking down at the sink. Right now she couldn't look him in the eye. So she avoided the mirror altogether. Rinsed out her toothbrush, put it in the rack, lined the toothpaste up against the back wall, then left the room still looking down.

Was her desire to add Pete to the fun a sudden desperate attempt to dilute the mix? Water down the potent seed Tyler was filling her up with? It might be just that. And if that was the case she was right to do it. This had to stop soon. It was becoming madness.

Tyler wasn't keen on the idea of sharing the bed with Pete. Flat out said, No, but she felt like he could still be persuaded. She'd touched Pete in the van the other night, did it so Tyler couldn't see. Rubbed Pete's little cock through his pants until he came. She had felt good about that. Like it was the right thing. It somehow made all the other things she was doing—truly awful things—seem to fade in their wickedness. Smoothed off the sharp edge of the very dangerous knife she was playing with.

Jess sat on the edge of the bed, checked the clock, made sure the alarm was set. Two more days of classes and then she was off for five full days. This was going to be a weird stretch. She had so much to prepare, hosting Thanksgiving for, what? ...ten people including the kids. Her dad flying in from Arizona, Patty and Russ coming over. And guess what everyone, Tyler was still here. *Oh, yeah, Dad, have you met Tyler? No? He's just the gorgeous hunk who lives in our house now. What's that, Dad? You think that's weird? Why?*

Pete came to bed after her by a minute or two, and she was already on her side, her back to the centre of the bed. She was lost in a list of groceries and errands and recipes when she felt Pete's hand on her hip. Then she was acutely aware of it. Knew what it meant, knew what it wanted. She felt obligated, duty-bound to his touch. Saying no right now in this heavy

climate would be a bad precedent. It would come with a heavy weight, like dropping an anchor when you were at full speed.

She let him explore, felt his warm soft hand work under her pyjama waistband, slip across her bare cheek and search for her warm centre. His fingers prodded at her, desperate for some approving moisture but she just didn't feel it right now. She let her knees come apart, let him run his fingers across her dry twisted flesh.

She turned to him, his hand coming out of her pants, and he was waiting for her, his eyes catching hers, they were wet and trembling and she forced a smile for him. She couldn't say anything. Her mouth wanted to move, to shape some sort of sound for him, but her brain struggled.

"Pete..."

Her hand went over his chest and she slipped under his waistband now, and she found his little half-aroused cock. She pulled on it with her fingers, felt it stiffen. She pushed the covers out of the way with her elbow, pulled the front of his pyjama pants down with her other hand. She looked down at his penis, glad she had a reason to break her eye contact. She watched her fingers stroke his short shaft for a little while, until he was completely hard.

She said, "I just can't get aroused by tiny dicks anymore, baby," she tried to smile, make him feel good.

"What are we going to do then?" he said.

"Look down at my hand on you," she said, and she held his penis out so they both could look at it.

"You're used to much bigger now aren't you?"

She just didn't want to talk about his small penis anymore. She stroked him a little faster, circled him tightly with a finger and thumb slipping it over the ridge of his glans the way he liked.

"Ah," he gasped.

She said, "Soon you'll have to move to the basement, you know. We can set up a room down there with your little trains. Okay? I'd do it now, but I just haven't figured out what we'll tell the boys. That's the hard part. We're going to have to do this very gradually."

"Mm, is he going to sleep in my bed, here?"

"Sleep? I suppose, he'll sleep after he fucks me. Fucks me like a man would. Then, yes, he'll lay that pretty head of hair right where you are now, wrap those big arms around me, protect me, keep me safe while I sleep."

"He could take care of you, couldn't he?"

“In so many ways, Petey, in so many ways.” She stroked him quickly and lightly, responding to the trembles she felt from him.

He gasped, “What else?”

She thought a moment while she kept jerking him, she said, “I’m going to take Tyler to pick up my dad. I can’t wait for my dad to meet my new boyfriend. I think he’ll really like him. Dad’s a man’s man too. They’ll bond over football, don’t you think?”

“Oh, Jess.”

She stroked him faster and faster, she was watching him now, his head tilted back his mouth agape. She felt herself start to tear up, felt her eyes swell and sting. “Pete? I’m scared. I think I might really be falling in love with Tyler.”

“Ah, don’t stop, oh—”

She had to stop. She was going to lose her mind. She took her hand off him, buried her head into his collar, squeezed her eyes shut so hard she saw stars.

“I’m sorry, Pete, I’m sorry, I’m sorry—I can’t...”

He turned to her, bouncing around in the bed so he could face her. She covered her face with her hands.

“It’s okay, baby, it’s okay,” he said. His arms went around her and he held her. She felt him kiss her forehead.

“Aren’t you in to this anymore, Jess?”

“Yeah.”

“Are you sure?”

“Sure, Petey.” She nodded, still had her face buried in her hands.

“Jess, I don’t want you to do anything you don’t want to do. Tell me what you want, honey. I’ll do whatever you need, okay?”

“I’m fine,” she said, her voice a funny muffled whisper, talking behind her palms, afraid to show her husband her face, “this can get pretty intense sometimes.”

“Don’t do anything you don’t want to do, please, baby.”

She nodded behind her hands.

Jess pretended to sleep, let Pete hold her until she could hear his breathing turn into a light snore, then she slipped herself out of his arms and went down to the kitchen. She poured some milk into her mug and set the microwave on high for two minutes.

She looked out the window, into the black of the yard. The snow that had come was melted now and it left everything wet and worn looking. Pete had the shrubs bundled up in burlap out there and an orange snow fence strung across the back of the yard to protect the new cedars they had planted in the Spring. The wind came across that field at the back of their house and the snow it brought could have buried them before they had a chance to take a good hold on this earth.

She turned and lowered herself to sit on the floor, slid her back down the kitchen cupboards, sat cross-legged and let her head fall back. The light from the microwave above her cast a white sheen on the glossy cupboard of the island across from her and she could see the silhouette of her sad slump-shouldered reflection in it.

She heard the jingle of Sargent's collar. He came around the island, moving cautiously, then when he saw her sitting on the floor at his level, his whole body started to wag and he submissively came to her, excited to see her, walking low and expectant. She put her arms out to him like she hadn't seen him in a year and he threw his body against her and she hugged him so tightly. She pulled him down to the floor with her and lay on her side face-to-face with him, scratching his chest while he pawed at her shoulder softly, his big black eyes watching and blinking.

"What am I doing, buddy?"

Was she lying to herself? What the fuck was she saying to Pete in bed? Where did those awful ideas come from? The microwave sounded out its long beeps above her, shut down its radioactive hum and the kitchen got too quiet, too dark again.

She loved sticking that knife in Pete. Saying the most hurtful things because he told her he liked them. She liked doing it. She used to think she liked doing it because it made Pete happy. But she could feel some truths bubbling up in her hurtful fantasies that she whispered to him. She *was* really excited for her dad to meet Tyler. Couldn't wait for her dad to see her with Tyler, felt like her dad would be proud of her, happy for her. Tyler was the kind of man Jessica Garrett should have married, should be seen with.

Beep-beep. The microwave reminding her.

Or would he? Conrad Garrett had suffered. His wife, Jess's mom, had strayed. She loved her mom but she'd really hurt them, hadn't she? Teresa Garrett had slept with another man from her work and it broke her dad's heart. Which broke Jess's heart. Seeing that man who represented so much strength in her life finally break down and cry. Right in front of his only child, sitting at their polished dining room table, head in his hands, his big shoulders shaking.

Beep-beep.

That was an awful time. Jess was out of the house two years later, off to university. Her parent's marriage was never really the same. Then her mom got sick and she died all in the space of four months and all Jess could think about was that they'd never gotten the chance to heal. That when her mom died and left them all she wasn't the same woman who'd raised her, made dinner every night, sang in the car on road trips, brushed her hair before she went to bed.

Beep-beep.

Maybe she saw it different now. She *was* the same woman, wasn't she? It was just Jess's eyes on her that changed who she was. Mom was a beautiful human being who had her own world going on in her head. Her own dreams and her own desires. Her own sadness and her own ideas of happiness.

She clunked the door open on the microwave, cutting off the tension, couldn't stand the dread waiting for what another beep may bring. She took her milk out and sat at the kitchen table, Sargent leaning on her knee. She drank it, quietly staring off into the dark kitchen forcing herself to stop thinking. Hoped the milk would work. Didn't know if she could ever sleep. So much to do. So much happening.

She finished, put the mug in the sink, she'd deal with it in the morning. She pat Sargent, guided him to his dog bed, then she tried to make her way

up the stairs as quietly as she could. She got to the landing and stood frozen, alone in the dark in an almost square hall with four doors in it. There were two doors here that led to two very different lives. It would be very easy to slip into that other bedroom. The one she shouldn't even think of entering, the one right across from her baby boys.

She opened the door to the guest room, stood and watched Tyler sleep for a moment. He was laying on his stomach, his head turned to the side, away from her, but she could see that strong profile against his white pillow. His arms were up above him, thick and muscular, dark ink drawn on them, bent, his big hands up on either side of his head.

She couldn't wait to be with him again, but they'd have to get through the holiday first.

PILGRIMS

TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 22ND

The lights in the gymnasium were off. She didn't have it dark, there were a few hurricane lamps on, sitting on cardboard boxes that had been papered up to look like cargo crates.

Jess was sitting on the edge of the stage that lined the one wall of the room that served as an auditorium and the place where they played basketball, did gymnastics... Normally this place was filled up with the springing sound of hollow rubber balls and kids yelling, the echoes of their voices making the place fill up with an almost indecipherable buzz of kinetic kid energy. Right now she had the place dead quiet and all eyes were on her. She was dressed as well as she could as a Pilgrim and she was trying to give every one the best idea she could about what the experience must have been like for those people traveling the ocean unsure of what they were coming to, cramped onto a creaky old cargo ship with a bunch of sailors who didn't like them. She had a long black skirt and shoes, her black cardigan, and her hair was tied back in a tight bun under a Pilgrim's coif.

The kids were sitting cross-legged on gym mats laid out on the parquet floor below her. Not just her own class, but two classes of second-graders and two classes of third-graders. The teachers had them close together trying to give them an idea of what it might be like in those close quarters.

Jess continued, "There were mostly farmers and shopkeepers on board, weavers and servants. Some people came as families and some men were on their own. Some were out of work in England and looking for a new life, some were just looking for adventure." She paused for effect, looked

around to make sure she still had their attention, said, “Thirty-five of them were Pilgrims...”

She hopped down off the stage, left her microphone for Carol who was entering stage left, ready to tell them about who the Pilgrims were. Jess disappeared quietly behind the boxes on the right and made her way to the back wall, leaned herself against it next to Sara. They both watched Carol work her way stiffly through the Pilgrims’ story.

Sara had her head back, leaned against the cinderblock wall, watching through sleepy eyes. She said, “Your dad going to make it?”

Jess whispered, “Yeah, he’s coming tomorrow, I’m picking him up at the airport.” She kept her eyes ahead, Carol was reading from her script, a white blue-lined sheet in her trembling hand. “You’re driving out to Battle Creek?”

“Nah. I canceled.”

“Oh, no. Why?”

“Can’t do the family thing right now. Not in the spirit. Too many questions I can’t answer.”

Jess chuckled, nodded. “I hear you. What are you going to do?”

“Just me and my little man.”

Jess waved her hand around between their thighs, searching for Sara’s and she found it, put her fingers through hers. “Please, come for dinner. Please, come have Thanksgiving with us,” she said, looking up at her friend.

Sara kept watching Carol, smiled, said, “I thought you’d never ask.”

GRAMPA

WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 23RD

They'd come in off the people-mover from the parking garage an hour before her dad's plane was arriving and Tyler wanted to have lunch. He'd driven and it gave Jess a thrill to see this big muscular guy in the driver's seat of the minivan; like he was a dad. Her husband. It was like that day driving out to the water park, this crazy thrill, like she was playing house.

They ate at Johnny Mercury, a retro fifties diner in the airport. Tyler put back a Smokehouse Double Burger and a Drunken Milkshake. Jess just had a Coke and picked at his fries while she watched him eat. Kid could eat. He needed fuel for that body though, and he wasn't driving some Hyundai.

She had rubbed his hand while they waited for the bill and she asked him what he was like at school.

He seemed to bristle and she said, "You know what I mean, what was it like being a big jock in college?"

"What are you getting at?"

"Oh, not that," she'd said. "I don't care about that. I mean, not really. I just wondered what...I just want to know more about you."

"Well, it wasn't that long ago. I was like this," he said and waved his hands over himself for her, smiling and showing her the goods.

He was right. Wow, he was right—it was just three years ago.

"What were *you* like at school?" he leaned forward, raised a curious eyebrow for her.

"What do you think?"

He narrowed his eyes at her, finally said, "Studious."

“A nerd?”

“No. Fun. But did well. Good marks.”

“Mm,” she’d hummed. “Yeah, that’s pretty close.”

“What do you think *I* was like?”

She’d smiled. “I don’t even want to say.”

“Yeah, pretty close,” he’d laughed.

Jess paid the tab, left the tip, and now they were walking through the long modern arched concourse of the renamed John Glen Columbus Airport, looking for arrivals out of Southwest Airlines, her dad flying in from Phoenix.

They were walking side-by-side through the packed Thanksgiving foot traffic and Tyler looked at her, held his hand out for her to hold it.

She put her hand out, let her small little digits wrap around his thick palm, her thumb hook around the other side, she squeezed him tightly like she didn’t want to lose him in this crowd. He smiled and she sighed and they walked on and she felt so good.

How had she let it come to this? How had her marriage loosened its belt so much that its pants were going to fall right down? She was walking with a man that wasn’t her husband, holding hands like they were in love. They’d had sex—powerful, earth-shattering sex—many, many times. He lived with them. She wasn’t going to let him leave. She was going to introduce him to her dad. *As what?* Her friend, she guessed.

She’d left Pete at home. Knew he would suffer. She had a butterfly thrill right now thinking of him at home worried about all the things she and Tyler might get up to. Worried that he was submitting to Tyler and exposing his weakness to her masculine father.

She didn’t know why his pain tickled her. It was like she was hurting him for something he’d done to her. Retribution. And like that made it okay for her to do the fun and dirty things she wanted to do especially since he wanted her to hurt him. Their relationship had become a twisted painful infinity symbol.

They arrived at the glass wall where her father’s flight would be disembarking. There were dozens of people already there, dotted along the glass a few deep. There was a sliding glass door off to the right where other flights had already started to let passengers out.

“You nervous?”

“Excited,” she said, beaming.

“You love your daddy?”

“Do you think I was a daddy’s girl?”

He snickered, put his arm around her and pulled her close to him, looking down into her eyes, said, “Yeah, I can see it. You were definitely a daddy’s girl.”

She shied away, giggling.

“Maybe,” she said, hearing the little girl coming out in her own voice; not liking it but also somehow liking it.

“You still are a daddy’s girl, aren’t you?” he laughed and he put his hands under her open coat and squeezed her sides, and she said, Stop, but she didn’t want him to.

They were face to face, she looked up into his beautiful blue eyes and she couldn’t help biting her lip. She kissed him, softly and quickly. He pulled her back, kissed her and held the back of her neck.

“Mm, Tyler,” she sighed and she wrapped her arms around his thick neck, laid her head on his chest.

“Here’s people now,” Tyler said, and she looked past the long glass wall, could see passengers coming out of TSA into the arrivals section, headed for the baggage carousel.

She stood on her toes to see over the people in front of her, looking to catch a glimpse of her dad.

“What does he look like?” Tyler said.

“White hair, tan. Distinguished.”

They both scanned the passengers as they slowly filed into the baggage claim.

“What does your dad think of Pete?”

She shrugged, looked down at her loafers, tapped the toes on the tiled concourse floor. “He doesn’t hate him.”

“He knows you could have done better.”

She slapped his chest, chastised him, “Tyler,” she said.

There was a woman watching them flirt. Well-dressed, middle-aged with dark hair, looking over her shoulder at Jess and Tyler—she looked Jess up and down, smiled and nodded to her. Jess reached down and held Tyler’s hand again.

“What’s he do?”

She said, “Retired. Engineer. He stopped working five years ago. Lotta, lotta golf these days.”

She squeezed Tyler's hand when she saw her dad. "There he is," she said.

Her dad had come into the claim area, just a bit taller than most of the other guys. Looking good, real good at sixty. He had a black polo shirt on, he was more tan than ever, his hair thick and pure white, parted to the side. She bounced and waved her arm to him over the crowd but he couldn't notice her.

"Come on," she said to Tyler, squeezing his hand and trying to pull him through the crowd, pull him closer to where the sliding glass doors were opened. Tyler got ahead of her, made way for her, parting the crowd with one hand, people clearing away without protest for a man of his size and strength. She drummed her palms on his back with excitement and gratitude that he was getting her through.

"There he is, there he is," she bubbled.

Her dad was coming through the doors, his eyes scanning the crowd looking for her, and she hopped around Tyler and threw her arms around him.

"Daddy!" she cried and she squeezed him tight, one leg kicking up.

"Hey, lollipop," he laughed, putting his hands on her waist.

She hugged and hugged until he said, "Okay, sunshine, pop's got a sore neck."

She let him go, said, "Is it okay?"

"Yeah, Jessy, just hurts when I look left and when my little girl tries to strangle me. Who's this guy?"

She turned and Tyler was right behind her, up close, looking to shake her dad's hand.

"This is my friend I told you about that's staying with us. This is Tyler. Tyler, this is my dad, Conrad."

"Oh, hey, yeah right, good to meet you," he said, shaking Tyler's hand, giving him a good dose of eye contact. "I didn't know he was so young."

“Where’s Grampa staying?” Pete Jr. said.

Pete was up on a step stool, awkwardly holding out the wand from the Dyson, vacuuming along the top of the curtain rod in the

Dining room. He heard him but his brain was late making sense of it. He said, "Huh?" but started to answer. "He—"

"Where's Grampa staying?" Petey said again.

Pete stepped down off the stool and shut the vacuum off. "He's staying at a hotel, Petey."

"Oh," he said, looking down, obviously disappointed.

Sorry, kid, he thought, your mom's boyfriend's taking up the only spare bedroom in the house. He booked Conrad a room just about two minutes down the road, prepaid for it. He'd lend him his Buick too, to get back and forth over the next few days.

Petey was helping, looking out for Andy and walking around with a cloth and a spray cleaner wiping at things like his mother would do. Pete ruffled his hair, said, "Don't worry, Petey, he'll be here all the time, he'll just drive down the road to sleep. You won't see him any less."

Petey took Andy and his cleaning stuff into the kitchen, getting himself to work in there, and Pete watched him a moment.

He smiled. He had some exciting news.

Right now, however, his twisted little soul was surfing on a big wave of emotional pain, a thirty-foot Pipeline, its slippery feet carving on the crest while sickly sweet but humourless dread ruffled what was left of its hair. His face fell just thinking about it. He shuddered. Jess right now was off with Tyler. Picking up her dad just like she'd told him when she was stroking him in bed. His face tightened like he would cry. What would she be doing? Kissing him, holding his hand, her and her dad, and Tyler all laughing in the van. Maybe laughing at Pete. Conrad would like Tyler, wouldn't he? He looked like the kind of man that should be with the apple of his eye.

"Hoo boy," he whispered, and he turned the vacuum on, got back to work.

He had another little worry to contend with. What happened the other night in bed. Those things Jess had said to twist him hadn't left his mind. They'd stuck with him. Those were awful things she'd said, she was getting very good at tuning in to his hurt. Those things seemed different in the light of day when he heard them again echoing in his mind in the morning and his cock wasn't hard.

As much as he was thrilled by the suffering she was giving him—even right now his heart was clamped tightly in his chest with worry, barely

enough room to stretch a full beat, but in his belly there was an odd arousal—he was hopeful that his exciting news might bring an end to this. Give him some sweet relief. He wasn't sure how much more of this game he could stand.

THANKSGIVING

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24TH

“O h my gosh,” Jess said, “sshhh, let me get my camera.”

She'd gone in to ask her dad and Tyler how many burgers they wanted. Tyler and Conrad and her boys were in the family room, preparing for what was going to be an epic day of Thanksgiving football. Conrad was in Pete's chair, turned to face the TV, Petey was sitting on the floor on a cushion next to his Grampa. Tyler was laying on the couch, feet up, and he'd fallen asleep. It was a half hour before the game started and he'd drifted off during the pre-game show. He had one arm up, his hand behind the cushion his head was on, his other arm was wrapped around Andy who'd fallen asleep as well, laying along Tyler's body. It was out-of-this-world cute. She could almost tear up. Andy's innocent face laying across Tyler's chest, his sweet eyes lightly closed, his gentle brow relaxed and peaceful, his little pouty lips slightly parted. The funny thing? What made it picture-worthy: Tyler's face held the exact same expression. They looked related.

She tip-toed into the kitchen, even though they had fallen asleep in front of the loud television and her steps wouldn't be heard over it—she just didn't want them to wake up before she got a chance to capture this. She went to the kitchen grabbed her iPhone off the counter next to the cutting board where she'd been preparing her stuffing. She was walking through, swiping at the screen to get to the camera when she saw Pete coming down the hall in his apron, holding a spatula. He shrugged at her, expectant. He was waiting to hear how many burgers to put on the grill.

“How many?” he said.

“Hold on,” she whispered. She pursed her lips and gave him a silent shush, held up her index finger to tell him to wait.

She padded down to the family room and moved the phone around so she could get a good composition while her father watched her. She moved it lengthwise, it was funnier when you got the scale in perspective, how big Tyler was. She pressed the red button three or four times.

She felt good she got it, stood there smiling, watching her little baby fast asleep on Tyler. Her dad was watching her, and it made her feel a little self-conscious. It wasn’t bad what she was doing, was it? That’s her son, and it was so adorable the way they were laying. She could feel her dad watching and now she didn’t want to look over at him. It had to be bad she realized. When she had the camera up she remembered thinking how she didn’t want Pete to have followed her in and catch her doing that.

She should want that though—Pete would think that hurt was exquisite. Didn’t she want him to hurt, want him to see these things? Or were they becoming too personal now, private between her and Tyler? She was lost in a hedge maze sometimes, not sure where she’d been or where she was going, all the shrubs, the walls, they looked the same sometimes and she was just truly, truly lost.

She held her palm against Andy’s cheek and watched his eyelids flutter, watched her little boy come awake.

“Wake up, sleepy,” she said.

Andy opened his eyes and then closed them, drifted off again. She laughed.

She grabbed Tyler’s big toe through his sock and shook his foot, said, “Hey, sleepy number two. How many burgers do you want?”

Tyler was just as slow to wake up. His eyes fluttered, slowly parted and there were his bright blues looking up at her—he didn’t know where he was. He looked around and groaned, contentedly, looked at the football on the TV.

“Game hasn’t started?” he said, his mouth so sleepy he garbled his words.

Jess said, “I don’t think so, it’s just noon.”

He squeezed Andy, looked down at Jess’ beautiful five-year-old, and snorted. He stretched until his legs shook, and stroked Andy’s shoulder.

“What was that?” he said, and smiled.

“How many burgers do you want? Pete’s grilling.”

“Mm. Two. No, three. No buns, Jess. Tell him I don’t want any bread.”

“Okay. Dad?” she said turning to see her dad watching her from Pete’s chair.

“I’ll take just one, Jessy,” he said to her. There was that strange look again. She wasn’t even doing anything.

“Petey?”

Petey jumped up, said, “I’ll go tell him, Mom,” and he headed for the hall to go out back.

Tyler said, “Tell him I don’t want buns, Petey.”

“Okay,” Petey said, his voice coming from down the hall. The sliding glass door rumbled.

There was a knock at the door and Sargent jumped up barking and wagging, trotting through the kitchen headed for the front door.

“That’s got to be Patty and Russ,” she said, no one listening to her now, all their eyes on football.

She could see their silhouettes in the window of the front door, held Sargent’s collar, and opened the door to let them in. Patty brought a green bean casserole and Russ was holding a pumpkin bread. She thanked them, brought them into the kitchen and then Russ was gone. Another football fan in the house. She heard her dad call out, *Hey, Russ, how ya been?*

Jess sent Jacob to go find Petey out back with his dad at the barbecue and Tammy stayed to help her mom and Jess in the kitchen getting the dinner ready.

“He still here?” Patty whispered to her.

Jess shrugged, very animated, threw up her hands and closed her eyes. Tried to make it seem like it was out of her hands, like, *Gosh, Patty, I don’t know what it’s going to take to get this guy out of here.*

Sara arrived in the middle of the first quarter of the Vikings-Lions game and Jess went out to help her. She’d brought three bottles of wine (thank you very much) and creamed onions in a casserole dish, and Jess carried in her little boy, Bart, unbuckling him from his car seat and walking him behind Sara hugging him up on her hip.

She got Sara into the kitchen and they poured themselves a glass of wine. She introduced her to Patty, saw right away that those two would get along well, two compatriots in cynicism. Then Jess took her for the tour of all the guys in the TV room. She said her hellos, narrowed her eyes and nodded when she saw Tyler. Pete was out back still, done grilling, but busying himself out there with chores. Not a fan of football.

Bart was ready for a nap and she let Sara take him upstairs and put him down in the master bedroom. When she got back she helped Patty and Tammy cut vegetables and mostly they talked about stuff they wanted to talk about, and nibble and drink their wine. Jess was so glad that she'd come.

Then the questions came about Tyler. Not the normal inquisitive interest in what he was like, what it was like to be so close every day to someone who was so hot, but a little more about why he was still there. *What was he going to do?* She danced around it as best she could, said the job market had been tough, he's got work and he's definitely contributing to the household and that it won't be long until he finds something permanent. She felt like she made it sound pretty reasonable, she gave logical answers that in many ways were, quite frankly, accurate. But she couldn't help notice how defensive she got and how any question about Tyler made her reactive, made the back of her neck hot and made her want to fight back like she was being challenged. But she *was* being challenged and maybe she should be; Tyler shouldn't be here anymore, he should be out—he was ten years younger than them, he had a different lifestyle, or at least he should have. But he was here and whatever was happening it felt good and it felt right and Tyler seemed satisfied.

When Jess was ready to boil the potatoes she wanted the stock pot she kept on top of the cupboard in the laundry room. When she left the kitchen, a roar from the football fans behind her in the family room, she found Tyler and Sara talking in the hall. She didn't like the way Sara's head was cocked. She didn't like how closely they were standing. Sara was attractive. Taller than Jess, very pretty face. Maybe not as pretty as Jess. Sara never quite lost all the baby weight but somehow she wore it well. She looked very cute with her big hips and ass, her big breasts. She was confident, wore slim fitting clothes, proud of her curves, knew a lot of men liked that. She was young too. Younger than Jess.

And Tyler looked like that kind of man. One that would grab a big pretty girl with curves and do awful things to her; he'd probably fucked a lot of big pretty sorority girls back at college. They probably had all heard about that big dick and wanted to see if it was true.

So she interrupted them, just a strange hormonal reaction. She walked up and got herself between them and told Tyler she needed him in the kitchen. Sara looked at her awkwardly, those big pretty brown eyes of hers narrowed suspiciously again and Jess walked back with Tyler realizing no one would need Tyler in the kitchen for anything, how obvious did she have to make this?

Jess kept Tyler a while in the kitchen waiting for Patty to clear out so she could talk to him. He hung out, got himself another beer. She could see the smirk on his face; a kid who knew he was in trouble. She didn't like that look, it was like something a little boy would do waiting to hear what his teacher was going to say, or his mother.

So when Patty finally left and she was alone she didn't say a thing. She could be sexy, she didn't have to be jealous, she had a choice. But he was on to her.

He got next to her at the island, both of them facing out of the kitchen.

"Somebody's not jealous, I hope?" he said, and she jumped feeling him put his hand on her behind.

"Tyler," she said.

"It's been a while," he said.

"It has," she agreed. "But now?" she raised her eyebrows to him, motioned to the counter at all the food being prepared.

She kept working and his hand absently fondled her rump, squeezed and kneaded and she let him do it. She didn't hate it.

"You are so amazing, you know."

She said, "Am I?"

"I mean it. You are *everything*."

"I don't know what that means."

"I'm lucky to be with you."

"Me?"

“My happy homemaker,” he said, watching her still try and prepare food while he had his hand moving over her sensitive areas, dropping his hand down until she felt him brush the top of her thighs and it made her scalp tingle.

“You’re what makes me happy,” she whispered.

His hand slowed on her and she felt the tips of his fingers trying to slide in between her legs, pushing the fabric of her skirt against her.

“Tyler, don’t. Are you crazy? There’s so many people here,” she could feel herself go red, but she could also feel the corners of her mouth curl up into a smile and she couldn’t stop it. He saw her smile and his eyes narrowed, he was up to no good, and that made her smile even broader, her lips sliding up her teeth.

“What?”

“There’s no way we could get away with it.”

“That sounds like a dare.”

“More like a threat.”

“You don’t scare me,” he grumbled, squeezed a handful of her cheek firmly.

“Even with this knife?” she joked, but she felt her upper lip starting to get a little warm.

“Why don’t you run upstairs and slip off your panties?”

“Tyler. My family is here.”

“I bet you I could make you come while you were standing in the kitchen with everyone just on the other side of the wall.” Still smiling, holding her eyes, a wintry sparkle in the blue there, reflecting light coming in from the kitchen window.

“I bet you could too,” she said, smiling, watching her hands chop up potatoes.

“Run upstairs and take them off. I can give you a little squeeze down here,” he said, putting his big hand right up between her legs, “every time someone’s got their back turned.”

“Oh, Tyler, oh, ah, that’s so bad.”

His hand was moving between her legs. It was below the island if someone came in they wouldn’t see. “Oh,” she whispered again, felt her eyes want to close. She put her knife down and faced him. He held his hand rigid for her, pushing against the front of her skirt now, looking into her

eyes, and she started to hump her desperate mound against his fingers. “Oh, don’t make me wet,” she groaned, turning it to a laugh.

“You are so sexy,” he said.

She opened her legs a little wider for him, let him push himself against her. She could hear her breaths get lusty. This was too much, this was Thanksgiving. She was supposed to be cooking. But...fuck, he had a way. She held his wrist, her other hand came up and she grabbed his forearm. He had a hand up on the counter supporting his weight while his other hand was doing nasty things down below; she dug her fingers into his rock hard muscles.

“Kiss me,” she whispered, looking up into his eyes. Just half a minute and they would stop. He moved himself to her, holding her eyes and she kissed him quickly, bit at his lip, closed her eyes, just for a second.

There was someone in the hall.

She turned quickly to her potatoes, picked up her knife. Tyler moved behind her and ran the sink, poured himself a glass of water. A body had passed through from the family room across the hall and into the laundry room. She could see a shadow of someone in there right now, watched the grey shape move along the hallway wall.

“Oh, no, oh shit,” she whispered.

There was a clinking of bottles in there and someone banging a pot around. It was Sara and she came out to the hall and walked toward them into the kitchen, she had her arms filled with beer bottles and an empty snack bowl pinched between her fingers.

She put the things down on the counter next to the sink, said, “We’re going to need some refills out there. Where do you keep your beer?”

Jess chopped potatoes, said, “Huh? Oh, there’s a beer fridge out in the garage, just through the mud room. Thanks, Sara.” Chop chop.

Sara looked at Jess and Tyler and nodded, said, “Okay.”

They watched her leave.

Tyler leaned over her shoulder watching down the hall. “Do you think she saw?”

Jess frowned, said, “I don’t think she could contain herself if she saw.”

It hadn't been the best day for grilling but it wasn't so miserable that he was driven inside. The sky was grey, cloudy, maybe a little low and oppressive, but there wasn't any rain or wind and the temperature wasn't so cold that he didn't mind being out here taking the time to scrub the charcoal off the grills of the barbecue he'd got just this season from the Save-Mart. He scrubbed the grills until they shone, sprayed them, scrubbed them some more. He would stop and throw Sargent's tennis ball every time he brought it to him, then wipe his hands on a cloth.

Sargent gave up eventually, came back with a stick and lay at the bottom of the patio steps and chewed it. Pete stopped his relentless cleaning and came to sit on the top step and watch him. He looked out over the yard, the wrapped shrubs, the bright orange snow fence. Winter was coming very soon, and they were calling for a doozy. He frowned, hoped he was prepared for it.

The sliding glass door rumbled behind him, opened then closed. He turned and saw Sara walking out to him.

"Hey," she said, and she sat next to him on the top step and handed him a can of beer.

"Thanks, Sara, I was actually dying for one."

"Well, you're welcome," she said, looking out over his yard now too.

He pulled the tab on his beer, told her he was glad she was there, glad that she could make it. She pulled her tab, said she was glad to be there and they touched can rims together.

"You good?" she said.

"Yeah, I am. Why?"

"You're out here a lot."

"Mm. I like it out here," he said, gulping beer.

She was watching him, he could feel her eyes moving over his face.

She took a sip, said, "How're the boys doing?"

"They're doing great, I think. Know something I don't?"

She looked at him and it seemed like she might have something to say. Her expression changed, and he watched her lips tighten, purse. She looked away, looked down at her hands holding the beer can. He swore the colour of her face changed.

He chuckled, said, "You okay? You look like you saw a ghost."

"I just got some bad news. About a friend."

Now he felt stupid. He said, "Oh, I'm sorry. I hope it's not serious. Is it somebody you know very well?"

She said, "It's somebody I love...and I think they might be sick."

“H e looks way too comfortable to me,” Patty said.
Russ said, “I know. Did you see him?”

Pete stood outside the powder room. Russ and his sister were in there with the door open and he could hear them talking quietly. He felt really guilty lurking in the hall listening to them talk but it felt like he'd passed the point he could break away, afraid now that if he left they would hear a creak of a floorboard. Then they would feel bad that Pete had overheard some of the things they were saying.

He didn't come down this hall to listen, didn't follow them so he could find out what they were thinking. But he was finding out. It wasn't anything surprising. *How could Pete allow this? What was Jess thinking? Who is this guy? What about the boys?* All the things a concerned sister who loved her little brother would be expected to say.

He was going to have to get out of the hall, they would come out soon and all three of them would be face to face and that would be uncomfortable. He didn't want them to see him right now. He took a careful step, heard his knee creak, hoped they couldn't hear that and he shifted his weight forward, leaning his body towards the kitchen.

Jess walked from the family room ahead of him, returning an empty platter to the kitchen. She turned and he screamed inside his head.

“Pete, have you seen the boys?” she called to him.

He shook his head. His eyes were wide.

She looked at him strangely.

“I think they went down to the basement,” Patty said behind him.

He turned and their eyes met. He looked down and made his way to the kitchen.

Pete had been hanging around the kitchen for a while and it occurred to her he was waiting for the coast to clear so he could say something.

She kept herself busy waiting for him to get his chance. Wondering what it was going to be. What was wrong now, Pete?

Pete asked Jess, "What do you think of Sara?"

"My Sara?"

"Yeah."

"What do I think of my friend?" she smirked.

"I don't know her as well as you do. I just mean...is she a good person?"

Jess scrubbed her devilled egg platter in the sink, getting the sponge into all the divots the eggs would sit in. She shook her head, wondered where he was going with this. She said, "Yeah, she is. She's very caring. She's a good teacher, a great mom. Why?"

Pete was standing next to her, not looking at her but over at the arch that led to the family room. He said, "Yeah, I thought she was nice too. I was just wondering, you know, she and Tyler might make a good couple."

The back of Jess' neck went on fire. "What?" she said.

Pete went on, "She's pretty, Bart could do with a dad. I just wondered...you know..."

She put her tray in the drying rack, firmly, hearing the porcelain clink against the stainless. She wanted to slam it down in there, but she held back. She liked it, didn't want to break it. She said, "Is Tyler looking for a girlfriend? I don't understand at all why you would possibly want to meddle in their lives." She stared at him, her mouth grimly set.

Pete put both his hands up in defense, one hand holding a can of Coors. "I'm only thinking of Sara and Bart. It must be hard and lonely."

Jess said, "Tyler is looking for a job, Pete...he's not looking for a wife. Okay?"

"Okay, okay." Pete took a sip of his beer, looked around the kitchen, said, "He can't stay here forever, you know. I was just thinking of your friend."

Pete got himself out of the kitchen and went in and sat in the family room. He took a footstool between Russ on the end of the couch and

his father-in-law sitting in Pete's recliner on his right. Patty was by the window going through her phone and Tyler and Andy were on the couch past Russ. Tyler was leaning forward, intent on the game, and Andy would watch, get bored, doze off, and sometimes climb on Tyler's back.

The game was in the fourth quarter. The table was littered with peanut shells, crumbs, and there was a platter with three baked cheese pastries Jess had made that were old now, the orange cheddar turned hard but still oily. When this game was over they were all excited for 4:30. Redskins versus Cowboys. About as traditional and American as a conflict could be. Dinner during halftime, then they'd finish that game. In the evening was the big head-to-head. Colts-Steelers and Tyler was, of course, a big Steelers fan being from Pennsylvania.

A commercial came on, loud and jarring, and Russ got up and squeezed past Pete, mumbled, *Going right through me*. Jess's dad turned to Pete, he looked at him, looked him up and down and his mouth creased into a slim line. He said, "How you doing, Pete?"

Pete nodded, said, "Good, good," went through the same rigmarole he'd tell anyone about managing a busy—very busy—big box store. Conrad listened, seeming disinterested but yet somehow caring. He looked like he was waiting to say something.

Conrad and Pete didn't have the best relationship. Never any trouble between them, never a bad word. They were just two guys who were very dissimilar. Like Pete and Tyler. Just two guys who had far different interests.

Conrad stopped him talking—Pete was going in circles anyway—put one of his big old white-haired hands on Pete's knee. He said, "Pete, I want you to know that I think you're a good dad."

It took him by surprise. He felt instantly overwhelmed. It was nothing like Conrad had ever said before.

"W-What?"

"Those boys of yours. They love you. I think you've been a great father."

"Thanks, Conrad," he said, feeling his face flush with blood.

"I just want you to remember that." He swivelled in Pete's recliner, turned back to the TV and took another sip of beer.

Remember that when?

Pete felt a real tremble in his belly. A quiver. If he looked down he knew he'd see his sport shirt ruffling. He was trembling with emotion. A lot of different ones. He couldn't decipher how he felt. Good and terrible all at once. He got up before anyone would see him cry.

The Pennsylvania Legacy was running on its own. A ghost train. No one down in the basement yet there it was pulling its coal carts through rustic old Calumet Bay.

He stood and watched it run for a moment still feeling a lingering wave of emotions coursing through him. He knelt down and looked under the trestle tables that held up the recreation he built. He peered through the dark until he could see the white painted outside wall come into focus. No kids under there. He checked the furnace room and the cold storage but there was no one.

The command centre had been left on, train running on the rail, his American Flyer was off the track and laying on its side in the dusty parking lot at the General Store.

He just wanted to come down here to get himself together.

When Pete got back to the family room Tyler was sitting on the footstool next to Conrad, he was talking earnestly, moving his hands around a lot like a salesman. Conrad was handing him a business card, he was nodding, and he said, *No, that is really something, it would be interesting to see where it would go.*

Andy was sitting in Tyler's spot and Petey was there now, sitting next to him, his back against the couch, his skinny legs sticking straight out, feet dangling off the seat.

Pete walked in front of the TV, around the coffee table, to address them.

"Boys, do you know anything about the train set?" Andy shook his head. No. Petey was sad. Sad before Pete had said a word. Petey looked to Tyler, back to Pete and he said, No, but his voice barely broke above a whisper.

"Well, I'd like to know why—"

“Pete.” It was Tyler, he motioned with an open palm to the TV. Pete was interrupting the Cowboys-Redskins pre-game.

Pete got down to their level, said, “Boys, were one of you down in the basement with the trains?”

Andy was sleepy, his eyes half open, he whispered, *No, Dad.*

“Petey? Do you know why the trains were still running down there?”

“These trains...” Tyler said.

“Pete...” Conrad said.

“Petey, come with me,” he said and he walked Petey out of the family room and down to the powder room. When he was in there Petey’s face screwed right up like he was going to bawl. He went beet red. Pete put his hand on his shoulder and squeezed Petey’s little palm with his other hand. Petey cried and said that it wasn’t him and that Tyler said they could and that Jacob asked Tyler and that it wasn’t his idea and that even though he was down there he still didn’t want to. Pete told him he should know better than to ask Tyler what to do, Tyler doesn’t know anything about the rules around here and Petey said he didn’t know what to do anymore.

Petey broke away from him and he was really crying and Pete stayed in the powder room, down on one knee. He heard him run upstairs and slam his bedroom door. Pete stayed like that a while, listening to his own breathing and he knew that things couldn’t be like this anymore. Tyler was going to have to go. But there was hope. Pete had exciting news.

Jess had the dining room table set with the good silverware. She had a gingham tablecloth over the old walnut table that had been her family’s when she was growing up. Just a dumb wooden table but it held so much meaning, so many memories and it seemed kind of nice seeing her dad standing next to it now, in her own home with her own family. She wondered if her dad could recognize all that weight the table came with or if it was just her because it was her youth tied up in it. To her dad it was probably just some table he and Mom bought from a department store when they were first married. Maybe couldn’t even tell her where.

Her centrepiece was a section of birch tree trunk, the white paper peeling on the sides, and it was hollowed out. She’d arranged a bouquet in

the centre of it, sunflowers, pink alstroemerias, green poms and some purple daisy poms, then there were small pumpkins and some other gourds around it, and pinecones scattered artfully like she'd seen in a magazine. She'd lit ten dripless candles and they were woven through the arrangement.

The food was ready, served in dishes and on platters, fine bone china that had been her mother's mother's. There was Sara's creamed onions, Patty's green bean casserole, Jess' potatoes and candied yams, her own double-cranberry sauce, a Brussels sprout and chestnut salad, homemade bread, glazed carrots, roasted squash with brown sugar and bacon, ham, shrimp, a baked Kale and vegetable gratin, and of course the turkey with her apple-maple-walnut stuffing.

She didn't know how any of these fellas were going to eat after all the snacks she'd prepared for them this afternoon, but they better figure it out because this was an epic meal.

She stood at one head of the table as everyone found their seat. They all nodded to her, acknowledging how well she'd done, how great everything looked, and she said she had a lot of help and she thanked Tammy and Patty and Sara. Pete was at the other head of the table, holding his seat and waiting for the ladies to sit down first. Tyler was at her right, Andy was at her left, and her dad looked quite happy to sit by Sara who looked a little worse for wear. They all looked a bit that way. They'd all indulged a bit too much in drink during football. Russ hadn't said a word, she was convinced, in the last hour.

And as every one sat and grabbed their napkin and the littlest ones were put into their boosters she said to Pete, "Where's Petey?"

Pete knocked on his son's door and he heard Petey quietly say, *Yeah?*

He went in and Petey was laying on his bed and he had his tablet next to him but he was reading a Goosebumps book his mom had brought him home.

"Hey, buddy," Pete said. He sat next to him on the bed. He looked all right, calm, no more tears.

"Hi, Dad," he said.

Pete put his hand on his back and he said, "Dinner is ready, you going to come down?"

"Yeah, Dad," he said and he sat up next to Pete. "Dad? Can I sit with you?"

"Sure, Petey. You don't want to sit with your friends?" he said and he rubbed his shoulder.

Petey shook his head.

Pete sat with him, looked around his room. He was neat like his mom. His toys put away, his books on their shelves, his bed was even made. Seven-year-old Pete was quite different, sharing a room with his older brother Michael, the two of them living in a filthy little boy nest of ripped up comic books and broken G.I. Joes.

"You still having some trouble with Jacob, Petey?"

He nodded again, his two hands clasped between his knees, kicking his legs against the side of his Avengers comforter.

Pete said, "It was Jacob who ran the trains?"

Petey nodded, shrugged, and looked up at his dad. He said, "Jacob says Tyler is Mom's boyfriend."

"He says what?"

"He always says Tyler is Mom's boyfriend. I hate him. He makes kissing noises, he—"

"You can't let him say that, Petey. Just...just don't listen to him. That's not true, buddy." Pete held his son tight as he could.

When Pete brought Pete Jr. down and he got him a seat next to his dad, Conrad had everyone hold hands around the table and he gave thanks and said grace, and every one of them said Amen even though none of them had been to a church in years.

Pete stood up and he asked everyone to lift their glass for a remarkable woman, his wife. He told them all what she meant to him, and all the things she does for the boys. He talked about her award, her work, her passion. And ended with, of course, the wonderful meal she'd prepared.

"I would be nothing without you," he said finally, and everyone said, *Hear, hear*, touched their glasses, drank, and then they ate.

Pete watched Jess down at the end of the table. Her blonde hair was pulled back, her cheeks had gone red from drinking wine all day in the kitchen. Just not a drinker. But her eyes were glassy, and she was all smiles down there, her golden earrings sparkled as she laughed, and he loved to see her happy. He would do anything for her to be happy. Give her anything.

Conrad had been talking about his condo board down in Arizona. Pete could picture him sitting at the head of some table in a sunny but air-conditioned room, a bunch of white-haired ladies hanging off his words, his golfing buddies all nodding at his decisions, Conrad's big hands clasped under his chin, his class ring gleaming. He'd said, *Not if Conrad Garrett has something to say about it.* Zoning changes affecting a parking lot visitors to the condo had been using to park overnight were changing, essentially closing it off even though it still wouldn't be in use.

Andy asked, "Why does Grampa have a different name?"

Jess looked at Andy, said, "Garrett?"

"That used to be your mom's name too," Tyler leaned close to him and said, "Jessica Garret."

Petey heard and he laughed. "Jessica?"

Tyler laughed too, he said to Petey, "Is that funny?"

"Mom's name is Jessica?" Petey said.

"Your mom used to be Jessica Garrett. Back when she was your age. She was Jessica Garrett, but some of the kids called her Jessica Rabbit and she hated it."

Jess rolled her eyes, smiling, bit her lower lip.

Tyler said, "That's why she changed it to Jess."

There was some chuckling but Andy didn't get it. He said, "Why?" looking around him.

Tyler said, "Because she used to have big teeth when she was little. Like a bunny rabbit." He scrunched up his mouth and bared his teeth to Andy, made a funny face like a rabbit eating.

Jess laughed out loud and Andy giggled.

Patty looked over at Pete.

Pete nodded, his mouth clamped. He didn't know that.

It was time.

"So, listen Tyler," he said down the table.

Everyone turned and his scalp tingled. He didn't expect to have everyone's attention.

"Listen, I don't want to toot my own horn, some of you may know I'm a bit of a bigwig around Save-Mart," he joked, put his palms up to stave off the applause.

All faces were turned to him.

He said, "Uh, I made some changes. Uh, s-structurally. I...I've created a new structure I'd like to implement and it requires a position be filled. I've changed to a new system of inventory and warehousing management and there's a job. A manager. A j-job for you."

Tyler looked to Jess and she shrugged. Pete hadn't told her a thing.

"I won't discuss compensation, uh, here, uh-obviously but I can say that it will be better than a first year teacher, or comparable. And it has a great, uh, great benefits package."

Tyler kind of stretched in his seat, inhaled, his chair creaked. He said, "Well, that's great, Pete. Yeah, I mean," he shrugged and leaned forward. "But Pete, I'm a teacher."

"It's a job, Tyler. A great job."

"Yeah, but..." he kind of looked around to see if he could get some support.

"You don't want it?" Pete frowned. Patty shifted in her seat.

"Well...no."

"Why not?"

"I'm sort of not into retail. No offense."

"Oh, you're above retail?"

"Not above it, no. I'm a teacher, Pete. All that shit made in China. Not for me, not a good fit."

Pete was stare-eyed. He shook his head. "Made in China? Who else is going to make it? America's filled with the kind of people who'd turn down a perfectly good job when they needed one. How can we ever make things here anymore? In America. Tell me. Everyone wants their stuff made in America but they won't spend an extra fifty cents for a God—" he caught himself, Petey staring at his crazy dad, whispered, "gosh-darn T-shirt. When price dictates your purchase, guess what happens? I mean it's simple—"

Jess said, “Pete you always say that you hate that stuff is made in China.”

He went quiet. Thanks, Jess. He did. He did hate that.

Russ fell asleep after dinner during the second quarter of the Steelers game. Patty woke him up told him they should go and he said, *No, no, one more beer, let me make it to half time.*

Everyone was painfully stuffed. Conrad was on the recliner and he had the footrest kicked out, the toes of his gnarly black-socked feet sticking straight up. Tyler was in his corner with Andy again, laid right back, stomach noticeably bulged. Russ was on the other end and he didn’t look like he was going to make it. His eyes, as well as being sleepy, were red and watery. He had something white in his beard and nobody had thought to help him, not even Patty. Pete figured all the guys were around ten beers in.

Patty left him to it, shaking her head and smiling, being a good sport about it. Pete said he’d grab some beers. He looked around, the other two raising an index finger. They were all in.

He went to the garage, passed through the kitchen. The girls were all in there, the dishes were done, lights dimmed. They were having wine and talking. Didn’t even notice him go by.

He went out to the garage, down the wooden steps to the beer fridge. Things were a real energy hog. He got this old one at a garage sale of all places, cleaned it out and kept it for beer storage, only plugged it in for a few days a year; July four, Memorial Day, holidays like Thanksgiving.

They’d really gone through the Coors today. Still half a case left, but they’d drank almost two cases. No, maybe more. Maybe forty-five cans. He grabbed a fresh case off the top of the fridge slid it towards him, heard the scratch across the top. Then something fell right past him. Something heavy and deadly his brain told him quickly. And in the split second it took to travel to the floor he remembered that it was an axe head—he’d been using the sledge end, broke it at the neck, put the head on the fridge, forgot about it—now it was looking to chop his toes off.

He did a crazy tap-dance, glad no one was around to witness it, kicking his knees up high a few times each leg, hands up overhead holding the case

of beer from falling on him. It hit the ground, chipped the concrete, bounced, got tipped off the toe of his dancing slipper and tumbled two feet across and hit the kickstand of Tyler's bike. He froze.

Nothing happened, just a clunk off the aluminum, bike didn't even budge. That was close. Tyler had put his bike away in their garage for the winter. Pete had cleared a space for him to store it. The garage was used for storage anyway, it's not like Pete and Jess were putting a vehicle in it. Tyler had quite a few things stored in the garage. Pete looked at Tyler's boxes, his squat rack, his barbell, his weights. He was taking up a lot of space, wasn't he? Getting very comfortable.

Pete put the toe of his worn leather slipper on the axe head and scraped it around in circles, enjoying the vibrations as it grated on the concrete, felt that energy traveling up his foot. He went in a few protracted circles then shot it off like an air hockey puck, let it slam off the kickstand and ricochet off into a cardboard box. The bike wobbled once.

Tyler's stupid bike. His muscular body bent over it, his legs spread on either side, that big cock and balls sitting on the seat vibrating with the roar of the motor. Girls turning to watch him go by, his thick muscular arms stretching out his tight T-shirt, tattoos all down them. Fuck that guy. I mean really, fuck Tyler.

He looked up at the mudroom door.

His foot went over the axe head again, let it go around and around filling up the garage with the sound of energy being stored. Then he shot it off, enjoyed the loud ping, watched the heavy metal head shoot off in the other direction this time. The bike wobbled again but didn't fall. The kickstand showed a dent.

He opened the fridge, took the case of beer and slid it under the opened one. He grabbed four cold beers and held them in his arms, headed for the stairs. He put them down on the 2x4 railing so he could switch off the light. Then stepped quickly back down, walked to the bike and kicked the kickstand hard with his toe.

It didn't fall but he collapsed with the pain that shot up his leg and exploded in his brain. For sure, absolute certain he'd just broken a toe. He lay hissing on the concrete floor as the pain got worse, so bad he thought he'd scream, then it slowly subsided and just settled as a deep penetrating throb. Apparently the kickstand only bent one way. He wiggled his toes, they weren't broken. He stood up, straightened Tyler's kickstand, went up

and closed the light, grabbed everyone's beers and limped in to watch football.

Sara was the first to head home, bundling up her little Bart and saying a strangely tearful good-bye to Jess and Pete. Patty said her good-byes at half time, buckling a very happy and sedate Russ into the passenger seat, Tammy and Jacob in the back of her Odyssey, probably asleep before they even got home.

Jess put the boys to bed. Andy wanted to stay up and watch TV with the guys but she told him he knew he couldn't do that and he agreed. She was upstairs a while, Pete figured she was reading to them. He tried to watch more of the game but he didn't care about football and his eyes just kept closing on their own. He mumbled a good night to Tyler and Conrad and they grunted. He stumbled upstairs and went into the bedroom, brushed his teeth, put on his PJs and climbed into bed.

He lay there for a while trying to fall asleep but he could hear Jess down there talking loudly, loud laughter coming from her. He tried to push it out of his head, thankful now that he'd had so much beer and food his brain couldn't be distracted by their distant voices for long. He pulled up the cover just as an added buffer and tried to will himself to sleep. He had to work in the fucking morning.

Jess came in to the bedroom about an hour later and she was quietly laughing to herself about something. Pete wasn't sure if he'd slept in that time or if he'd woken up just as she came in but he felt like he hadn't been asleep at all. He watched her slip into the bedroom, try to be quiet, close the door behind her. She carefully walked in the dark, feeling along the wall with one hand until she made it to the bathroom. He could hear her brush her teeth in there, and then she peed. When she came to bed she was just in a pair of panties and a loose T-shirt. He watched her bare legs as she stumbled her way into their bed.

When she was under the covers he moved to her, slid himself behind her until they were touching. He put his arm around her, wasn't trying to get lucky, he just wanted to feel her. His hand was on her belly, felt her little tummy swollen from over-eating. He was feeling it too. Her hand went over his and it made him feel so good.

He said, "We might have a little problem with Petey."

Her head turned swiftly on the pillow to him. "What is it?"

"Jacob has been teasing him. Saying Tyler is your boyfriend."

"What?"

"Petey's not taking it well."

"What did you tell him?"

"That it's not true. Don't listen to him."

"Oh," she said, and she rubbed the back of his hand, staring at the ceiling and thinking.

"But the real problem? It must be coming from Patty. Jacob must have heard her say something. Do you think she knows?"

"That I fuck him while you watch? No, Pete, I have to be honest, she would never think that. No one would."

"I know, but do you care that my sister thinks that you are fucking him on your own? Behind my back. Because that's what it would seem to be."

"Yes. Of course I do," she said, eyes still open looking up at their stucco ceiling.

"He's got to go, Jess. I mean now."

Her head turned so she could face him, her silky blonde hair twisting on the pillow. She said, "We can't do that, Pete. We can't."

"He has to, Jess. It's getting too crazy. Sara was here, your dad. This guy is in our house. What are people thinking—saying—behind our backs?"

"You love it though," she said provocatively.

"Jess." He wanted to be serious, but just the feel of her light lean body under his hands, the slight smell of her faded perfume, the dim silhouette of her pretty face turned to him—she could get away with anything.

"You know you do. Watching me with him. Knowing he's fucked me so good. Standing there with my dad right next to me. Seeing my dad shake hands, watch football, joke around with this man who makes me come so hard," her fingernail touched his chest, then scratched down him, working

over his belly, “Who’s got that big dick that I love. Knowing that I’ve done the dirtiest filthy things with that thick—”

He tried again. “Jess. We can’t.” He held her wrist, stopped her hand from exploring.

“Petey, we’re not kicking him out,” she said quite seriously.

He lay for a while, looked up at the ceiling with her, felt her fingertips lightly scratching at his belly.

“That’s bullshit about that job I arranged, for the record,” he said.

“Sweetheart...”

“No, really, I went all out to do that. To help him.”

“I know.”

“And he turns it down? I mean, who turns down a job that pays well? That has benefits. I would have made him a manager.”

“I know.”

“You know how many people I see come through there that would kill for that job? Julio has a hundred cousins would cut Tyler’s throat if I said that’s what it would take to get that job from him. He won’t even consider it? Do you know how many people deserved it over him, ones already with me for a few years would have shit their pants when I gave it to him? The trouble *that* would give me? I put my neck on the—”

“Pete, I understand your frustration, but he’s a teacher.”

“He’s not. He’s a guy who needs a job. To get out of our house.”

“Pete, slow down. He *is* a teacher. You got him a great job. I know it. *I* know it, okay? But honey, the job is so good he’d never be able to leave. He’d never be a teacher if he took such a good job. He’d just become a part of Save-Mart and never go on to do the things he wanted to do.”

“Tell me about it.”

“Hey,” she said, pat her palm on his stomach, “what were *your* big plans?”

He shook his head slowly in his pillow. “I thought I was going to be the big hero today.”

She smiled, said, “You are to me. I know.”

He turned to her, wanted to see her face, he said, “Do you really think you’re falling in love with him?”

She didn’t answer.

“Jess?”

“No,” she said, finally, still looking up. “He’s just a kid, Petey. He’s in a different stage of his life.”

“He’s attracted to you.”

“Do you think so?”

“Fuck, Jess. Of course he is. You’re beautiful. And the things you do to him?”

“Do you think he...do you think he thinks I’m good in bed?”

He let her wrist go, put his palm across her thin neck, brushed his thumb on her cheek, said, “Jess you *are* good in bed. How could you think...what more could you do? You’re incredible. He’s a hot twenty-five-year-old guy and look at you—you’ve got him eating out of your hand.”

“Do you think Sara is in the same league as me? That Tyler would go for her? You wanted to set them up...” she whispered to him, he could feel her get warm under his fingers.

“You’re so much prettier than her, sweetheart. You are. He wouldn’t go for her. You’re the special one.” He kissed her forehead and she put her hand around his wrist and held him. “I just wanted him out of the house. That’s why I said they could be a couple.”

“Petey, he’ll leave when it’s time,” she said.

“It is time.”

“No, Pete, it’s not.”

“He shouldn’t be around the kids.”

She said, “Oh, come on, why?”

“He’s on drugs.”

“He’s on drugs?” she pulled back, her eyebrows up in the centre, making the cutest little furrow in her brow.

“The steroids, Jess.”

She tsked, rolled her eyes, said, “No, he’s not.”

“That’s impossible, Jess. Impossible that he’s not on steroids.”

“It’s not. He’s been lifting weights since he was thirteen.”

“He’s *so* big.”

“Some men are just genetically gifted,” she said, and her hand went down his forearm and over his shoulder, travelling again and he knew where it was headed. She was in the mood tonight. “Some men are born big and strong and they’ll just be that way no matter what they do. Some men are born with little tiny dicks,” her hand went under his waistband, “and some are born with big long heavy things that can swing around, slap their

thighs while they walk.” Her fingernails dragged over his scrotum. “Pete, you’ve seen his balls. If he was on steroids his balls would shrink. They’d stop producing testosterone, shut themselves down. He has big, huge balls. I’ve held them—they’re not shut down at all. They’re vibrant, bursting—”

“Okay, Jess, that’s enough.”

He could see her smiling, the moonlight putting a little twinkle in her eye. She could feel him growing, his little thing hardening against her wrist. “I’ve put them in my mouth, Petey, and sucked on them,” her finger slid up the underside of his erection, “they’re so big I can only get one in at a time, Petey.” She was laughing, her thighs were rubbing together under the sheets and she slid one leg up over his, whispered, “Oh, Petey, you should feel what it’s like when he empties them inside you...”

“Jess, are you drunk?”

“Maybe a little,” she giggled.

Pete kissed her forehead and asked her, “How much wine did you have?”

She squinted, gave him a cute smile, said, “A little more than I should have.”

He kissed her chin and she tilted her head back in the pillow.

“You want to put that little thing inside me and try to get me off?”

“I do.”

“Tyler’s been stretching me so wide, do you think you can even do it? Do you think I’ll even feel you?”

“I can do other things too, Jess,” he whispered to her.

“Petey, would you go down on me? While I think about Tyler,” she put an arm around his neck.

Their bedroom door opened quietly, Tyler slipped in holding onto the doorknob, then turned and closed the door without making a sound, let the latch go quietly. They stopped, Pete looking over at this violation, Jess looking over her shoulder with him. They watched him looking around, wide-eyed. Their eyes were used to the dark but Tyler couldn’t see a thing, he crouched, took a step, whispered, “Jess?”

Jess whispered back, “Over here.”

Jess turned away from him, her hand came out of his pants and she left his embrace. Tyler made his way to the edge of their bed. He had an urge to grab her roughly by her slender shoulder, yank her around and bore his eyes into her hers, make her feel the hurt she gave him, but he didn't. He bounced in the bed, turned himself around and put his back to them, pulled the sheets up to his ears.

Jess whispered, "Oh, no, no, you can't come in here, Tyler."

"I just want to talk before bed."

"Oh, Tyler."

"Come on, Jessy."

"Is the door locked?"

"Yeah."

Pete heard Jess lift the sheets for him, inviting him into their bed. Then he was in, Pete could feel his heavy weight shifting around behind him, making the springs squeak.

Tyler whispered, "Conrad fell asleep watching Sportsbreak."

"Didn't you wake him up?"

"No. He's fine."

"You should wake him up, send him to the hotel. Ah, no, he can't drive can he?"

"None of us can, Jessy. He's sleeping just fine on the couch. I put a blanket over him."

"Do you like him?"

"Yeah, he's a good dude."

"Ah, oh, Tyler." There was movement behind him, ruffling fabric, skin on skin.

Tyler said, "You feel so good, you're so warm down there."

"Mm. How was your game?"

"Steelers won."

"Ah, mm. You must be happy," her voice was breathy, airy.

"Where my hand is makes me happy."

She sighed, then it turned to a little giggle. "You can't be in here."

Tyler whispered, "We can be quiet."

"Pete's *right* here."

"He can watch. I don't care."

"The boys...my dad's right downstairs."

"Dinner was incredible," Tyler said.

“Do you think everyone had a good time?”

“Oh, for sure.”

“Did everyone like the dinner? Get enough to eat?”

“Get enough to eat? Feel my stomach...”

Pete could feel Jess shifting around behind him, her elbow went into his back.

Jess giggled, “Someone’s losing their abs.”

“It’s your fault.” Pete heard a kiss, a sound like Tyler had kissed her.

“Will you still want to fuck me when you make me fat?”

Jess’ elbow was still moving against his back, she said, “I think you’re sexier than ever right now.”

“Really? You wouldn’t care if I got big and fat?”

“No.”

“Well, I’m not going to. I like watching your eyes when you see me naked.”

“I do love your muscles...”

“Do you want me to get peeled again?”

“What’s that?”

“Do you want me to get ripped again?”

“I like you however you want you to be.”

Pete didn’t really see a difference in how he looked. He looked the same. Maybe just a little smoother. But he didn’t get as close as Jess did, get as good a look or put his hands on him.

“Remember that night we were together down in the family room and you came from touching me?”

Jess snorted, “Yes.”

“That made me crazy.”

Jess whispered, “I was a little worked up.” Her hands were doing something again, Pete could feel her elbow tapping into the middle of his back.

“That was incredible that night.”

“A bit awkward.”

Tyler laughed, agreed, “A bit.”

Pete said, “Guys?”

“What’s wrong, Pete?” Jess said.

“I have to work in the morning.”

They giggled, he could hear them, feel them moving behind him. Giggling so hard now they were making the bed shake.

Tyler whispered, "It's hard to stay lean during this time of year especially when my little lady makes a big Thanksgiving dinner and, God, Christmas is just around the corner."

Jess laughed, tried to keep it quiet.

Christmas?

"I'll have to do it in the new year. I'll get myself all cut up again you can feel my muscles."

Pete said out loud, "You should be in your own bedroom."

"I locked the door, Pete."

"Did you?" Pete hissed over his shoulder.

"Yeah, I did," Tyler said firmly.

Jess's back had been sliding down his and now he could feel the soft little soles of her bare feet against his own. He jumped when she touched his kickstand-toe. A zipper was being drawn down, under the bed covers.

Pete said, "Jess?"

"What" her voice was muffled, she was under the sheets.

"Nothing," he said.

Tyler gasped, "Oh, fuck, you're such a good, good, girl."

Jess was blind below the blankets but her fingers worked under the denim, her wrist scratching on the teeth of Tyler's zipper. His cock was warm, half-hard—firm but flexible—and she pulled it out of his unzipped pants. She kissed along the top of it, worked her lips down to his glans and then pushed it into her mouth. She squeezed at his balls still stuffed behind the rough cotton pants and she heard him groan up above her. Her head bobbed on him but the big thing kept folding up on her so she gripped him firmly with one hand at his base. That really worked for him and he let his legs open and more of that fantastic cock emerged from his pants. She pushed him gently on his hip while her mouth was still on him and he rolled to his back and she moved with him, kneeling now over him. His hands pushed his pants down and she lightly stroked him and played with his sticky balls while he got them down his legs and kicked them off.

She sat up and pulled her shirt over her head. She said, "Take your shirt off."

Pete was plaintively watching her kneel there in the moonlight coming in their bedroom window and it made her nipples harden. She felt like the most important girl in the world. She smiled knowing his eyes were playing over her smooth skin, looking at her pretty breasts swing.

"Yours too," she said to Pete and she watched his sad face change.

Tyler took his shirt off and threw it on the bedroom floor and she let her palms slide all over his beautiful but Thanksgiving-bloated body.

Pete sat up and he pulled his V-neck over his head then clutched it to himself, hid his weak body from them. He stared at her, blinking.

She stroked Tyler, said, "Your pants too."

Pete floundered around, rocking from side to side, getting his pants pulled down under him, hiding his penis from them. He tossed his clothes off the edge of the bed and sat cross legged, sideways to them his hands between his legs covering himself. She could see him blinking.

She said, "Let us see it."

"Jess," he complained.

"We're all friends, Petey."

She felt funny about it when he finally took his hands away and he laid back uneasily. She felt embarrassed.

Not embarrassed for him but embarrassed for herself. Like she was in high school and her cool friends just caught her talking to her nerdy friend from middle school. She was embarrassed for Tyler to see her husband naked knowing that was what Jess had got for herself, what she had settled for. Pete was representative of her and seeing Pete's shame would somehow make Tyler think there was something wrong with Jess. She cursed herself for thinking so horrible about the father of her children.

But there it was: Pete's little pecker hard as could be sticking up out of his messy pubic hair, pointing forty-five degrees towards his belly. His small tight ball sack bundled up, tightly hugging his skinny shaft. Thing wasn't much longer than her fist.

"Oh, Petey," she said, shaking her head.

She got herself down between Tyler's legs again and she stroked his floppy cock and sucked on the end of it. Performing for Pete who she knew had his eyes glued to her every move. She stroked Tyler, held her hand in a wide c-shape around his girth making him look to Pete even bigger than he

was. She moaned and hummed like Tyler had the tastiest cock in the world. Right now her handsome boyfriend tasted very salty; like a man who'd just spent the whole day sitting on the couch, eating, watching football, and drinking. She wasn't sure if it was her imagination but he also tasted like gravy. It didn't matter, he had her so hot that even this different, dirty kind of Tyler was sexy as she could imagine. She sucked him until he she had that big thing hard and then she let her left hand wander until it found Pete's little penis. She gripped it and stroked it and just that simple contact made her husband shudder and jump and she was worried this was going to be over before it started. So she squeezed him instead and held him. Let him feel her hand on him, her thumb on his tip, but didn't give him too much. He was the kind to come quite suddenly.

She let him go and winked, said, "Touch me, Pete. Act like you're a man, like you know what you're doing."

"O-okay."

Jess held Tyler's scrotum up in the V of her right hand and she ran her tongue over his balls while Tyler watched her. Pete put his hands on her back, rubbed her, moved down her waist and over her rump until he was between her legs. He felt good down there, running his fingers through her damp folds. She was on her knees and her rump was up in the air and she swayed it for Pete, let him know she liked what he was doing.

"Get up," Tyler said, and he nodded to her with his chin.

Tyler raised up with her, his eyes locked on hers. Now all three of them were looking at each other, kneeling, sitting on their heels on her bed, all of them completely naked.

Her hands went between both their legs, grabbed their cocks and gently stroked them. They just stayed like two dumb boys, arms at their sides watching her little girl hands on them. She caught Petey sneaking a peak over at Tyler's.

"Did you want to touch it, Petey?"

Tyler looked over at Pete, caught him looking between his legs, said, "Pete if you touch my cock, I will fucking knock you out, okay?"

Pete nodded, wide-eyed.

Jess laughed. She felt bad for Pete. He wasn't confrontational. She didn't like to see him bullied but somehow seeing him dominated so easily with that simple phrase also really turned her on. He recoiled from Tyler; he didn't want any trouble. Seeing his little dick in her hand, Tyler's long thick

one flailing around in her other hand, knowing Pete was watching, seeing the difference, both of them realizing, witnessing—it was unavoidable—how much better she could do. She could feel his little dick suffering, hard as a rock but it was like it didn't want to be there. Tyler's big bully cock came in the room and Pete's sad little penis wanted to slip out a back door, run home and go read comic books in its room.

She laughed silently, open mouthed, bent forward until her head was on Tyler's big shoulder.

Pete said, "What?"

"Your dick is so small, Petey."

"I know, Jess. I don't want to touch his...it's not like that."

"Okay. I just don't know about you anymore."

"What do you mean?"

She shrugged, still stroking both of them. "What you get from this. What you're looking for...what you want from me."

Pete rubbed her arm, bent so he could catch her eye, said, "Don't stop, all right? Everything is fine. I love you."

"I know," she said. But she was starting to struggle with this. Why would her husband want this? Want her to be shared. If Tyler was her husband he wouldn't share her. Nor would she want to be shared. This had all started so hot, so crazy and exciting, a dirty thing she was doing with her husband, but if she slowed down too much, looked around, she could see how everything was starting to get twisted.

She pushed it away, watched her hands work their penises, said, "Look at my two men. I can't believe I'm doing this. Look how different they are. Petey, my little Petey."

Maybe she didn't get it but he was her husband and she would give him what he wanted. Surrendering to it gave her a thrill. She said, "Petey and his little peter," and her shoulders shook laughing at her own joke.

Pete squeezed her arm, said, "You're kind of funny when you drink. Maybe you should drink more."

She saw he was smiling but she shook her head, said, "I don't think it's for me."

Tyler said, "You gonna have regrets in the morning?"

Pete said, "I think we're all going to regret this in the morning," and Tyler laughed. God, that turned her on. She wanted to have something to regret.

Tyler was sitting back on his heels, his legs wide enough for Jess to be in there, her pretty face bobbing over the first few inches of his fat cock, her hair tucked behind her ear. Pete watched her, one hand bent in such a feminine fashion, up at her face her fingertips touching her shoulder, the other hand holding his thick cock in place while her mouth stretched over it. Thirty-five-year-old woman on her knees bent like that shouldn't look so good. He could take a picture of this right now and sell it, his wife looked so sexy. Her skin smooth and soft, her breasts hanging forward and swinging gently, she looked like she was Tyler's age. She didn't look like a woman you would think was Pete's wife.

"Hey man, maybe I sounded like a dick down there, I didn't mean to...I appreciate you trying to get me that job. Thanks."

Pete looked up to see Tyler watching him, addressing him. He was on his knees, back slightly arched, his palms on the backs of his thighs, while Jess' blonde head bobbed between his legs. Pete didn't know what all the fat talk was about, bent like he was you could see his abs.

Pete nodded, watched Tyler's expression change as Jess did something new down there, pleasuring him. Tyler's eyes closed for a moment, and he gasped quietly. Pete said, "Okay."

His eyes were open again, he put his hand on Pete's narrow shoulder and squeezed him, said, "I hope you understand though." There was a loud suction noise from Jess as she sucked air in around the sides of his glans.

Pete nodded. He looked down and saw that Jess had him pretty deep in her small mouth and she'd clenched his hanging balls in her little hand.

Tyler let his shoulder go, put both his hands on the sides of Jess's head, cradled her. She looked up at him, and his thumbs brushed her hair back over her brow. He said, "You're so beautiful." It made Pete feel a little uncomfortable him saying it like that, Jess looking up at him and his wide cock stuffed in her mouth, but he didn't look away. His heart felt suddenly sluggish.

Tyler held her head in place and gently ran the big head of his cock in and out of her mouth and Jess' lips complied, opening and narrowing, coming to a pout on the tip of him, spreading wide around it when he plunged it back in.

"Ah, fuck, Jess, your little mouth is like velvet," he said. "I can't wait another minute," he said, and he let her go, pulled his cock out and it fell between his legs. "You gotta give me that pussy."

"Okay," she beamed and she bounced herself up higher on the bed, didn't take her eyes off him. She sat back in the middle of the bed, her knees up, her legs apart, and her hand was over her sex, her fingers working through herself.

Tyler crawled up her body on all fours, pushed her back laying flat, kissing her mouth. Pete moved up higher with them, sat and watched them; if he reached out he could touch them. Sitting this close he could even feel the heat coming off their bodies. Tyler kissed his wife, she sucked on his lips, his tongue, her head back, her eyes closed. Tyler kissed her neck, and Pete watched her hand come up around his big wide back and scratch his skin lightly. He had her moaning.

Jess' hand came over to Pete, seemed to be reaching to him, and he took her hand in his own and held it. She squeezed him, shook him off, then searched between his legs. He moved his hips, put his penis where she could grab it and she did. As soon as her hand wrapped around his little thing, he surged precum, and Jess worked it around, stroked him, three fingers and her thumb slipping over his sensitive penis.

Tyler raised up, looking down over Jess, looking almost mean in this light. His cock wasn't entirely hard, just fat and swollen and it swung between his legs past the middle of his thighs.

"I like him sometimes when he's kind of soft. He doesn't hurt as much," Jess said. She had caught him looking, knew what he was thinking. She was looking up at Pete, her eyes glistened wetly, looked down then at her hand on his cock, and he felt self-conscious again.

Tyler was on his knees, his legs spread wide so he was lined up with Jess's sex. Jess's pretty legs were draped over his thighs, and she'd put her eyes back on Tyler, anticipating his penetration. Her chest heaved.

Tyler held his cock, squeezed it hard so the end filled up with blood. He slipped it along Jess' pink folds, up and down, making her smile, then pull her lips into her mouth. He pushed and Pete could see that big thing buckle,

fold up a little bit. He squeezed it harder, tried again. A full day of drinking and over-indulgence had taken its toll on him. But just when Pete thought there was a chance that his rock-hard pecker might get pulled into the game, Tyler breached her, pushed himself inside Jess, made her gasp. Her hand tightened on Pete's cock as she was slowly filled with Tyler.

"Oh, yes, Tyler," she sighed.

He watched them fuck for a while. Every once so often his wife's had would remember to stroke him. When she'd asked him to take his shirt off then his pants he'd had visions of Tyler in one end Pete in the other, or oh, God, Tyler in her front and Petey sliding himself in her backside. He had been overwhelmed by the prospect, aroused but frightened, now it would seem his worry was unnecessary.

He turned from their vigorous, passionate activity, looked to the chair from which he watched the last time—the first time Tyler had come inside Jess without a condom on. He watched from there with a whiskey, sitting in the dark corner. Tonight he was closer. He was included. But was it better? He was somehow active yet absent.

He could see how Jess's inclusion came about through some sort of feelings of guilt. That was a bad sign. Her including him in some way was very scary and he would feel much safer sitting in that chair watching it happen like it was on a screen in front of him.

Jess had drawn her knees up, opened her sex wide for Tyler, and her little feet were bouncing with Tyler's thrusts. The room had become warm, damp. Pete put his hand on her knee, rubbed his thumb over her kneecap, felt her smooth shave, her soft skin. He could feel a creak under there, with each thrust her calf would bob and her little knee would flex. That was her bad knee. The one that had ended her dancing. The one that had been operated on twice and had her in and out of the hospital and rehab when she was eighteen and nineteen. He wondered what she was like back then. What would it have been like to know her? A young off-the-charts gorgeous, tight little blonde eighteen-year-old Jess. It made him smile. He hoped she had the best time, hoped it was wonderful.

Jess was eye-fucking Tyler. It was intense. She was staring into him, her face a desperate sort of snarl, urging him to fuck her harder, urging him to get deeper. Her free hand scratched at his chest, and she was grunting horrible phrases. They were somewhat unintelligible, but they sounded vulgar, a lot of, *come ons*, she might even have said, *fuck that pussy*.

Whatever she was saying she had Tyler's full attention, he was staring back into her and their contact like that made Pete uneasy. He wanted her to close her eyes. He could see that Tyler's lazy hard-on had come alive, woken by the activity, aroused by his wife's tight slippery insides, and it was hard. He could tell. Angry red again, gleaming, thick with a slight upward curve.

Jess let out a yelp, caught herself, then a loud moan—then she bit her lip to stop it, keep it in. Her face contorted, a frown, her eyebrows troubled as she tried to restrain emotions that didn't want to be held back, that wanted to yell out to the room, let everyone know what a great night they were having. Even through her clamped lips, she was making groans and cries in her throat. A pain and pleasure sound, someone getting something they knew was bad for them but right in the moment it was just so, so damn good.

Tyler whispered, "Cover your mouth, Jess, I know how you like to sing when I fuck you, you'll wake those boys—that's a song they've never heard before, they've never heard their mommy make noises like I make come out of you."

"My dad's...just downstairs," she said, not like a concerned mom, but like a naughty high-schooler worried her parents were going to hear her.

Tyler fucked her faster, deeper.

"Has your dad ever heard you like that, some...high school boyfriend make you crazy in your bedroom, ah, fuck you so good you cried out his name over and over?"

She shook her head no, gasped, she said, "They were just...little boys." She bit her lip, looking up at him through her eyelashes.

"Who's fucked you better?" he said and he let himself plunge very deep.

Her head went back and her mouth opened in a gasp. Her hands clasped her breasts and she squeezed her nipples. "Ah, you're the best, Tyler."

"Who has the best cock?"

Her eyes were clenched shut, but she laughed, "Oh, my God, you do."

"Tell me you love my cock."

"You know I do, baby."

"Tell me."

"Ah fuck, I love your cock. I love it, I love it," she was laughing now.

He fucked her harder, getting himself closer, his face turned mean, he snarled, "Your little pussy was made for this cock."

She squeaked, "This little pussy needs your cock."

“Oh, Jess, you’re so bad, baby,” Pete whispered to her. He was stroking himself, let his arm touch the warm skin of her side and it put a shot through him like electricity.

Jess hissed, “Stroke your little cock, Petey”

“I am.”

“Stroke that peanut while I get fucked by a real man.”

She was hitting all of Pete’s high notes, she had his head swimming. “Oh, fuck, Jess, you animal.” He stroked himself faster.

“Petey, Petey?”

“Yes, baby?”

Tyler was pumping into her like a piston, a steady mechanical pounding, she was bouncing under his power, her breasts swinging and slapping. Her eyes were closed, she gasped, “Put your hand on my tummy.”

He let his cock go, eager to feel his wife’s smooth beautiful belly. He lay his flat palm on her tight stomach and she put her hand over the back of his, she pushed him lower.

“Can you feel his big cock moving inside me?”

He could. He could feel a big knot pulsing under her surface, in and out, in and out, Tyler’s swollen tip running under his palm, driving Pete’s wife out of her mind. “I do, Jess, I feel it.”

“Fuck, you two are gonna make me explode,” Tyler laughed.

“You want to feel him cum inside me, Petey?”

“Yeah, Jess.”

“What if he put a little baby in there Petey. Wouldn’t it be fun if I was pregnant again? I like having babies.”

“Oh, Jess, oh...”

Tyler was growling with each thrust.

“Don’t you want to watch my belly get bigger?”

“Oh, Jess,” he could feel his eyes swell, sting. “Jess, kiss me,” he said and he forced her face to his, clenching her warm cheeks with his hand. She closed her eyes and he put his lips over hers, bit at them. She kissed back absently but her mouth just wanted to hang open as Tyler fucked her, made her feel so good, so he sucked on her tongue. His hand travelled down her neck and he felt her breasts bounce with Tyler’s thrusting. He held her left breast, gripped it and put his face in the hollow of her neck and clenched his eyes shut. She was everything to him and he would die without her, but he

was no fucking good for her. “Oh, Jess, I love you so much,” he whispered, and he felt a tear squeezed out of his eyelid roll into his sideburn.

“Oh, ow, oh, God, Petey, his big cock feels so good,” she cried into his ear.

The headboard started to bang against the wall, and Pete had to leave her, sit himself up. He wiped his eyes dry, took a pillow and he shoved it between the headboard and the wall. He watched his wife’s face while Tyler fucked her. She whipped left and right, her eyes closed, her mouth open, moving like she wanted to say something but she was just panting. She was sweaty and shiny and her light hair clung to her cheeks.

He couldn’t imagine anything more beautiful in his life than his Jess. How she was now. Happy, joyful, being pushed through an intense ecstatic ordeal that had her heart pounding, her sex throbbing, saying the craziest dirtiest things. This was how he’d pictured it. This was what he wanted for her; he wanted her to be given this fantastic gift. He couldn’t do this. He could do a lot of things, he could make her come, but not like she was about to.

He watched it build in her, watched her chest heave, glisten with her excitement and effort, watched her mouth form sounds that eventually turned into a mantra, slowly coming into focus as, *I’m coming, I’m coming*. Her grip on her own breasts tightened and he thought she had to be hurting herself, squeezing so tight her hard brown nipples looked like they were popping out from between her fingers. He knelt over her and he rubbed her belly for her and it made her open mouth smile, bared her perfect white teeth to him. Seeing that happy face made his heart leap. He wanted to kiss her again but he didn’t want to get in the way of what looked like it was going to be a fantastic orgasm. He didn’t say a thing just watched and waited and rubbed, felt her wonderful body get rocked by each deep hard thrust of her big dick boyfriend. Then as he saw her happy head start to nod affirmatively, letting her two men know it was going to happen, he held his hand steady, curious to see if he could feel Tyler come inside her; didn’t think he would. Jess came first and she cried out high and sharp, her hands shot up and she clamped them over her mouth. It made him laugh the way her eyes went wide, then they clamped tight and he could hear her hissing behind her hands. She rocked and rocked, a vein stood out on her forehead, he watched it in her blonde wispy hairline, saw it disappear in that beautiful head of hair that was the same colour as his baby boys’. It sounded like she

was crying, high pitch sobs buried in her own clamped hands; sweat ran off her face and he saw it pool in her slender clavicle.

“You’re so fucking amazing, Jess,” he whispered.

The orgasm made her face tingle, her gums above her front teeth and the roof of her mouth ached and she pressed her tongue against them.

“Oh, shee-ee” she hissed and she cramped right up, a spear running a sharp pain through her middle. “Oh-oh-god...” she croaked, her face tightened painfully.

Then she cried out, arched her back to relieve the tightness, her arms went out to Tyler, her hands clawing at him, showing him she wanted him on top of her. He collapsed on her, warm and sweaty, his weight felt wonderful. Her arms clutched him, her fingernails scratched at his hard ridged back. She hissed in his ear, “Fuck me harder,” and when he did, she hissed, “Harder, Tyler, harder.” His cock felt enormous inside her, stretching out her tight insides, so wet and slippery, somehow sliding through her with ease, he wasn’t hurting her even though she knew that he’d got himself hard as bone. He was going to come.

She said, “Come inside me.”

He said, “Are you sure?”

She said, “Give me that come, I love your come,” and she scratched at the back of his head and pulled at his hair.

He held himself up over her, and he pounded her desperately, he wanted to get that release now too, jealous of her orgasm, and he *wanted* to come inside her. She could see it in his clenched face, could see the passion, the tremble in his tightened brow. Sweat dripped from him and she felt the warm drops on her skin, melting into her own slick heat. “Fucking give it to me,” she whispered.

She watched his face but he wouldn’t open his eyes. Her hands went down the small of his back and her fingers dug into that hot round rump of his, felt those muscles flex and release as he worked to fill her up with that hot sweet seed he had in those big balls.

“Come on, Tyler,” she said, “come for—” but it was her that came, it was like a rumble in her tummy and she yelled out a loud *Oh*, and her hand

clamped over her mouth again. She was still coming, her head thrown back and eyes clamped shut when Tyler roared out into the headboard and she felt him splash her insides with that thick wet heat of his. “Oh, yes,” she cried, and she humped him back, helped him coat all her insides with his nectar. She was crying out, *Oh, oh oh*, over and over as his deep thrusts slowed, when Pete’s hand covered her mouth and she realized she had lost control.

Tyler groaned, rolled off her and fell on his back next to her, he was panting and gasping, his breaths heaving, he was laughing. “Oh, shit Jess,” he said.

She covered her face in both her hands, felt how they could just slide over her wet skin. Pete was kissing at her neck, and she opened her arms for him, tilted her head and let him. He climbed over her and she thought he was going to try and make love to her. She put her hands on his shoulders, ready to say dirty things to him, let him get himself off inside her. He kissed down her chest, sucked on her nipples. She thought of the horrible things she could say, got herself aroused thinking about being nasty to him. Her breaths didn’t slow, her heart was still pounding and feeling her weak husband’s desperate kissing, his need to be validated sexually being transmitted through his trembling hands—it had her right on the edge again, she felt a tremor through her hips, an orgasm just waiting to be coaxed from her, she just needed the right touch. She said, “Petey, I don’t think I’ll feel your little thing, sweetie. He just pulled out baby, he—”

His kisses went down her hot belly and her eyes bulged. She said, “Oh, no, no, no, Petey.” But he kept kissing. She urged him, “Petey, please don’t, please, honey, don’t.” She didn’t pull away. She could climb away from him, scoot up the bed but she didn’t. She wanted him to stop but instead her legs opened for him, her knees came up and she watched him kissing her lower and lower. “Oh, Pete, don’t, honey, don’t.” Tyler took her hand and she looked up to see him sitting next to her, still panting, looking at Pete between her legs. He looked serious, sad maybe, he whispered, “Just let him. Just let him if he wants.”

She moaned out a long low mournful *No*, her brow furrowed, and when Pete’s tongue slid between her aching folds she jumped, cried out, bit her lower lip. She couldn’t take her eyes off him. She saw his balding head twisting between her legs, and she brought her thighs together and held him softly while his mouth worked through her, his tongue licking her up and

down. “Oh, no, Petey,” she whispered, “Tyler came inside me, no, Petey,” but it didn’t stop him, and as Tyler squeezed her hand tightly and her weird husband did absolutely magical things to her in a spot where her lover just emptied himself she was lifted up to the ceiling on a gargantuan swell; an orgasm that washed through her streets and buildings like a tidal wave and she cried out her husband’s name, told him to please, please, stop.

BLACK FRIDAY

FRIDAY, NOVEMBER 25TH

They'd all had too much to drink last night. When Pete came awake his eyes opened, struggled to focus on the spackled mountain shapes of the stucco over the bed. He did not feel good.

He didn't even want to look over—didn't want to catch his wife's eyes this morning. What would she think?

Tyler, some time during the night, had gone to his own room. He was quite sure of it. He could picture Tyler slipping his legs into his jeans at the side of the bed. He was pretty sure that had happened.

He turned and looked. Tyler was gone, the bedroom door ajar. Jess lay next to him on her back. She was awake too, eyes open, looking up at the ceiling like he had been. He turned his head back, chewed the inside of his lip.

There were light quick footsteps in the hall. He looked down to the gap in the door and saw that Petey was there standing behind Andy who had decided it was okay to come in. There were rules about Mom and Dad in bed. Petey knew them; if the door was closed he was to let them sleep. Andy crept in while Pete watched him, happy but cautious. He wanted to climb into bed with them and now he'd found a loophole—the door *was* open.

Pete leaned off the side of the bed and grabbed his briefs; his T-shirt was out of reach.

"Hold on guys," he said, slipping his underwear on under the covers.

"I'm not wearing anything," Jess whispered up to the ceiling.

Pete got out of bed and grabbed his shirt, the boys crawled into his space, saying *Good Morning* to their mom. She was smiling, but obviously troubled. Her eyes were squinted, her brow furrowed.

Pete found her T-shirt on the floor and had to get to his knees to find her panties under the bed. He stuffed them under the blanket and felt her hand under there snatch them from him. She whispered, *Thanks*, but he was too embarrassed to look her in the eye.

“What’s the rules about bugging us in the morning, boys?” he said.

Jess slipped her panties on under the covers.

“The door was open, Dad.” Petey said earnestly.

“All right,” he said, “but your mommy’s pretty tired this morning. Why don’t we let her sleep?”

“It’s okay, boys,” Jess mumbled, slurring a bit, her face scrunched up painfully, “just turn around for a second so I can get a shirt on.”

Andy giggled and he and Petey sat on the bed, turned their backs to her.

Jess sat up and turned, her legs coming out, her feet touching the floor. She covered her breasts even though the boys weren’t looking, and she struggled with one hand to find the opening of her shirt. Pete helped her, took it and put it over her head. She slowly got her arms through the holes and Pete watched her bare breasts sway.

“Okay?” he said to her, not sure what he meant.

She looked up at him through her eyebrows, her eyelids fluttered uncontrollably. Her expression was hard to read. There was something deep there, something going on behind those hurting narrowed eyes but he’d never seen it before. They were in new territory here. She looked guilty, at least a little, which was good because maybe she realized that she bore some of the weight in this tragedy their marriage was becoming. Then she held her head in her hands, her blonde hair a messy tangle, she let her elbows touch her knees, sighed, said, “Terrible.” Wasn’t sure what she meant either.

Petey said, “Why were you naked?”

“Just so hot last night,” Pete said for her, and he watched her draw her legs back up, get herself under the covers. “Just lay with me, boys,” she whispered with her eyes closed, and she put her arm around Andy and pulled him down to lay with her. Petey climbed over her, she groaned, and he lay at her other side, his arm around her.

“I have to get in the shower,” Pete said to no one.

Andy said, “Will you make us Gill pancakes for breakfast?”

“What’s that?” Jess mumbled.

Petey said, “Dad’s favourite pancakes.”

Pete cleaned himself up, got dressed, and as he left the bedroom, heading to work on one of the busiest days of the year, he looked back at his family sleeping in bed. He closed the door behind him, saw Tyler’s door and thought about him slipping in behind him once Pete’s car was down the driveway. Tyler climbing into his bed with his wife and kids while he was away at work, lighting up Jess’s eyes. But that was crazy, right?

She was slipping through his fingers. He could feel it.

Pete was in the can. Sitting with his head in his hands in a stall at the Save-Mart, trying to get his shit together. Desperate to purge himself of some of the pain he felt. He shot up, turned and dropped to his knees. Got his head over the bowl, stuck his finger deep into his mouth, felt his index finger tickle his esophagus. That set it off, that clicked his gag reflex, he felt it all surge up and out and he gripped the edge of the toilet seat, clenched his eyes until they were tearing, and spewed his wife’s wonderful dinner into the blue water. He choked and coughed, splashing up turkey and potatoes and beer and commercial grade cherry-scented disinfectant. Something else in there as well.

Now *he* knew what Tyler tasted like too. It wasn’t orange rind or whatever she had said that day she sucked him in their bed. He didn’t know where she got that from. Salty was right. Good God, that thing of his had really left his little wife gaping. He didn’t want to think about that.

It wasn’t gay. It just wasn’t gay. It was about Jess. He would do anything for her. Anything to keep her.

Apparently his contribution, the greatest thing he could come up with, was to show her he loved her so much he would still go down on her even when she was left forced open, with her boyfriend’s warm semen leaking out of her. What a turn on. What a stud she must think he was. How fucking manly. Tyler didn’t stand a chance against Pete’s sexual prowess. *Fuck, he wanted to scream.*

“God, I’m such a stud,” he said into the bowl, hearing his own porcelain echo.

“What’s that, Chief?” Julio, standing on the other side of the stall door, making sure his boss was okay.

“Nothing,” he said, spat into the bowl.

He flushed, got himself stood up, straightened his clothes, took a deep breath and went back out to Julio. He’d come in here with his boss when Pete took a dizzy spell. It was twenty after ten right now and the place had gone its usual shade of Black Friday batshit brown. There was a lineup of a hundred people when he drove up this morning. There had been two fights broken up so far, he had a sales associate knocked down—she was all right—and four displays had been ruined. Stuff was flying off the shelves, the registers were lighting up, and that was what was important. Money, money, money, nobody get hurt (make it until 6 P.M.). Then breaking up an argument in Electronics, Pete took a weak spell, had to steady himself. Julio said he was white as a ghost. Helped him into the bathroom.

Pete splashed some cold water on his face.

Julio said, “Bad turkey?”

Pete said, “No...late night.” He saw his reflection. Hated seeing his own stupid puffy face in the ugly fluorescent light. What did he look like to his wife when he went down between her legs and she looked at the top of his bald head while he put his mouth over the spot where her boyfriend just came? Had her boyfriend’s seed in his mouth.

“I should get back out there, boss,” Julio said. His walkie-talkie squelched and he turned it down.

“I’m coming out, Julio. I’m fine.”

Julio watched him in the mirror. It felt like he could see right through him. Could see into Pete’s soul, see his shame and humiliation, see how worthless he was. Could he see the philosophical semen on his lips? See the depths he would drop to, so desperately low. See what kind of man Pete was.

Guy like Julio, what would he think? Husband letting another man fuck his wife, then go and eat her out afterwards. Macho guy like Julio. He’d hate Pete, he bet. Wouldn’t talk to him any more. Call him gay. Tell everyone, all of them laughing behind his back. Why did he do that last night? That was huge, humiliating. Absolutely tragic. How could Jess even look at him anymore?

Julio's walkie-talkie went off again, someone needed help. Another confrontation. Urgent.

Pete said, "Let's go."

Julio's face brightened—he loved this job—and he clapped Pete on the back. "That's the spirit, Chief."

Pete rolled his sleeves up as they stormed their way through the crowds, headed back to Electronics.

He could see the problem up ahead. A group of shoppers around two struggling figures. The shoppers were helping by yelling and filming the tussle on their iPhones.

There was a young mother there and she had her arm over a box, a thirty-five inch LCD TV on sale for \$79. Her toddler was crying. A heavy set guy had an arm over the other end. Guy had to be five-five, two-fifty. He had curly hair hanging out from under a baseball hat with flames on it, a checkered flag. His big jiggling arm had a handful of the poor woman's hair and she was screaming. But she wasn't letting go of the TV.

Pete got there a step ahead of Julio and he put his hand on the guy's shoulder. He was in the kind of mood right now where he was going to fucking take care of shit. He squeezed his shoulder, gently but firmly, and he turned him to break him away from the young mom, get his attention away before he hurt her, he said, "Excuse me, sir, we're—"

Last time he'd been in a fist fight was in 1991. After school, Grade seven, almost the end of the school year which was a relief because when he got knocked out his head hit the soft grass. Had it been a cold Calumet Bay winter he might have never woken up, banging his head off the ice, probably would have died in the hospital. His fight that sunny day let him know something: he would never get in another altercation in his life. Since then he'd always kept his mouth shut, stayed far from trouble.

He didn't see the punch coming, wouldn't have expected it because he wasn't doing anything to deserve it as far as he could tell.

He never really went out apparently, just dropped down to one knee, but he didn't remember anything between getting hit and Tamicka putting a bag of ice on his jaw in the infirmary. He said, *What happened*, and Julio said, *That lady hit you, Homes*. He said, *What lady?*

PART VIII

ADVENT

POWERPOINT

FRIDAY, DECEMBER 2ND

Pete's iPhone chimed at 4 A.M. His eyes hurt to open, the muscles in his temple fought with him, tried their best to force his eyes back closed but he knew he had to get up. No option here.

He sat up, everything in his body sluggish and heavy. He leaned to the side, headed for the edge of the bed and almost fell over. His head was swimming. Once his feet touched the carpet he knew he was going to make it. He stood up next to the bed, the window out to the backyard just in front of him. He looked out over the snow, his orange fencing doing its work, keeping his baby cedars safe from the coming onslaught. The windows in here could do with some taping, he could feel a bit of a draft coming in from the edges. He stretched and rubbed his neck, made his way for the door, grabbing his phone from the table. The hall was dead quiet and he closed the guest room door quietly behind him, just touching it to the jamb but not latching it. His bedroom door opened as he put his hand to it. Tyler coming out, his huge body filling up the frame.

He was shirtless and sweaty smelling, just wearing a pair of boxer shorts. He said, "Holy, fuck, dude, she was on fire tonight." Then before he brushed past Pete he flicked his hand to Pete's balls, faking him, not making contact, but making Pete jump, throw his hands out weakly to block him, a grunt squeezed from his chest. Tyler laughed and slapped him on the back, headed for the guest room. All Pete's belly muscles had contracted abruptly to pull his testicles up to safety and as he closed his bedroom door behind him they were aching now anyway, even though he hadn't even touched them.

Jess was laying in their bed and he watched her. He imagined she was naked under the covers, what he saw of her was bare. Her shoulder, her arm, the slender triangle of her shoulder blade. No shirt, no bra. She'd been laying nude with another man, probably in his big warm arms. That was what she wanted. She'd told him. Told him she fantasized about what it would be like to sleep with Tyler. After sex. To fall asleep alone with him, feel his body next to hers, feel those strong arms hold her and cradle her as she drifted off to sleep. Now she knew.

Somehow though the thought of his wife being *on fire* with this young guy got him aroused again. His cock wasn't getting tired of this game. His cock loved every minute. However, his heart was on a roller coaster and while it was screaming on the downhill, it started to panic during the next slow climb up—afraid, wrought with anxiety about how steep the next drop was going to be.

Now, his brain bounced around, wishy-washy. One minute rationalizing, getting data from his cock that liked the quarterly numbers, letting Jess get away with this; then telling Jess it was off, his heart having sent in a powerpoint saying there was no way they were going to survive the next big drop. So he was stuck in limbo. He wasn't in a place to make a decision. And as far as Jess was concerned Pete was enjoying the torment. He told her he was. He also told her to stop. But something about a muscular man ten years younger than you sliding his long thick cock in and out of you so well, making you come over and over—something about that made Jess only see the willful torment. The *Tyler is staying* side. Jess was only listening to the Pete that said to keep going. Oh, she heard the other Pete, but she chastised that one. Teased him with dirty words until she coaxed the other Pete out of his shell, the Pete she wanted to hear from. So as long as Jess enjoyed sex with Tyler he was pretty sure he was stuck like this. So now here he was at three in the morning swapping out beds with her lover so the boys wouldn't know. Some predicament.

She'd never mentioned his Thanksgiving Feast between her legs and he didn't want to bring it up. He hoped...there was a chance...that she had too much to drink and didn't remember it. But he was pretty sure she remembered and just didn't want to talk about it. Tyler would remember. And Tyler would remind her probably. He wondered if the two of them had talked about it behind his back. What would they have said? Did they make fun of him? It probably wasn't good that no one had mentioned it since.

He slipped in across from her, the bed still warm from Tyler. He watched her peaceful face nestled into her pillow. He wasn't sure she was sleeping, he said, "Did you like laying with him?"

She nodded for him, her gentle sweet mouth showing a slight sleepy smile.

"Well?"

"Well, what?"

"Tell me what it was like?"

"Sleeping with him?"

"Everything."

"Pete, it's three in the morning."

"We don't work tomorrow."

She snorted, smiled again, but didn't open her eyes.

"Did he put his arms around you?"

"Yeah."

"Did he spoon you?"

"Yeah. Come on, Pete."

"I want to know," he said and he put his palm on her warm cheek.

Her hand came to his wrist and held him. She said, "After we made love he...he put his arms around me and I pressed my back into his chest."

"Was he naked too?"

"Yeah."

"Come on, Jess."

She groaned, "Oh, Pete, I'm so tired."

He stroked her cheek with his thumb.

She said, "He was naked, we both were. His body was so warm. We made love and he really did make me come, like, four times. Then...I don't know...Pete, he put his arms around me, I could feel his hard body against my back. He's so big, he makes me feel so small and safe. It was so nice, Pete. It really was."

"Did he come inside you?"

"Mm. Yeah. Once."

"Is that a good idea? Should you still be doing that?"

She didn't answer. Just lay with her eyes closed his thumb stroking her soft cheek.

"Jess?"

"I don't know, Pete. Maybe not. We'll stop, okay?"

“No, I just mean, you’ve been doing that for a while now. It seems...”

“Yeah, I know. He only did once.”

“How many times did he come?”

“Jesus. Twice, Pete.”

“Okay.” He didn’t want to ask about the second time. Probably in her mouth, he figured, given the hostility.

He let his hand slide down her thin neck, over her shoulder and slip in under her arm. His heart thudded, waiting to be told to stop. Knew she didn’t want him like that right now, but he wouldn’t be able to sleep if he didn’t try.

His hand went over her breast and he cuddled her soft familiar flesh. “Jess, show me your eyes, please, baby.”

She groaned and frowned, kind of chuckled. Her eyelids fluttered, and slowly they struggled to open the slightest sliver, enough to light up a white spot in there from the moonlight coming in their bedroom window. She sighed.

“Take it out,” she said, closed her eyes back up.

He slid his pyjama pants down his thighs and then put his hand back on her pretty breast.

Her lazy hand fumbled around his belly, scratched his hip, then her fingers bumped his erection. He was so hard he ached.

She laughed.

“Are you laughing at my size.”

“No, how hard you are.”

She stroked him sleepily for a bit, then said, “Do it for me,” and her hand left him. He took over for her, stroking himself and watching her placid face, her bare shoulder. Her fingertips went over his tight scrotum.

“Your balls are so small compared to Tyler.”

“I know.”

“They don’t hang at all. I just want to put my arm down.”

“You like his balls better?”

“I like his balls better. I like his cock better. His body. Petey, I like everything about him better than you.”

“Oh, Jess.”

Her other hand came up to support her elbow while she tickled his balls. Her eyes were still closed.

“Petey? I’m going to marry Tyler and we’re going to move somewhere fun. Somewhere warm. We can start a Charter School. We could really do that. Maybe go to Mexico. Help underprivileged kids. We can live by the water, be in the sun. Get out of this snowy dump. I can see my new husband with his shirt off every day and then ride that perfect cock every night.”

“Ah, Jess...” He was so close.

“Petey, Petey?”

“Ah...yes?”

“Stop, baby, stop.”

“What—why?”

“Don’t come. I don’t want you to mess up my sheets. Can we finish this up in the morning?”

“Jess, seriously?”

“Yeah, put it away. I just want to sleep, okay? I’m exhausted”

“You promise?”

“Promise what?”

“We’ll finish in the morning.”

She giggled, whispered, “Maybe.”

“You’re torturing me.”

She smiled from her pillow, said, “You love it.”

PARADE

SUNDAY, DECEMBER 4TH

The Hudsonville Shriners were out in full force. Russ said to Jacob, “That means Santa must be close.” The kids went wide-eyed as the men passed with their red fez hats; older guys with white hair, suits and overcoats, handing out candy canes to all the kids standing along the edge of the main street watching the parade.

“Merry Christmas,” one of them boomed. Guy had to be six-foot-five and he knelt down like he was forty years younger. “Here you go, boys,” and he gave handfuls—guy had big hands—of candy canes to Andy, Petey, and Jacob, “and for you little lady,” he said, and on top of candy canes he gave Tammy a Hershey's Kiss from out of his shirt pocket.

“Thank you,” Tammy said and her tiny face beamed.

Patty and Pete, Russ and all their kids were on the snowy brick sidewalk on a sunny winter Sunday, watching the Hudsonville Santa Claus Parade. They had got a great spot right up at the edge of the street, but earlier he had Andy up on his shoulders walking around the shops with Russ while Patty poked around inside some of them, doing some pre-parade shopping. Now Pete's neck and shoulders were sore. Jaw too. Three weeks since that heavysset woman he thought was a guy hit him and sometimes his jaw would still ache and click.

It had got him two days off work and what seemed like some legitimate sympathy from Corporate. Store sold its ass off that day, total gangbusters. Plus Save-Mart had a sales associate go down hard, hospitalized in Omaha, and the lawyers had everyone in full sensitivity mode which was great because that had been just about the most horrible day he'd ever endured.

It was cold and crisp out, the snow on the street had been ploughed and the sidewalks too, but there was white in all the town's creases and somehow it made their little village seem quaint and homely. It put his heart in a good place. West Hudson GMC was going past now pulling a trailer behind a new Sierra. He waved with the kids to the people on its Nativity scene; pretty young woman holding the baby Jesus was the daughter-in-law of the owner Bobby West who played in the NHL for two years back in the eighties.

"Here he comes, guys," Pete said and he crouched down, excited to get their little boy viewpoint, though his days of such simple excitement were long gone.

Andy whispered, "Santa," and his eyes were peeled way back, mouth hanging open.

Then it was over in a minute. His boys fifth and seventh real live viewing of Santa. They were buzzing. They all waved as he passed, ten feet above them, his sleigh on a tall flatbed trailer pulled behind another West Hudson Sierra, this one a glossy Christmas red.

Even Petey said, "Whoa," as he passed, Pete frowning that Petey didn't seem to have any sign of suspicion over Santa's incredible logistics yet.

When it was done, Russ clapped his big leather mitts together, yelled, "Who wants hot chocolate?" There was resounding affirmation and Tammy got ahead of them, skipping. Patty walked behind Russ and she touched his elbow. She said, "You take them for a minute," and Russ looked to Pete and then nodded to his wife. Seemed like this was something they had previously discussed. Pete knew what it was going to be and his heart pounded and he could feel his pulse in his neck.

Patty said, "Come here, Petey," and she stepped up into the alcove of an old Victorian storefront. The windows were bare, the tenant giving it up before they could make it to Christmas. Pete glanced out and saw Russ leading the kids into a coffee shop.

"What's up?" he said positively, but he knew he was about to have a heart to heart. At least Patty looked pleasant. Sometimes his sister could get a little mean.

"Petey, we need to talk about this man that's living in your house."

"I know," he shrugged.

"What are we doing about this?"

"He still needs our help, Patty."

“No, he doesn’t,” she laughed. “He’s not even a nice guy. He doesn’t seem grateful for your help. He’s taking advantage of you.”

Pete said, “We like having him around.”

“No, you don’t. You can’t. Pete, don’t be so fucking blind. Can’t you see what a bad idea this is?”

“I know, but it’s okay.”

“It doesn’t look okay.”

“Patty it is. It’s complicated.”

His sister shook her head, said, “It’s complicated is the millennial version of saying, *I don’t know how to deal with something so I’m just going to leave it be*. It’s bullshit.”

“Patty, sometimes things really are complicated.”

Shaking her head at him again, she said, “And sometimes it’s bullshit.”

That was fair enough.

“Where is Jess today again?”

Pete said, “She’s doing our Christmas shopping, I told you.”

“Missing her boys watching the Santa Claus Parade?”

Pete looked down.

“Tyler with her? *Helping* her?” She said *helping* sarcastically, like it had air quotes around it.

“Yeah, I think he is.”

“Petey, my baby brother,” her wool mittens went up on to his shoulders.

“Petey, that’s a warning sign. I don’t want to say something to upset you but you need to wake up, honey. You need to get control.”

Pete adjusted his scarf, felt it scratching and itching out of the blue. “I know, but...”

“No *buts*, Petey.”

“It’s not...it’s not...everything is not entirely how you see it, Patty.”

“You have another man living in your house and he’s getting very comfortable. I don’t like the looks of it. What else is there to see? What am I missing, Petey?”

“I mean, I know what you’re saying...but there’s more to it...I see it differently, and I’m on the inside.”

“That’s right. I’m on the outside. I have the big picture, Petey. Trust me.”

Pete shuffled uncomfortably, rolled his head on his shoulders. “Patty—”

“Tell me why you can’t go right now, make him leave? What is it?”

Pete looked out at the street, traffic resuming, families still milling about but starting to disperse. "I don't know."

"Is it Jess? Is Jess the one that's stopping you?"

"No. Maybe. She's part of it...I don't know what to tell you. It's just not so straightforward."

Patty was unconvinced. As far as she could see nothing could be more straightforward ever. She couldn't comprehend what would stop her brother, what could allow for this to go on. She said, "Have you ever thought about the blonde that he got fired for messing around with?"

Pete stared at her, his head felt very heavy. "What do you mean?"

Patty shrugged her shoulders, her eyes looked sad and tired. He knew what she was saying and that she just didn't want to say it. It would be a horrible thing to say about the wife of someone you love.

He said, "You mean Jess?"

She said, "Well?"

Pete had gone over this so many times that he'd lost the conviction. He just shrugged his shoulders now too and said, "It wasn't Jess." He stared at her Santa Claus brooch pinned to her wool coat. Couldn't look her in the eye. He added, "She was with me that day, I saw her at the Save-Mart."

Patty watched a big family pass by, kids hopping and jumping instead of walking. She nodded. She believed him. She had to. But she wasn't convinced. Pete could tell she still believed Jess had been unfaithful to him.

Finally she said, "You know what, it's your life." Her hands went up and she closed her eyes. She was resigned. Like she just couldn't deal with this anymore and she was right about that—she was banging her head against the wall. If somebody wasn't going to listen you were just gonna knock yourself out and that's what she was doing because Pete didn't want to hear all the logic she had for him.

She turned to step down out of the alcove and stopped. She linked her arm through his, held him close to her. She looked at him, said, "I'm turning forty in a few months, Petey. I won't take any more shit in my life. I have no more tolerance for it. Your fucking wife better get that meathead out of your home or I'll come in there and do it for her. For you."

GOOD BOY

WEDNESDAY, DECEMBER 7TH

Andy had fallen asleep during 'Frosty the Snowman,' Pete's favourite Christmas show to watch with the boys. That was big in the Mapplethorpe household when he and Patty and Michael were little. They had a late dinner and it was pushing the boys bedtime but Pete put the DVD in anyway and he and Tyler and Jess and the boys had sat in the family room and watched it.

"You want me to put the boys to bed?" Tyler said to Jess, sitting next to him on the couch. The scene made his scalp tingle and he heard his sister's voice in his head repeating those things she said to him standing in that snowy shop doorway. Andy asleep on the couch, laying with his head on a pillow, Jess sitting next to him, and Petey sitting on the other side of Tyler, his eyes too heavy for him to focus. Jess was in her loose PJs, barefoot, her hair tied back and her glasses on. Comfortable. She looked *very* comfortable next to the guy who'd she'd struggled to prepare her looks for when he first moved in. Patty was right, wasn't she? In a way he knew all along, but it was like he was really seeing it for the first time.

"Yeah," Jess beamed, "Aw, would you?"

"Let's go guys," he said. Andy was asleep and Tyler picked him up like he was as light as a sandwich and he carried him upstairs, Petey stumbling along behind. Jess watched them go, she was smiling.

He didn't know what to do, didn't know what to say. Jess flipped through her phone. He didn't even feel like he was in the room, and for a moment he shook his head thought maybe he was dreaming or something.

He wasn't. This was real. He was witnessing what it was going to be like around here when he was gone.

"Jess?" he said.

"Yeah?"

He was happy just to hear her voice. Even if she didn't look up.

"Nothing."

She looked up. She said, "You okay?"

"Yeah, just feel a little funny."

He went and poured himself a Dewars and puttered around the kitchen. When he came back Tyler was sitting on the couch with his legs up, and Jess was sitting in the V between them, her back against his chest. Tyler had the remote and he was flicking through to find something to watch. Pete sat back down in his recliner.

"Should you be sitting like that?"

Jess said, "Come on, Pete, why not?"

Pete looked at her, shrugged, shook his head at her, like, *isn't it obvious?*

"Pete, all this worry about the boys; when have they ever come down here?"

"But they could."

"Just relax for once."

Tyler said, "Yeah, man, try and be cool."

They watched TV for an hour at Tyler's whim. Jess lay the whole time nestled in the crook of his legs, her eyes getting sleepy, her head resting on his big chest. It was almost 9 P.M. when Pete saw Jess' head go back and her mouth open. He thought it was a yawn and, when it went on too long, there was a scary split second where he thought it was a medical emergency.

That was stupid. They had a blanket over them and underneath that he could see Tyler's hand was moving between her legs. It was horrible and in the same instant that his eyes felt swollen and his sad breath caught in his chest he was also somehow sexually aroused.

He sat and watched them under the light of a floor lamp behind the couch casting a sixty-watt spotlight on their dirty action. Jess was letting him do it, letting him touch her between her legs, her eyes were closed and her head rocked slowly on his chest. She smiled, said, "I can feel you growing."

“Hey, okay. Guys?” Pete said. “Maybe you could go to a bedroom?”

Jess kept her eyes closed, said, “Pete wants us to go to bed, Tyler,” and she laughed.

“You know what I'm saying,” Pete said.

Jess sat forward and her hand stroked at Tyler's thighs. “If he wants us to...I could go for a real good one now. If you're up to it.” Her hand drifted up higher, right between his legs. “Wow, I think you are.”

Tyler told her to lay back against him, said, “Get back here.” His hand went between Jess's legs again and she gasped. The blanket was pulled back now and Pete watched Tyler's hand push down under the front of the waistband of her pyjama pants. “This dirty girl isn't wearing her panties.”

Pete realized Tyler was watching Pete, saying it to him.

“You get me so wet,” Jess said, “let's go upstairs.”

“Unh-unh,” Tyler said. His big hands went around her trim waist and he lifted her off him, pushed her forward and her arms went out to support herself. She was almost on all fours, one leg out, her bare foot on the carpet.

“Tyler,” she exclaimed with a big smile.

He grabbed her pyjamas and swiftly pulled them down over her rump, down to her bent knees, made the smooth flesh of her thighs jiggle.

“Tyler!” she cried out again, not moving away from him at all.

Then Tyler's tongue was in her backside, Pete could hear him breathing, hear his tongue working between her cheeks.

“Ah,” Jess blurted, laughing again. “Oh, wow.”

Pete watched her face, turned to the ceiling, her mouth hanging open. “Oh, Tyler...don't, I...haven't showered...since this morning.”

His face came up and he kissed her bare white cheeks. The left one, then the right one. “You are so fucking hot, I'd do this if we just walked across the desert.”

“Well, do it then,” she said over her shoulder and she crawled along the couch until she had her elbows on the other arm, wagged her backside slowly for him.

Her pyjama pants had come down her legs and bunched up around her ankles. Tyler grabbed them and pulled them right off, doing it roughly and making her squeal. He pulled her ankles then, laughing while she pretended to kick him, naked from the waist down.

“Don't act like you don't want it,” he said, on his knees over top of her, grabbing at her kicking ankles. Pete saw her stick her tongue out at him,

laying on her back in just a pyjama top, her head on the pillow.

"I *don't* want it," she said, play-acting, her voice breathless, helpless, "I'm just so powerless and you're just so strong." She put her hands up over her head on the arm of the couch, making coy playful faces at him. "You could do whatever you want and I couldn't stop you."

"I could, couldn't I?" Tyler said, narrowing his eyes and then biting his lower lip. "Let's see that tongue again."

Jess complied, closed her eyes and stuck her tongue out, the tip coming to a narrow shimmering point. Tyler walked on his knees higher up her body, and Jess's body shook with a little laugh, knowing what he was intending to do. Sure enough, he hiked the front of his sweatpants down, and pulled his cock out, large, half-engorged, swinging over her face.

"No peeking," he said, and she giggled.

He held his thing out until it was over her, said, "A little more," and her tongue flexed and squirmed, stuck out farther. He tapped her tongue with the tip of his penis and she laughed. Her tongue went back in her mouth.

"Let's see it again," he said, and she complied. Now her eyes were open. He rubbed the underside of his growing glans across her wet little pink tongue. "That feels nice," he said. Jess started to laugh, her lips pulled back and her tongue went away again.

"Hey, give me that tongue again."

She gathered herself, closed her eyes and she held her tongue out for him.

Pete looked down the dark hall to the foot of the stairs worried what someone might see if they came down here. "Okay, that's enough," he said. "You have to stop now."

Tyler kept his eyes on the head of his cock sliding over his wife's tongue. He said, "You going to make me?"

Pete stayed seated.

He slid his cock head across and over her tongue. "Do you want to watch me come in her mouth?"

Jess, laughed, said, "Don't make him watch that. Unless he wants to. Pete do you want to see him come in my mouth again?"

"I don't think so."

She looked over to him, turned her head up, Tyler's cock dragging across her cheek, she said, "You don't? Really?"

"No, I don't want to see that."

“What if I just come all over her face, all over her glasses, Pete?”

Jess frowned, looked up at him hovering over her, said, “Don’t do that.” Tyler laughed.

Pete stood up, his erection tenting out the front of his pants, quickly adjusted it, and made to leave. He would just go upstairs and leave them to it. Tyler snapped his fingers and pointed back at the recliner, said, *Sit*, like he was giving a command to a dog.

Jess looked up at him, said, “Sit, Pete, sit—”

So he did. He stopped and he backed into the recliner and sat back down.

“—Good boy.” Then she laughed. He saw she was being sweet, saw the sparkle in her eye and it made him smile.

Tyler held her face in his hand and peered down at her, smiling. “We’ll have to find something else for him to watch. Or maybe we can watch him. He always watches us.” He whispered into her ear but Pete could hear him, “Tell him to take his little dick out.”

Jess turned her head up to face Pete again, she said, “Take your little dick out, Pete.”

He knew he shouldn’t but he did. He did his zipper down and pulled his hard cock out the front of his briefs. Tyler raised his eyebrows, said, “Did you know your wife was such a bad girl?”

“No, I didn’t.”

“Come here, Jessy,” he said and he sat on the couch, pulled her along until she was sitting on his lap, her legs spread over his thighs, her sex bared for Pete to see. Tyler’s sweatpants were down a bit, his aroused cock sticking out on an angle touching his wife’s thigh. Jess was bare from the waist down just wearing a short-sleeved pyjama top. She lay her back against him. His hand slid around over her hip and between her thighs, her mouth opened when he found her hot folds. He whispered to Jess, then, she said, “Stroke it for us, Pete.”

“Look at that little thing,” Tyler said to her.

She was watching his penis in his hand as he stroked himself for them. He felt so vulnerable but suddenly strangely at ease. There was no denying what he had, there was no pre-tense, not that there ever had been, but somehow with her big dick boyfriend petting her wet girl parts, the two of them witnessing the size he had, he somehow felt—*okay*. Let them see it. This was it. She already knew it. She’d seen it many, many times before.

“Is this what he feels like?” Tyler asked her and he slid his index finger inside her a bit.

She liked it, she said, “Oh, mm, maybe a little bigger.”

“Like this?” he said, and he changed, now sliding his middle finger inside her.

“Mm, oh yeah, like that,” she said and she rocked her hips against his gentle thrusting, his finger easily moving in and out of her, making a light wet sound.

If she saw herself right now, if she could see her as Pete saw her, sitting doing this with this man—would she recognize herself? Would she see the Jess that she knew? Would she be horrified? Aroused? Or would she be stuck just as Pete was, somewhere in a dark, breath-stealing purgatory between; afraid for someone he loved but licentiously charged, desperate to see how bad she could be.

Tyler whispered in her ear over her shoulder, “You like it when he ate you out? After I came in you? Did you like that? Tell him you liked it.”

“I liked it, Petey.”

Pete said, “Did you really?”

“Ah...I don’t know.” Her eyes were closed behind her glasses, she was mostly thinking of her lover’s touch right now.

“Jess, was it okay?”

She nodded, bit her lower lip. She turned her head to Tyler, her arm came up and her hand caressed his cheek, she said, “I want that cock.”

“Where?” he said, before lightly kissing her lips.

“You know where.”

He flexed his hips, pulled his cock up with its own tendons; it lifted on its own up off her thigh, up until it rested in the crease of her hip. “Show me,” he said.

Her hand went down, played with him, stroked him, smoothing down his underside; the skin of her stomach bunched as she thrust her own hips up, raising her mound for him, then guiding him through her wet folds with her fingers. She gasped and smiled as he entered her. Her hips went down, relaxed and Tyler’s girth spread her sex wide.

“That’s it,” she said.

“You like that don’t you?”

“I do...ah...it’s so good.”

Jess' face was worth the dreadful price of admission. The upturned ecstatic face was off a religious painting. This was her epiphany and he was witnessing it. He wanted that face for her. Wanted her to feel so good that she lost control. He stroked himself, wanting her to open those big blues, lower them between his legs and see his arousal.

Tyler said, "Make him do something," nodding towards Pete with his wide chin.

"I don't know..."

"Go on."

"Like what?"

"Whatever. You know what he likes."

She thought a while, Pete thought she looked like she was trying to find a way out of asking him to do something. Like she thought it was juvenile.

"Kiss his balls, Petey." Tyler didn't tell her that. That was all Jess.

Tyler laughed. "You want him to kiss my balls?"

Then she giggled, "Yeah."

"You heard her, Pete, man."

"Kiss his balls, Petey."

"You want me to?"

"Come and give them your blessing."

He got off the recliner and moved to them. He hated every step, dreaded that he would consider this, that he was going to do it even though he shouldn't. He felt self-conscious, the two of them watching him, his pants down his thighs, his little hard-on sticking out of his pubic hair. He felt weak and silly and small. But he still got to his knees between their open thighs.

He smelled her. Smelled his wife. Her familiar end-of-day smell. Sex-in-bed-with-her-before-sleep smell. Not showered, not clean. But not dirty. Just her natural girl smell. It made his heart ache.

"Wait, Petey."

"Yes?"

"I can't see..." She was peering down between her legs at him. "Hold them out for me."

"I can't look," Tyler said.

Pete put his hand up reluctantly. He looked at where Tyler had entered her, her pink lips struggling around his girth, dark and engorged. He was sliding in and out of her almost imperceptibly with their tiniest movement.

He felt the heat from their connection. His fingers went under Tyler's warm scrotum and he lifted them up.

"First the left one, then the right one," Jess said.

His balls were heavy. And big. Felt so different than his own balls. He didn't want to do this. Hated it. But a tingle in his soul moved him, told him, *For Jess we will do anything*. He pulled them away from Tyler's body, far enough that she could see.

"Oh, no," Jess said, a quiet, crying gasp.

Pete looked over his shoulder.

There was a little figure standing in the hall, a shape in the shadows watching.

"Oh, Jesus Christ," Pete yelled and he fell back. He scrambled back on his heels, his chest heaving; he hid himself behind his recliner.

Jess clutched her heart and he watched her in horror. Was this killing her like it was killing him? What the fuck had they done?

Her head rolled back onto Tyler and he wanted to rush to her, hold her, but he couldn't bear for one of his boys to see them all like this.

"It's Sargent," she laughed, her chest shaking, her breasts jiggling under her light shirt.

Tyler laughed too, then said, "All right—enough with this sideshow." He held Jess to his hips, still inside her, turned and got to his knees. Jess was face down on the couch, her rump stuck up in the air, her boyfriend's cock buried in her. His hands went all over her back and he was pumping himself into her. It was so fast and smooth. He was so strong, she was like a toy to him.

She was moaning into the pillow.

Pete watched, still on the floor on his butt, his knees up, pants down. They'd just had that scare and yet here these two were, like selfish, irresponsible teenagers back at their play. Tyler pulled his T-shirt up over his head and threw it aside. Jess's head was buried in the pillow, her arms folded up under her, disappearing under a sexy tangle of her blonde hair. He watched her get fucked. Watched her thighs shake as she was pounded. Watched that thick thing sink in and out of her. Tyler's muscles bulged as he worked. His hands explored his wife. Squeezing and slapping. It went on a while before Pete saw that the curtains were open.

He said, "Hey, people can see in. The lights are on..."

Tyler growled, “Let them see. Let them see us, see what’s happening in this house. They’d root for you, wouldn’t they, Jess?”

“Ah, yes,” she squeaked.

“Want you to get what you’re getting right now.”

“Ah, they would...”

Pete got up and zipped his pants. He could see the street out there in the dark. Knew that anyone standing out in the dark would see very clearly Jess getting fucked from behind by some muscle bound stud under a bright floor lamp. He went to close them, stood by them. He was intensely aroused by the danger. A crazy, lascivious thrill. The enormous apocalyptic shame if Tonya Waterhouse and her mom pushed their pram past right now and saw this scene. It tightened his belly.

“Let them see the man of the house,” Tyler growled as Jess stifled a cry.

COUNTRY BARN

SATURDAY, DECEMBER 10TH

Tyler had the girls at the charity gift wrap table blushing. There were four of them volunteering their Saturday to wrap purchases made at the Hudson River Country Barn. Four pleasant women, two in their twenties and two in their forties, all of them rosy-cheeked and glassy-eyed, smiling ear-to-ear, trying to please this handsome, young dad.

Pete had come here, brought Tyler and the boys, so the men of the house would have a chance to get a gift for the most special lady in all their lives. He purposely avoided the Save-Mart. Jess deserved better. He'd said, *We have to go somewhere nice, doesn't Mom deserve something nice?*

So they were here in the expensive retail boutique inside this renovated old barn and its grounds, with its amber lighting, high ceilings, barn boards and dazzling, dramatic displays; Country decor, expensive clothes, a café, a jewellery store, and then farm supplies for some reason. Petey had bought his mom a picture frame made out of barn board and Andy picked a silver brooch in the shape of a dragonfly. Pete asked Tyler what he was going to get Jess and he said he already has her gift, but he didn't say what it was, standing there with his hands in his pockets. *Why didn't you stay at home then?*

Pete bought her a black wool scarf for Andy's dragonfly to pin on. He had a print made of Andy and Petey and Sargent for Petey's frame and he bought her a pair of very expensive flannel pyjamas in a lumberjack plaid, and some good lotions and soaps that came in a white wicker basket.

Now Pete was bringing some coffee and hot chocolate over to a table outside the café next to the charity wrap booth. He heard one of the older

women say, "Oh my, you two are so cute."

A younger one, sitting, wrapping, gushed, "Are these your boys?"

Tyler said, "Yeah, this is Petey, and this is Andy." He put a hand on each of their backs.

The boys said, *hi*, very shy and quiet, Petey turned back and looked at Pete, his brow creased with worry. Pete smiled and waved at him, showed him that he got his hot chocolate for him.

Tyler said, "Boys, tell these wonderful ladies how you would like your mom's presents wrapped." The boys just stared and Pete heard Tyler whisper, "What's your mom's favourite colour?"

Petey whispered, *Blue*.

"Well, tell 'em your mommy wants blue ribbons."

Pete Junior smiled and he told them his mom likes blue and Tyler laughed and pat him on the back. Then he came over to sit with Pete while the girls talked to Petey and Andy and wrapped their presents and made shy little girl faces over at Tyler.

"Couple of future ladies' men right there."

Pete nodded.

"You know I'm going to take her from you, don't you?"

Pete seized up. His breath caught in his chest. "What?"

Tyler sipped his coffee, leaned over, his eyes on the gift table, said, "I want her, and I'm going to take her from you."

"No, you're not."

"You don't see it coming?" He looked to Pete now, raised his eyebrows and smirked, then turned, called out, "How's it going boys?" And the girls answered, said they were doing great.

Tyler took another sip of his coffee, said, "I'm sleeping in the bedroom again tonight."

"That's three nights in a row." Pete's voice was a dry distant whisper.

"That's what she wants, dude."

Pete pushed his coffee away. He thought about his dumb Christmas gifts, how there was no gift he could get her to tell Jess how he feels for her. He wished he was worth something to her. He wished he could be more.

He whispered, "She doesn't love you. Not for real. It's just sex. She just...wants your body."

Tyler winked over at the wrapping table, said, "Well, we'll see, won't we?"

PROWESS

TUESDAY, DECEMBER 13TH

“**W**ait, that’s it, ah, that’s it,” Tyler said.

Jess was straddling Tyler, her fingers laced through his, bracing her while she squat over his hips. He was so hard and full, and she had control of it, sliding herself up and down, squeezing him and milking his girth with her little muscles.

“Ah, oh, you feel so good,” she sighed.

It was half an hour before she had to pick up Andy and she felt so fucking alive. She was naked except for her glasses and her black cable knit socks pulled up just below her knee. She felt young and she felt sexy and her lover made her feel so good.

She raised herself up so just his big glans was inside her and she rocked her hips let her tight canal swallow and lick at his sensitive end. She smiled when he gasped and closed his eyes. She felt it too. A high-pitch tickle up between her eyes, high in her brain’s atmosphere, made her lids flutter and her mouth hang open.

“Does that...feel good...baby?” she panted.

They’d stumbled in here naked, unplanned. One kiss in the hall and well, the next thing you knew his penis was in her mouth, then their clothes were off and they were coming in here, lips locked, Tyler walking backwards, her legs wrapped around his waist. He said, *Climb on me*, and he lay there, his erection wagging, and she did. He was a stable slab underneath her and she sunk his cock inside and worked him up and down until they were both sweating.

“Oh, yes,” Tyler nodded and his eyes clamped shut. She bounced and bounced, just stroking his tip. She liked doing the work. She liked doing the fucking. Tyler looked good on his back. She watched his sweaty muscles work under his skin, his dark tattoos dance as his arms flexed, she felt his sweat between her fingers, mingling with her own.

“You going to come for me, baby?” she said.

“Agh, ahh,” Tyler blurted and she felt him go rigid inside her. She’d got him so hard doing that she could feel even the flange of his cock head had gone hard.

“Oh, no, Tyler,” she said and she lifted herself off and his cock fell into her waiting hand. She stroked him, her little grip not quite enough to make it around his thick cock. She stroked him fast, just quick pumps up and down his end. He was wet and slippery from her insides and his own leaking. She was on her knees watching her own hand working it fast and light, twisting and squeezing. Her other hand clawed at his stomach. He grunted and buckled, his cock swelled under her fingers and he exploded all over his belly.

“That’s it, baby,” she said, stroking, running her thumb along the channel of his glans, watching his seed squirt from him. He emptied himself in ten pulses, roaring with each, splashing up onto his chest, across her arm, onto his belly and somehow even getting it on her thigh and a drop on her cheek.

“Oh, baby,” she laughed, holding him, squeezing him hard enough to bubble a bead from his hole.

“Oh, fuck, Jess,” he said.

She collapsed next to him on the bed, her head on his chest and shoulder, and his arm went around her.

“Oh, Jess,” he sighed again and it made her laugh. She held her hand out and watched his seed drip from her fingers onto his stomach.

Her arm crossed over him and hugged him tight and she grunted with the effort, kicking a leg back for an extra squeeze. “Mm, Tyler,” she exclaimed. Her mouth went over his nipple and she pulled it into her mouth.

His hand went down her hip and he said, “Want me to make you come?”

She raised her head up to him, smiled, said, “I’ve got to go pick up Andy.” Then, raised her eyebrow, said, “Did I really take it out of you?”

He nodded, and it gave her such a thrill to think she could have sated this beast; that she could have left him dumb like this with her sexual prowess. She wriggled her finger through his slippery stomach, said, "I better get in the shower then."

"Unh-unh," Tyler said. "I want you to go like this."

"Like this?" she said, smiling at him.

"Dirty. I want the Daycare to know what you've been up to. I want them to know who you belong to."

"Oh, do you?" she said.

"Pout your lips," he said, and she did, made like she was kissing.

He touched a drop of his semen on her cheek and he smoothed it across her lips until she laughed and it pulled her lips tight. "I can't, Tyler."

"You will. No panties, either. Leave them with me."

She climbed up his hard body until her face was over his and her hair fell around him. "Can I wash my hands?"

He shook his head.

"Fine," she said and she wiped her fingers off on his chest and across his shoulder and arm trying to find dry skin. "You're so dirty."

"You're so dirty."

She said, "We make a good couple don't we?"

"Too bad you're married."

That gave her a funny feeling she didn't like.

She pushed herself off him, she stood up and let him look at her at the side of the bed before she got dressed, turning, smiling and bending.

It felt dismissive. Like an excuse. A reason not to do something.

She put her skirt on, her shirt and her sweater, picked up her bra and dropped it next to him with a smile. Let him see she could up the dirty ante. Then she took her panties, a black pair of Fruit of the Looms, and she slid them under his cock and tied them in a knot around the middle of it. She put her hand on his chest and bent and kissed his lips.

She left to go pick up her son, didn't once let him see that she had been bothered by his comment. It was probably nothing anyway. Nothing to make a fuss over.

Driving her minivan through the wintry suburbs she felt a nameless dread. And the farther she got from Tyler the more it started to worry her.

HOLLOW

FRIDAY, DECEMBER 16TH

“So, Abby, Mike, we have good news and we have some not so good news,” Jess said. Kevin and his mom and dad sitting across from her in her classroom at the end of the day on the last day before Christmas break.

“Oh?” Mike said, and he looked over at his wife, both of them a little concerned.

“Good news is that Kevin has come so far in just the last month I feel really comfortable in saying he's got a great grasp on division. He's putting in all the work—we can't take all the credit, we have to tip our hats to him.”

“What hats?” Kevin whispered up to his dad, and Mike rested his hand on his knee.

Abby said, “What's the not-so-good news?” and Jess said, *Well, I'm gonna miss him over Christmas.*

“And that's it?” Abby said with a smile, “So there is no bad news?”

Jess laughed and said, “No, there is no bad news, I just wanted to go over his tests with you, let you know how far he's come. I sent the tests, put them in this folder for you, and I've given him a few more challenges that you can help him with over the next two weeks so that when we come back in January we'll be up and running. Sometimes a long break like Christmas can really slow down someone's progress.”

“He's been so great about it. Mike and I worked with him and he's been fantastic with maintaining a schedule. We just chip away at this in bits and pieces and I have to say we couldn't have done it...really, your help, with everything you've done for us...we can't take all the credit and all the

applause but we wouldn't even have this project he was so successful at without your guidance—without your attention to our son.”

Jess smiled, waved her off.

“Over the Christmas break we’re going to be going away to see my sister in Myrtle Beach, be nice to get away from the snow, but we will make sure that Kevin goes through all these worksheets,” she said tapping her son on the head with the manila folder that Jess had given her and then she said to her son, “The ball is in your court as they say.”

Jess said, “The ball—” and she stopped and then she nodded, “is in—” she had a brief unsettling image of Pete holding Tyler’s balls and preparing to kiss them. His thin lips pursed, pouted, ready to press against Tyler’s big testicles, make his loose scrotal skin bunch. Her heart raced.

“You okay?”

She nodded.

Mike said, “You don’t look okay—you sure?”

“Yeah,” she said, nodded again for them. It was an awful image. She was an awful person. She did that for Tyler. To impress him.

Over Abby’s shoulder Jess could see Sara in the small rectangular window of her classroom door, she looked anxious. She had been a bit funny this last week and Jess wondered if she had something going on. Something with her family. She knew that Sara's mom blamed her for Sara's divorce and she knew that Sara's dad didn't like the idea of his daughter raising up Bart all on her own and he thought that the kid needed a father figure. Sara didn't think so and was the kind to let him know. Sometimes it caused some strife, some upset, between them and she wondered if there had been another blow up.

It looked like she had something pretty heavy weighing on her and Jess wished she didn't have so much on her own plate—wished she could take some time right now and go sit with her and have a coffee and work this out. She didn't like to see her friend in distress but here it was the last day of school and they just never got the time to get together. Earlier today, Sara had said, *I need to talk to you before we go away on break, I might not see you and there’s something I need to talk about*. Judging by the way she was biting her thumb—her hand to her mouth, thumb between her teeth—Jess thought it was going to be big.

Kevin’s dad shook her hand and he said, “Really, I can't thank you enough, it's so great that we have somebody we can talk to like this,

somebody that really does care about our boy, believes in Kevin's success," his eyes seemed a little watery and that made her feel a bit upset as well but in the best way.

They stood up and she walked to the door and Abby stopped and said, "Oh, congratulations on your award. We were there that night. You looked fantastic up there and you deserve everything they give you, everything they say about you, because we can't stop talking about you to our friends."

Jess could feel her face flush and she lowered her eyes and said *Thank you*. She wanted to say, You know the thanks is in the success, and when somebody like Kevin does so well that's all she ever really wants from this job—but she was afraid of sounding hollow, so she just put her hand on Kevin's head and said, "Students like Kevin are the only thanks I need." It didn't make much sense, sounded just as hollow when she said it, but they all politely laughed and she opened the door for them, told them to have a good time at Myrtle Beach, said to Kevin, *I'll see you when you get back*, and she watched him walk down the hall with his parents.

She stepped out and looked up and down the hall but Sara wasn't there anymore. Whatever it was must've been so big that she had scared herself away.

MISSILE

SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 17TH

Jess and Pete got back from the Save-Mart Christmas party at 10 P.M. The kitchen was dark, even the dimmed lights were turned off.

The party had been pretty tame compared to last year but there were a few people at Save-Mart that weren't there anymore. It was still a great time and pretty lively. Julio brought a King's bread, a *Rosca de reyes* that his wife made. He made sure that Pete and Jess had some. It was a sweet bread full of candied fruit, pretty delicious with butter and coffee; Julio clapped her on the back when her piece had the baby Jesus figurine. He said she was blessed, Pete said, *I'm the one that's blessed*, and kissed her cheek. Julio told her it also meant she was on the hook to make *tamales* next Christmas. She'd laughed but later she put it into her calendar and she would do it.

Tyler's phone was face-up on the island next to a bottle of vodka and some cut up lemon. The screen lit up bright in the dark kitchen. Pete was standing in the hall, hands on his hips, bothered by something. She was bothered too. She picked up Tyler's phone and went to Pete.

He gestured down the hall with both hands, palms up, like he was unveiling the new model Nissan at a car show. His face was serious. "He's down in the basement," he said. *Oh boy, down with Pete's trains.*

The basement door was open, the lights on down there lighting up the open door in yellow and splashing a square on the wall across the hall. She could hear the trains.

Jess went down first, holding up the front of her cocktail dress and padding down the wooden steps in her bare feet. Pete was coming behind her. Tyler was there, sitting with his back to them, his elbows resting on the

trestle table Pete had built. He had his drink next to him, his head resting in his palms watching the trains pass along the tracks with their plastic electric sizzle.

Jess said, “Hey.”

“Hey,” he said, still watching the trains.

Jess said, “What’s your sister’s name again? Carla? With a C, right?”

“Yeah,” he nodded.

“She never spells it Kayla? With a K?”

Tyler knew what she meant and he turned, looked down to her hand, saw his phone in her tight grip. He calmly put his hand out for her to return his phone to him. She held on to it. She had seen the screen light up in the kitchen, saw a girl’s name and a snippet of conversation and it made her blood boil.

His hand was still out, expectant, and he said, “It’s not my sister.”

“No kidding it’s not your sister. I know it’s not your sister.”

“Give me my phone.”

“No.”

“You can’t get into it.”

“You don’t want to show me what’s on it?”

“Give me the fucking phone.”

It had started. She could feel herself in it. This was a fight. She hadn’t wanted one. Sure, she was mad about the text, but she felt she was being playful. Tyler wasn’t playing around at all. Her hand wouldn’t give up the phone.

“Tyler—”

“We’re not a couple you know.”

It was like he’d slapped her. She felt stunned. He was right but she didn’t see that she was unreasonable. He was talking to another woman. Of course she would be curious.

She looked to Pete and her heart sank. She’d looked to him for support here. Turned and saw his sad, hollow expression, standing there in the shadows at the bottom of the stairs with his hands in his suit pockets, his shirt unbuttoned and tie loosened. Her husband. The man who in her entire life, every day she’d known him had her back one-hundred-percent. He was empty. She was alone in this. He didn’t have her back. She felt tiny. A scared hundred-ten pound girl with no power. She’d felt so strong in the moment, like she was righteous and she was going to keep his phone or

something, get him to tell her his passcode so she could read his texts. She thought she could go toe-to-toe. Now under his humourless stare she knew she would do anything to make him smile right now and forget all this nonsense.

“Give me my phone,” he said firmly.

She did. Handed it over to him. She curled against him, rubbed up against him like a kitten. “How were the boys tonight?”

He ignored her, looked at his phone and then put it in his pocket. “You know I’m a free man, right? I can go anywhere I want, any time I want. I can walk out the door and get on with my life.”

She felt her lips tremble. She looked to Pete and felt like she could burst into tears. What he said hurt, but more she hated her husband seeing her being treated this way.

“I know,” she said, lowered her eyes from him.

“I can leave tomorrow. Leave you to your husband.”

“Don’t.”

He got off the stool, stepped back from her and she folded under his stare. He looked her up and down and she hated the feeling. Like she was being measured. Was she worth his time?

“Are you going to be a good girl from now on?”

She nodded for him. Felt her heart pounding. Like there was light at the end of the tunnel. Like he was offering her his hand again.

“Are you going to be good for your daddy?”

She nodded again. She would be good. She could feel her eyes get wet and she struggled to keep it all in. She didn’t want to cry right now; cry and turn him off with her dumb emotions.

“I like your dress,” he said, looking down at what she was wearing. Just a simple, clean black cocktail dress she’d bought in the mall. But she felt good in it.

“Take it off for me.”

She looked away. If her eyes met his right now she might break down. Her hands went up behind her and she clasped the pull between her fingers, held the fabric tight with one hand and slowly drew the zipper down. She pulled her arms out of the sleeves and let the tunic fall forward, revealing her bra. She felt like she should perform, like she should make this a show but her heart felt like it had stopped and she just was frightened, scared. Rejected. She pushed the dress down her hips and let it fall to the floor. She

stood in front of him now, her little feet pressed together, her toes clenched up on the concrete, she had one arm folded across her middle holding onto her other wrist. She still couldn't look up. She stood a long tortuous moment like that, but he didn't say anything. She chewed her lower lip, glanced up at him, still watching her. He didn't need to say anything.

Her hands went back again, unclasped her bra, and her breasts dropped. She shrugged out of the straps lightly, let it fall to the floor and she covered her breasts with her hands. Her nipples tightened. She chanced a look at Pete, standing there in his black suit looking like he was attending a funeral. Tyler was blank too. Watching her hands on her flesh, her chest rising and falling as she breathed. She let him see them. Her hands swept her belly, dipped into her panties and she pushed them down, bent a little until she could step out of them. Then up again quickly, worried what her breasts looked like when she was bent and they were hanging forward off her. She covered them up again.

His hand came up and brushed her arms away. Her nipples went to stone in his gaze. She was quivering. Her back trembled, her arms went to goose flesh. "What do you want?" she whispered.

"What would you do for me?"

"Anything."

The corner of his mouth pulled up to a mean smile. He said, "Take one of Pete's trains. We're going to have a little fun."

Pete watched his wife turn, her eyes were wild right now. But she was compliant. He watched her put a bare foot up on the stand he'd built so that Petey could watch the trains when he was littler, and now it was for Andy. She stepped up, completely naked, her hands supported herself on his *paper mache* landscape. The American Flyer was coming down the track. A slender bullet-nosed missile.

He didn't know where this was going. He supposed the worst. He couldn't let Jess do that. He wouldn't watch the mother of his children defile herself. What could he do? If she would do it, how would he stop them? Jess watched the train coming to her. She looked like she would cry.

Her pretty breasts swayed, she was trembling. As the train went under her she picked it off the track.

Tyler's hands went to her shoulders, and he touched her tenderly. He kissed the small of her back, just above her bare rump. Kissed his way up his wife's beautiful body.

"Stop, Jess," he whispered.

He turned her to him, she clutched the silver train between her breasts. Her face was like their little Petey's when he was about to bawl. "I'd never ask you to do that, baby, how could you think I'd mean that?"

His sweet Jess looked so lost, so mixed up. Like the face of someone on the news lost at sea just rescued by a search team, bright camera lights in their face. Tyler took the train from her gently and he put it down on the table behind her. He kissed her chest, her collar and he put his arms around her. Jess collapsed on him. She fell into him like a cord had been cut, her arms went around his neck, her eyes closed, her face sad.

"Kayla is from dotEd, the online teaching. You're my girl." He touched her cheek. "Look at me. I'd never hurt you, you know that?" She nodded for him, her eyes glistening, hanging on his every word.

"Jess, I love you."

Jess's mouth fell open. Her chest stuttered for a breath. Pete could literally see her head shaking. Her neck was stiff, clenched, the tendons stood out. Her eyes glistened wetly, tears pooled under them.

"I love you too," she struggled, her face trembled and screwed up. He put his arms around her and her arms went around him desperately, she clasped herself to him. He kissed her, her eyes closed and a tear streamed down her cheek. She hugged him tight, pressed her naked body against his, pressed it like she wanted to become one with him. She whispered into his ear and her little arms squeezed his huge neck as tight as she could.

He pulled himself back, said, "I'm going to make love to you tonight like we've never done it before."

He had Jess nodding again.

"I don't play with trains, girl."

Pete felt something press into his back and it startled him. It was the banister. He'd fallen against it. He struggled to get his hands out of his pockets but they wouldn't cooperate; they were heavy and wooden. His life was ending.

Tyler's hands roamed, stroked her skin gently, down her belly, her thighs, back up and across her belly again. She held him, her eyes closed, her sad face turning to something else; inspired.

"I want to kiss your whole body, like we did on our bed," she whispered.

"God, Jess, I can't wait."

She said, "I'm going to make love to you all night."

"I want you so bad, Jessy."

Tyler's hand touched her between her legs and her knees buckled. She gasped into Tyler's mouth. He bit her lips, and she bit him back. Pete's arm went around the banister, held it for dear life.

Tyler said, "Go on, get yourself up into that bed, baby girl."

She nodded, stepped down from the stand on to the concrete. She gathered her dress up, clenched it to herself and when she trotted past Pete on her toes she couldn't even look at him.

"Jess—"

But she was moving up the stairs and he watched her go. Watched that bare bottom that she used to wag only for him, those long legs that were his to caress, watched them get to the hall and disappear. When he turned back Tyler was in front of him. His hand was playing between his legs. He was hard, evident under his sweatpants.

"We don't need any cleanup tonight."

Pete had gone brittle, when he spoke his voice felt as weightless as crumbs. "Tyler, don't take her from me. I'll do whatever you want."

"She's been gone a long time, Pete."

"She's mine."

"Pete." Tyler put his hand on Pete's shoulder and he felt the weight of it push his feet into the floor. He stared into him. First time he'd felt afraid of Tyler. He felt a tremble in his belly, in his bowels. First time he'd felt that he could be mean or bent. And having him in his face in a tight space like that he thought how powerless he was. He always knew. It was scary. He was a powerful man. Not a kid really. Pete could call him a kid as much as he wanted if it made him feel better about his wife sleeping with him. But Tyler was a man. Solid. Heavy. His body took up physical space differently than Pete. They were like different things altogether. Pete knew, absolutely knew, that if Tyler wanted he could just hold Pete quietly, put an arm around his neck and squeeze him until he was dead. It was frightening. How

had he ever let this man touch his beautiful wife? This man had held her and fucked her and kissed her and done all sorts of terrible things he'd probably never even seen. He'd let this demon into his family.

PART IX

NEW YEAR

WHITE CHRISTMAS

SUNDAY, DECEMBER 25TH

Jess heard the stomping little boy feet outside the bedroom door and her heart fluttered in her chest. Her eyes shot open.

Christmas morning; little boys couldn't wait to see what Santa brought them. Her sudden immediate urge was to grab the blanket and throw it over Tyler sleeping next to her as naked as she was. And, simultaneously, in that same instant, she had a desire to be caught. A feeling like it would be better if the boys knew. It would take that dreadful task from her; if they burst in here and found them it would be terrible but at least she'd never have to build the nerve and sit them down, try and explain herself.

No need for worry; those little feet hammered down the steps and she could hear them cross the family room to the Christmas tree. She lay in bed and laughed. Her neck pounded from the adrenaline. Tyler stirred next to her. Her arms snaked around him, struggled to squeeze that big chest.

"Boys are up," she said. She pressed her bare skin against his back, caressed him with her naked body.

"Kay", he mumbled.

"We better get up." She looked at the clock. It wasn't even seven yet. Those boys.

Tyler sat up and stretched and she watched her hand rub his back, squeeze his muscles.

"What? ...Are you sleeping in?" he said to her, turning and catching her daydreaming.

"No, I'm up," she said and she sat up next to him.

Tyler got out of bed and crossed the room and she watched that big body work. "Nice butt," she said and he slapped it for her as he closed himself in the bathroom.

She got up and threw her pyjamas on and a robe, went out into the hall. She stopped in front of the guest room door, stared at it. She knocked gently but there was no answer. She knocked a little louder, still nothing. She quietly opened the door, peeked in. He wasn't there. The bed was empty and made.

She heard his voice quietly talking as she came down the stairs. He was in the family room with the boys, dressed and sitting on the couch. Pete was in the corner, teeth brushed, hair combed, shirt tucked in; their little boys were in their pyjamas and they each had a present torn open.

"You guys couldn't wait for me?" she said, smiling. Not really mad, the scene too heart-warming to feel anger.

Pete smiled, he said, "Just one present, Jess, I let them have one."

"Mm. I guess that's okay," she said. "What did Santa bring?" She sat on Pete's recliner.

"Look, Mom," Petey said and he held up a box. Build-Your-Own Creature.

"Santa got that for you? Wow," she said. Andy showed her his Lego Cargo Plane and she gave him the same mystified reaction; the wonders of Santa.

"Can I get you a cup of coffee?" Pete said to her.

"Yeah, that would be nice. Thanks, Pete."

Pete went into the kitchen and she grabbed Andy and hugged him to her. Petey was opening the box, pulling out the long legs and body parts. She watched him intently snap pieces together, slowly constructing what looked like a kind of scary mechanical spider. Then he called Andy to him and she watched her oldest boy show his little brother how it worked, even let him give it a try.

"Oh, wow, and it glows in the dark too," he said, reading the box while Andy made it march on the carpet. "We'll have to wait until night...Mom, can we stay up later tonight...just a little?"

She nodded. Pete brought her a coffee and she said thanks. He went back to the couch and sat down; she could feel him watching her.

Petey said, "Can I open another present?"

Pete looked to Jess and she took a deep breath.

Andy said, “Shouldn't we wait for Tyler?”

“Another gift?”

Jess sat with her back against the couch, Tyler was in his corner and the boys were playing with their toys on the living room floor. They had their torn wrapping paper bunched up in heaps around them, the crumpled paper making them look like giants playing in a colourful mountain range. Jess had opened her lumberjack plaid pyjamas and her lotions, she had opened up her picture frame and said how much she liked the picture of the boys with Sargent that Pete had printed, and she gushed over Andy's dragonfly brooch and how nice it looked on the scarf that he'd bought her.

Now she held a small box. Light blue with a thin, dark blue ribbon curled at the top and Pete was tense with anticipation. She opened it and he watched her delicate fingers pull the paper apart and she found a jewellery box.

“Oh, Pete,” she said as if she knew. She pulled the top up and he could see her eyes when she saw the heart-shaped pendant he bought her, studded with diamonds. “Oh Pete, you shouldn't have. That's too much.”

She looked for a moment like she didn't know what to do. She took the pendant out, the long gold chain hidden in the velvet fabric of the box unwinding behind it. She opened the gold clasp and Pete could see her hands were shaking. Her mouth was firm, her face tense. She still wasn't looking at him. She put her hands behind her neck, up under her silky hair and she locked the necklace in place and then her fingers ran on the gold chain and centred the heart on her collar. Tyler's big hand squeezed her shoulder and she looked up to him. Pete's heart sank. He didn't know what reaction he wanted—he didn't know what he wanted to see her do—he knew he touched her with his gift but he guessed that he hoped there would be fireworks. A spark, like she would jump on him, lock her lips on his and act like a woman who would never, ever leave him. She looked back to Pete and she said, “That must've cost so much. Are you sure?”

He nodded. He wanted to say, *Jess, I love you I would do anything for you*, but somehow with Tyler over her shoulder he lost his nerve. He put his

hand out and hoped she would take it. She did, and he pulled her gently towards her and she touched her forehead to his and he put his hand on her neck. She said, "Oh Pete, thank you." She kissed him on the cheek and she ran her warm hands along his neck and she said, *Thank you*, again.

"Now it's your turn," she said and he felt the door close in his heart—that moment that he'd anticipated was over; his gift to her was given, not forgotten, but now in the past.

He picked up the box that she had given him, wrapped in Christmas paper with cheerful cartoon Santa faces and a big white ribbon that went all the way around. There were scissors on the coffee table and he cut the ribbon, let it fall free, dug his fingers into the corners of the wrap and shredded it off.

He trembled when he saw it. It couldn't be. A 1980 Lionel Loco 726 Steamer. Had to be a Grade A, came with the box. Cowcatcher intact, pristine. The train he'd wanted and lost. Better. Perfect.

He choked. Sobbed. Caught himself. Didn't want to lose it all in front of anyone. His breaths came ragged as he struggled to contain himself.

Jess's arms went around him. They were sitting cross-legged, knee to knee, and she bent and put her arms around him, her palms circled his back. He cried softly into her shoulder.

"Oh, Jess. Jess."

"I got that a while ago, Petey, couldn't wait for you to open it."

He hugged his train to himself, squeezed it like he wanted to squeeze the woman he loved. Tears rolled down his cheeks, down his neck.

"There, there, baby," she whispered.

He sniffed loudly, "Yeah," he said, trying to compose himself. She let him go. He sat up. His hands went over the box, caressed it. He had to cover his face with his hands, he could feel everyone looking at him. The boys worried faces turned to their dad.

"It's okay, guys. Your mom just knows how to buy gifts is all." He cried into his palms.

Petey left his spider-creature and came to his dad, climbed on his back and he hugged him. Pete laughed, "Don't worry, kid, I'm happy. Your mom got me something special."

"I know dad, it's your train."

"You want to help me set it up?"

"Yeah."

“Come down with me after breakfast?”

“Yeah?”

“You’ll be the first to run it.”

“Okay, Dad!”

He rubbed Petey’s forearm, tapped him so very lightly, let him get back to his toys, could see his excitement, felt invigorated by it. His face scrunched up, he struggled not to break down again. He wiped his eyes.

“Did you guys do your gifts?” he said, looking up to Jess. She was watching him, Tyler was watching him too over her shoulder.

She said, “Yeah, we did our gifts already.”

He said, “What did you get for Tyler?”

She looked to Tyler, said, “Oh, I couldn't put it under the tree.” Tyler smiled.

Pete couldn't help making a face, pulling the corners of his lips up showing a little bit of disgust and a little bit of hurt.

Jess said, “Oh Pete, not like that—it's just something that doesn't go under a tree.”

“What is it?”

She didn't answer, she just shook her head and she looked away.

Pete said, *What did he get you?* and she laughed and said, *Now that really couldn't go under the tree*, and Tyler laughed too.

Pete didn't press it. He nodded, looked back down at his train.

After they opened their presents Pete and Tyler cleaned up the wrapping paper that covered every bit of the floor of the family room around the Christmas tree. They did it in silence; working together but not talking. The boys played with their toys while they watched TV. Jess made breakfast for them all. For an hour Pete didn't feel too miserable at all. Everyone was together, everyone seemed happy, it was Christmas, the house smelled like bacon, coffee, and maple syrup. Jess danced around the kitchen in her robe with her diamond necklace and he watched her. She was happy. As happy as him. Even though there was an enormous intangible threat of destruction hanging over them ready to smash them to smithereens

if the cable snapped, for a few hours that morning everything seemed quite warm and fine.

After breakfast when Pete was doing the dishes Jess told him she didn't want to go to Patty's this afternoon.

"What? Why?"

"I just feel funny is all."

"Jess, we have to. She's expecting us."

"Go without me. Take the boys."

"Jess, *she'll go crazy*. You're going to stay back here with Tyler?"

She shrugged and nodded.

"No way, Jess. Don't do that to me. Not on Christmas. Not now. It'll ruin everything. That's all she'll talk about."

"Pete, it just feels strange."

"Jess, it would be so much worse if you didn't go. So much worse. Please, Jess. The boys? What are they going to think?"

"Pete..."

"Please, Jess. Bring Tyler," he pleaded with her.

She was relinquishing. She was shrugging her shoulders now, but her head started to roll around on her neck, her eyes looking up at the ceiling.

He took her shoulders. "Please, Jess. Please."

"Fine," she said.

And after that hurdle was cleared he went upstairs to get ready to go to his sisters for Christmas dinner and some of the pain that had seized his heart had loosened its hold. Tyler stopped him in the hall. Coming out of the master bedroom while Pete went into the guest bath for his shower, Tyler stopped him with a big hand on his shoulder.

"Hey man, I know we didn't get each other gifts, but I have one for you."

"Oh yeah?" he said, dubious, sensing something.

"I'll give you one more week with your wife and your family. Okay? Seriously, man. Merry Christmas." Then he went downstairs and Pete went and sat on the edge of the tub and wanted to die.

Pete showed Petey how if you turned the dial on the control box you could adjust the speed. He had Petey on his lap, sitting on his stool in the basement, just the two of them. It was a fantastic Christmas moment. The greatest part of this whole Christmas break.

“I know, Dad, I’ve seen you do it. I know how.”

“Okay, Petey. Just let me show you any way. I like to.”

So he went on, showing him the old control box his own dad had used. It had a flat aluminum face, dials and switches like an old stereo from another time. It had metal sides that someone had thought would look better with a woodgrain embossed on them. Petey asked him what each switch did. He could tell his kid was humouring him because he already knew the answers. Maybe Petey needed this moment too. It had been a strange time for his family and as much as he and Jess did everything they could to protect the kids it had to be taking its toll on them. Petey more than Andy. But then Andy looked to Petey for so much guidance. Little Petey was a bit young to have so much burden. He kissed his back.

Who knew where his son was going to take this thing if he had the spirit? Probably have the whole thing wireless and auto-control. Stuff from the future Pete couldn’t even imagine.

“So, buddy, you think you got the hang of it?”

“I know I do, Dad,” he said, and Pete could hear the conviction in his voice. He peeked around at his little man, saw the intensity in his eyes as he worked the trains, tried fine tuning things in the switchyard. Still a kid, but an emerging independence. He was becoming a person. This would be his last Christmas where he believed in Santa. Next year he’d be part of the adult team, part of the shadowy conspiracy tricking baby Andy into believing it was all real. Petey was emerging into the world where you became aware that nothing was real.

“Dad?”

“Yeah, bud?”

“Why do you sleep in the other room?”

Pete had known this would happen. They were still careful about what they let the boys see. But one of the things that had fallen off was the 3 A.M. bedroom swap. It was a lot of trouble. Sleep-disruptive. You couldn’t do it every night. And Tyler was in there all the time now. The door was always locked.

The boys didn't burst in in the mornings, it wasn't like they did that and you had to preserve a family image. They didn't come in the bedroom if the door was closed so why did everybody have to wake up in the middle of the night and play a dirty game of musical beds? He should have fought for it to continue. Protect his kids a bit better. But he'd given up in a lot of ways. And somehow he agreed that he needed his sleep. Now it would seem that while Petey hadn't burst in on Mommy and Tyler sleeping in bed together, he might have seen old Pop coming out of the wrong bedroom.

"I...get a better sleep in there, Petey."

Petey's brow furrowed. It was an acceptable answer, it made sense. But right, where did Tyler sleep? "Are you going to...divorce?"

His little Boy Scout knife stuck in his heart. He ached for his baby boy. "No. No, Petey." He hugged him. "Are you worried about that?"

Petey nodded.

"Do you know someone whose parents divorced?"

He nodded again, turned to the trains still, but Pete could tell he wasn't watching them anymore. "Yeah, Noah. And like a few more people in my class too. Like Steve Caldwell, and—"

Shit. Everybody breaking up these days. "Not me and your mom, buddy. This is complicated. Complicated—but I love your mom to death. Does it bother you?"

"No. It's weird."

"Are you okay with Tyler being here?"

"Yeah."

"Do you like Tyler?"

"Yeah, I do. He's funny."

"Me and your mom will always love each other, kid. We'll always be in your life. Completely devoted to you, okay?"

"I know, Dad."

Pete Junior said, "I love a white Christmas."

"Me too," Andy agreed from the car seat next to him, turning to look at his big brother.

Jess looked back and smiled at them both, cleaned and combed, dressed in their best, sitting like good boys on the minivan benches. So grown up. They were pulling onto Patty and Russ's street, Pete driving, her boys behind her, the cargo full of presents for Tammy and Jacob, Patty and Russ. She could see the ribbons poking up above the boys' shoulders.

It had snowed for Christmas. And she had to agree with her little Petey, it *was* wonderful to have a white Christmas. The streets looked fresh and bright, their town was cheerful. The drive was a pleasant prelude before what could be a rocky afternoon.

As much as she would like it if Tyler had come, as Pete suggested, it would have been awkward with him there. He wasn't specifically invited but Patty knew he was still living with them. Surely Patty wouldn't think they'd come and just leave their friend at home. Never knew with Patty though. Better that he was at home. None of the gifts were from Tyler, Patty and Russ wouldn't have any for Tyler—what was he going to do when it was time for the gifts? Sit there empty-handed?

But she just couldn't leave him behind. Thank God he caught on and offered to stay. Just like with Patty you never knew with Tyler. It was that kind of thing he would demand to do just because he wanted to or someone had told him he couldn't. At least there would be peace today.

They pulled into the driveway and Jess's neck cramped. The beginnings of what could become a migraine crawling up her sore neck and across her scalp to stab her in the eyes. This was going to be hard enough without Tyler.

Pete took her hand and she squeezed it softly. "Thank you again, Jess. Means a lot." His face was earnest, sad, but content today. Troubled but peaceful. She felt for him.

"Sure, Pete." She gave him a pleasant face despite the stabbing pain. She gently squeezed his hand back.

"Merry Christmas," Patty said at the door. Pete kissed his sister then Russ was there taking up some of the presents from Jess's arms, getting her hands free for her.

"Thanks, Russ," she said, and Patty hugged her and kissed her cheek.

"So good to see you, Jess," she said. Quite fervently. "So good," she still held her arms. She wondered if Pete had been talking to her. What would he have said? She seemed surprised to see Jess there.

Russ got them into the kitchen, got them all a drink in their hand. Just a white wine for Jess, she'd be driving home. The boys went off with Pete to the Family Room, taking their presents in and putting them under the tree. They would have their dinner, then all sit around the tree before the children's bedtime and exchange their presents.

Patty had her in the kitchen helping. There was a lot of polite and pleasant talk about work, the kids, school, the holidays in general. New Years' plans came up and Jess worried they were getting into talk about the coming year and things Jess just didn't want to deal with right now. But she didn't. She was fun and light. Not really like the Patty she knew.

She was taking the gravy boat into the dining room when they were almost ready for dinner and she saw the table set. She put the boat down and looked over the table. Counted seats out of curiosity. Had Tyler been welcome?

"Counting place settings?"

Patty had caught her. Jess said, "What?"

Patty's face was serious. In an instant Jess knew the pleasantries had been feigned. Patty had been instructed to be on her best behaviour. But she'd been laying in wait; looking for Jess to cross a line and now she'd thought she'd caught her.

Patty put her casserole dish on the table, candied carrots and ginger, steaming hot. "Jess, can you come with me?"

"Sure," Jess said, feeling suddenly weak in the knees; her hamstrings started to quiver. She followed Patty through the kitchen and down the hall to the door that led to their two-car garage.

"I need your help in here."

"Okay, Patty."

When she was first dating Pete, and they were at a restaurant and she had first met Patty, a guy at the bar told someone a joke that apparently was about cancer—who tells someone a joke about cancer?—and she splashed her drink in the guy's face and Jess watched Pete's sister put a grown man in a headlock and walk him around the bar until someone had to pull her off of him. Quite frankly she had always been a little bit afraid of Patty. She was tall, almost as tall as Pete, she looked like she could handle herself, and everyone knew she had a bit of a temper.

Patty opened the door, held it for her, stared at the side of her head as she passed. She stepped down the stone step into the cold, dark garage.

Perfect place for an execution.

“Listen, Jess, I’m not going to make a scene today. It’s Christmas and my children are here. I don’t want trouble. I really don’t.”

“Patty, it’s not—”

“You have a grown man living in your home. He’s not some kid who needs your help. He hasn’t been in the third grade for twenty years, sunshine. If you can’t see what you’re doing you might need professional help.”

“What I’m doing?”

Patty said, “This has to stop. You have to get him out of your house. I can’t believe you would think you could bring him to *my* house. Who do you think you are—going to bring a man here on Christmas Day with my kids here?”

“Patty, he’s *our* friend—”

“No, he’s not. He’s not your friend. The whole thing is so fucking strange now and you’re too blind to realize it...you’re caught up in it, you can’t see it and you’re driving *me* fucking crazy. Do you know what you’re doing to my brother? Do you know what I would do to you if you hurt my brother? You *have* to get him the fuck out of your house.”

“Patty, I can’t do it. It’s not that simple.”

“It is that simple and if you don’t do it I’m going to come to your house and I’m gonna do it for you and you won’t like it. Do you understand? He has to go.”

“Patty, look at me—it’s not that simple. You’re seeing just the tip of the iceberg. You think you know everything that’s happened but you don’t. How do you think this is happening? Do you think that it’s just me?”

Patty stared at her. Her whole head was trembling, her jaw was clenched, her mouth firmly set. If Jess looked she knew she’d see her hands were clenched in fists. She was thinking. Jess waited. She waited for Patty’s eyes to suddenly roll back like a slot machine, spinning and spinning until two cherries popped up as her pupils, her mouth clicked open and quarters vomited all over Jess’s feet as she finally realized what was happening in her brother’s marriage.

Your brother is in on it. Your brother wants it in some weird way. Did you know your brother has a small dick? Did you know that your brother wanted his wife to fuck somebody with a big one? You don’t know what is going on in our bedroom. This was Pete’s idea, I would never have done

this—he wanted me to fuck that kid. Maybe not that one but someone, and now I’ve done it and I’ve gone and fallen in love with him and the idea that I would kick him out and not feel his big hands on me, his arms holding me while he makes love to me...I can't be without him, I can't have him out of my life.

Jess waited but it didn't happen. Patty didn't get it, because if she did she would've fallen to her knees, her heart broken for what had become of her little brother. Her poor Petey was such a good human but he was so broken, so hurt.

There was *something* in Patty's eyes that told her she understood that it wasn't all that it seemed. She acknowledged that. She wasn't happy. Her eyes still bore holes in Jess and as they walked back into the kitchen from the garage, ready to celebrate the holiday as a family, she still had a fear that Patty would grab her by her hair and throw her on the ground.

Pete knocked on the bedroom door. There wasn't an answer. He knocked again.

Tyler was downstairs, he could hear him talking on his phone in the family room. He checked the lock, it was open. He opened the door and stepped in, said, "Jess?"

She was in the bathroom, getting herself ready for bed. "Pete?"

"Sorry, Jess, I need the charger for my shaver, it's in my dresser drawer."

She poked her head out of the bathroom, her hair tied back in a ponytail, her lips showing toothpaste in the corner. "That's fine, Pete," she said. Upbeat. Like it was crazy that he'd be worried about coming into his own bedroom, but he just didn't know any more. Her pleasant tone did make his heart jump, that was for sure. Her happiness was directly tuned into his own. Suddenly, walking across the bedroom, he felt quite good.

"Yeah, I just need it for—"

"Uh-huh," she said, spit out in the sink. Ran the tap full blast and took a swallow right from the faucet.

He opened his dresser drawer, held his breath in a weird anticipation, but found everything the way he left it—then wondered, did he think Tyler

was going to take his stuff out and put his things in there? Like he'd open the drawer and it would be stuffed with football magazines and protein bars? He felt suddenly hopeful. He grabbed it, a zippered pouch with his charger and brushes and a cleaning kit, tapped it against his palm, liked the fat pleather feel of it, went to the edge of the bathroom door and watched Jess. She let him.

"Thanks again for going to Patty's with me, Jess. It meant a lot."

She smiled at him, rolled her eyes and took a deep breath, said, "You don't even know, Pete."

"I mean it, thanks. We're still a good team."

She nodded. Rolled her eyes again in a way that made Pete think maybe his sister might have said something that bothered her. He hoped not. Hoped she'd keep her nose out of it.

"And the train? I mean it. You're the greatest. Petey and I...we..."

He shook it off, she knew what he was going to say. He couldn't say it. He'd bust up for sure. "Just thanks."

She leaned her butt back on the edge of the counter, faced him, folded her arms across herself lightly, brushing her elbows with her fingertips. "I know," she said. Her smile meant everything to him.

"Okay," he said. *Now the bad news.* "You know...Petey asked me something today."

Her face went blank. "Oh?"

Pete worked his way around how to say this. He wanted to talk about it but he didn't want to know her opinion. Didn't want to hear something like, *Well, we're going to have to tell them we're separating.* He wasn't ready yet for that. He'd never ever be ready for that. For sure didn't want Christmas Day to forever be the anniversary of the night the love of his life left him.

"I think he's a little worried. He knows I sleep in the other room."

"He does?" she said, her face looking a little hurt and worried. "Poor guy," she said, casting down at the bathmat now.

Pete nodded, didn't know what else to say really. Secretly wanted her to snap out of this, come to her sweet senses and bring this family back to the way it was.

Nothing.

"Okay, I guess...I'm going to go to bed."

"Okay."

He turned and headed for the door, she stopped him. "Petey?"

“Yes, Jess?”

“My gift...for Tyler...”

“What is it?”

“In February...we’re going to go away together.”

The two of them together. Without him. Somewhere sunny. God. “Wow. Okay. Where?”

“Just to Florida. Five days. I’m only taking two days off on either end of a long weekend.”

“Uh-huh” he gasped, he felt for the edge of the bed behind him and sat on it.

“I just want to get away. I need to get away.”

He lowered his head, felt himself beginning to cry and he didn’t want her to see him. Came out of nowhere.

So they were going away together—with all the things they’d done, that was nothing. Still, she would be so far. She was being pulled away from him, their distance apart getting greater and greater until she would just be a speck on his horizon, him lost in a dark scary ocean the last thing he’d see is her, a tiny dot in the distance, before he was swallowed and consumed. “Sorry, Jess,” he said, pinched the bridge of his nose and a tear fell off him, landed on his khaki pants, turned a spot dark and slowly spread. “I’m sorry—”

She sat next to him, right next to him. He could feel her against his body. “It’s okay, Petey,” she whispered, he could hear a choking sadness in her voice too. Her hand rubbed circles on his back, soft and sweet and warm. His heart wanted to explode.

She wiped her own eyes. She sniffed.

“Will you tell me all about it. Everything you do?”

She quietly said, “I don’t know, Pete.”

“Please,” he said, and he turned, risked it all, and he put his arms around her. She let him. He kept his face turned from her, didn’t want to kiss her, didn’t want to push it, but he needed to hold her. Needed to feel her in his arms one more time in case he never got another.

“Okay, Petey,” she said, her hand sweeping the back of his arm.

He let her go, let her be, glad to have that moment. “Okay,” he said.

He sat with her, side by side, both of them looking across to the bathroom door. He wanted to stay as long as he could like that, feel her next

to him, both of them on their bed in their bedroom. She let it go too, stayed connected, and he hoped she felt something, felt a nostalgic pull like he did.

She stood up finally, her bad knee giving a quiet click.

“Hey Jess, what did Tyler get you?”

She turned, leaned on the door jamb, she smiled, she shook her head and turned up her nose. “You don’t want to know.”

“I do. Please, just tell me.”

She stood and watched him, exhaled slowly, dragging it out forever. “No, you don’t. Close your eyes.”

“Why?”

She walked to the night table and opened the drawer. “You sure?”

“Yes, Jess.”

She turned and dropped it in his lap. Heavy, big, rubber. It bounced on his thighs. A dildo.

“He bought you a dildo?” he said, feeling good that it was such a dumb, dirty gift. He picked it off his lap, held it by the balls. It didn’t look very well made.

He suddenly recognized it, he’d seen it plenty. “Wait, is this—”

“Yeah.”

It was a cast of his own cock. It made him sick to hold it in his hands, to know that Jess had held the real thing, now he knew what it felt like. Knew how impressive it must feel in his wife’s dainty grip. Shockingly different to his own. It instantly ruined his night.

“Here,” he said, handed it back to her.

“You asked.” She took it from him, put it in her lap and laid her hands over it.

“It’s dumb,” he said quietly.

Her hand unconsciously went to her necklace, touched his diamond heart on her collar. “Hey,” she said, “it’s not dumb. It was personal.”

“Whatever, Jess.”

“Pete, he doesn’t have a job right now. It was sweet the way he did it. I know it looks vulgar, I’m not stupid. But he was funny and he was cute...the way he gave it to me.”

“How was that?”

“Pete. It was between me and him.”

“Jess.”

“Pete, I can’t explain it to you. You won’t get it. It was personal.”

“Doesn’t have a job?”

She sighed. “He quit that job.”

“Quit it? Well, is he...how’s he going to help out around here?”

“He’s going to find something else. Something more permanent. Local.”

“Jess—how? As a teacher?” That would be impossible.

“We’re going to figure it out.”

“I don’t know why you think you can help him. Save him.”

“I’m not saving him. He doesn’t *need* saving.”

“He could have taken that job at Save-Mart.”

“Yeah.” She nodded. She put her hand over one of his, held the big rubber cock on her lap across her thighs with the other.

“What are we doing?”

She stared at him. Pursed her lips.

He said, “How can you love another man?”

She shrugged her shoulders. “Pete, I don’t want to talk about it.” She took her hand back, folded her arms up like she was cold, crossed a leg over the other.

“I know you don’t,” he said, looking down at the carpet. “You better get rid of that,” he pointed his chin to the dildo pinched in her lap.

She put it back in the drawer and closed it up.

“I mean really get rid of it. If the boys found that...”

She nodded, arms folded up again. She seemed farther away now.

“Jess, can we stop the humiliation?”

“You don’t want that anymore?”

He put his gaze down, thought about it. “I like it. But I don’t want it.”

“Okay. I can stop. I should stop. You okay?”

“You know he taunts me?”

“Tyler?”

“Yeah, he threatens me. Says he’s going to take you from me.”

“Oh, Petey,” she said, her face went sad, she bit a lip and put her arm around him again. “I’ll talk to him.”

“Oh, no, Jess. Don’t do that. Don’t.” He shook his head. “I’ll deal with it.”

“Are you sure?”

“Jess, do you love me?” He kept his face as rock-solid as he could.

She thought a moment, looked at him speculatively. “I do, Pete,” she said, looking into his eyes. “I love you very much.”

HICCUPS

SUNDAY, JANUARY 1ST

“**T**his is what it’s come to,” Pete said to the empty room. Standing in the master bedroom looking out the lone window onto the driveway, he’d come in here at, what, 2:30 A.M. now, to see if it was them coming home.

It was.

There they were, the two of them practically spilling out of the taxi onto the snowy drive. They were laughing. His heart sang to see her with that big drunken smile on her face but he was broken seeing her in the arms of that man. He looked good, dressed well in a charcoal overcoat and his hair combed up nicely on his well shaped head. Jess stumbled on the slippery walk in her high heels, her strong legs flexing under her wool car coat. They looked like an amazing fun couple. Someone you would want to get to know and then later get jealous of.

Tyler held her steady while she had her small clutch open, rooting for some cash. She gave him some bills, watched and waited for him while he went to the open passenger window of the cab and paid the driver.

She didn’t seem to even care who might see her with Tyler anymore.

The two of them had gone out together in the evening for dinner and to celebrate the New Year. Out to the Cantina on River Street in the city. Jess hadn’t invited him explicitly but Pete let them get ready, waited for an offer, an inquiry into what he might be doing tonight. Then it was obvious he was staying home with the kids. That was fine with him. If he said he was going to go with them it would have been accepted. Jess probably would have called the sitter and he could have tagged along. He just didn’t feel like he

wanted to spend the last night of the year ‘tagging’ along with his wife and her boyfriend. He let her have her night.

He and the boys had a great time and he kept the sadness at bay until they’d gone to bed. Then he hit the bottle for an hour and watched home movies.

He left the bedroom and went to stand in the hall, heard them come in the front door. He wanted to duck into his bedroom but he had a concern that they were going to be noisy, wake up the boys. He could hear them down there, already talking too loud, and he felt like shushing them. Then there was a thump, something fell, opened, and contents spilled across the linoleum. He pictured Jess on her knees and her purse scattered across the hallway. Now he wanted to stay in the hall to make sure she made it to bed without getting hurt.

Sargent was on them. Pete could hear his nails on the floor, an excited grumble coming from him. Whatever had happened it got her laughing. Laughing hard enough where he could tell she couldn’t breathe. Laughed herself until she was empty and then forgot how to inhale. It made him happy. Made a smile come across his own lips hearing her like that.

“Up we get,” Tyler grunted and he must have helped her up.

They came in to view now, Jess stumbling to the bottom of the staircase, Tyler doing all right behind her, hands out to catch her if she fell.

She looked up the stairs, seeing where she was going and caught Pete’s eyes. She smiled, said, Hey Pete, and then she shushed him even though he hadn’t said a thing. Pete moved to the top of the stairs to help her when she got there.

“Come on, Jess,” he whispered, “let’s get you to bed.”

“Yeah,” she gasped, and she worked her way up the stairs carefully in her high heels. He took her hand as she got to the landing, Tyler had his hands on her waist.

“Had a good time?” he said, stating the obvious.

“We went dancing,” she whispered to him, a hoarse whisper-yell.

“Okay, Jess,” he said. “You smell like whiskey.”

“And tequila,” Tyler joked behind her. It made Jess laugh out loud and then she covered her mouth with both hands.

“I got her, Pete,” Tyler said, guiding his wife past him, headed to the master bedroom.

“You okay, Jess?” Pete said as they passed.

She said, "Petey, Petey, come in here, come here. It's New Year's."

"It's late, Jess."

"No," she argued, "it's New Year's. I don't want to go to bed."

"She likes to party," Tyler said to Jess as he helped her to sit on the bed.

"I do," she said slyly.

Seeing her sit there, liquored up and happy, beaming really, all made-up for a night out, hair a mess from drinking and dancing; it all melted his heart. He was happy for her. Happy to see her so happy.

"You look happy, Jess."

"We had fun," she said. She hiccuped.

Her hands fumbled with the over-sized buttons on her coat and she took it off, pulled her arms out and let it fall back on the bed. The shoulders of her dress were covered in glitter and confetti.

"Look at you," Tyler laughed and he brushed her shoulders for her, brushed the glitter on to the bed.

"I *am* the party," Jess laughed.

"You are," Tyler agreed.

Pete backed towards the door, enjoyed the moment for her. Knew probably what would happen next and that she would enjoy that too.

"Petey, no, come and talk," she said and she patted the bed next to her. Pete looked to Tyler. He was taking his coat off. Pete could see lipstick marks all over his neck in his Jess's shade. Tyler turned away and hung his coat up in the closet, started unbuttoning his shirt.

Jess had just about the most fun in one night she could remember. They'd gone out to the restaurant for a late dinner, then there was dancing. They had a whisky tasting, more dancing, some tequila, then a lot more dancing. Everyone was in the best mood. Happy, happy faces all around. Not a care in the world. She danced for, like, maybe two hours. Then they did the countdown, confetti collapsed from the roof all over them, coming down so hard it pelted her like a sandstorm. They laughed and Tyler covered her, protected her. They kissed. Then more dancing, more drinking, but it was a little hazy. Flashes of the cab ride. In the hall. Sargent licking her face. Was she on the floor?

She was feeling better now. A little better at least. But poor little Pete looked so sad. She hiccuped.

“I’ve got the hiccups,” she said, turned her face up to him.

“You want a glass of water?”

She nodded.

Pete went to the bathroom, ran the faucet. She watched Tyler undress and she felt her face turn evil; a devilish, mischievous smile she couldn’t stop pulled the corners of her mouth up, she narrowed her eyes. He was pulling those muscular legs out of his pants and she liked what she saw. His big round rump in those tight white briefs, those muscles stretching out his T-shirt. The black dragons all down those shining muscular arms. *Turn around, Tyler.*

“Here you go,” Pete said.

“Thanks, Pete.” He put his hands up on either side of her head and put pressure over her ears. She drank while he held her. He clasped them tight, let her drink and tip it back until the glass was empty. She put her head down and he let her go.

“Better?” he asked her.

“Yeah,” she said.

Tyler sat next to her on the bed, his weight pushing the mattress down and her body came to rest against him. His arm came around her waist and she closed her eyes.

She hiccuped again, laughed.

Tyler laughed too and it felt good to shake up against his body. Then he was gone, bringing his knees up and crab-walking backwards up the bed.

“Here, Pete,” she said and she handed him back the empty glass.

“Do you want to try it again?”

Her eyes closed and she held up two index fingers for him, indicating him to wait. She didn’t hiccup. She said, “No, no. That one was just an anomaly.” She laughed as she hiccuped again. “Okay, try again.”

Pete went off to the bathroom and she felt her way around the bed, grabbing Tyler’s shin, then climbing up his body on all fours. All the lights were on in the room, bathing it all in bright, but she felt better with her eyes closed. She climbed up his thighs, felt how hard they were, gave his big sagging package a honk as she passed, got lower until her chest was against his stomach and then she slithered up him until she came to rest very nicely in the crook of his big arm.

“I had a wonderful time tonight,” she said.

“Me too.” He turned to her so they were face to face, laying on their sides. She opened her eyes a little and he kissed her softly.

He should leave them to it. Let them do their thing.

Something about the way Jess had called him in here, said she didn’t want to sleep, *it’s New Year’s, Pete*—had him oddly aroused. Not primed right up and horny but a vague sort of tension under his bowels, sizzling along his undercarriage and throbbing in his prostate. He stood and watched.

A heartbreaking scene for sure. His lovely wife laying in bed with another man. This woman who he had stood with on an altar—his family, her family watching—expressed his love for her and heard her love expressed, they were pronounced man and wife; everyone threw confetti that Spring day, walking out of the church and into the limo. Now she was kissing a handsome boy ten years younger than her, doing it in their bed. He was beautiful, muscular, looking very sexy in his tight T-shirt and briefs. Jess was rubbing herself on him, her pretty New Year’s dress hiked up her thighs as her legs rubbed him, going up and down his hard thighs. She would be wet under there. Those long dancer legs rubbing like that was a symptom of her arousal. He knew that, knew her for nine years now, knew when those legs started rubbing like a cricket that a quick swipe between them would show you her heat, her wet. Her arms were going over his muscles, her pretty hands squeezing and scratching. Their heads twisted on one another, her silky hair tangling up in one of his big hands. There it was: he was stiffening. Quickly and urgently, pushing out the front of his pyjamas.

Jess’s hand went down between Tyler’s legs and she gripped his big soft cotton bulge. He watched that a while, her small grip coddling that big thing, the white shape underneath changing, swelling, becoming misshapen. Then she slipped it under his waistband, pulled that big tool out, squeezed it and stroked it, the whole time she bit and sucked and pulled at his lips and he did it back.

Tyler's hand pulled at her zipper, tried to open the back of her black dress. He couldn't get it started. His other hand was trapped under him, maybe under her. Each pull on the zipper only pulled the far side of the fabric with it and it just wouldn't unclench. Pete put down the glass of water, got on the bed, walked on his knees and he held the fabric tight, pushed Tyler's hand away and undid his wife's zipper. Tyler slipped his hand underneath the fabric, felt her warm smooth back and it made Pete smile for some reason. He knew that feeling. Knew how she would feel under your fingers. Lucky guy.

Pete lay on the bed behind her and watched, put his head on the pillow, like he used to do when he slept in here, and he watched the two of them together. Tyler's hand pulled the strap of her dress off her shoulder and Jess's arm came up, her elbow struggled underneath it and Tyler pulled it away hard, Pete watched her tight skin creased by the fabric. Her elbow slipped out and now he pulled it down. Pete reached out with both hands and undid her bra for her. Tyler pulled that away too and now she had one breast bared and Tyler's hand was going over it, coddling and exploring. Their breaths grew more lusty.

Jess pushed his briefs down his thigh and Pete could see her stroking that cock over her own hip, her little hand struggling with his girth. Tyler sat up, broke away from her. His lips were swollen and wet from their kissing. He looked down at Jess, romantic, passionate intent in his eyes. Jess looked back, her eyes wet and trembling. It was so bright in here.

Tyler's shirt came off, pulled up over his head and thrown aside and Jess's hand was on him, feeling his hardness. His cock wagged over his hip, held up by his briefs. He leaned over her and grabbed her dress. The whole skirt part had bunched up around her waist from her humping herself against him and he was able to pull it right off her, her thin arms going up over her head and her hair clinging to it briefly before it was thrown aside like his shirt. Her thumbs hooked into her black lacy panties and she hiked them down. Her usually graceful legs kicked themselves clumsily out of them. Tyler pushed his briefs down a bit farther then collapsed next to her; they resumed their noisy kissing. Jess threw her leg over his hip and Tyler shifted, grabbed his cock. Pete looked down to see. He stroked it between her legs, he could hear how wet his wife was. Then he slowly slid it inside her and she gasped, her head turned to the side and Pete watched her sexy

profile, the woman he loved, as another man lovingly put his cock inside her body.

He watched them like that, both of them on their sides, making love for the longest time. Jess made soft sweet noises, little squeaks and gasp and moans. Tyler very slowly slid himself in and out of her, she held his cheeks in her hands and kissed him. They went on and on, it was very caring. Being so close to her, to feel her love, her passion; it was strangely beautiful. He watched her pretty round rump jiggle and flex as she made love back to him. He wanted to reach out and put his palm over one of those cheeks and feel her again. Would it make her happy? She was loved. She really was. Loved completely by two men.

She'd called him in here. Told him it was New Year's. She didn't want to sleep. She was the party, she said. She *was* the party.

He sat up and took his T-shirt off, lay back and got his pyjama pants down and off. He lay there and his heart was pounding. He watched them for another minute. Watched that sexy rump work; wriggle and hump, her cheeks flex and release.

He was harder than ever. He was small and slippery. He had to.

Jess felt Pete's palm run along her side and over her hip. She didn't know what to make of it. Her first urge was that it felt pleasant and familiar, then she felt like he was disturbing her. Disturbing them. But she couldn't stop him. He was her husband. And, most strangely, his touch put the weirdest feeling inside her. A palpable carnal lump that she felt deep in her belly. Dirty. Like dirtier than she could ever be. Two men in her bed. Two men who wanted her.

Her husband was dying inside as a man that was so superior to him took his woman from him. She felt his pain. Could feel it in his clammy touch. She felt his breath on her back, felt it hot and ragged. What must it do to him to see her like this? To see her fulfilled? This was what she could do with her life. This was her man here in her bed with her. Did he see it now? She saw it now.

"Oh," she gasped, high and quivering, when Pete's hand scooped around her front and she felt it on her belly, between her and Tyler;

dangerously close to where she and her lover were connected. What would it feel like for him to touch her there? Touch her where she was being penetrated. *While* she was being penetrated. Her breaths heaved thinking about it. Thinking what Pete would feel. Feel her boyfriend's thick cock. How hard he was right now. He could grip it see what a real man felt like. Hard and throbbing, substantial, dominant. She was being taken right now. As much as she started this and wanted it, desperately felt the love between them, ultimately she was being taken. Owned. Pulled away from another weaker male. One who couldn't hold on to her because he wasn't strong enough. Capable enough. He didn't have what it took and now another bigger, more primal male was claiming her as his own. She loved it. She gasped again. "Ah, my two men," she whispered.

Pete gripped her thigh and she let him, pushed her rump out to him. Let him feel. Let him slither his soft hand behind her, feel how she was penetrated, feel her man split her until it hurt so good. Feel her lover's testes, swelling with a seed that he would put inside her. Fill her up with his nectar, plant his offspring deep inside her. *Squeeze them Pete, touch them.* He has me. Those balls are for me. His hand squeezed her cheeks, spread them. It felt amazing. It pulled her creases apart, and Tyler's plunging felt instantly more pronounced, fresh and wet.

"Oh, God," she whispered into Tyler's mouth.

"Oh, Jess," Tyler whispered back, "you are so tight, so amazing, baby."

A prodding. Gentle at first. Wet and small. She couldn't believe it. "Oh, Petey, are you crazy?" she asked him. He didn't answer. Didn't need to. She felt the answer in his trembling behind her. He was going to do it. She wasn't going to stop him.

"Oh, Petey..."

He slid his little tip into her anus while Tyler had her claimed from the front.

"Oh," she gasped, she clenched her eyes shut, but rolled them right up, her head came back and her mouth hung open. Tyler's mouth grabbed at her tongue and she gave it to him, let him suck on her.

Tyler's thrusting slowed, let Petey find his little way back there. She let her husband's gentle tool snake it way up inside her, Tyler slowly resumed, and she didn't know if she could handle it. Not the feeling, but the pleasure. She felt her brain take off on a parasail over a crystal blue Caribbean water, high, high above, a slight tropical breeze through her soul.

“Oh, my two men,” she whispered again.

He couldn't believe his dirty little Jess let him do it. The mother of his children. The woman he'd loved for so long, the gentle caring angel who raised two boys, breast fed them, worked tirelessly for the little kids in her care at the school, bake sales, halloween parties, funerals—he'd held her hand and cried with her during sad movies—she had two men inside her at the same time writhing on them in her own bed.

“Oh, you, oh,” she moaned. He dug himself in, ran his hand up her smooth side, felt her ribs, let his hand come up over her soft breast, felt her nipple, clenched hard and tight, graze against his palm. She was trembling, gasping, looking up to the stars while her eyes were closed. He knew she was coming. Not some barn burner but a long slow one. He loved those ones too. Loved when she rode it out, softly turned her head from side to side, watching something going on behind those closed eyes, her brow gently furrowed like she couldn't quite understand what she was seeing.

“Oh, Jess, you're so amazing.” Tyler ploughed and Pete held firm, and Jess wriggled on the two of them. Her arm came up over her head, exposed herself to the two of them completely, surrendered to them. She was going to let them do whatever they wanted.

Tyler became insistent. Pete could feel his hard tool grinding against his own inside his wife. He could feel that hard cable that ran along his underside pushing against him, claiming all of his wife's space. Pushing him out of the way and making his wife's hot interior his and his alone. Pete pushed himself harder, he thrust himself into her. She had never felt so good ever. He'd never been here before in this tight space behind his wife. He loved it. He loved every bit of her. He wanted to be like this with her for all night. He wanted this to last until the sun came up. Tyler pushed his hand off her breast and he took it up for himself. Pete swept down between them, his hand held her belly. He could feel Tyler's impressive size lurking inside her—restless, a leviathan; he plunged deeper.

Jess yelled out when Pete found her button. She was swollen hard. She buckled when he worked it. He ran his finger on her, gently, then forcefully pressed it to her. She was wet like he'd never felt. She came again, bucked

so hard she almost came off him. But he had her pressed hard enough against her lover that it was contained. He slid himself in again. Tyler's thrusting grew urgent. He was deep in his wife. She was loving it. Pete pushed himself deeper, felt Tyler's sticky sack against this own.

Tyler hugged her to him, he could hear the breath squeezed from her with his force. Pete's hand was stuck between them. Tyler pounded her until she shook, so hard now, so fast, Pete was getting bucked off. He gripped her hips, dug his fingers into her flesh and he pounded her from behind.

Tyler pulled her away. Turned with his wife impaled on him, lay on his back with Jess over top of him. Her hair hung down in his face and their lips locked. Jess' hand moved to her own rump, she spread a cheek. Pete scrambled up, climbed over Tyler's bulging thighs and he kissed his wife's back, his heart momentarily stopped when he felt her delicate skin under his lips. He slid himself inside her. Watched himself sink slowly into her dark puckered hole. She gasped into Tyler. He heard her. She felt him. She knew he existed.

Tyler lay rigid for her, let her fuck him, let her slide her stretched out sex up and down his size. Now Pete had control of her bottom and he claimed it. It wasn't for his pleasure. It felt amazing, so amazing it was like joyous fireworks were spraying off in all the colours of the rainbow inside his heart—but he resisted it. He did it for her. Gave her his hard little tool and put it in place for her to enjoy. Everything was for her. She bumped and writhed on them and watching her slender back work—showing off her pretty muscles working underneath, watching her tight skin bunch at the small of her back when she arched her rump for more pleasure, her thin arms holding her body up while she fucked two men—the image had his balls tightened up high and desperate. He was pumping his lubricant into her, she had him more excited than he could remember in ages. His wife was a complex, complicated, sexually troubled yet wantonly vibrant young woman. A job, a husband, two kids, a household; none of it had extinguished her licentious spark. He lightly slapped her cheek, self-consciously. She gasped. He did it again. He spanked her bottom harder.

“Ah!” she gasped to Tyler.

He slapped her again, harder. He felt hard as stone inside her. Her rump showed a red hand. He smiled, he closed his eyes and rolled them up, let himself enjoy the feel of her tight insides on him. Gave himself permission

to be a part of this. He loved her so fucking completely, bad girl that she was.

Tyler pulled her from him. Twisted her away. Pulled her easily from his short length, rolling under him, knocking him over as they bumped around between his thighs. He got behind her again. Lay on his side with his head on the pillow. He allowed himself to feel her. Let him enjoy the warmth of the skin of her back. His hand went down and scooped one of her jiggling cheeks up and parted them once more. He slid in again. *God, she let him do it.* She was an awful, dirty woman. He smiled into her back, pressed his face against her. Felt Tyler's thrusting rock her beautiful body against his. He fucked her. He thrust his little erection in and out of her while her boyfriend had her pulled apart in the front. Buried deep inside her.

"Oh, Tyler," she whispered.

Pete felt filled with love.

She was gasping now, pained yips, and squeaks, her hand clawed at Tyler's big arm. Pete was going to come. It was glorious. He hadn't been with her forever it felt like and now he was going to claim her insides with his seed, he went faster; he could feel it coming.

She cried, gasped, "Stop, stop," and she kicked her sweaty legs like she was swimming underwater, kicked and kicked until they both slid out from inside her and she swam above them to the pillows.

T Tyler scooped her up and cradled her. She looked so small against him. He looked like he could protect her from anything.

She said, "I'm okay, I'm okay."

Tyler said, "Did he hurt you?"

"I'm fine. It just started to sting," she whispered to him. She curled up against his big strong body, her hands went between her legs and she was soothing the places where they'd entered her.

He suddenly felt very lewd. Perverted. Like he was some creeper who'd been hiding in the closet, came out and sneakily stuck it up some girl's butt while she was with her boyfriend. He felt like he'd ruined their night. But it was his night. His wife.

"Jess?" he whispered.

“I’m fine, Pete, really.”

“Did we get rid of your hiccups?” Tyler asked, being cute.

She thought, then giggled, “Yes.”

He said it again, “Did we?” and he tickled her sides.

She cuddled into him, hugged an arm around him, giggled again, “Yes.”

Tyler’s erection stuck up between them, glistening, sliding across her thighs. He felt suddenly aware of his size again, laying naked in bed with them. He looked down, didn’t like what he saw. He had nothing to cover it with. They were laying on the bedspread.

Tyler whispered, “I still want to make love to you.”

“Me too,” she whispered. “I want that too.”

Tyler kissed her forehead.

“I can’t do both though. Not again.”

“That’s okay,” Tyler said. “Pete can watch. Oh—”

It was like something occurred to him. He let Jess down on the bed and twisted behind him, opened the drawer on the nightstand.

“Look what we’ve got here, Pete.” He turned holding the huge, but accurate, pale rubber replica of his own cock. The end of it wagged out of the end of his fist.

Jess covered her mouth while she laughed, “I can’t do two of those, oh my God, are you crazy?”

“Not for you. For him.”

Pete said, “Jess, I thought you got rid of that.”

“For him?” she said to Tyler.

Pete frowned, “For me?”

“Why would she get rid of this?” he said, looking at in his hand, admiring it.

“Why would *I* want it?” Pete said, still frowning, puzzled.

“He wanted me to get rid of it,” she said to Tyler.

“Why?”

“Because the kids might find it.”

“Always with the kids. I care about those two boys as much as you do. They don’t come in here, Pete. It’s fine. I made it for her.” He poked her thigh with it.

“Tyler, they could come in here. That drawer isn’t locked. What would they think?”

Jess smiled, looked up at Tyler.

“Jesus, Jess.”

Jess said, “I’ll put it somewhere better.”

“Like up Pete?”

Jess smiled and then quickly sucked her lips into her mouth like she didn’t want Pete to see her amused by that.

“Why the fuck would you say that?”

She looked up to Tyler, then back to Pete. “I don’t know. I—”

Tyler said, “You know... Why you wanted her to fuck other men. To be your proxy. Send her to do the things you want to do yourself.”

Pete’s head shook in disbelief.

“You want to put that in my ass? You think I want that in my ass?”

“Isn’t this what you want, Pete?” Jess said.

Tyler said, “When you watch you want to be Jess. You want to be fucked, you want to feel this cock of mine inside you. Now’s your chance. Let Jess put it in you since I won’t.”

Pete looked to Jess. “Is that what he’s been telling you?”

“Do you want that Pete? Do you want me to do that for you?”

“What? Are you two fucking crazy?”

“Yeah, you do,” Tyler chided.

Pete went serious. “No, I don’t.”

“Let her do it, man, no one’s going to judge.”

“Is that what you think, Jess? Is that what he’s poisoning you with?”

Jess’s eyes were down. Looking at the rubber cock in her hand. “I don’t know what you think. I can’t figure it out, Petey.”

Pete said, “Tyler, I’m the man in the house, all right? I might not look like you or swing some big dick but I’m the *man*. I bought this house, I work, I have responsibility; those are *my* boys, I’m their father, I pay the bills.”

“But I fuck your wife.”

Jess didn’t like it, said, “Hey—”

“She’s my wife.” He put his hand on her knee. “This is my wife and you fuck her because I love her, you were fucking her at my will, you are just a gift that I’ve given her.”

“He’s not a gift to be given or tip-huh-taken, Pete,” she said. Her hiccups were back. “And I’m not ah-anyone’s property.” She threw the cock away, off to the foot of the bed. “I don’t know what you want, Petey. Not anymore. I don’t know what any of this was all about.”

“Any of what?”

“Wanting me to have sex with other men.”

“I want you to be happy.”

“By fucking men that aren’t my husband?”

“You thought it was hot.”

“Hey—I thought the men were hih-hot. I thought Tyler was hot. I never thought hard enough about whether it was right or not.”

“You think it’s wrong?”

“It was. For me it was. But now...” She put her hand over Tyler’s.

“Jess, I told you...I don’t want this *hurt* anymore...I don’t want you to hurt me.”

“I’m not trying to hurt you. I honestly...I don’t know what you want...I don’t...I feel like I don’t know you...”

“Jess...don’t know me? How could you—”

Tyler pushed his hand off her knee. Jess looked weak and sleepy. She looked deeply troubled. Sad.

Tyler said, “You know she was going to dump you.”

“What?”

“She was going to dump you but you got lucky and squirted those little grapes inside her. You got her pregnant.”

Now Jess was mad, she turned on Tyler, “How dare—I told you that...it was pip-private!” Her face screwed up, and her eyes were quivering. Tyler’s arms went around her and he held her.

The bed was gone underneath Pete. Everything was gone. Everything he got up for every day was taken from him. His wife, his children...his family—what was it all ever fucking about, what did it all amount to? He existed in a void now, nothing, emptiness. All that he saw as real to this point was not real. “Jess, do you think...I robbed you? Do you think I took your life away?”

Her head was pressed against Tyler’s chest, her eyes closed, a tear had accumulated under her lashes, swelled large and round, and Pete watched it tremble, waited for it to fall. “No, Pete. How can you say that? Our babies, Pete. You gave me our babies. You never took anything from me. You gave me those two lives.”

Pete bent, fell until his forehead touched the bedspread. With his face hidden the tears came. They flowed from him, his back heaved. “Jess, I just

love you so much. All I ever wanted was for you to be happy. I didn't want trouble. I didn't want you to miss out on pleasure."

He felt them moving next to him. When he looked up he saw that Tyler was kissing Jess again. She had her back to him, her head turned over her shoulders, her pretty lips seeking to make contact with his. She was biting at his lower lip, her eyes closed. Tears had streamed across her cheeks but her face was peaceful as if she were asleep. Tyler was stroking his half-hard cock, then he kneaded the glans up between his wife's legs. Pete watched her legs part for him. That big thing pushed against her soft pink parts, pushed and then slowly spread her until it was sinking into her body. She said, "Oh," a little gasp that disappeared behind Tyler's pouting plump young lips.

Pete watched that thing of Tyler's plunge in and out of his wife's body, claiming that sacred space for himself. He watched it disappear inside her, that thickness spread her wide; knew she felt it, knew he felt good inside her.

His wife was gone. That wasn't her getting fucked like that. Her eyes were closed, her mind absent. She was just a beautiful warm body being penetrated, an organism whose brain was only kept alive by the pleasure signals that Tyler's thrusting was zipping up there. Jess was gone.

He watched a while. It was ugly but there was something somehow wonderful in it. He stroked her bare pretty foot. Ran his thumb over the nail edge of her big toe. She came once more. Her eyes still closed. Her mouth hung open after she'd cried out. Her brow furrowed. She was going to come again.

He got up and put his pyjamas back on while the two of them continued on. They were going slow and passionately. Lovingly. Tyler held her wrist back over his thigh. His other arm was wrapped underneath her, his forearm coming across her softly jiggling chest. She was sighing and gasping with his movement, feeling it build inside her again. Jess had her little hand clamped over his. Her head bobbed loosely with his thrusts.

Pete went to the door, watched another moment. Watched Tyler's big balls move on his thigh, tighten up and release as he came inside Jess. Again and again he shot his seed inside her, he was softly groaning, biting his lower lip. Pete turned the light off and went to bed.

MAKEUP

TUESDAY, JANUARY 3RD

“Hey, Julio, you ever have someone in your life...you know...become a problem?”

“A problem? How you mean, *like a problem*?”

“Yeah, like, I mean, they’re...you know—”

“All kind of problems, Pete.”

“They’re just ruining...your quality of life.”

Julio thought about it a moment, trying to figure Pete out. Was this a test or something, like was Pete evaluating him for work purposes or was he genuinely interested? His eyes went narrow.

“Seriously,” Pete urged, sensing Julio’s discomfort in approaching it.

“You mean, like, a neighbour?”

“Yeah, like a neighbour. Someone not in your family or anything. But every time you see them they ruin your day.”

“What they do though? Like, threaten you?”

Yeah, that was close. “Right, that’s perfect. Like that. You don’t feel safe with them around.”

It was just the two of them sitting in the Security Control Room with the lights off. Julio was at the long desk in the centre of the room in front of four computer stations only one of them active at the moment. The wall above him had four thirty-inch monitors flicking scenes of various store locations from the CCTV security cameras across the Save-Mart.

Pete saw him in here as he was passing by in the hall and came in to sit with him. He didn’t come in here to talk about this. Just wanted to sit with somebody.

“You’re asking for real.” He said it and it wasn’t a question.

“Yeah.”

He laughed, then, said, “I don’t know, I guess. Yeah, maybe a couple of times.”

“What do you do?”

“I don’t know, Pete. Two times I called the cops...one time the guy moved away. He used to yell all the time about my friends, my cousins, parking on his side of the driveway—Pete, by an *inch* or two. Couldn’t be normal, homes went off yelling like he was going to pop his top. One day—just gone. Another time, Maria had a guy, like, stalking her at work...”

Pete leaned forward. “What did you do?”

He shrugged. “He would send her, like love letters, they were really...” He shook his head, like he just remembered how disturbing they were.

“Did you talk to him?”

He shrugged again. Didn’t want to tell his boss. “All those times I learned one thing: nip it in the bud, you know? Don’t let it go, wait for the other guy to smarten up; set it straight right from the beginning. Guy or girl?”

“Huh?”

“You got problems with. Guy or girl?”

“Guy.”

“That’s lucky. Girls are crazy.”

“They are,” he agreed.

They sat in the dark for a moment, Pete swivelling in the chair, rocking around with his heels dug into the linoleum floor. He had his arms folded, his mouth bunched up, twisting while he thought.

Julio got up, pat him on the shoulder as he passed, said, “I gotta get back to work, boss is a real asshole.”

Pete chuckled, watched him walk to the light in the hall. “Hey, Julio, thanks.”

“Sure thing, Chief,” he said. “Hey, Pete? Don’t you do anything crazy.” Then he was gone down the hall.

He wouldn’t lose his Jess. Not for real. He couldn’t bear it. But he was powerless, empty. His adversary twenty times the man he was.

Right in front of him, like a beacon, a call to action. Two tall, long-legged girls, hair swishing behind them, tight jeans, expensive parkas.

He jumped out of his chair and burst down the stairs, headed for the sales floor. He marched across the Save-Mart, his Hush Puppies squeaking on the polished floor. He found them, locked himself on them, their thin bodies jiggling unfocused in his determined but blurry high blood pressure vision.

Then he was on them, fast and hard, ordering them what to do before his brain had time to stutter. He put a hand out and stopped them like a cop, he five-finger-pointed them to an abandoned sales desk. He was firm. When one rolled her eyes it just made him more mad.

He got in her face. "Do you think we're fucking stupid around here?"

"What?" she said, surprised but indignant, thrusting her head forward and shrugging.

"*What?* Don't pull that shit with me. You don't think we've got cameras all over this place? You don't think we just watched you up in Control? Saw what you did?"

"Saw what?" Her arms folded.

"Please. How many times you going to rob this store? I've got video evidence of you, multiple times. Enough merchandise now you can consider this a goddamn felony. You like that?"

The quiet one began to show a crack. Probably had a future to worry about. Stole to impress her bitchy friend here. He lit into her.

"What's your home number? The cops are on their way and I want to make sure your parents are here to talk with them. And you think we're going to go light? No fucking way. I've had it with you and your kind. The store ain't budging. Full charges. You get that? Guaranteed you'll see a jail cell."

The more resilient of the two said, "Her dad's a lawyer, he—"

"Good. Fucking great. You'll need one. You won't have to pay to hear that you've got no leg to stand on. Your dad'll tell you that shit for free. Listen, Alan fucking Dershowitz couldn't save you, we got video of you, ten different angles, pulling your fucking games."

"Don't call them..."

"Too late."

Quiet one broke. She cried for real. Pretty like his Jess, even with a scrunched up miserable face. Her friend started to twist too, hearing her sobs. She thought she was tough but she wasn't.

“Look at you. You’re a couple of sob sisters now. All fucking high and mighty strutting around here but when the shit hits the fan you two are as worthless as they come. My favourite part? The part I’m looking forward to? Parking, watching you pick up trash at the highway in your boxy orange jumpers. I’ll take my lunch break every day, film it so the rest of us here can get a laugh. Pretty faces like yours are a target in there. You know that? Gang girls’ll take a box-cutter to—”

She gasped through her tears, “Please. Please don’t...”

“Too late...”

The strong one chiming in now too. “Please, don’t—we’ll pay, we’ll—”

“Seventy-five dollars.”

“Seventy-five dollars?”

“Four months ago you took five Maybellines.”

“Four months ago?”

“Seventy-five dollars plus tax. In cash. In my hand. You dump out the stuff you took today—”

“We didn’t take anything today.”

“Seventy-five dollars plus tax in my hand right now, you never show up here again, I’ll call the cops off.”

They complied. Their hands shook uncontrollably taking the bills out of their leather purses and placing them in his eager held out hand.

He felt like a million bucks. Couldn’t believe he’d done it. They laid the cash out on him and he escorted them to the doors, resisted every urge he had to kick the taller one in her skinny ass on the way out. Fucking cunts.

He knew what he had to do.

He stormed back up to admin, marched between the desks outside his office.

“Tamicka, cancel the rest of my afternoon,” he said, passing by her, bustling into his office feeling ten feet tall.

“I’m not your secretary, Pete.”

He poked his head back out of his office, said, “I know, I just mean if anyone calls. Please?” He grabbed his coat off the coat rack and thrust his arms through the sleeves. He put his toque on storming for the doors.

Tamicka said, “What you want me to tell em?”

“Tell them I’m doing something I should have done a long time ago.”

First day back to school and Jess felt surprisingly enervated. Like she might be coming down with something. It *was* the season and as many times as she washed her hands it didn’t stop her coming face to face with all sorts of bugs in this virus mosh pit. Of course, she hadn’t been here in two weeks.

She was going through the admin, squirting green aloe vera hand sanitizer just in case, adding echinacea to a mental grocery list, when she saw a lone cherry-coloured envelope in her mailbox.

She was alone in the small mail room across from the chest-high reception bank, unattended so early in the morning. All the mail slots were empty, except for hers with that strange single oddly-coloured envelope.

In a gold sharpie someone had written her name across the front. Otherwise it was unaddressed. No postage mark, no stamp. It had been put here by hand.

She opened it and read it.

One sheet, a floral scented paper, folded once, and then written in a careful woman’s hand:

Jess,

Never in my life have I ever met someone who has inspired me more than you. I look up to you, and often, when troubled, ask myself- What would Jess do?

I feel like now you might be the one that’s troubled, and I don’t know how to help a friend in need when her challenges are so great, so overwhelming, and perhaps, none of my business.

I saw you kissing Tyler in your kitchen. I saw where his hand was. I saw what he was doing to you and I saw that you wanted it. I don’t blame you. You know all the things I’ve said about him.

I also know it had to have been you with Tyler that day that he was fired.

I'm not blind, Jess. Unfortunately, others aren't as well. I will always stand up for you, but you need to know that there has been talk behind your back.

What worries me—and is where I wonder that this may not be my business—is that you do this under your husband's nose.

How could you do that to another human being? How can you hurt someone so deeply? Don't you love him? Or didn't you at one time?

You are plucking at heart strings that have been pulled far too tightly. From where I'm watching it looks like it's so painful, so horrible, tragic—the kind of thing that ends badly, ends violently. Please be careful, baby.

Where I think this may be my business—and the reason I felt strong enough to write this letter—is where your behaviour, your indiscretion, overlaps your children.

Jess, people break up all the time. You know I know that. Children recover. Children can adapt to new fathers, new mothers. But they can't see it unfold before them. They can't witness the destruction of someone they love. They can't witness you do this to their father.

I won't condemn your actions though I might like to. But you are irresponsible. Selfish.

Maybe in some way I am happy for you. But right now you are not the Jess I know and love.

Come back to us.

You have to make up your mind. Whatever you decide to do I will support you.

*With tremendous love,
Sara.*

Something terrible happened in her classroom.

She'd welcomed all the kids back to class that morning, saying hi to them as they came in and hung up their coats and jackets on the hooks along the back of the wall. Her heart was heavy, her back felt sweaty and she was even sicker than she had been before she read the letter. Maybe if she'd felt better she would have seen it coming. Stopped it from happening.

Kevin was there, obviously back from a nice vacation. She said, "Wow, nice tan, Kevin." And as he was about to answer Cory Wilde punched him right in the face and knocked his tooth out with a bloody splash. There had been a commotion prior, a little heated exchange between Cory and Florencia Torres. There was a crush there, she knew that.

Cory hit him from behind, a bit to the side of him. Kevin didn't even see it coming. He was smiling when he was hit, his happy eyes on hers. Then he was down on his knees clutching his face and his blood spilled on her floor. His wailing broke her heart.

She grabbed Cory by his shirt and held him in case he wasn't done. His eyes were red and weepy too. Then Kevin changed within the time of one of his heartbeats. Crying gone, he jumped up in a rage and came at Cory swinging with both fists. Jess held Cory in an arm and put the other between him and Kevin, tried to cover him. Kevin came in swinging and jabbing. Cory didn't want to be protected, he was swinging as well, even kicking his little legs out.

"Boys, boys, boys!" she cried.

She got herself between them, held them apart, but they kept at it, trying to tear at each other around her. Then Carol was there, maybe a little too excited, her voice high and shrill, making the energy a little worse. But Carol took Cory, and Jess told her to get him to the office. With Cory out of the room Kevin went back to crying. She felt so bad for him like that, breaking down, bawling and wailing, his face bloody—all his friends watching. She grabbed wads of the utility paper off the roll at the side of the

room and she pressed it to his mouth. She soothed him, held him and hugged him.

“Baby, it’s okay, Kevin. You’ll get a new tooth. It’s okay, don’t cry, buddy.”

Over Kevin’s shoulder, was Florencia. Standing there, dumbfounded. Holding a plush shark that said, *Greetings from Myrtle Beach*. This was over a girl. What was going on? ...These kids are only eight.

“Okay, okay, Kevin,” she said when Victoria got there from the front office to help him down to the First Aid. She went out to the hall with him, told him quietly that they’d call his mom for him, he’d be okay. He nodded into his bloody paper.

Her heart was pounding, her neck swelling from the intense action as she stood and watched him being helped down the hall. God, it had all happened so fast she hadn’t the time to get upset. Now she was. She felt so much for him.

She went back into the class, everyone in their desks now, so upset they didn’t now what to do, just sitting in their places watching her, looking for guidance. She flexed and opened her hands.

“Class, class...” she whispered.

Her shirt was open. Yanked by one of the boys, a button had popped off in the centre and her bra was showing.

“Oh,” she whispered. Closed it.

They all stared at her and she didn’t know what to say. Where to begin.

“I...I’m sorry...”

What did she look like to them standing up here? A woman who got a floral scented note of reprimand. Some advice from a friend on not being such a dirty beast in front of her husband and kids.

When did she stop being Jess Mapplethorpe?

Their eyes were on her, looking at her sweet and lovingly. She was a liar. She wasn’t who they thought she was. She was a woman who had a secret so terrible she could barely look into those sweet faces. She was ashamed of herself. She hadn’t realized it. She should be ashamed.

It washed over her while she stood with thirty sets of eight-year-old eyes on her. Their innocence amplifying her filth, her deceit, her decrepitude.

She had to sit down. Her legs would not comply. Her left arm tingled. Pins and needles. She clenched her hand and opened it. Did it again. It

wasn't even there. She held it out to look at it. She saw her small hand, her thin fingers, her engagement ring and wedding band. Wait—*was* that her hand?

She stammered something. Wasn't sure what she had tried to say, but it wasn't words. She put a hand out to steady herself, one leg tripping over the other, legs didn't know what they were doing. She pulled herself along the desk, dragged herself to her chair and fell in it sideways. The kids called her name. She could barely hear them over the siren. What *was* that siren and why was it so loud? The kids were concerned. Their faces worried, horrified—what was wrong with their favourite teacher? She held a hand up to them.

Please kids, just give me a minute. The words in her head coming out nothing like that over her dead lips.

Someone ran from the room, Karla Lopez, she thought, black hair bobbing. She struggled to get a grip, not lose it in front of these sweethearts that looked up to her, loved her. Then the school nurse was there, sitting with her and she realized she wasn't sure how long she'd been out of it like this. Everything was blurry and she heard someone say to another that she was having a stroke.

Pete was doing sixty-five in a thirty, tears in his eyes. He'd got to Jaden Van, went to admin, said, *Page my wife*. Principal was there, she came out of her office, said, *They already took her to the hospital, Pete*. Pete had said, *Took who to the hospital?*

Sara was there then, bounding through the heavy metal double doors and running right to him with her arms out and she hugged him. Sara was crying; inconsolable. Pete had stuttered, *What's going on?* Sara said she didn't know, someone said Jess had a stroke, EMTs took her to the hospital.

He ran to the car, left them all standing there calling after him, his vision was blurry and his ears weren't working. All he could hear was his own heart, his feet on the pavement. He ran into a parked car and fell to his knees. He looked back to the school. He should have asked more. What happened? How was she? Was she talking? Fuck—what hospital was she in?

Now he was surfing through snowy traffic squeezing his vinyl steering wheel so hard his knuckles were white. He had the 105.5 local station on, desperate to hear if there was any news about a young beautiful teacher taken to the hospital from the elementary school. They didn't say a thing. Didn't they know how important she was?

"Come on, come on!" he screamed through the windshield. He swerved right through the intersection, through a red light on Tullyfield then punched it down that wide four lane road—right past the green Hydro box where Jess had arranged her dirty surprise party, down to the intersection at Waverley and he slowed and then rolled right through that one, wincing and pulling up his shoulders at the honking and screeching of rubber on wet winter pavement. But he didn't get hit and he went across the curb bouncing the old Buick into the hospital driveway, roaring all the way up and then stopping on an angle under the alcove of the ambulance bay at Emergency.

He hustled in through the sliding glass doors, his slushy feet slipped on the polished floor and he grabbed the hand sanitizer stand to stop himself from falling. A dozen people and some nurses at Triage all stopped and watched him. He hated hospitals but he was no stranger to them. He beat a line straight to them. The crowd parted for him. Everything about him gave off a message of absolute terrible panic.

"My wife!" he gasped, throwing his hands down on the countertop. "Mapplethorpe, Jess Mapplethorpe!"

Tall nurse, dreads and a pink smock, she knew, said, "Three curtains down." She pointed across the hall, down the centre of the room on the other side. Long fluorescent room, dimly lit, only half the lights on, a dozen curtains making tragic little spaces along either side. She said, "On the left."

He whipped around and stumbled across the hall and into the long room.

"Hey!" The nurse called him.

He turned and the nurse said, "She's going to be okay."

"She is?" He stared at her kind face. He started to cry. He turned back, continued down to the third curtain and pulled it back.

"Jess?"

"Hi, Pete," she said weakly.

She looked so small and fragile sitting in the hospital bed, her thin arms and body swimming in her big blue gown. Her hands were clasped together

in her lap, her hair hung down straight across her collar, her little ears peeking out the sides.

“Daddy!” Andy shouted, and he hugged himself to Pete's leg, his tiny face red from crying.

“What? How did you get—” Pete said wild-eyed looking around the small curtained space.

Tyler was there already, Petey was too, sitting in the cushioned chair next to the bed. His face was red, he had both his little hands clenched around Tyler's huge hand up in front of his face. Tyler had him huffing on his bronchodilator.

“Petey?”

“He's okay, Pete,” Tyler said. His face was somber.

Petey pushed the inhaler away and nodded to his dad, swallowing and gulping, his skinny legs swinging off the edge of the chair. Pete ran his hand over Andy's blonde head and walked the two steps to be by Jess's side with his youngest clinging to his leg.

“Jess, what happened? Are you all right?”

She nodded and grabbed a wadded up Kleenex from the bed sheet and pressed it to her eyes.

She said, “Tyler, can you...”

“Yeah,” he said.

“Oh no, Jess,” he whispered, watching Tyler take Petey out past the curtain, his hand on his shoulder. He bent and scooped Andy up and held him over his hip. They left and the curtain closed softly behind them.

He put his arms around her. “God, Jess, what happened?” His eyes were welling up.

She patted his arm. She spoke, her voice quiet and hoarse, said, “Pete, I'm fine now. I'm okay.”

“But what happened?”

“I took a...spell today. Just...I...my ears were ringing, my heart was pounding and I...thought I was dying. I was sure I was dying.”

“Are you okay?”

“Yeah, I am. My blood pressure was through the roof and they were worried about my heart.”

He squeezed her tight. No one worried about her heart more than he did. “How is your heart?” Worried about the answer.

“I'm fine. They said it was a panic attack. They sedated—”

“A panic attack?”

“—me, calmed me down and then I was okay again. I didn't feel like I was dying anymore.”

He was so relieved. God, he was so relieved.

He said, “Baby, is it the stress? Is it stress?”

“Pete, I can't do this anymore.”

“I know, Jess, I can't do it either. We have to stop.”

“No, Pete.”

“I know—”

“No, I can't do this anymore. Us.”

He let her go, his fingertips brushing her soft cotton back as his head came up and struggled to focus on her big icy baby blues.

“Us?”

“I just can't do it, Pete.” Her face scrunched up tight, went beet red, her mouth screwed up and she started to cry.

“Don't, Jess. Don't cry. Sweetheart, don't stress.”

“Pete, you have to go.”

“Go? Hold on, Jess.” It was all catching up with him. He squeezed her shoulders. Wait. *She was done with him?* She couldn't do *us* anymore? Come to see her today to set this all straight. Come to see her today to claim her as his own. Now she was telling him she wasn't going to be his.

“Pete, don't make this hard...you know...knew...” She broke down sobbing into her clenched fists.

He put his arms around her again and she crumpled against him. She murmured into his chest.

“What?”

“I want to divorce,” she cried.

“Jess...no.”

He stepped back from the bed and watched her crying, her shoulders heaving and she sobbed into her Kleenex.

“Jess.”

But she didn't look to him. Her pretty hair fell forward and she hid from him.

“No...Jess?”

He took another step back. His hands clenched at the curtain behind him. He couldn't breathe. He couldn't breathe at all. His vision was dim and narrow. He clawed at his tie; he had to get out of there, had to get away, get

some air. He thrashed and thrashed at the curtain, trying to find a way out, couldn't get it, stumbled forward through it. It slid up over his head, and he went on clumsily through the centre of the room, his hand grabbing at the hanging cotton walls for support. *God no, God no.* He staggered out into light of the hall, stopped before the nurses. The tall nurse looked up through her eyebrows at him and smiled. "Told you," she said.

"Dad?"

Petey and Andy were sitting on an upholstered bench up against the wall to his left. Andy sat on Tyler's lap.

He nodded to them. His face felt tense—his breath came to him now but it was in a ragged stutter. Tyler watched him, gauged him. He wouldn't show Tyler that he won. Really won. Took everything he had from him. Tyler wouldn't see him cry today. Pete wouldn't let him.

He turned on his heels and marched down the hall headed for his Buick.

Andy said, "Where are you going, Daddy?"

"Dad? Where are you going?" Petey called after him.

"You hang in there, kiddos." He choked, stumbled his way out to the car sitting in the ambulance bay. His hand shook like mad trying to get the key in the ignition. He slipped it in and let his head fall forward to rest against the wheel. He turned the key, started it. The speakers vibrated, the 105.5 traffic report exploded in his ears, scared the fuck out of him and he jumped back. His open palm slammed into the stereo control. Pain shot up into his shoulder, ripped at his palm. The radio got louder. He screamed, *Fuck!* and sat back, brought his Hush Puppy up and slammed his heel into the radio over and over until the knobs flew off, the display cracked and then went black, and splinters of plastic pinged all around the cabin and onto his suit.

"Fuck! Fuck! Fuck!"

When he was done and it was quiet and all he could hear was his own terrified breaths he put the car into drive and crept to the back of the parking lot. He parked under the long jagged branches of an old maple tree. Must have been a wonderful shady spot in the hot summer back when his life made sense. He climbed into the backseat and curled up on the bench, hugged his knees and cried as hard as he liked because no one could see him.

PART X

LIVE FREE

BABY CEDARS

THURSDAY, FEBRUARY 9TH

Pete was awake at 4:45. Been awake for a while. Just staring at the ceiling.

He sat up, turned the alarm off before it would sound in a few minutes. He rolled his head around on his neck, stretched a bit, then slumped and looked around the cold, empty room. Big, fat snowflakes whisked past the window going sideways, white blobs against a grim, gunmetal sky.

He growled quietly as he got up, scared the thoughts away as they came to get him. The hurt, the pain, the loss; they did him no good. He got out of his pyjamas, got on some tights, some running shorts, a fleece and a shell. Pulled a warm beanie over his balding head, grabbed his running shoes and softly went out into the hall, headed to the kitchen in his socks.

He smelled coffee coming down the steps. Patty was up already. He came into her kitchen quietly. She had a robe on, standing over the sink with her back to the room watching the snow out the window. The kitchen was dark, just the under-cabinet lights on.

“Good morning,” he whispered to her, didn’t want to startle her.

She turned quickly, wiped her cheeks with the back of her hands. She’d been crying. “Oh! Good morning, Petey.”

He pretended he didn’t notice her tears, said, “You’re up early.”

She sniffed, wiped an eye with one finger, said, “You are too. Going for a run?”

“Yeah.”

“I just can’t sleep. Come here,” she said and she held her arms out to him.

Patty was a tough cookie. She was protective of her two brothers when they were growing up. He relied on her far more than he'd relied on his brother. She'd fought some of his battles for him. He hated to see her like this. She was suffering knowing his hurt, knowing there was nothing she could do about it.

She hugged him. Held him tight. He closed his eyes and felt her sleep-warm body. He was desperate for some human contact, to feel someone's love.

"Thanks, Patty."

"You're welcome, kid," she rubbed his back, then let him go.

"Okay," she said, wiped at her eyes again, another fresh sniffle. "Big weekend here. I'll do the groceries tonight on my way home. God, those boys, we're going to have a great time. Russ is at work on Saturday, but Sunday we'll hit Great Wolf Lodge. Tonight we'll go to the movies. I'm going to spoil them rotten..."

Pete hung his head. "Thanks, Patty. Not the Water Park though, okay? Can we do something else?"

"Whatever you want, Petey."

It had been one month without her. One month without the love of his life. She was with that other man. Playing house. In his house. With his kids. Her happy face didn't swell his heart anymore. Now her happy face was part of his pain, part of his black, ashy heart. There was a time when her joy was his joy. But now, living on the other side of town, excised from her life, her joy was a deadly dagger.

He got the boys on the weekends. She was kind about that. No divorce yet, no lawyers, just a separation. *There was hope, right?* But this weekend was her trip away. Her five days in Florida with her new mate. It hurt so bad—but, hey, five days with his boys.

"What's wrong?" he said to Patty. She'd got sullen, leaning now on the sink, her arms folded, looking at the floor, boring holes in it with her eyes. Her brow was furrowed.

"Pete, I swear I'm going to smash that pretty face of hers to a goddamn pulp."

"Don't, Patty. I love her."

She mumbled, "Going to leave you with the kids while she runs off on a vacation with that big, dumb piece of shit."

"Patty—I'd take my kids any time for any reason."

“Pete, I know—doesn’t it bother you that she’s doing this? Doesn’t it make you mad?”

He winced. Pinched his nose, squinted, kept the tears at bay. It’d be nice if he could get away with one day where he didn’t cry. Could be today, if he could just keep it together here.

“Patty, please...I’m barely holding on.”

Patty came to him, she put her arms around her little brother and she held him again. “I’m sorry, Petey. I’ll shut up. I’ll stop. I guess I got all the rage in the family. You were left with all the kindness.” She kissed his cheek.

“You’re plenty kind, Patty.”

She’d let him move in here. Not let him. Told him. *Made him*. He wasn’t going to be a burden though. He had three apartments to visit next week. Big step, big painful step, but he couldn’t inject his sadness into his poor sister’s life. He couldn’t tell her yet. She’d be mad he was looking for his own place.

“How long you gonna be?”

“Maybe an hour.”

“We’ll have breakfast?”

“Can’t wait, Patty.”

He put on his shoes and his gloves, headed out into the cold and the dark and the sideways snow that stung his face. He ran out of Patty’s subdivision, headed across town.

He circled his old neighbourhood, boxed around it. Down Springlawn, over Benson Boulevard, up Watson, then a bit of a jog near the highway out by the Dunkin’ Donuts. Then a straight line across town back to Patty and Russ.

He’d boxed around it, afraid of it, wouldn’t enter. But he was looking for a weakness in the fence, like a zoo animal, except he was looking for a way to get in there.

He ran hard and fast, a slower pace than when he was younger, but he got that heart pumping until it hurt, until his lungs gasped and heaved and his throat burned like oxygen was jet fuel. The pain, for a while at least, pushed it all away...

Jess had booked tomorrow off. Then Monday was a Professional Development day and she also took Tuesday for herself. That gave them five days together. Out of the house, away, just time for the two of them. Jess and Tyler. She absolutely couldn't wait. She ached for this. Ached to be away from it all.

Right now though she was still in snowy, cold, February in Ohio. Dayton, to be exact—at the Boonshoft Museum of Discovery, three Jaden Van classes on a field trip, Sara and Carol there as well as about ninety kids. Most of them were watching the universe played out for them on a round screen in The Dome, the Space Theatre.

Jess sat next to Sara, across from the theatre in the Hall of the Universe, on a bright red velvet bench under a six-by-six image of the Milky Way; an arrow pointed above them, it said, *You Are Here*. They were watching the kids across the carpeted hall, most of them transfixed by the scale of what they were watching on the screen. Maybe thirty in there with Carol, the rest were milling about, running from station to station, pressing every button on the interactive displays to see what would happen. Jess and Sara taking a break, standing guard to make sure no one slipped out and ended up away from the group, getting lost in Science Central. Bunch of other, bigger kids in there from another school.

Sara said, "Scale of one to ten, how excited are you to go away?"

Jess closed her eyes, said, "Ten plus. Can't wait. Flight's at eleven."

"What if we don't get back in time?"

"Don't even."

"What if there's a traffic jam and we don't make it back to Columbus until—"

"Stop, stop, stop. I swear I'd just drive there. I *need* to get away."

"I know, Jess," Sara pursed her lips and looked at her friend.

Jess said, "I need to so bad."

"I'm looking forward to my house guest."

"Thanks, Sara, Pete's sister doesn't like dogs in the house. I could send him to the kennel but last time I don't think they kept up with his special food. When he came back to us his coat was terrible, he had the worse...you know...poops. I worry about him."

"Jess, I'm looking forward to it."

"You sure? He can be a handful."

“I’m sure. I had a dog growing up. I’ll take him to the Dog Park. Hit on some guys.”

“Aw. He’d like that. The Park part...I’ll drop him off right after work.”

“I can come pick him up.”

“No, it’s okay. I’ll bring him over.”

Carol came out of the dome, a curt, clipped walk, straight to Sara, kneeled to her side. She said, “When you’re done your break, let’s get them lined up along this wall here. Three rows. We’ll do a head count, then move on to the wildlife.”

Jess leaned forward to hear what she was saying better, to include herself in the plans. Carol kept talking, looking straight ahead at the kids in the theatre, starting to get up and move around. The film had ended and the side screens lit up now with some dazzling infographics about the Sun.

“And here,” she said, “this is the petition to reinstate the after-school music programs. Here’s a pen. Get her to do it too,” she said, thumbing over to Jess, then she rose and went back into the dark of the theatre.

Sara looked to Jess, her eyes wide, she laughed, “Uh-oh, somebody’s a little jealous.”

“Jealous of what?”

Sara winked at her.

“Oh. No...I think she hates me now. Not jealous, just...she thinks I’m a terrible person. She won’t even look at me.”

They all knew that she was living with Tyler. Probably all thought she was a terrible person. All the teachers knew that Pete was out of the house and that Tyler had moved in with her. Pretty Miss *Teacher of the Year* had shackled up with some stud kid who was ten years younger than her. Things had got a bit frosty around here. She knew they likely said a lot of nasty things about her behind her back.

One thing she would never cop to, as ridiculous as denying it sometimes sounded, was being the one caught with Tyler that day at the school. The one who had his big cock between her breasts. Nope, that wasn’t Jess. Some other blonde girl. Story she told: She and Pete took him into their home to help and it was Platonic, then somewhere along the way she fell for him. Nobody listened. She knew they all thought it was her getting dirty in his office. She would never, ever admit it. They could waterboard her.

Administratively, Tyler was in the high school’s past, and despite the rumours, she had never been called to bear on it. Tyler’s dismissal was long

gone and they weren't interested in getting to the bottom of the mystery of the slutty blonde girl. Probably most especially when that blonde girl might be one of the Department of Education's shining stars.

Still, the rumours remained.

"Miss Mapplethorpe, when are we going to see the otters?" Kevin and his friend Simon from Sara's class bounded up to her and he grabbed her wrist. The otters were the hands-down fan favourite. One of those constants you knew coming here with ninety kids; wear running shoes because there is a lot of walking, and save the otters to the end if you want to keep them all on their best behaviour.

"They're up next, Kevin, hold your horses," she laughed. "Show me that smile," she said.

He did, smiled a toothy kid grin. He had a temporary tooth in, looked good, it would do the trick until his adult teeth came in.

"Okay," he laughed, he squeezed her arm and then ran off. At least her kids were still behind her.

They were quiet a moment, then Sara said, "Is it nice, being with him? I don't mean in a dirty way, I mean...maybe I mean in a dirty way. It must be something..."

Jess didn't know how to answer without being gross. She didn't want to gush but she couldn't wait to tell her at the same time. "It is...very nice."

"Okay."

"Yup." She couldn't stop a smile growing across her face.

Sara scratched at her cheek, looking away, a smile spreading across her face now too.

Jess said, "Your friend was right."

"About—"

"Yeah."

"Really?"

"I can't even describe..."

"Say no more."

"Pete was pretty small."

She cocked her head, said, "Aw."

Jess looked out across the room at the kids out there. "Tyler's was quite something to get used to."

Sara winced, shook her head, said, "Too much, too much."

"Oh, I'm sorry."

“Yeah. Well, too much here,” she said, her face bright, drawing funny circles with her index fingers indicating this big educational space with all these children running around. “But over a bottle of wine? Then you can tell me whatever you want...”

“Sounds good.”

Sara got closer to her and she slipped an arm around her and hugged her.

Jess hissed and flinched, “Careful, my side’s sore.”

T Tyler said, “I’m going to miss you, buddy.”

“I’m...miss you too.” Little Andy’s eyes were wide and wet. Poor kid had been through an emotional wringer this month. *It’s all your own fault, Jess.*

Tyler was down on his knees and he had those thick, strong arms around her little five-year-old. Poor Andy. He wasn’t going to be alone this weekend, he was going to be with his dad, but this was a lot to take. He’d lost his dad, only saw him on weekends this last while, now he was going to lose his mom. He had to be so confused. She’d try and explain it to him when he seemed troubled, she was sure Pete did the same when he had them. How does a little boy brain make sense of such a huge change? *Fuck, Jess.*

Petey stood off to the side, waiting for his turn. He looked just as worried. Standing, on the verge of tears, his hands together in front of him, one foot over the other.

Tyler held Andy in one arm, opened the other for Petey, invited him in. “Come here, Petey, come on.” He hugged Petey to him too, Petey’s little arms went around Tyler’s big neck. “It’s just a couple extra days, guys, you’re gonna have fun with your dad.”

Petey said, “I know, you’re just so going so far away.”

“We’re not that far, Petey,” he said to him. “Just an hour and a bit by plane.”

“I don’t like planes.”

“Aw, Petey,” he laughed, “we’re going to be fine.” He shook the two of them gently in his arms, trying to cheer them up.

Jess wanted Tyler to say his good-byes now before Pete got here. Same when he would come pick them up on Friday nights. This had to be hard for her husband, he didn't need this in his face. Didn't need to see the new family living in his old house. She exhaled, blew the ghosts away.

"Okay, boys, your dad'll be here in about ten minutes. You sure you have everything?" She'd packed all their bags, knew they had the essentials. But favourite toys changed almost daily and it could be a big deal if something got left behind. Pete could, of course, just swing by and pick it up. Tyler had convinced her it would be better for Pete if he didn't stay here when they were gone. It might have made things easier, but he said it would be hard on Pete. He might root through their things, or, who knows? ...Do something crazy like throw all their stuff out if he got set off staying in his old house. It would have been better for the boys probably, just stay in their own home, but maybe Tyler had a point. It was just a few extra days, and they had such a good time with their dad at their Aunt Patty's.

"Yeah, mom," they both said, practically together, looking down at the floor while Tyler still held them.

Tyler squeezed them tight, let them go then and they stepped back, looking pretty morose. He said, "Babe, did you find my passport?"

"Yeah, I got it. I got you insurance too, I put them together. They're in your carry on."

"Okay. You sure I need a passport?"

"I don't think we do," she frowned, "rules just changed, I don't want to get some weird re-route or something and end up in a state that needs a passport."

He shrugged. "Okay, dudes, bring it in for a huddle." Pete and Andy came in and they all put their arms over each other's shoulders. He kissed them both on the forehead, one-two. He stood up, said, "Be good," and he headed for the kitchen. He turned, said to Jess, "You seen my sunglasses?"

"Packed. In your carry on."

He smiled to her, "Thanks, Jess."

"Oh, did you get to the snow fence today?"

"Ah shit, babe, no, sorry, I forgot."

"All right. It'll be okay, probably."

She squat down to her boys' level, called them to her now. They came in and hugged their mommy hard. "Unh, careful boys, you're getting so strong." She squeezed them back, said, "Like Tyler said, Be Good."

Pete sat in his car in the driveway of his home. What used to be his home. Everything inside him felt so heavy and resigned. Everything inside him desperately wanted to give up the fight. His body was weak and the weight inside him so black and heavy he could feel everything he had slumping, giving in to gravity, wanting to quietly pass away and leak out his asshole.

"You can do this, Pete," he whispered inside the old Buick with the duct tape over the stereo. "You can do this."

He got out and proceeded his Death March to the front door. It opened as he got there. She'd been watching, waiting. He hoped he looked stronger than he felt.

"Hi, Pete," she said quietly and she held the door open for him to come inside.

She looked so good. Maybe a little older than he remembered. He was the one who took all the force of this devastation in his marriage but there was a little splashback. She was his beautiful Jess still, but the toll of what she'd done showed on her face just the tiniest bit. He wanted to take away her hurt, then, on the exhale, he smiled thinking what it would be like for her to take the hurt a thousand times more.

"What are you smiling about?" she asked him.

"Oh, didn't realize I was."

"Andy, Petey," she called out to the kitchen. "Thanks again, Pete."

"I'd take my boys every day of the year if I could, Jess."

"I know you would, Pete. You're the best dad. I just mean thanks for not making this difficult. I wouldn't blame you if you did."

"Boys would suffer. They've suffered enough." He saw it. He'd got her. "Okay, boys!" he called out. They were already coming, headed down the stairs. He could see they were excited to see him and it made his heart swell.

“Dad!” Petey yelled and came to him. He hugged them, squeezed them tight.

“You guys ready for a big weekend? Your auntie has big plans...”

Petey nodded and hugged his dad’s neck.

“How about you, Andy?”

“I’m ready.”

“Good. If you got everything I think we should get going...”

“Hey, Pete?”

“Jess?”

“Uh...that last storm leaned the snow fence right back. The snow is crushing it. I’m worried those little cedars we planted aren’t going to be protected if another storm comes. Do you think it’ll be okay?”

“No storms forecast for the next few days.”

“Do you think you could come by, just prop it back up if there’s a storm coming?”

He looked at her there. His pretty wife. Her sweet face and her silky blonde hair and those big pale blue eyes that he could stare into forever. Ready to travel, her thin, toned legs showing off their gorgeous shape under her tight yoga pants, her big wooly socks over her perfect feet.

He said, “Hey, Petey?”

“Yeah, Dad?”

“Could you take Andy out to the car?”

“Sure, Dad.”

“Thanks, buddy. Get him in his car seat.”

Petey took his little brother down the driveway holding his hand.

Pete turned to Jess, looked down on her. “No.”

“No?”

“No, I can’t do that.”

“Pete, c’mon, I—”

“You want me to bring our boys to my sister’s. Don’t want me to stay in my own home with them while you’re gone. You want me to come back here and fix the fence that leaned over? On *my* time?”

“Pete—”

“Your He-Man can’t take care of that? Why doesn’t he do it?”

“But we’re leaving in—”

“Jess. No.” He held a hand up; *just stop speaking, Jess*. He shook his head, trying to shake away the tears he felt coming. *Fuck, Jess*.

“Jess, all the time I knew you, all the time I spent loving you, I could never have predicted this. I could never have seen you like this. I never, ever knew you were such a poisonous cunt.”

His words slapped her right in her face. She was stunned, her head quivered, her mouth hung open. Then she turned mad.

She pulled her open hand way back to hit him. Her eyes were wet, she was tearing up. She didn’t swing. He’d never seen her mad. Never saw her raise a hand, ever. *The truth hurts.*

He stood there ready to take it. He didn’t even flinch.

“Go ahead. Do it if you want. Everything you’ve done—you think that’s going to hurt?”

“Get out,” she whispered, her arm still held back.

“Go ahead if it’ll make you feel better.”

“Get out, Pete,” she said, a tear streamed down one cheek and it rolled over her delicate jaw and down her neck.

He turned his back to her, slammed the door behind him. Didn’t want her to have the chance to glower at him from the door as he backed away. Let her upset face ruin his weekend.

FLYING KITES

FRIDAY, FEBRUARY 10TH

Pete took Friday off. After his run, after a nice warm breakfast with Patty, Russ, and the kids, he let them go off to work. He made himself a ham sandwich, put it in a Ziploc bag, gathered his things together. He drove the kids to school and got Andy to Daycare. He needed a day to himself too.

He stopped at the Dunkin' Donuts drive-thru, got himself a large coffee and then headed out to the 270, the big wide highway that helped him bypass the city, then got on the 23, Portsmouth-Columbus Road, heading south. It was nice and quiet this time of the morning. The 23 was a peaceful two-laner, two lanes south, two lanes north. Well-ploughed, everyone going at a good steady pace. It was a pretty grim looking day out there, wintry but dry, not too cold. Here it was, ten in the morning, and it was so dark and scary out it looked like the sun was setting.

He drove in quiet. He was going to get the radio fixed but he figured maybe it was just time to trade the Buick in. See what he could get for it without a radio. He enjoyed the quiet anyway. It let him think. The rubber hiss off the road put him at ease.

About a half hour later he had to pull off at Circleville and he found a McDonald's. He parked and ran in and dropped a quick number two. That second coffee of the morning really doing the trick. He snuck out without buying anything, got back on the 23 heading south.

After Chillicothe the 23 became the 35 but if you didn't look at the signs you wouldn't know it. He started to feel a little sleepy after an hour and a half and he turned the defroster off of the hot setting. That warm air

buffeting his face felt nice but after his run this morning it could lull him right to sleep.

Somehow he made it without dozing off. Two and a half hours on the road from Columbus and now he could see it. He was at the Ohio River. He could see it in the distance, wide and brown at this point even in February. On the other side was West Virginia. He could see the changing landscape on the horizon. It was getting rockier here, the terrain rolling and wooded. Less snow, which was nice, the roads just wet.

He made a right onto a country road called the 380, should take him through the heart of the Queen City Wildlife Area. He was just about forty-five minutes from his destination. The 380 was a narrow, tough, winding road that ran through rugged, rolling hills. It would climb high, then suddenly dive-bomb down, rattle over a rickety old bridge that crossed a fast-flowing stream. The sides of the road were densely wooded, a thick evergreen forest. Just a dusting of snow in its needles, branches reaching right out over the road. Then the forest would be gone for miles. Vast stretches cleared, scraped away, only the remnants of a surface-mining operation left on a rocky patch.

It was somewhere along there—maybe halfway through the Reserve, where the asphalt climbed and climbed—that he turned the old Buick at a crest. The road dropped away in another dive into the spire treetops. The sky stopped him, literally made his eyes go wide. He pulled over.

He'd never seen anything like it. Couldn't believe he was witnessing it.

He grabbed his sandwich off the passenger seat, got out of the car and went and sat on the hood. Took his wool hat out of his coat pocket and pulled it down over his ears.

The sky was low, a chaotic mottled grey—steely blue-greys, ochre-greys, green-greys, twisting and writhing above the blackened tips of the high pines and spruces. It was roiling. The sky was moving in swirls all around him like he was witnessing it being painted in thick heavy oils by an unseen hand holding an unseen brush.

He opened the baggie and took a bite out of his sandwich. Sat there for a good while shivering and eating, the sky dancing low around him.

He couldn't leave things loose anymore. Everything needed to be tightened up. Batten down the hatches as you might say. There was always a storm coming. *There was always one.* If you left something loose the

wind would take it, rip it away, leave everything you had, everything you loved, vulnerable.

Nip it in the bud, Julio had said.

He was right. *Don't let things go*, Pete.

Last time he saw Michael—saw him when he was alive—he'd stood in their bedroom, healthy enough in the moment to taunt him. He didn't remember what it was about, Michael wanted him to do something but he couldn't recall what it was. It was hazy. Hazy because it was unimportant.

His mind had held on to the moment Michael put his bare foot on his pristine Pitt Issue #1 (in mint condition) that he had stupidly, carelessly left out of its bag on the floor between the two beds in the room he shared with his brother. He could picture Mike saying to him, *Do it*. Pete said he would, he would, just don't wreck it. Then Mike did anyway. Michael was a bully. A bully of the highest order. Some of the things...didn't like to think of it. But he loved him. He was his brother.

Michael took a wicked turn in the next week. A bout of pneumonia. Then he was hospitalized.

Pete could have gone to visit him, but he would look at that comic, still on the floor. He'd imagine his brother's bare toes scrunch up slowly, deliberately, his damp skin getting a good bite on the clayed paper, bunching up the centre of the cover until it was absolutely ruined. He didn't go to the hospital. Michael had been in the hospital before, and this time, Pete was really mad. One afternoon he got home from school and his dad was there, not still at work like he should be. He held his hand and told him his brother had died. He was devastated. He loved Michael. He should have been bigger.

Who gives a fuck about a dumb old comic book?

But only the passing of time and the tragic loss could ever put that juncture in perspective.

He crumpled up his sandwich baggie, tucked it into his pocket, took his phone out. He took a deep breath, looked out over the sky. It had gone placid. That weird wonderful moment had passed.

He texted.

Pete: Jess, honey, I'm so sorry for what I said...

First thing Jess saw when she opened her eyes was a gently swaying palm tree against a brilliant blue sky. She could even hear the fronds rustling in the breeze through the open window.

“Oh, thank God,” she whispered.

She lay on her side in the motel bed, just a crisp white sheet over her folded up legs it was so warm. They'd come in very late last night. A red eye that brought them into Tampa at about one in the morning. They didn't check into the motel until 2:30. There was a cute little lizard in the dark on their door step. Straight to bed. Too tired for hanky-panky after all the travel. They had five days, might as well get some rest before they kick it off. She was going to make the most out of every moment they had here.

She sat up and looked around the little room filled with joyous, low, early morning sunshine. The room felt warm and hazy and orange. She stretched. Tyler was next to her, laying flat on his stomach his big arms up on the pillow on either side of his head. The sheets were down to the middle of his back and she looked carefully at the drawings on his arm. The dragons, waves, the state of Pennsylvania, FSU (didn't he go to Albright?), a bunch of American emblems. She drew along the scaled, finned tail of a dragon. Traced it as it curled up along his hard tricep, over the sharp ridge where his big, round shoulder bulged. The dragons were her favourite. Her finger slipped off the tip of the dragon's tail, into an un-inked landscape. This was uncharted territory, a no man's land, waiting to be claimed. She bent and kissed him. Felt his hard back under her soft lips, brushed them along the bulging cords and knots under his skin. She was in the mood.

She slowly pulled the sheet down while he still slept. Lower and lower. No briefs? She kept going until the sheet was gently climbing up that hard sexy rump of his. He *was* naked. She'd gone to bed in just her panties and a T-shirt. She didn't see him climb in, just put her arm over his back and fell asleep in about thirty seconds. He was a dirty bird. She let it slip lower, down the curve of his ass where it met his thigh, then along his thighs, lower and lower. He was beautiful. She climbed on board. Straddled him like she was riding a horse bareback. Threw a leg over his waist and put her

little rump against his. She bent again, pressed her lips to the deep valley that ran between the slabs of muscle under his cannonball shoulders. Kissed her way up to his neck, kissed at his hairline. He stirred. She smiled.

Her thumbs dug into his muscles, kneaded them, felt their density, their strength. He was a solid, hard mass. He groaned. She sat upright, dug them in, working them like she thought might feel good. He made sounds like it was working. Lower and lower, her hands gave him pleasure, sending some pretty nice signals back to her too. Her fingers very much liked what they were doing.

“Mm-morning,” he grumbled, his pretty boy lips in a misaligned pout. She wanted to gobble up those lips.

“Good morning,” she whispered, very sexy-like.

He laughed underneath her, and the firm feel of him moving below her, set her to tingle. She pressed her mound into his back, let her hips gyrate on him. Her lips went to his back again, kissed, then she let her body fall against him. She pressed herself to him, hugged him tight with her arms as best she could.

“We’re going to have so much fun today, baby.”

“Mm.”

Back to kissing, working her lips against his warm skin. She kissed lower and lower, up now on all fours. She bit his rump very gently. He laughed. She bit him again.

“Mm—ow. Hey.”

She gave him a little sorry kiss on his bare round cheek. Her hands came up, explored him, enjoyed the sexy feel of him under her palms. She bit and licked him, scratched his perfect boy-rump. She ran her tongue in big friendly circles over his skin. She could feel him tremble and jump.

“Ticklish?” she asked him.

“A little,” he mumbled.

Her tongue ran across a cheek towards the centre, then down along his crack. That really made him jolt. He was laughing up on the pillow.

She clenched his hard cheeks with her claws, pulled them apart gently. Her tongue licked up the middle, not too deep, just testing the waters.

“Jess,” he exclaimed quietly.

She giggled. His legs slowly parted for her.

She pulled his cheeks wider, let her tongue probe deeper. He was clean, but wow, was he hot in there. Hot and kind of bitter, coppery. She tickled at

his little asshole with the tip of her tongue.

“Jesus, Jess,” he laughed, and couldn’t help himself—his body jumped away.

“Are you ticklish?”

“Yes,” he said. “Man, you are so bad.”

“I know.” She kissed the backs of his thighs. That made him tremble too. She got herself to the side of him. Wanted to get a little deeper. Her tongue slid up the inside of his thigh, tickled its way up until her nose bumped the back of his scrotum. She kissed that now. That really made him jump.

She let her tongue slide all over it, push his big balls around inside his bag, left and right up and down. She even bit at it a little bit.

“Hey, Tyler?”

“Yeah?”

“Where you hiding that thing? All I see is balls back here.”

He laughed a little, said, “I’m laying on it.”

She slid a hand up alongside his balls, moving underneath his body.

“Which side?”

“Uhh...to the right,” he said and he lifted his hips up off the bed a bit for her. She found it going sideways across his hip on the right. Not hard yet, but it was on its way. She took it, pulled it straight down between his legs, his balls draped over it.

“Mm, I found it,” she told him. Made him laugh with that.

She bent between his legs and kissed the underside of it. Kissed that little cleft on the bottom side of his fat cock head, took her tongue and slid it up and down that crease. He moaned. She kissed her way up the underside of his shaft until her nose was into his balls again. Then kissed her way back to the tip.

“Oh, Jess,” he moaned, a chuckle breaking it up.

He was getting firmer under her tongue. Her thumb went under it and she lifted it off the bed a bit so she could slip his glans inside her mouth. She sucked him inside, swirled her tongue around and around. Sucked and released, let him hear that suction pop. She went on and on, kissing his shaft, tickling his tip with her tongue, sucking and stroking a little until she had him very hard. She got up on her knees, sat her rump back on her heels and looked at it between his legs from this angle. Her new man with his unbelievable body, legs slightly spread, his manhood hard, laying on the

bed almost halfway down his thighs. His handsome face turned sideways on the pillow.

“Come on Tyler, you’re awake now, roll over for me, baby.” Her neck was getting sore.

“You ready?”

“For what?”

He sleepily turned himself over, but his eyes were on hers, watching her.

He rolled onto his back slowly. His long, hard cock wagged straight out then fell on its side across his hip. He rolled over and put his arms up under his head, tucked them under the white cotton pillow. He was absolutely ripped.

“Oh my God, Tyler, what have you done?” she laughed. She covered her mouth with her hands, let him see her excitement. Played it up, but, yeah, she really was excited.

“Surprise. I got peeled for the trip.”

He looked like he had no body fat. Zero. She could see every separated slab that made up his abs. Muscles that went from his abs to his ribs, muscles on his ribs. Veins ran up from his groin and slipped in between the ridges of his midsection, disappearing somewhere.

“You like?” he said to her.

“You are gorgeous,” she said.

“Chicken, fish, and greens, for like three weeks now.”

“Uh-huh,” she was admiring.

“I know how you like it, babe. God, hardest part was keeping it from you.”

“Oh, Tyler, your body...” she said and she got on all fours and crawled over him, got her face over his chest and kissed him there, then worked down. She gave him the same treatment she gave his backside but kissing his sexy front had got her plenty aroused. Downright horny. Hornier. She kissed and felt, bit her way down him until the tip of that big dick was under her chin.

“Mm, Tyler, you’re so perfect,” she said.

“You are s—oh, man,” he gasped as her tongue slid quickly from the tip of his penis down his shaft and between his balls.

His balls went into her mouth, just one at a time, played with them in there. Her hand stroked his shaft, her thumb made circles over the hole. She

got him hard as a rock.

“Oh, wait, Jess,” he said, “please, baby, take that shirt off, show it to me again.”

She sat back on her haunches, smiled for him, seductively. She folded her arms up, grabbed the bottom of the T-shirt and pulled it up over her head. She let him see her bare chest, loved to feel his approving eyes on her. She inhaled, filled herself up, said, “How does it look?”

“Oh Jess, very sexy, baby,” he said, and he softly touched under her breast with his fingers.

She’d gone with him, maybe after a few too many drinks in the city, and he convinced her to get a tattoo. She got the phrase ‘Live Free,’ like Tyler’s knuckles. Done in a very feminine, swooping calligraphic font over her ribs just under her right breast. It hurt like the dickens for a while but it was mostly healed up now. It wasn’t red or raw anymore.

Tyler said, “Jess you look so amazing right now. This light...”

He leaned to the bedside table and grabbed his phone, “Jessy, let me get a picture of you.” He flicked through screens getting to his camera.

“I don’t know, Tyler...”

“Don’t you want to see how pretty you look?”

She giggled, “No.”

“Please, Jess.”

“Not my face.”

“Baby...”

“Not my face. That’s the kind of thing that gets a girl like me fired.”

“You’re already on thin ice, aren’t you?” he said, smiling at her slyly. He snapped a picture.

“Tyler!” She was mad. She hit his stomach with the bottom of her fist.

He was laughing. “Jess, Jess, I swear, your face isn’t in it.”

“Are you sure?”

“Come see,” he said. He was looking at his phone. She lay next to him, pressed up against his side.

“See?” he said and he showed her the screen.

Her face wasn’t in it. Just her breasts, her tummy, the tops of her thighs. It put her on fire seeing herself like that. It kind of made her feel a little crazy inside. A good crazy. She looked really nice in that picture. The way the sun came in the room and played on her—she looked really nice.

“Hold on,” she said, rolled and got her glasses from the table next to the bed. She looked again.

“I like it,” she said reluctantly.

He turned his head to her, said, “I want to film us together.”

“Doing what?” she said dubiously.

“Making love.”

“Tyler...”

“Look how good you look, Jess. No faces.”

She wanted to. She wanted to be talked into it—but she knew she would do it. Knew she wanted to before he even asked.

“How?” she asked him quietly. Her hand snuck across his hard belly and grabbed his cock, lightly stroked it.

“Whatever you want, Jess.”

She watched her hand on him, looked at his wonderful cock in her grip. Watched that little hole in his big tip winking at her as she went up and down him.

She slipped her panties off, sat up and made her way to his hips, kept her back to him, faced his feet. She gripped one of his thighs and turned her head over her shoulder, told him, “Okay.”

She heard the ding that he was recording. She took his cock in her hand and she guided the tip between her legs. Worked her hips on it, back and forth, getting him wet from her. She was soaking. Then she held him steady and she slowly sat back on him, let him sink inside her. Once he was in, her other hand came back, gripped his other thigh. Her head fell forward as she felt his awesome size push her apart. “Aungh,” she moaned-gasped. “Mm,” *fuck, could you recognize that sound as her on a dirty video?* She didn’t care right now. He felt so good inside her. Painfully large at first, his entry always consumed her, rushed all her attention to the feeling between her legs. Feeling forced apart, claimed. There was no ignoring his presence. He had her full attention.

“Ah, baby,” she sighed, keeping it to a whisper, keeping her voice out of it.

She felt the camera’s eye on her. She put on a show.

Jess did all the work. Sliding her rump up and down, shaking and wagging from side to side. Letting his big thing almost come right out and then bouncing down hard again on her young lover. Tyler kept himself quiet. He didn’t ruin it by worrying her with his voice in the video, or

worse, actually moaning her name. He let her work, let her make them both feel good.

She folded her feet up over his hip bones, got complete control of his thing inside her. Now she could shorten her thrusts down his shaft, fuck him more forcefully. Her girl muscles squeezed him and sucked on his tip as she let him almost fall out of her. Then she would thrust back and down, take him deeper, hear him groan. She wagged and swayed, bounced and dipped, brought him right to the edge. His grunts were quick and desperate now. She wanted to look over her shoulder, see that handsome face with the parted lips. See him close his eyes as he shot himself inside her. She loved to watch him come. He made her feel so good.

She felt the tremors in his legs as his big balls started to send their generous contents forward. His fluids charging through tubes, spiralling through all sorts of organic delivery systems; his cock flexed and surged. He pulled out of her, guiding her rump forward with one big hand. His hot, wet seed landed up her back, bubbled and spurted from him, and she felt its heat spread across her bare ass. Tyler muted his pleasure, bit his lips and grunted. He splashed and splashed, and she had to suck her own lips into her mouth to stop herself from gasping out his wonderful name.

His phone dinged as he stopped recording. She glanced over her shoulder at him, saw him with his head turned, his eyes closed. His phone was clenched face down on his chest, clutched in his hand. She laughed and giggled, wiggled her butt against his hot cock that she could still feel pressed against the soft flesh of her cheeks.

“Oh-ho, oh baby,” she said.

She could feel him laugh himself back to life underneath her, his body shaking with happiness. He gently slapped his tool against her bare ass.

“Oh, Jess,” he said, “you are so wicked.”

She turned, lowered herself to his hard belly. She kept his eyes on his and snarled for him. She found a white splash on his stomach and she ran her tongue to it. She swallowed it up, then, with her pouted lips, kissed her way along his unbelievably hard belly. She collapsed in the crook of his arm, rested her head against his shoulder. She could feel his semen turning cold on the skin of her back. She pulled a sheet up, touched it back there to take it away, Tyler pressed it to her and helped her dry herself. She did a happy, slinky waggle against his naked body while he did.

“Let’s see it,” she said.

His chin touched the top of her head and he held her to him while he put the phone out where they both could watch. His thumb worked the screen, found its way to play the video back for them.

It was very strange to see herself like that. Just her rump, her hand holding his hard cock. Wow, he was big. Then her hand playing his tip against her folds, you could hear their wet sounds played back through the tinny phone speakers. The light was dim so she couldn't get much detail of what she looked like when it was sinking inside her, but she had to admit it was hot watching that thing disappear inside her body. It was very dirty. More dirty than she had expected.

She watched herself try and be sexy, wag her butt for the camera with Tyler's cock inside her. She giggled and covered her mouth.

"That's what it looks like?"

"Oh, mm-hmm," Tyler grunted.

She could see her bare feet come up, her toes curl up as she flexed and tried to get control of him. "Aw, look how tiny my feet are. Oh, it makes my ass look kind of big..."

"Are you fucking kidding. You are so fucking sexy."

"Am I?"

"You're perfect, babe," he said and kissed the top of her head.

She looked up into his eyes, ran her hand over his forehead and scratched her fingers through his thick hair.

"Look, Jess," he said, eyes still on the screen.

She watched again. It got uglier. She leaned forward in the video, that big thing spread her opening wide. She saw her pink girl parts skewered for the first time. She covered her mouth, gasped, "That's my—oh!"

"That is. That's your cute little asshole," he laughed.

"Oh, turn it off," she gasped and she put her palm over the screen.

He was shaking her with his laughing, pulling his hand away so he could still watch. Her hand chased after it, tried to block his view. "Oh, Tyler don't, that's terrible."

"Jess," he laughed, "I see it every day."

She hugged him, put her arm around his big chest, looked away from the phone. "It's awfully dirty."

"That's what Pete watched all the time," he said, still laughing.

Pete watched that?

Her Petey watched her like that. That was what he saw.

She could feel the smile fade from her face, she went blank. Pete watched her do that. He wanted it, but it wasn't what she thought. It wasn't as sexy as she thought. It was ugly.

"Jess, look. Don't you want to watch me come?"

"I've seen you come. A lot," she said, trying to buoy her spirits. She turned her face to the screen in time to see his cock erupt over her skin. The video was shaky. She watched it with him to the end. Saw the last of his spurts land on her flesh. He shut it down, tossed it aside into the sheets. His hand came up to her waist and he held her against him now with both arms.

Jess said, "Did you ever taunt him?"

"Pete?"

She nodded, her chin digging into his chest.

"No. Taunt him how?"

"I don't know. If you did, that was mean."

"I didn't. I swear. I like Pete. What did he say?"

"He said you teased him. Told him you were going to take me away from him."

"I did, didn't I?"

She kissed the skin of his chest, still stared across the room at the swaying palm tree against the sunny sky.

She bounded up, got out of bed. "Let's go."

"Where?" he said, laying flat on the bed still, looking spectacular without a single thing on.

She put her hands on her hips, stood naked in front of him, said, "Out of here. Let's get some breakfast. I need to go outside. Please, let's go do something outside." She just needed some sunshine right now.

The High School for Queen City wasn't even in Queen City. Queen City, in fact, wasn't even a city.

Pete was still on the 380, coming into a stretch lined with poorly tended houses, a Dollar General, a Wesleyan Church, an auto mechanic, and an abandoned low bungalow factory that used to be a dairy. That was it, that was Queen City as far as he could tell. Then he took a side-road that after about a ten-minute drive ended up in an enclave. A little community made

up of small, square clapboard bungalows. Probably miner's homes, back when this place was hopping, mines mostly drying up about thirty years ago now.

That's where he found South Guyan High School. It was a tall, ochre-brick block. The 'U' in Guyan was missing where the name was spelled across its faceless wall. Pete thought the place could have been abandoned if it weren't for all the cars in the parking lot. The pavement was cracked, weeds left from the fall had frozen in place. A snowy, disused railway ran alongside the parking lot and then around behind the school, beyond the football field. It was about what he'd expected, maybe a little worse. This was practically Appalachia.

He looked at his own reflection, looked into his own eyes, twisting the rearview down so he could see himself.

"What are you doing?" he said. "I don't know, man," he answered himself.

He fished a laminated card out of his pocket that he'd printed up at work. It was a square ID, about four inches by four, his photo in the corner, the Save-Mart logo in the other corner. Under his name, and a UPC code that didn't mean anything, was the vague but descriptive title he'd given himself: Investigator. It was on a lanyard and he hooped it over his head. He unbuttoned his jacket, grabbed a zippered binder off the front seat that was filled with a bunch of unrelated Save-Mart reports. He headed to the front door.

Inside, the school was just like any other school. Sure a little run down, a little dirty, but there were happy kids in it and it showed that they liked it there. Hand drawn posters in the high-ceiling lobby about an upcoming dance, a banner ran overhead, said, Country Pride, in letters done in markers made up to look like camouflage.

Their Administrative area was behind some glass wall on his left and he made his way over. He walked through the doorway and laid out his binder on the reception desk, took his hat off and put it in his pocket. There were only two women in there, both quite similar. Short and heavy, both wearing sweatshirts to work. They were separated in age by about twenty years.

The younger one looked up, got out from her desk and came to the counter. She had stringy blond hair, no makeup.

"Can I help you?" she said. Her voice was pleasant which was a surprise because her face looked like she wouldn't be.

“Well, maybe,” he said. “One second,” he urged her while he flipped through some of the Save-Mart pages that meant nothing. “Uhhh...” he hesitated, pretending to read something. Finally, he looked up at her, gave her a big smile, said, “Hi, I’m Pete Mapplethorpe and I’m from Save-Mart.” He presented the ID to her, let it dangle from the lanyard.

“The store?” she said, her face scrunched up. She read the ID. “Oh.”

Never said he was an investigator. Said he was from Save-Mart. Someone complained, they’d never find this ID anyway. It’ll be in the garbage. He’d say this lady couldn’t read right. Might need glasses.

“Yeah, so, I’m looking into a...” looking down at meaningless reports again, “Tyler MacKenzie...”

“Tyler?” her face brightened.

The older woman looked up now, watching them through her glasses.

“You know him?”

“He’s okay? He’s not...in any trouble is he?” she got quiet.

“Don’t know him,” he said. “He might be a victim of fraud. His name keeps coming up on...well, it’s complicated. I’m just trying to track down the real Tyler MacKenzie, make sure he exists. It’s been a bit slippery trying to find him.”

“The real...oh, Lord. Come here,” she said.

She walked down the long counter and crossed over to his side, waved him to follow her. She stopped at a glass cabinet and he stood next to her, looked inside. There were trophies and photos, footballs, and jerseys. Mementos going back to the 1960s it looked like. Back when the high school football coach wore a suit.

“You guys like your football,” he said.

“We sure do. Look right there,” she said and he followed her finger to a picture of a football team. Bunch of skinny teenagers in their jerseys and shoulder pads. Right in the middle of them all, a smiling, happy, familiar face.

“That guy in the middle?” she said, “that right there, mister, is a very real Tyler MacKenzie.”

Pete nodded. “He exists,” he said quietly.

“Boy, don’t he?”

“Well, what can you tell me about him?”

“Those boys loved him. He was about the greatest gym teacher we had around here in a very long while. We didn’t win that year, but he built us a

better team. Hey, if you see him, you tell him we only lost four this year?"

"He hasn't been in touch at all?"

"No. He up and quit last year over the summer. No, two years now, I guess. We all miss him desperately around here."

"He wasn't ever in any trouble?"

"Trouble? No, sir. He was never any trouble."

"You know why he quit?"

She thought a moment. "No. Never said. Or I never heard. I usually hear everything, you know. Nah, he just didn't come back in September, said he was moving. You know, you look at him...how long was he going to stay out here in the middle of nowhere, right?"

He sighed. "Yeah." They both stood upright again, walked back to the reception.

Pete zipped up his imitation leather binder. Didn't even know why he'd driven all the way down here. Thought a moment, said, "Any known acquaintances?"

"Friends?" she said.

"Yeah, how about girlfriends?"

"Well, just about all the girls wanted to know him better, see if they could catch his eye. But, no, he didn't see anybody."

"So, you're telling me he was just an all-around great guy?"

"Pretty much. Any of us at the school would vouch for him, I swear."

What a weird way to spend a day. What a strange thing for him to have done. How Hitchcockian. What was he even expecting? What did he think he was going to find?

"Thank you for your time," he said, impossible to hide the disappointment in his voice. He left through the double doors and shuffled to the Buick.

He'd headed out this morning so invigorated. He had a mission. He had something to do. In an odd way, he did it so he could spend the day with his Jess. This was for her. Even hundreds of miles apart he wanted to feel like he was a part of her life.

He got in, did up his seatbelt, started it up. Someone was waving to him. He went to wave back. Realized he didn't know anybody here. He squinted. It was the older woman from reception. Coming through the front doors, waving, walking off the curb and coming out to the car. He did the window down.

“Hey, sir,” she said, out of breath from the cold and hustling fifty yards.

“Yes?”

“You’re looking for Tyler MacKenzie? I hear that?”

“Yeah. You know him?”

“I have a friend who did. Sort of. I think he might want to talk to you.”

“You do?”

“Want me to call him?”

“Yeah, please.”

She took her phone, punched in some numbers, held it to her soft face; she smiled to Pete warmly. Then she turned away to talk, but Pete could still hear her.

“Hey, Mark? It’s Allison, down at the school...well, hey...not too bad...uh-huh...and you?...oh, yeah?...really...so, I have a man came by here to the desk and he was looking for Tyler MacKenzie...I know...said he’s from Save-Mart...I don’t know...collections?...didn’t say...you would?...hold on,” she put the phone to her stomach, said, “Yeah, he would talk to you.”

Pete nodded.

She got back on and she talked a while with him, talked about a lot more than Tyler. Then she put her phone against herself said, “Can you meet him tomorrow?”

Shoot. “I’m only here today.”

Allison got back with Mark and she talked a while longer. He didn’t know how she could stand out in the cold like that, he wanted to ask her if she wanted to sit in the car with him. The lower curve of her glasses had frosted up. She hung up.

She leaned into the open window of the car, said, “If you want to meet him he’ll be at Muncie’s Tavern tomorrow from twelve til two. It’s on the 218 just as you get into Asheville. On the right-hand side. It’s just twenty minutes south of here if you go back to Queen City and take the 380 south a bit.”

“I don’t know,” he said. Should he do it? Was it healthy or was this getting crazy?

“He’ll be there whether you are or not, so don’t fret it. He’s away today, then he works the overnight shift tonight. Do you have a card? I’ll give him your number...”

“No, that’s all right.”

Allison looked around a bit, said kind of quietly, “He looked into Tyler too.”

“Can you give me *his* number?”

“Just call the Asheville Police Department, ask for Lt. Mark Draper.”

Seventy-three and sunny beat anything Ohio could muster in a February.

They were on the south side of St. Pete’s Beach, on Gulf Boulevard, a motel right on the water. The Bel-Aire, a flat-roof Modern bungalow, probably been serving vacationers for eighty years. She liked the slanted windows at the tiny check-in, the way everything was painted white except for a pale yellow racing stripe that ran around the whole main entrance. It felt like it was from another time; if no one had their smartphones out you could imagine this was the fifties. And at \$163 a night, plus one free night, it was in the budget.

So far today they’d done nothing. She had wanted to take advantage of her time away. This was taking advantage though, wasn’t it? This was making the best of it. Doing nothing is exactly what she came here to do. So far today she had fucked Tyler, had a big brunch, laid on the beach, read part of a book and napped. This really was taking advantage of her time away.

Now she was sitting on a lounge on the patio, had turned it slightly away from the pool so she could look out past her hot pink painted toenails at the beach and the gulf beyond. She still felt full from their brunch, like her stomach even stuck out a little. They’d walked down the beach when they got up until they found a restaurant that looked interesting. It was great, just the kind of place she wanted. Raised up from the sand on sun-bleached decking, a grass-roofed hut that served them eggs and bacon and waffles out on the patio in the sunshine, protected a bit under some low palms. She was so hungry after her morning ‘exercise’. Now she was full. She ran her hands over her rounded bare tummy. She’d got a little sun, she could see her white skin starting to redden a bit. She moved the straps of her bikini top to reduce the chance of a tan line there. Her skin took the sun

well and she hoped she'd come back with some nice colour even if they were only here for five days and it was February.

Tyler was coming back to her, turning heads as he went. He'd gone back to the room to bring them some drinks. They weren't licensed here, didn't have any poolside service at all but you could bring out things from your room. Tyler went back to get some orange juice, splash some vodka in it for them. Here he was, walking back across the patio. He wasn't wearing speedos, but he kind of might have well been. He had tight swim shorts on that went down his thighs a bit, but you could see that he had a lot between his legs. And his body had everyone watching, even the husbands. He screamed sex; out loud at the top of his lungs. She wanted everyone's eyes to follow him, see him end up on the white vinyl lounge pressed right up next to hers. She wanted them all to know that was hers. That veritable tattooed-sex-God had chosen her as his mate. Deal with it, ladies. I ain't half bad either, you ask me.

A smile broke her face, a warm and very happy feeling washed over her as he sat down next to her. There was a young mom about her own age watching. Behind sunglasses but her head had tracked him right to where he was now. She was all right looking, pale and brunette, still recovering from a baby-body. Her doughy husband looked over too. She dared a smile to them. You should see how good we look when we fuck. Well, not my dirty bits, that looks a little weird. But our bodies? God, *his* body.

"Mm, kiss me, Tyler," she said, for show and for warmth.

Tyler closed his eyes, leaned in and pressed his lips to hers, handed her a plastic hotel cup filled with OJ.

She took a sip. "Wow, that's strong," she said. He smiled under his black sunglasses.

Tyler put his drink on the ground, turned his back to her, said, "Babe, can you do my back?"

With pleasure. She got the suntan lotion and squirted some liberally into her hand, then swiped it across his hard shoulders and neck.

"What do you want to do tonight?" he said, his head turned to the side.

She worked the lotion over his skin, looked at her own hand moving across him. "Go out for dinner?"

"Sounds good. You wanna go dancing?"

"Mm. Maybe tomorrow. I'm still in the mood to just chill out. We'll eat late. Want to walk on the beach or something. Watch the sunset?"

“Anything you want, Jess,” he said, turned away now watching the water. The wind tugged at his thick hair.

She watched his handsome profile, his strong jaw, his defined cheekbones, that strong brow. “Hey, let’s go to a club tomorrow night, okay?”

“Yeah,” he said into the breeze. “Thank, babe,” he said, about the lotion. He lay back down next to her. She squirted some more oil into her hand, put a little dollop on his chest, snapped the lid closed. She ran her palms together, looking at his beautiful body. He was so lean. He’d done that for her. Just to light her eyes up. Just to turn her on, make her feel crazier when they made love. It was working. She put her hands on him, rubbed the lotion on his front. Her soft girl hands going all over his rock hard muscles. She was rubbing his front. He could rub his own front, but she wanted to do this. She knew she was being watched. Yeah, this was blatantly sexual. But if a woman rubbed lotion on her husband most people wouldn’t think twice about it. She’d seen it already today. Wife even rubbed her husband’s front. Husband didn’t look like this though. Tyler was all sex. Everything about him would make you think about it. This right now, what she was doing, was practically a sexual act in public. She wasn’t entirely sure, but she thought she might have got herself a bit wet from it. Her hands went lower, over his chiselled mid-section. He looked like what you would see in a movie. Her hands went self-consciously low, below his belly button. The tips of her fingers swept just a hair under his waistband.

“Okay,” she said, stopped herself. She rubbed her hands over her knees, got rid of the excess lotion, lay back on her lounge. The two of them now elbow to elbow looking out over the Gulf. She let her eyes close and felt the heat on her. It felt amazing. Exactly what she needed. Maybe she was one of those people who could suffer from a Vitamin D deficiency. Maybe she had Seasonal Affective Disorder. She napped.

When she awoke her hand subconsciously went for her phone. She picked it up, knew what she would see.

Pete: Jess, honey, I’m so sorry for what I said...

Now there was more. Four brief messages. She scrolled quickly past, didn’t want to read them. She saw the keywords anyway as they flicked by.

Sorry. Love. Hurt. Crazy. She threw the phone back down to a towel on the lounge, down at her hip. Where she couldn't reach it easily.

His words had stung. *Poisonous cunt*. He'd never had a harsh word for her once in all the time they'd lived together. Men before him had. Bad boyfriends, her failed engagement. Men could be awful. No one was as awful as her though, were they?

Pete wanted the hurt. He thrived on the suffering she thought. What piece of her got off on it though? What piece of her wanted to punish him, and why? How could she have done those things?

She'd deserved his scorn. Didn't she? She would hate to itemize the hurt she'd delivered to him. She hated him right now; the sting of his words leaving a symbolic red hand on her cheek. But she didn't *hate* him. She'd never hated him.

Did she resent something? She didn't resent getting pregnant. Maybe Tyler's presence made her realize she wasn't young anymore. That there was fun that she didn't have. But that wasn't Pete's fault.

Pete *wanted* her to have fun. He'd always wanted that. She looked over at Tyler sitting next to her. The sun glistened on his skin, lighting up the hard edges of the muscles he'd worked so hard to reveal to her. Pete had practically given Tyler to her.

It was amazing. Those harsh moments that had transpired a thousand miles from here in the dark rooms of the small home they shared seemed so demented now. So cold and distant. She couldn't believe they'd ever happened. The world was such a big beautiful place. Or it could be at least. The sky above her was infinite, deep and blue. The sun's heat made her feel happy and nurtured. Birds soared above her, a gentle breeze caressed her.

There was a man running on the beach, stumbling along in a heavy, non-athletic gait. A friendly, big-boned German man they'd seen at breakfast. He was running clumsily through the sand in his Birkenstocks with a kite in his grip, trying to get enough speed to launch it. His little boy walked in the other direction, running out line. The mother sat in the sand and watched them. You didn't need to run like that. Pete could have told them how to do it. You just needed a little tension on the line and the wind would do the work for you. She brushed a tear from her cheek.

Tyler heard her sniff and he turned. "You okay, Jess?"

"Yes. Just miss my boys," she said.

"Won't be long, boo-boo," he said.

She smiled weakly. "I know. Doesn't mean I don't miss them..."

"We'll be back in just a few days. Practically not much longer than when Pete takes them." He was looking out over the Gulf behind his shades. "Cheer up, babe."

She'd like him to just let her miss them. He meant well. But she enjoyed feeling how terrible it was for them to be so far from her. She wanted to think about them even if it hurts.

WORTHY

SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 11TH

This was one strange day.

Pete stood out front of Muncie's Tavern. It looked like a whiskey-faded dump; sitting on the outskirts of town where serious drinkers would spend their time. Two cars in the parking lot, a dinged up Pontiac and a Suburban, plus his Buick now. Parking was a small, cracked pavement patch between an auto wrecker and a vacant office space where a private realtor once had been. A metal sign out front had faded where his name had been stuck on with adhesive vinyl then peeled off, probably when he went bankrupt.

He pushed the glass door open by its slanted aluminum handle, felt like he was stepping into a crime novel. He drove three hours again this morning just to come here—to find what?

The place looked empty. One lone drinker at the bar. It was just after lunch time.

He approached the guy hunched over the bar with his elbows on the brass rail. He was a worn out looking sort of guy with bags under his eyes. About Pete's age but he looked like he'd seen harder times. Maybe he was that realtor from next door.

"Excuse me...you Mark Draper?"

Sandy haired guy looked over his shoulder at him with watery, yellowed eyeballs.

"What?" he said with Pall Mall breath.

"Over here," deep voice, came from behind him.

A big fella sitting in a burgundy, worn-leather booth. He was maybe fifty, shaved head, handlebar moustache with the tips curled up. He had an authoritative face. He looked like a cop. He lifted his big hand up, shook Pete's hand with his elbow still on the table. An easy but powerful handshake.

"Hey, I'm Pete Mapplethorpe."

"Good to meet you, Pete. Mark," he said. "Have a seat," he gestured across the booth from him.

"Uh..." Pete still stood, looking out through the dusty window of the tavern. "Listen, I don't want to be a pain but...I got...I brought my kids with me."

Mark hefted his big torso around to look out the front. He laughed. Petey in the front seat of the Buick was telling Andy a story that required very big, explosive hand gestures.

"Sure. Where do you want to go?"

"Well, they saw a sign coming into town for a Chuck E. Cheese..."

Mark was a good sport about the venue switch.

There was a Chuck E. Cheese's right next to a Wal-Mart on the main drag, the 520, that ran along the Ohio River. They were in there now, Pete said he'd get lunch and he ordered two pizzas and some Cokes. Apologetic to Mark since this Chuck E. Cheese's didn't serve booze. He told Petey to take Andy, go have some fun, but they wanted to hang around. They were curious about this big guy with the super-villain moustache their dad wanted to talk to.

"Guys, come on, beat it. Go have a good time...look at all the fun stuff," he held his hand out towards the Play Zone. There were about a dozen kids on driving video games with real steering wheels, playing skee ball, shooting hoops for prizes...

"Go on, boys, it's like a little casino for kids," Mark said.

Andy said, "Are you really a policeman?"

Mark took his wallet out of his back jean's pocket, flipped it open so they could see his badge. "What do you think of that?"

Andy said, "Woah," looked up to Petey.

Mark flipped it closed, said, “Petey, go take your brother. That’s an order. Less you boys want to spend the night in lockup.”

Their faces were blank looking at him, blinking. Petey smiled.

“Hold Andy’s hand, Petey,” Pete said.

“I will.”

Mark folded his arms up on the table in front of him, regarded Pete. Kids ran all around the table, the place was a zoo.

“So, Pete, you’re with Save-Mart.”

“Yes, I am.”

“Save-Mart has an External do its investigations.”

“Yeah, but I am with Save-Mart.”

Mark squeezed and rubbed his nose, looked around, thinking. Pete saw Andy with Pete Junior, his older brother helping him at a game called Dog Pounder. The two of them trying to launch colourful balls into a big cartoon bulldog’s open mouth. It kept repeating, *Boy, am I hungry*. They were laughing their heads off. Two very resilient young boys.

“Pete, I’m a take a guess on something if that’s all right with you.”

Pete nodded to him.

Mark steepled his fingers in front of him, said, “Tyler friends with your wife?”

“Yeah,” he said, rubbed his palms over his forehead. “You a detective?”

Mark laughed. “No. I’m the Night Watch Commander for this peaceful town. I take care of it while it sleeps.”

“Oh.”

“She run off with him?”

Pete shifted around in the blown plastic bench. “She did.”

“Allison said she thought that’s why you came by.”

“Really?”

“Said your eyes looked like mine. Back when my wife took off with him.”

“She did?”

He nodded.

“That’s a bit melodra—”

“I see it too. And she was right, wasn’t she?”

“What happened?”

He leaned back, didn’t look like he wanted to talk about this. He kept it simple. “My second wife. Quite a bit younger than me. When she was in

her twenties she...liked to have a good time...she was sober a long time when I met her. Every once in a while though she liked to top her resolve up with an AA meeting. She met him at one..."

"Tyler's an alcoholic?"

"Don't think so. He might like to think he's one. Gives him some excuses maybe when he's feeling low. Maybe he could be one down the road. But he's not like the other people that AA helps. My wife used to say that about him. Before she fell for him and she wasn't afraid to mention him. Said he wasn't a drunk, but there was something about him..."

"Needed saving?"

"Something like that."

The waitress came by holding a tray with four enormous Cokes on it, full of ice and lemon wedges, straws stuck in the tops. Those boys were going to need two pee stops on the way home. She told them their pizzas were coming, then she got swallowed up by a birthday party on its way to a table with a hostess.

"Did she leave you?"

"I got rid of her when I found out. I...I loved her. She was my second wife, we were only together seven years—"

"That's a long time..."

Mark shrugged.

"Tyler made it sound like he had to get out of town..."

Mark shuffled his bulk to the edge of the bench, leaned forward, said, "When I first found out, I admit, I lost it. It wasn't good." He looked over to see the boys were still wrapped up in their game. "I was going to kill him. Lord, I told him I would. I meant it. If I found him back then I'm certain I would have shot him dead. He took off."

Pete looked down into his Coke. "You would have saved me..."

Mark laughed, closed his eyes. "Yeah, I woulda done you a favour."

"You didn't try and hunt him down?"

"I did. I was obsessed for a long time. Didn't find him. Found out a lot about him. There was a lot of things he was running from."

Pete looked up at him, concerned suddenly. "Mark, is he dangerous? Should I be worried for my wife?"

She was hot stuff in Ohio. Here she felt a little faded, a little less vibrant. She didn't seem as vital against these young little girls who'd never had children, never fed a little baby or two from their breast. They were tanned and young and smiling. They had tight young bodies, the skin under their chin never ever bunched up in a weird way if they had to look down at something under their glasses. Their youthful beauty was effortless. They were kids.

There were three of them around her Tyler. It was one pretty girl first, then her friend showed up. Jess watched one of them look back to her table, make a wide-eyed, *He's so hot!* face, then a third hopped her kid-like body over. They were so obvious. Putting out that girl energy—sipping drinks through pouted lips, batting eyelashes, and swinging their hips while they talked. Oh, they were good. Tyler was into it. He liked the attention. He looked fantastic in a pair of faded army shorts, flips flops, and a charcoal t-shirt that clung to his ridiculously big chest and shoulders then got a little loose around his narrow middle. His hair was piled up over his forehead, above a pair of black Wayfarers. She liked watching him, but not like this. This hurt.

They'd walked far up the beach from their motel, heading north before lunch. Didn't see anything they liked, then crossed over the hot Gulf Boulevard once they were in Clearwater to see if there was anything on the main drag. Found this big loud sports bar, packed, patio full of lively young people here to watch a basketball game. Tyler didn't care about basketball, but he liked the energy here; this was his kind of crowd.

They sat outside but in the shade of a pergola. A black fan anchored to one of the beams was pointed right at her face which was great because the hot walk up the beach in her bare feet had left her pretty tired. They split some nachos and a pitcher of beer, now she felt bloated again. Great with these slim girls virtually rubbing themselves up against him like cats right in front of her.

She had thought she and Tyler made such a good couple. Looked so good together until she saw him standing next to girls his own age. They would look like an even better couple. Any one of those girls.

He broke away from them, came back to the table and she watched carefully to make sure no numbers were passed back and forth. He sat back at their tall brushed aluminum table for two, putting his feet up on the rung of the stool.

“Making friends?” she asked him, putting on a smile.

“Oh, please,” he laughed, put his arms on the table and leaned into her, slipping on some charm. “Know how many dudes been clocking you since we got here?” He put his lips out and she kissed him, put one hand on his forearm.

“That’s nice,” she smiled, “what if one of them came up, leaned over me here, talking real close?”

“Oh, I’d knock him the fuck out.”

She sighed, scratched and squeezed the skin of his forearm. “Mm, that’s kind of sexy.”

“You’re mine,” he told her.

“Kiss me again, then. Kiss me for real.”

He did. He leaned over the table and closed his eyes and she met him with her lips, kissed him softly, bit his lips gently, sucked on them. Not too much. Not enough to get them kicked out of there. Enough for those three girls to get the picture if they were looking. God, she hoped they were looking.

The waiter came back with her card and said it had been declined.

“Ah, shoot,” she said, fished through her wallet, gave him a different card. “Sorry, use this one.”

“I wanna go to that club tonight, Boom-Chicka, I think it’s right around the corner from here.”

“Okay. I want to sit on the beach until it’s dark first. Want to take a cab home? I’m pooped.”

“Nah, let’s take the beach again. I’ll carry you.”

The waiter came back with her receipt and she thanked him, left some cash on the table for a tip.

“Let’s go,” she said. They headed off the patio and around the side of the bar, down a brick path between two gardens filled with palm trees and shrubs.

Tyler stopped on the path, bent down a bit, showed her his back. “Hop on,” he said.

“Tyler!” she laughed, but her legs were already working their way over his hips, her arms going around that strong, thick neck. He stood up with her on his back like she didn’t weigh a thing. She yelped, reached behind her to pull down her coverup. She’d come here in a bikini and flip flops and sunglasses, just a light, breezy, long, striped top hiding all her bare bits. One

of her flip-flops fell off onto the walkway and Tyler squat down and picked it up like she wasn't even on his back.

She held her bare little foot out for him with her hot pink painted toenails. He slipped it onto her foot, sliding it between her toes like she was Cinderella.

She put both her warm hands over his face, slid them along until they covered his eyes. "Trust me?" she said.

"No," he laughed.

"Come on, be my robot," she whispered into his ear.

"Where am I going?"

"Left. Ten feet."

He stumbled into the red mulch that made up the floor of the garden. She laughed, said, "Not so left. Less left. Like..." She squinted, thinking, said, "ten-forty-five."

"What?" he blurted out, laughing and stumbling, her hands stopping him from seeing where he was going.

"Ten-forty-five, like on a clock. Isn't that military? Don't guys talk like that?"

"I don't know," he said, his hands were out in front of him, feeling around, making sure he didn't walk into something.

"Keep going," she whispered in his ear, making it sound a little sexy.

"Am I going to fall down a ditch or anything, Jess?"

She let her hands off him. They were in the middle of the garden. In a clearing of red mulch only about three feet square, at the foot of a tall, fat palm that soared above them. They were surrounded by tall shrubs but you could still sort of see the walkway from where they'd come. Beyond, there was a side road coming off the main drag, above them a sign for a Burger King drive-thru. She slid off him.

"We found an oasis," she said, stood up on her tip-toes to kiss him. His hands went around her waist. He moved her until her back pressed against the trunk of the palm tree. He pinned her there with a passionate kiss.

"Mm, Tyler," she said between moments when her mouth sucked on his young lips. Her hands roamed his body until her palm found its way between his legs and started to knead his generous package through his army shorts.

"Don't get me started," he said, "it's a long way back to the hotel."

"What if I suck it right here?" she said into his mouth.

“You’re my bad girl, but you aren’t that bad.”

“You don’t think I’m bad enough?”

“You’ve still got a lot of good in you.”

Her hands worked his zipper, pinching the pull, holding the fabric tight with the fingers of her other hand. She pulled it down. She kissed and sucked his lower lip while she worked a hand into his fly and then under the waistband of his briefs. “Then you be the bad one. I’ll be good. Show me how bad you can be.”

He held the back of her neck firmly, kissed her deeply. She found his cock, pulled it out into the daylight. Her smile broke his kissing away.

“You’re pretty hard already.”

“Turn around,” he said to her.

She did it. She let his thing go and she turned, put her palms up on the trunk of the tree and looked over her shoulder at him. “What are you going to do?” Her hands were already moving up the hem of the cover-up, letting him see her rump.

“Good, now pull those bottoms to the side.”

“Why?” she asked him, but her fingers already slipped under the fabric of her bikini bottoms. She clawed them to the side, let her dirtiest bits be exposed to him.

“What do you think I’m going to do?” he whispered into her ear, pressed his chest against her back.

“I think you’re going to fuck me.”

“I *am* going to fuck you. Right here where anybody could see us.”

“Do it,” she urged him.

“Pull those cheeks apart for me.”

“Oh, Tyler. Don’t we need lube for that?”

He held his palm out for her, right under her chin. “Spit in my hand.”

She did it, she pursed her lips and she spewed as much spit into his waiting palm as she could muster. His chest pressed into her harder, pinned her to the tree. His hand went back behind her and she could hear the wet sound of him stroking himself with her own spit.

“Do it,” she said again.

His big, swollen glans pressed between her cheeks. It slid up and down her crack, trying to find a weakness, trying to find her little hole so it could bury itself deep inside her body. “Careful,” she reminded him.

He moaned behind her as he found it, his plump head plunging, pushing apart her tight dark ring not meant for sex.

“Ah,” she gasped out, and he shushed her.

She pulled her lips in between her teeth as his huge size slowly, agonizingly sunk inside her. It felt so *bad*. His hand slipped to her front from her thigh. Slipped in between her legs and rubbed her, big fingers roughing her delicate feminine folds.

“Ow,” she whispered.

“I want it to hurt you.”

“You’re so big Tyler,” she whimpered.

He slid himself in and out of her. He talked tough, he threatened to hurt her but he was gentle. God, he felt good inside her. He was the sexiest man alive.

“Fuck me,” she urged.

It made him laugh. “Just when I said you weren’t bad enough, you show me you’re the baddest bitch ever.”

“I’m bad, aren’t I?”

“Baby, you make me so fucking crazy,” he said. His thing went deeper, and she cried out again. “You gonna come for me? You gonna come with me in your ass?”

She nodded, her eyes closed.

“Do it. Think about it, what we’re doing,” his hands worked between her legs and she followed along, thought about how bad they both were. How hot they were, how sexy. What it would look like if you were a stranger and stumbled on two attractive people engaged in such a horrid but lascivious practice.

“Ah-oh, keep going,” she creaked.

“You going to come for me? I know you are—you’re already dripping. You’re the sexiest woman I ever met...”

She thrust her own bottom on him, put her little hand over his big hand. Guided his fingers so they’d do the right thing. She pushed him into the proper places, the ones she would touch for herself late at night, the ones that she knew best. She showed them to him, showed him her dirty secrets down there. His big strong hand was eager to learn.

“That’s it, that’s it,” she gasped up into the palm tree. “It’s coming.”

“Come for me, Jess, baby.”

His hand worked faster, it knew the deal now, and her hand just rested on his wrist, along for the ride. He definitely had the hang of it. She was going to come. As long as nobody walked in and ruined it, she was going to come.

“Aungh,” she blurted and her legs buckled. Her torso collapsed against the tree and the bark scraped at her soft face.

She covered her mouth with her hand, rode out a quick but healthy and satisfying orgasm that eventually stretched a smile on her face that one hand couldn’t cover.

“Oh, stop, stop, stop,” she urged him. She held his hips at bay, stopped him from thrusting that big thing inside her anus.

He leaned against her, his body felt so good against hers. When her eyes opened she could see heads moving around over the shrub tops. Unaware of the things she and Tyler were doing, but still shockingly close. She felt self-conscious, tried to recall how loud she’d been when she came.

“Take it out,” she said, trying to turn to face him. He did, his thing falling out from inside her and she felt it tap against the back of her thigh. She turned right around now, put both her palms up on his cheeks and she kissed him. His hands felt like they were pressing her down. She went with them, went and kissed her way down his neck, down to the ‘v’ of his T-shirt. Now what? Could she go lower?

“Jess, baby, I wanna spend my whole life with you,” he said up into the tree, both his hands on the trunk now supporting his weight against it. She slid lower.

His cock was there. She didn’t like this. It had just come from a very bad place. She had a lusty tingle in her belly but was it enough to try and work this thing into her mouth? The point from which she ate and talked. Ew. She couldn’t help but be repulsed by the idea of putting this big thing in her mouth when it had just been up inside her bottom. She gripped it in her hand. Just grabbing it made her stomach roil, turn over like she wanted to heave. She held her breath and moved her lips closer to his dirty cock head. Her hesitation was his anticipation and she could sense his urgency. He’d become stone in her grip. He was trembling, waiting to feel her lips on his big, sensitive tool.

“Please, Jess, please, baby, put it in your mouth, you bad girl...”

She looked at it, its one eye staring at her stupidly. It didn’t look dirty. It wasn’t dirtily smeared from her insides or anything. She was clean after all.

God, any one of those little sluts chatting him up at the patio would probably do this without a second thought. Girls these days. Only old moms worried about germs. She put her lips over his swollen head, plunged herself over it let it sink in her mouth. He was desperate to have it stroked and his hips sunk him deeper into her. She gagged. Retched up on his hard cock. Her eyes watered. She hated this. Hated it but she was here to impress. She was dedicated. She shut her eyes hard, felt tears stream down her cheeks as he gently fucked her open mouth. *Fuck it, Tyler. Get off in my little mouth. Come in my mouth.*

When she finally breathed she smelled it. Her own dirty smell. Vinegar, poop, and perfume. Like her panties after a long hot day. His cock was dirty from her. She retched again. Retched but contained it, didn't let that beautiful cock of his get away from her. She pushed all those thoughts away, just enjoyed the hard, hot, fleshy feel of him in her mouth, let his thick thing plunge in and out of her. She gripped him at the very base with one hand, where he emerged from his fly, hoping that was far back enough that it hadn't been inside her.

"Rr, Jess," he growled and she stopped.

"What?"

"Get up here, baby."

She raised up to him, her back scratching along the rough surface of the palm behind her. His hands gripped her shoulders and he pulled her to his waiting mouth. He bit her lips and sucked on her tongue. His hand gripped his cock and she felt it searching for her heat. Her hand went down, pulled the bottoms aside and she held her breath while he slowly eased himself inside her. She was so wet she took him all in one slow stroke.

"Oh, Tyler," she gasped. Her hand scratched his neck, and up into his hair. Her head went back and her eyes closed. Tyler kissed her neck. He kissed and sucked and he bit her and she couldn't imagine a better feeling than this.

His thrusts got urgent. She got wetter as he pumped his precum inside her. His neck quivered under her fingers.

"Baby, come for me, Tyler, come for me."

"I'm going to come inside you, Jess."

"Do it, baby."

"God, fuck, Jess, you're so sexy, baby. You feel so fucking good."

"Angh," she cried and she bit her lip in bewildering passion.

“I’m about to come so hard inside you, baby.”

He grunted with his thrusts, he had her flesh shaking with his power.

“Yeah, do it. I’m on the pill now, baby, come in me every...time...oh...”

“Ah...Jess, it was so sexy...when it was wrong...”

“You want to make...ah...little baby with me for real?”

“I...ah...want to make four babies...four little ones...ah...little Andy and Petey will have..a big family...lots of friends...”

“Oh, do it, Tyler, please come, I want to feel it, baby...”

He choked and spurted warmly into her neck. She hugged him tight as his huge cock swelled large and hard as he launched his hot seed into her belly. He held her tightly, cried her name softly as he buried himself deeply into her until it hurt. He squeezed every bit out of those big hanging balls, he spewed every last drop inside her.

Her heart pounded in her ears like never before. It hammered a mile a minute. She felt so amazing. She breathed him in, scratched her fingers lightly through his hair. She felt so young. So vital.

She had babies, she was good at it. She would give him big, strong, healthy children. She was sexy. She was a mother. She’d bear all his babies, feed them from her own body.

“D

angerous? I didn’t find anything...I don’t think he would hurt your wife, no. I didn’t find anything like that.”

“What did you find?”

He looked down at the table, kind of shook his head, said, “I just wanted to know where he went so I could get him in a gunsight. More I looked, more I didn’t care about him anymore.”

“Really? Didn’t care?”

“He’s just a dumb kid. My wife’s stupid enough to fall for all that, all more power to her, you know. Go, get out of my life.” He waved his thick fingers out in front of him. “Yeah, I searched around, went through his records...even went to visit where he grew up, see if he ran home to his momma. Would have blasted him right on her doorstep. Found he’s just Pennsylvania trash. Trailer Park. Came outta there without a dad. Maybe

better without one though; four Domestic calls when his dad was living at home.”

“Oh.”

Andy was at the table then. “Daddy, can we have some more quarters?”

“Where’s your brother?” he asked him, putting his hand in his pocket.

“He’s holding the game for us, there was some big kids...”

“Here you go,” he said, gave him a five dollar bill. “Go get some change.”

“Can I spend it all on games?”

Pete squinted, pursed his lips. “Fine.”

Then he was off.

Mark went on after Andy had disappeared. “Listen, he’s seen some trouble. Assaulted a guy at a bar when he was in Albright. Him and two other players. Broke the guy’s leg. On purpose. That was the only bad thing I found. But he does have a lot of debt—”

“Broke a guy’s leg?”

“Drunken college athlete shit. He escaped charges, he wasn’t criminally liable. There wasn’t enough to charge him with, no evidence, three words against one. But victim got a judgment against him in Civil Court—owes that guy thirty-five grand.”

“Wow.”

“His last year at Albright? He was off the team. Didn’t find out why. Might be the assault. He finished last year without help from his scholarship. So the judgment, a year’s tuition, credit cards, whatever he owes his steroid guy—I figure he’s in pretty deep. Close to...well very high five figures.”

“He’s on steroids?”

Mark looked at him like he was crazy. “On steroids? Course, look at him. Winstrol, Deca, all sorts of Mexican veterinary supplements. I know he bought when he was here.”

Jesus, how big were his balls before?

“You know, going through his records, going out and seeing where he lived, talking to his momma, talking to men knew him on the team...after a long time I just didn’t care. I was tracking him down and I found all those things and I lost interest. I felt...I don’t know...”

“Bad for him?”

“No. Definitely not. I just didn’t hate him anymore. Actually felt real good to let it go. Let *him* go. First, I saw him as the man who stole my wife. This big muscular guy that walked right up and took her from me. Walked away with her. But after a while, I saw him...like a dumb human, not some villain. Just a stupid asshole. Fuck, though, you know...if I had shot him I still don’t think I would regret it. I’m glad I didn’t find him. Yeah, it was better for everyone that he ran away. It hurts...I don’t like to think about it. But with Linda out of my life now it’s been better.”

Pete smiled, said, “Until I came and brought it up. Sorry.”

“It’s good. I’m glad. When Allison called, said his name, I got pretty tight but I’m glad I’m talking to you. I wouldn’t tell you what to do but I can tell you that letting her go, letting the anger go, has done wonders for me. Kept me out of prison. I wouldn’t be popular there...”

Pete laughed, “You wouldn’t.” Pete felt suddenly emboldened in the thought that even this masculine guy could have his wife taken. It wasn’t just Pete. It could happen to anyone. Maybe he wasn’t such a loser.

“He can keep the money too. Just a couple grand.”

“She gave him money?”

Mark nodded. “He didn’t steal it, he just...he took what she offered. She did it cause she was kind. All in all, I think he’s just a little boy looking for a mother. You know?”

Pete nodded.

They looked over at the Play Zone, at Petey and Andy playing at the Skee Ball. Andy throwing the ball overhand, banging it practically straight down into the zero hole. Petey was trying to show him how to throw it underhand with both hands starting between his knees.

“Oh, shoot. Sorry.”

“Their mom’s with him now. They went on vacation together. She told me she wants a divorce.”

Mark exhaled. “Girls’ll fall for the bad boy. I hope you’re all right.”

“I thought she was better than this.”

“Tyler’s not the devil. He just doesn’t have a compass.”

“Great. My Jess is following him and he has no idea where he’s going.”

“I don’t know if any of this helps you at all. I hope you got something.”

“Yeah.”

“Were you hoping to hear he was a wanted felon and I was gonna go arrest him right now?”

“No. I didn’t know what I’d find out here at all. Didn’t even know who you were, let alone that you were a cop. I only knew he ran away from something here.”

“He took off so fast he left his dog behind.”

“What happened to it?”

“I still have it. He’s *my* buddy now.”

“He runs from his problems, doesn’t he?”

Pete called the boys over when the pizzas came on two tall metal stands. The four of them ate every single piece and the boys told Mark about their mom, it made Mark’s eyes sad but he was smiling. Not once did the boys mention Tyler.

Pete parked at the pale grey foot of Ohio Stadium. A small lot, close to the Human Sciences building, but it had cheap parking since he didn’t have a campus pass. Used to park here every Tuesday and Thursday nine years ago, late afternoon class, Managing Retail and Hospitality Operations. He locked up.

He carried Andy on his hip; he was sleepy from the long car ride back to Columbus. “Petey, take my hand,” he said.

“Dad, I have to pee again,” Petey said.

“There’s a nice clean bathroom where we’re going.”

There had been, at least, nine years ago in the Human Sciences Building. They found it. It was still there. Andy was awake enough to walk now, and Pete and Pete Junior used the facilities, Petey just tall enough to use a University height urinal.

“You’re getting tall, buddy,” he said standing next to his little boy.

He bought them a couple of Fruitopias from a vending machine because Petey said he was thirsty which meant Andy would say he was too, and he took them up to the fourth floor on the brick side of the facility. He walked them down the polished hallway and sat them on a bench that looked out across an open area in the centre of a confluence of hallways and glass doors. He sat down with them, popped the tabs on all their drinks.

This was the spot where he’d first met her. The spot where his eyeballs first landed on the best thing that had ever happened in his life. He could

see her, coming through that glass door on his right, her oversized sweatshirt, her sexy legs clad in dance tights. She had a gym bag slung over her shoulder. She was late and her face showed it. Her worried brow, her drawn cheeks—she'd needed that job, couldn't be late on her first day. She needed help. She was on the verge of tears.

Who was this coming in from the left to save the day? A young Pete Mapplethorpe. A good guy. He was kind of handsome back then, he was thin but fit. Why was he so hard on that guy? He tracked him across the hall, watched him address her with his voice made deep from lack of sleep, take the paper from her trembling hand. He knew where she needed to be. He would help her get there. He took her bag for her.

His two sons sat on either side of him. He wasn't going to cry in front of them. "So, boys, this is where your mom and I met. This was our school. Your mom came in that door and I was walking down from this side," he pointed with his finger. They followed along. "Your mom needed help and I helped her," he said quietly. "My life changed right here."

He'd taken her across the building, whisked her to where she needed to be, through the elevated red glass walkway that got them to the more modern, glass and steel side of the building. He'd stopped her before she went in, he'd dared to ask her out. He thought it was crazy. Weird guy like Pete asking out such a pretty girl. He'd hoped he didn't offend her. Her kind, sweet face agreed. She'd go out. She hugged him. She didn't think it was crazy. She thought he was worthy. *He was worthy. He* was the one who thought he was no good. Not her. Only him. She was innocent.

He took out his phone, texted her.

Pete: sitting with the boys where we first met, I

He deleted it. He meant it sweet, but that would be manipulative to her. That would be weak. Playing on her emotions. He'd been sending her these texts while she was away, like messages in a bottle, not knowing if she would ever read them.

He wasn't unworthy. That was in his head. He deserved Jess. She could have said No, but she didn't. His love for her was real. Couldn't her love for him have been real?

She'd told Tyler she was going to dump Pete, then he got her pregnant. Was she going to leave him? Did he knock her up and trap her? Hitch his heavy weight around her ankle with a burdensome chain?

He put his arms around his two boys and pulled them to his side. He wasn't bad looking. He wasn't. He was in decent shape. He was smart. He had some success. Why didn't he think he deserved her? Why did he think she was a trophy that he didn't deserve to win? She was a decent, warm, caring human being who had at one time loved him.

He could blame himself. He had done this to her. Pushed her away from him, into Tyler's arms. But he knew he was done with blaming himself. Blame was pointless. He was tired of it now and it didn't even tickle him in the belly in the slightest. Not when it was for real.

He got up and threw their empty drinks in the recycling bin, put his hands out to take his boys, walked them back out the way he came. Walked those initiate halls, where he walked a hundred years ago when he met the woman he loved and swore she would be his and he would be the one to protect her forever. By the time he got to the Buick he knew what he had to do.

“How do I look?”
“Hot.”

“Thanks, baby, I needed to hear that.” She stood on her toes and kissed him at the foot of their bed. She was wearing a black cotton dress and flats even though she thought it kind of made her legs look short. She'd put her contacts in for the evening too. She hated wearing them.

She turned and checked herself out in the mirror over the dresser. Did she look good? Was he just saying that?

She had no idea what twenty-year-olds were wearing to clubs nowadays. She didn't know what they were wearing when she was a twenty-year-old either though. She didn't want Tyler to see her nervous. She *was* nervous. It had been more than ten years since she'd gone to a club. A club like the one they were going to tonight. She could picture it, imagine what it would be like. Not like the Cantina when they went out on New Year's. Those people were mostly her own age, quite a few even older than

her. This was more like Tyler's world. Tyler's people. Even when she was Tyler's age she didn't really go to clubs.

Tyler was standing by the window holding back the white curtain edge with a finger. Of course, he looked good. He just wore the same grey t-shirt and changed into less casual shorts. That's how easy it was for him. He looked fantastic. Not so easy for a woman. Not so easy for her at least. Everything she'd tried was wrong. And when she'd cycled through everything she brought, trying each outfit on and rejecting it, she started from the beginning again. Trying now to at least not look *completely* terrible.

"Hey, cab's here, Jess."

"Okay." Her heart jumped. She checked her wallet in her purse again. Made sure she had lots of cash. ID in case they asked. It would be nice if they asked. She asked Tyler, "You have the key?"

"No," he said, standing outside on the concrete walk in the golden light of the setting sun.

"Hold on," she said, found it and dropped it in her purse.

She closed the door behind her, made sure it locked, and she shuffled quickly to catch up with him. He took her arm, walked her to the green and orange cab and helped her in.

"Boom-Chicka, please, in Clearwater," she told the driver, a young black guy with a tweed country cap, and a toothpick in his mouth. He nodded and they were on their way.

It was only a twelve-minute drive but they'd be in no shape for driving home and they didn't want to arrive there with their clothes damp from heat by walking. So she paid the guy fifteen dollars, tip included, and she got out of the cab with a brave face.

It was busy. There wasn't a line up like she worried there would be. It was quiet in February and that meant that just the right amount of people arrived to keep the place full and thumping but not too many to have a line around the side. Some places she'd heard liked that line though because it was practically advertising to the people driving by.

This place didn't need to advertise that it was where you wanted to be. You could tell by looking. The parking lot was full. Cramped, really. Valet was bustling. Nice cars too, no beaters that Jess could see. No minivans at all. The car that had been ahead of them in the cab was a Mercedes something and it was a Range Rover that pulled in behind them when they

got out and stood at the doorway. The place looked like it may have been a warehouse at one time. A big block that got itself some sort of architectural makeover when it was re-purposed. It had been given a very stylish coat of Florida stucco, pure white but now, at night time, the place was being blasted with a pulsing, vibrant, hot pink light. The name, Boom-Chicka, was written and re-written with finesse by a laser light. Drawing out the name with great orange energy that pumped and pulsed with the deafening, thunderous dance music.

Tyler helped her up the three short steps to the front doors in glass and steel. There were two big bouncers there in suits. Guys that looked bigger than Tyler but you wouldn't necessarily describe as in-shape. They checked ID and it gave her a thrill, hoped they'd see her age and appreciate how she was holding up. Guy didn't acknowledge it in any way, just gave it back to her and nodded with his head for them both to go in.

The place was beautiful inside. Sort of what she imagined a Florida club would look like. Purple and pink neon lights hidden under formed shapes that traced the curving edges of the bar and planters filled with yucca. Corners were softened with potted palms in brass cauldrons. The people there were beautiful, they looked in place, like they belonged here. She hoped she looked like she belonged here, she didn't feel like she did. Tyler was certainly turning heads.

"Let's get a seat, Jess," Tyler said into her ear.

Most of the crowd had gathered around the bars and were on the dance floor or hanging around the edges of it. The booths were all taken but there were two available tables.

They sat and talked, ordered some drinks. The music was loud but they could hear each other. By her second fifteen dollar cocktail, she was feeling a little better. She stopped thinking people were watching her and wondering why she was here. Now she wanted to dance.

She felt bold. She put her hand out to Tyler, led him to the dance floor. When she was out there she didn't care about anything. She moved her body well. She could dance. She was great at it. Could have been professional if it weren't for genetically weak tendons. She was good enough for this room that was for sure. When she moved out there she didn't think about anything else. Her body loved to move like that. She pressed it against Tyler, slinked it under his hands for him, let him feel her ability. Her sinewy grace, her flexibility. She danced herself against him

like she was a woman who was fucking him. Danced with him like she knew him carnally. It was the best thing she'd done with him when they were both clothed. They went on like that for hours. She had four more drinks. Tyler had more. She didn't need to sit. She could do this all night. When she went to the bathroom she looked in the mirror and saw her fresh face. Gleaming with sweat and vibrant. Healthy. Happy. What had she been worried about?

When she returned to the table from the bathroom she saw Tyler sitting there, a girl was behind him and she had her hands covering his eyes. Playing the *Guess Who?* game. She was young, twenty, short summer dress with spaghetti straps, an unbelievable tan on the healthiest, glossiest, most youthful skin Jess could imagine. One of the girls from the patio this afternoon. She peeked around, face-to-face with him, showed him all of her white teeth in a lip-gloss smile that didn't put a single crease on her face. Jess sat in her chair and thumped her clutch onto the table top.

"Oh, hey..." he said.

Girl said, "Taylor." Reminding him. *Right.*

"Hey, Taylor, what's up?"

Tyler and Taylor. How cute.

"I can't believe you're here," she was saying. She had her hands on his shoulders.

"Yeah, what a coincidence," he said. His head was turned to Taylor but his eyes were on Jess. "Jess, Taylor was at the patio today."

Jess said, "I know."

"Hi-ii," Taylor said, waving to her. Jess could see it in her eyes. A meanness. The way her hands stayed on Tyler right in front of her, content to confront.

"Really, Tyler?"

"Jess," he said, threw his hands up and smirked, "Come on."

He was pretending this wasn't on purpose. She didn't believe that.

She took her clutch and left the table. She walked to the dance floor. Probably wanted him to get jealous. Picturing her dancing with other men. She just wanted out. She cut through the centre of the floor, wedging between gyrating bodies and heading to the raised platform she could see on the other side. There was a bank of open doors there, spilling out into the open, night air.

What did he want from her—what was his intent? Did he want some threesome? Were Taylor's friends there too? Did he want a fucking orgy? There was something wrong with men. They were always so twisted. Sex was so odd.

The open doorway put her out onto a deck. A huge three-tiered space filled with more people. She walked to a railing, farthest from the crowds, a little blank spot out there, where she could stop and think.

Fuck, why did she leave?

She leaned against the rail, felt the chilly night air sting her hot sweaty skin. The patio looked out over a boat-studded inland waterway. Lights shimmered on the water's black surface. She hung her head and breathed deeply.

The group next to her was loud, boisterous. She wanted to leave, didn't want to be here anymore.

"Jess!"

Tyler's voice behind her. She felt instantly relieved that he'd followed her. She was stupid to run out like that. But Taylor scared the crap out of her. She closed her eyes and waited, needed to feel his arms go around her.

"Jess, baby, don't. Don't do this." His arms were on either side of her. She could see his big hands on the metal railing, he had her pinned, his chest against her back. She leaned herself into him. Those hands came up and his arms went around her.

"I'm sorry, Tyler," she whispered.

"What?" he said. He couldn't hear her over the noisy group next to them that roared out over something. Some ridiculous reaction, followed by raucous laughter.

She turned herself in his arms and she got in his ear, said it again.

"No, Jess, I'm sorry. I swear I didn't know."

"Okay," she said. *She hoped.*

"Really, Jess. It was a coincidence. I know how it looked."

She pressed her cheek into his hard trap. "I want to get out of here."

"You sure? We were having fun?"

"I don't know."

“Come on, Jess. We can go dance some more...”

Wasn't it after midnight? “Okay,” she said.

“That’s my girl,” he said, then kissed her forehead. “Baby, look at me...”

She looked up into his eyes.

“...you’re all I think about, okay? You’re all I want.”

She pressed her head against him, hugged him.

He hugged her back. “Let’s go have some more fun,” he whispered.

He took her shoulder and he walked her back towards the club.

A short, muscular black guy from the noisy group stepped back, stepped on her foot.

She yelped. He turned and he was apologetic. “Oh, sorry, I’m so sorry, ma’am.”

Ma’am? Thanks.

“Fuckin watch where you’re going,” Tyler said.

Jess said, “I’m fine, it’s okay. He’s sorry.”

Someone on the far side of the group said this: “Don’t bring your mom.”

Something like that, she wasn’t sure of the phrase. Maybe, Guy brings his mom...*mom* was in there. She was surprised. Sure, it stung. It was what she had worried about, but now she was confronted with it, her first instinct was to laugh at herself. Then in the next moment, it really did hurt.

She got in front of Tyler. She couldn’t stop him.

He walked into the group. There were maybe five guys and a bunch of girls. All young, guys were pumped up. But not like Tyler.

When the guy had said it, the girl next to him slapped his arm hard, chastised him, “Tony!”

Tyler’s voice was loud, he said, “Fuck you say, bro?”

Tony’s girl, the one that slapped him, got in between them now. She said, “He didn’t say anything, he didn’t say anything...” She was drunk. Pretty and blonde, but had too much to drink where she was slurring her words. While she was trying to calm things down her voice was shrill and somehow sounded angry. She made it worse.

Jess said, “Tyler, let’s go.” She pulled his forearm but she couldn’t move him.

Tony, the one with the loud mouth, was big, good-looking but a greasy kind of kid. Thick black hair, smarmy face, made expressions like he was on the Sopranos. He waved Tyler off with buttery condescension. Acting

like he wasn't afraid, but he wasn't backing up his statement, just trying to save face.

"Leave it alone," the drunk girl said. She glared at Tyler, stretched her body between them.

Tyler shoved Tony, reaching out over her shoulder and pushing his chest. "Watch your fuckin mouth."

Now Jess joined the drunk girl, she slipped in next to her and tried to get Tyler to step back. She said, "Boys, boys, boys." An eternal third-grade teacher.

One of the other five guys, in an effort probably to win the favour of his dumb friends, sought to be the hero. He thought he'd slip in and knock Tyler out with one punch. A fist launched from the crowd, hooking around from where Tyler couldn't see it coming. It caught him right in the mouth and he threw his hands up, but he didn't go down. He turned and now it was on. Phones came out to video from the crowd, the other guys in the group were hopping in place. Tyler tracked which one had hit him, and he hunched down. The sneaky puncher was a muscular, blonde kid with a tan and a polo shirt. The guy was afraid but he kept his hands up like he could stop him.

Jess screamed, "Tyler, don't!"

But Tyler launched himself at the other guy, tackled him at the hips and he brought him down to the ground like a lion taking its prey. He straddled the guy, who'd hit his head on the deck, and he swung on him, one-two. A left and a right. It took three seconds. Jess could see the kid's eyes staring dumbly at nothing. He was out. His arms reached up to try and claw at ghosts.

Tony tried to kick Tyler in the face while he was down. His girl had grabbed him and she was weighing him down. The kick got him in his neck and it did nothing.

Security was charging through the crowds. She saw two big black guys headed their way in skin tight yellow polo shirts with the club name on the chest. "Tyler, don't, Tyler!" Jess yelled.

Two more girls helped Tony, they got between them and it probably saved his life. Jess got herself into the fray again, another body putting distance between them.

The bouncers got there and they didn't care who started what, who hit who—they wanted the altercation busted up. Tyler, maybe from experience,

put his hands up like they were police.

“Kay bro, I’m good, bro, I’m good,” and he started walking away.

Jess ran to his side, “Let’s go, let’s go...”

“Come on, girl,” he pulled her to him and he walked her along with the crowd. His eyes were wide and he was smiling from ear to ear. His lip was bloodied.

“Oh, baby, your lip,” she said.

He brushed it with the back of his hand, looked at the blood there, and laughed.

He got her outside, out to the front of the club under the dazzling pink and orange lights. Jess fished a paper napkin out of her clutch and she stopped Tyler, she pressed the paper to his bloodied lip.

“You okay?” he said to her through his hand pressed to his mouth.

“Me? I’m fine, baby. Shaken up.”

“Sorry, Jess. That guy...” he said, looking angrily back through the club. “We should get out of here.”

“Yeah, let’s go,” she said, held her purse tightly to her, worried that someone was going to come after them.

They walked down the sloped parking area for the club, crossed a pedestrian footbridge that went over a very narrow channel that smelled like seaweed. Tyler tossed his wadded up, bloody paper into it. He checked his lip. It had stopped bleeding. They followed along a quiet well-lit narrow street with gift shops and closed up ice cream stands. Tyler got down and asked Jess to climb up on his back again.

“Tyler—” she resisted.

“Get up there, Jess,” he said.

So she did, climbed up his waist and held on to him while he stood up with her on his back. She hiked her skirt down.

He walked along the street with her like that, and her heart rate started to come down. It started to feel good again to have herself pressed against him.

“Take me to the beach,” she whispered into his ear.

“Jess, look at this,” he said.

“What?”

“The sign,” he said. They were standing in front of a surf shop—a small colourfully painted little beach bungalow right up next to the street. It had a thatch roof and a sign hanging on an angle-iron that stuck out from the

building at ninety degrees so you could read it walking or driving past. CASEY JONES SURF GEAR. And on top of the sign was a metal cartoonish silhouette of a train.

“Jess, the train.” He said. He walked her underneath the sign.

“Yeah?”

“We should get it for the boys.”

“What? No, Tyler. Are you crazy?”

“Climb up onto my shoulders, baby, come on.”

He hooked an arm under her knee and he started hoisting her farther up his back. She went with it. His other arm got under her other knee and now she was climbing up onto his shoulders. “Tyler, this is crazy. I’m going to fall. What are we going to do with a metal train anyway?”

“The boys will love it, they can put it up on their wall.”

“Tyler—” She was up on his shoulders now. Her hands gripped the sign. It was still too high. She could reach the train but there was nothing she could do about it. Plus, *it was stealing*. “Tyler, it’s welded on,” she said, faking her hands checking it. She ran them along the train where it connected to the sign so he could see her shadow on the sidewalk looking like it was making an effort. “Come on, get me down.”

“Aw, Jess.” He put his arms up so she could hold on, brace herself while she climbed back down his body and got her feet on the ground.

Then he said, “I’ll get it,” and he made like he was going to climb up the front of the building. “No, Tyler, don’t, don’t.” She had visions of him falling off the sign or it breaking with his weight on it and falling to the sidewalk and smashing his head open. He might be built like a tank but he could still get hurt. She wrapped her arms around him while he gripped an eaves trough and had one foot up on the painted stucco. “Tyler, baby, we couldn’t get it on the plane. Take me to the beach, please, baby.”

“All right, all right,” he laughed. “The boys would have liked it, Jess.”

“I know, Tyler, but we can’t get it home. Thanks though, baby.”

“Hop on,” he said, and he thumbed to his back, knelt so she could climb on him again.

He walked them out to Gulf Boulevard. There was a little traffic, and he ran across with her on his back. Cars honked. She stuck her legs out and she laughed as she bounced along, just a passenger for the ride. He kept running, heading down a wooden boardwalk with a sign that said, *Beach Access*. He ran under the lone light at the end that jutted on a greyed

wooden pole dug in the sand; he ran up a dune covered in gently swaying beachgrass.

“Oh no, you don’t,” she laughed.

He kept running, headed for the sounds of the crashing waves. She was laughing again, she said, “My purse, Tyler, my purse,” but he kept running. She could feel he was laughing too.

She threw her purse in the sand as she heard his feet slap on the wet tide.

She yelled in his ear, “Tyler, you’re crazy!”

Then they were in the water. She went under, pitched over his head, splashing into the deep salty Gulf. Her ears went quiet, filled only with an awareness of the bubbles and swooshing water. Then his arms found her grabbed her, pulled her to the surface and he helped her up and bobbed with her.

She spat water out, choked and coughed, said, “You are...a maniac.”

“You okay?”

She laughed, swam to him, put her arms around him. She kissed him, gripped the back of his thick, powerful neck and pressed her lips to him as hard as she could. She felt his swollen, coppery lip. She sucked on his wound. He was so sexy.

“Mm, this is nice,” he said, looking into her eyes, holding her and bobbing with her.

It was a dark night. She could see the stars in the deep black beyond. There was no horizon. The water they were in was as black as the sky. Light from the shore danced along the edges of the waves. It felt very scary suddenly. Like they were suspended in the unknown.

She said, “This is like the beginning of Jaws.”

“I’ve never seen it.”

“You’ve never seen Jaws?”

“I don’t think so.”

“You’ve never seen Jaws?”

He laughed. “No. Is it any good?”

“Any?...Okay, get me out of here.”

“Are you a fraidy cat?”

“Yes. Of sharks? Yes.”

“Wow,” he laughed.

She clung to him happily as he waded to where his feet could touch, then he walked her to the shore and he put her back down in the macadam and kissed her. Her hands went to the hem of his shirt and she pulled it over his head, heard it slap wetly in the surf. A wave came up and washed underneath her. She felt the fine sand working through her clothes, tickling her skin. She sat up and took her clothes off. Tyler stood and pulled his shorts down and stepped out of them. His cock was swinging, heavy and hard. She got a chill. He stood naked over her. She was as bare as him, sitting below him in the wet sand. Another wave came up, washed over his ankles and splashed along her bottom.

“Hold on,” she said. He stood and she admired him. His black silhouette against a starry night. Dim light from shore cut along the hard edges of his beautiful young body. This is how she wanted to remember him. “Okay,” she said.

He knelt between her legs, kissed her lips, pushed her so her back was on the beach. Her hands tickled around his hard body, felt his incredible muscle.

“Make love to me like I’m a woman. Not a girl,” she whispered.

His cock was ready. She could feel it against the inside of her thigh. Her legs lifted, wrapped around his waist, exposed her sex to him. She ached to feel him, she was desperate for him to fill her. His lips sucked on hers, kissed her chin. The tip of his huge cock slid into place and she held her breath. Then he slowly, steadily pierced her. His enormous size sunk inside her, filled her up, confirmed to her his passion, her passion. Sand scratched as he buried his hardness in her, it dug into her and she cried out. Another wave crashed below them and washed up around them.

She let it all out. All the pain she had held, all the regret, all the shame. She was vocal—she cried into the darkness with each deep thrust. Her soft girl sounds were rushed away by the pounding surf. Tyler made love to her. He wasn’t gentle, but he was deliberate, straightforward. She held his attention with her kisses as she tried to consume him with her mouth. She bit and sucked on him. She devoured his tongue his lips, felt her body pounded by his young strong hips. She was powerless under him, she held onto him for dear life as the water crashed around them, over her face, up between them, into her creases and where she was penetrated by the greatest lover she would ever know.

“Oh, Tyler,” she called out to the stars, knowing she was close. She felt free and young.

“I love you, Jess,” he whispered into her ear, an urgent pant that wavered with his desperate thrusts. He was going to come too.

She didn’t tell him what to do. He knew. This was lovemaking. It wasn’t dirty tonight. This was two people in rapture. She clawed him, thrust her head back as the orgasm came to her, let it be known it was out of the shadows and wanted to feel the light.

“Ah!” she cried as it lunged at her.

He roared in her ear, deep and masculine and animal, pure hard young male. He came. She felt it inside her, felt him flood her insides with his hot fluid. Stream after forceful stream tickling her with its heat. Her brow furrowed, her face swelled hot and red, she clenched her eyes, and the tears came.

“Oh, Tyler,” she cried. She hugged him like she never wanted to let him go and she sobbed into his wet salty neck.

“Oh, baby Jess, what is it?”

She shook her head in the hollow between his chin and shoulder and wailed and heaved. He hugged her, held her.

“Baby are you okay, what’s wrong?”

She cried, “Just hold me, don’t say anything just hold me tight, baby.”

Later, much later, must have been three in the morning, she woke up and couldn’t get back to sleep. Sand scratched at every part of her. Her back, her shoulders, in the tight folds of her neck. It was in between her legs, the creases of her ass and between her legs. It was even in her vagina. She got up, got herself in the bathroom.

She ran the shower, turned the lever to hot, stood and waited for it to come to temperature. In the corner of her eye, she saw someone else in the bathroom with her. An older woman wanting to be someone else. She looked good, she looked sexy. She only wanted to touch the things she thought had been moved from her grasp.

Jess put her hand out to the mirror, maybe to comfort her. She saw her trembling hand, reaching out to touch that woman’s fingers as she also

reached to her. Her hand shook—*her hand*, looking like someone else's hand, a visible mark left on her skin from where her ring should be. Where it had been for seven years. She avoided the reflection, avoided that sad woman with the faintest of lines starting to trace her eyes, the corners of her mouth. She stared at the hand. That *was* her hand. She had to convince herself. Attach herself before she collapsed again, lost in a panic like she did that first day back at school after Christmas.

She got in the tub, leaned her hands against the wall, lowered her neck under the chrome shower head and let the hot water wash over her. Even though she was only a thousand miles from home it might as well have been a million.

BANISHED

TUESDAY, FEBRUARY 14TH

Pete pulled into the driveway of the home that he'd bought with Jess seven years ago. Their real estate agent had messed up the offer. There was a two-day period where they thought they weren't going to get it. Then the other family that had put an offer in couldn't go firm in time. They got it and they threw themselves a party that night. No alcohol, Jess was pregnant.

The storm hadn't come this weekend. If it had he knew he'd have come here despite the awful thing he'd said to her. He wouldn't let anything happen to those two baby cedars.

The minivan was in the driveway, they'd got back from the airport all right it would seem. This wasn't going to be easy.

He got out of the Buick and he went to the front door, rang the bell. He stood at the glass insert of the door. A warbled image of his wife came out of the kitchen, drying her hands on a tea towel. She looked puzzled. He waved.

"Pete?" she said, opening the door for him, letting him in. "What is it? Is everything okay?"

"Everything's good, Jess. How was your trip?"

She looked up, hemmed, unsure of how to answer, like she didn't know what to say about it to the man who used to be her husband. It didn't matter. He didn't want to know how it was. He was just making small talk.

He stopped her floundering, said, "You got some colour."

"Thanks."

“You look good.” When she got a healthy tan after a long summer she would get the lightest blonde, almost invisible fuzz along the back of her shoulders.

“Where are the boys? I thought we agreed they would just come here after school tomorrow...”

“I didn’t bring them. They’re still at my sister’s.”

“You could if you were—”

“I won’t be bringing them back here.”

“Excuse me?” her face went firm.

“They can’t be here, Jess.”

She threw the towel she was holding down on the deacon’s bench, said, “They can’t...my boys? Pete, don’t start something, we were all getting along—”

“Jess, how much have you given him?”

Her mouth dropped. “What do you mean?”

“How much money have you given Tyler?”

She couldn’t look at him, she threw her hands up and shook her head, mumbling something to herself. Like he was rude to ask.

“How much, Jess?”

“I don’t know, Pete, little bits here and there. I haven’t added it up. I do keep track.”

“He say he’s going to pay you back?”

“Of course.”

“Nine thousand. A bit under.”

She stared at him.

“That includes the vacation though. That was your treat, I suppose. I was at the bank today.”

“It’s my money, Pete. I work.”

He shrugged, said, “Mm, debatable. We *are* still a family. But I won’t argue. It’s your money too.”

She folded her arms up and her brow lowered, “He’s not scamming me, you know. I’m not stupid. He loves me.”

Pete couldn’t help smiling. “I agree. I don’t think he’s conning you. I don’t think he’s after your money. Jess, I really believe he loves you. I really do. You’re too good to him.”

Her posture softened, she kept her arms folded but she slumped a little. He figured that this had been weighing on her. She wasn’t stupid. She

wouldn't just give her money away.

"Jess, do you know what you're doing?"

She was looking at a spot on the floor. "I don't know."

"I think he should go, Jess."

"Whoa, no way, Pete. That's not your decision."

"Well, the boys aren't coming here until I straighten something out with him. Is he here?"

"Pete, that is not a good idea. And don't you dare threaten me with my kids. Not my boys, Pete..."

Pete walked past her and headed down the hall past the powder room into the kitchen. He called out, "Tyler!"

"Pete, don't." She grabbed the arm of his coat but he pulled himself away.

"Tyler!"

She got up next to him again. Tyler was at the top of the stairs now.

"Pete? What are you yelling about?"

She whispered, "Pete, please don't tell him you're not bringing the boys back here."

She had no idea what had got into him but this was bad. She was worried for Pete.

Tyler came down the stairs and into the kitchen. Jess let go of Pete's arm and stepped to the side as the two of them came face to face between the island and the table.

Pete said, "I don't think you should be here anymore."

Tyler laughed at him. He was wearing a T-shirt and track pants, no slippers, just his bare feet. They'd been getting ready to go to bed, now this. "You don't?" Tyler said.

"That's not me, Tyler. I'm not saying that. Pete's saying that, I don't know what's got into him. Pete, I don't want him to leave. You have no right—"

"No right? I have plenty of rights," Pete said, moving towards her, making sure she was hearing him.

Tyler put his big hand on the front of Pete's coat and pushed him back easily. "Hey, don't go near her. Just stay over there."

Pete smiled at him. "Real tough guy, Tyler. Think you can take me?"

"Yeah, I do."

"No kidding, Einstein. You're real tough with someone you're not afraid of."

What was he doing? He'd gone crazy talking like that. "Pete, you didn't...you don't...have a gun...do you?"

He laughed at her, blurted, "What? Are you crazy? I'm going to go to jail over this lowlife?"

Tyler bumped Pete with his chest, moved him back. "You wouldn't stand a chance with me even if you had a gun."

Pete looked at him seriously, unafraid. "You know that's not true."

Tyler's jaw clenched and unclenched. His jaw muscles bulging and jumping.

Pete said, "You're not Superman just because you're saturated with steroids. Bullets will rip through you. I know you know that."

Tyler said, "Pete, I don't know what you're trying to pull here—"

"I want my family back."

"Jess made her decision. You're the one that's out."

Pete showed him his chin, squinted his eyes at him, said, "You're taking money from her."

Jess said, "Pete, don't—"

"You fucking trying to embarrass me?" he bumped Pete with his chest again, stepped into him until he had Pete's back against the wall. "Are you trying to fucking embarrass me?"

Then Pete said, "Go ahead. Why don't you break my leg? Break my leg and I can sue you for thirty-five grand that I'll never see because you're a deadbeat."

Jess cried, "Pete, have you gone cra—"

Tyler said, "Fuck you say?" cocking his head, squaring up.

"You're a deadbeat."

Tyler punched him hard in the stomach, lifted his feet off the linoleum, and Jess cried out, frantic. "Tyler, don't!"

Pete dropped to the floor on his hands and knees. His head fell, buried into the crook of his arm. He made a long, low moan. He couldn't breathe in.

She got in between them, pushed at Tyler, tried to give Pete some space. "Don't Tyler, don't, don't, don't."

"Way to pick sides, Jess," he said, fists clenched at his hips.

"Tyler, don't, come on now. I'm not..." She put her hands up on his chest. "Baby, please. Petey?" She turned to her husband, afraid to kneel to him in case it would upset Tyler. So she stood stupidly next to him, bent at the waist with her arms folded. "Petey, can you breathe?"

He was inhaling now, a loud raspy voice-tinged whine. He lifted a hand slightly.

Tyler grabbed Pete by the back of the neck and lifted him up.

"Tyler, baby, stop!"

He put Pete in a headlock and Pete let him. He was still struggling to breathe.

"Tyler, please!" she yelled. She hit him on the back with her little fist but it was like hitting the fridge.

"Jess, don't," he said. He took Pete and walked him down the hall, still in a headlock, Pete's feet stumbling along to keep up.

She broke down crying. That was her Pete. "Stop, Tyler!" she wailed now, her face trembled, her eyes filled with tears. "Stop! Please, don't hurt him. He doesn't mean it. He's not making any sense!"

Tyler let him go and shoved him towards the front door. Pete fell against it, then doubled over. His face was red, his eyes watery. Tyler turned back to her, said, "Jess, please don't cry. Jess, I'm sorry. I'm kicking him out, baby." He came right to her and hugged her. She cried into his chest. Cried and sobbed, put her hand on him as her tears soaked his shirt.

"I am...making sense, Jess. I...mean it. Tyler...knows what I'm talking about."

Tyler said, "Get out, Pete. Go. Look what you've done."

Pete leaned back against the door, still bent at the knees, face pained. He was clutching his stomach. He groaned, struggled for air, said, "Real great guy...you love my...boys so much...but this is what you do to their...father...what would they...think...ungh...they saw this?"

Tyler let her go and he strode right up so he could get in Pete's face again. He said, "You're really asking for it, Pete. I'm giving you a chance to get out of here without getting hurt."

Pete raised his head to him, he groaned, "That's...ah...why I'm here."

"Then go."

“I’m here...because you’re asking for it...I’m the one...giving you a chance...to get out of here...without getting hurt.”

Tyler leaned a hand against the wall next to Pete’s head, pointed a finger in his face while he said, “Pete, stop. You need to leave, okay? Don’t make a fool of yourself.”

Pete pushed his hand away weakly, said, “I talked to someone this afternoon...someone who knows you.”

Tyler cocked his head again, different this time. It made her think he knew what Pete was talking about.

“Who?”

“You fucked his wife too...he didn’t take it as well as I did.”

“What did you do?” Tyler was intent.

“He’s coming here to kill you...I came here to give you a chance...”

Jess gasped, “Tyler?”

Tyler said, “You’re fucking lying.”

“Mark Draper. Cop. Big moustache. You fucked his wife Linda. Met her at AA. He told me he was going to shoot you right through the heart.” Pete watched his own finger as he touched it in the centre of Tyler’s chest.

Jess said, “No, Pete. Tyler, what’s he talking about?”

Pete said, “Yeah, Jess. He ran away. Hid. He thought the coast was clear, but it’s not. This guy’s still hot. And now he knows where you are because I told him.”

Tyler shook his head. “He can’t still—”

“You think a man’s going to forget that? Forget the hurt you caused? You think he wakes up one morning and decides what you did to him wasn’t going to hurt anymore?”

Tyler slammed his fist right through the wall next to Pete’s head. It made a loud pop, and drywall crumbled to the floor. Pete ducked, slumped along the wall, his back pressed to it.

Jess cried, “Pete, what is going on?”

Tyler paced in the hall in front of Pete. Back and forth, back and forth, his arms pumping angrily. He stopped and he roared a tremendous rage-filled bellow, fists clenched and shaking. It was frightening.

“Why!” he screamed at Pete. “Why the fuck did you do that!” He grabbed the front of Pete’s coat and lifted him up easily.

“No, no, no,” Jess yelled and she hopped behind him and wrapped her arms around his big, broad back. “Don’t hurt him, Tyler!”

Jess and Tyler saw it first. Then Pete turned and watched too. Out the front window of the door, they could see headlights turning into their cul-de-sac. A car creeping slowly, ominously. A mysterious killer coming to execute her Tyler.

“Tyler?” she whispered.

Tyler let Pete go and he fell back against the wall, still turned to watch the madman he had summoned come to their home.

Tyler stepped backward, away from the door, his eyes still watching. The headlights got closer, slowly making their way to the Mapplethorpe driveway. The headlights lit up the snow in the yard.

Tyler slipped his bare feet into his boots, he grabbed his coat. He walked down the hall, his eyes were on Jess, he was shaking his head.

The car went past, pulled into the house across the street. A minivan. Ashley’s mom. Not a killer.

“Tyler, wait,” she called to him. “It’s the neighbour.”

Pete said, “He *is* coming, Tyler. *I swear*. He’s coming to kill you. He will be here any minute.”

Tyler marched to her. His face was so troubled. She wrapped her arms around him and he held her.

“I love you, Jess,” he said. He kissed her, held her neck and she breathed him in.

“Don’t go, Tyler. We’ll figure this out...”

Tyler stepped back, he wiped at his wet eyes with the back of his hand. “I’ll be back, Jessy.”

“Tyler?”

“Baby, I’ll come back.”

He walked down the hall backward, his eyes trembling. The laces of his untied boots danced around his feet. He walked through the kitchen his eyes still on her. “Don’t cry, Jessy.” He disappeared in the dark hall. She heard the rumble of the sliding glass door. It opened, then closed.

She fell to her knees. The tears came and there was no way she could stop them. She exploded in agonizing sobs. She fell back and sat on her feet, she cried up to the ceiling. Pete was next to her, standing quietly.

She screamed at him, “Why! Why, Pete! Why did you do that!” She pounded her tiny fists as hard as she could against her knees. Pounded them again and again, crying for her daddy like a spoiled little girl. She hated herself.

Pete knelt next to her, said, "I did it because I love you."

"Oh, no, no," she cried and moaned over and over and still her husband stayed by her side.

Finally, he took her by her hair, he was gentle but firm. He pulled her to him, to look him in the eyes, she gripped his wrist softly.

"If you'd chosen me I wouldn't leave you if there were a hundred men coming to kill me." He let her go and stood.

"I know," she gasped, "I know."

He left quietly and closed the front door behind him.

She cried herself raw, cried until she fell asleep there, curled up alone in her front hall in her dark, empty home.

EPILOGUE

FRIDAY, JULY 7TH

Pete drove through his neighbourhood on a beautiful, hot and sunny Friday evening. Everyone was out. The dog park was packed, runners out in their short shorts and headphones, Tonya Waterhouse was walking the sidewalk with her stroller and her new beau. Not too bad looking this guy, tall and slim. Her mom had gone back to her old life. He honked and waved to them.

He pulled into his cul-de-sac, headed for his home. The mini-van was there in the driveway, and a sparkling white Cadillac with Arizona plates. He pulled in behind it.

Sargent was at the gate at the side of the house, standing up on his hind legs, his happy, red face peering over the top, excited to see Pete. “Hey, buddy,” he said and he stood for a bit and ruffled his face-fur and shook his jowls. He went to the front door and knocked lightly.

“Hiya, Pete,” Conrad said, holding the door open and letting him in. He was looking tan and fit even though he wasn’t getting as much golfing done here as he would back in Arizona. He was wearing shorts and a black polo, had a dishcloth thrown over one shoulder.

“Shh-sh” he shushed him in a friendly way, gave him a wink and a smile. He held Pete’s upper arm and walked him to the family room. “She’s having a nap,” he whispered. He left him there and went back to the kitchen.

Pete watched her as she slept on the couch. Sleeping so peacefully, a hot sheen to her skin despite a fan on the floor beside her, blowing and oscillating. Bare legs, bare feet, little pale blue maternity dress that came down to the tops of her thighs. God, she was so fucking sexy when she was pregnant.

Since March they had been swapping an apartment. Pete would stay out by himself one week, she would stay out the other. Just so the boys would always be in their home. Pete and Jess would be the ones who would be disrupted, not Petey and Andy. Then Jess discovered she was pregnant.

Since then he'd let her stay at the house. He lived at the apartment but he was taking the boys on the weekends. Conrad had moved in six weeks ago to help her. She was third trimester now. She looked like she was ready to burst.

Tyler was long gone. Never did come back. Probably too ashamed. Didn't even know the gift he'd left Jess with. When Pete told Mark what he'd done he laughed so hard the phone went dead. He called back said he'd hung up with his moustache. Pete talked to Mark again about a month ago. Called him up on a whim because he was thinking of him. He said Tyler was in Kentucky. He was working as a Sales rep doing trade shows for a supplement company. He had a girlfriend.

Pete wouldn't tell Jess that. He thought she might hold some hope he was going to come back to her. Walk through that back door and they would pick up where they left off.

His bike was gone back to the dealership. When Pete looked into selling it, it turned up delinquent. Loan signed by a Tiffany MacKenzie. Tyler's mom. His stuff had been packed out of the house. Pete didn't do it, but he saw the boxes in the garage, piled up neatly on and around his weight bench.

He sat down at the end of the couch, looked at her as she slept. She was so innocent. Her face placid, tired, but somehow still so beautiful and vibrant. She stirred.

"Jess?"

Her eyes fluttered, slowly opened, the sun lit them up, her icy blue eyes wet and dazzling.

"Pete?" she said. She struggled to sit up and he held his hand out to her, pulled her up so she could sit. It exhausted her. She primped her hair, smoothed out where she had slept on it. "Hi, Pete," she said quietly.

“How are you doing?”

“I’m pooped all the time.”

“You look amazing.”

“I do?” she said, her little eyebrows going up in the middle.

He nodded and smiled.

“Oh, hey, congratulations. Dad told me about your job.”

“Thank, Jess.”

“Moving up to the big leagues, huh? You deserve it, Pete.”

He shrugged. He *was* being moved up, offered an executive job at the corporate office in Cleveland. A boost in pay. Actually not that tremendous, but it was a start. He’d calculated that after taxes, and no change in spending, the pay bump itself would replace the savings that Jess had given to Tyler in just over two years.

The job they offered, he knew, would come with a lot of bullshit. He knew who had it before. Just about killed him. Corporate figured—the way Pete took that Black Friday punch—he could take a lot of shit. He could. He could take all sorts of hits. Stay stood up. He had a strong back for burden, carried a lot of weight. They had the right man.

He didn’t know how he and Jess would work it yet, how he would see the boys while living in another city, but they would figure it out. Jess was on maternity leave now. Pete heard from Patty that Jess wouldn’t be returning to Jaden Van. Everyone there talking about what she did.

There was a sparkle on her neck. On a thin chain swooping over her fine collarbones hung a heart studded with tiny diamonds. He reached out and lifted it from her, held it. Her hand came up and held his. Her warm, soft hand lightly gripping the side of his palm...

“Jess, I’m seeing someone.”

Her faint smile dropped and her eyes went down. She nodded. “I hope she’s good to you.”

“She is.”

“Maybe you could bring her around sometime. We could all have dinner,” she said, trying to look hopeful.

“I don’t know...I don’t think that’s a good idea.”

Her eyes swelled, went wet. A tear gathered then rolled down one cheek. She shook her head like it didn’t happen. Her lips wriggled and trembled, her chin dimpled. Every part of him wanted to put his arms

around her. He said, "I better get the boys in the car—we've got to get going. Take care, Jess."

She sniffed, cleared her throat, said, "Help me up, I'll walk you out." He helped her to stand and she walked with him to the bottom of the stairs. Conrad was coming down with the boys, carrying their colourful stay-away bags for them.

"Hey, guys!" Pete yelled and he grabbed them and hugged them.

"Hi, Dad," they said together. He hoisted Andy up to carry him.

"Oh, Andy, you really are getting so big."

Jess said, "Not too big to give his mommy a kiss..."

Pete held him over to her, watched her plant a light, little kiss on his cheek with her pretty lips.

"Aw, mom," Petey said, hanging his head. Knowing he was next.

"Come here," she said, clawing him towards her with her index finger. She kissed him loudly on his forehead and stroked his face. She was really crying now. But she smiled for them.

"Say bye, guys," he said, and he took the bags from Conrad and thanked him.

"Bye, Mom!"

She waved and followed them to the door.

Pete got Andy in his car seat behind Petey, who got in the passenger seat of the brand new Buick all by himself. Pete sat in the driver seat and looked at Jess there watching her three guys from the open front door. She wriggled her fingers to them, her other hand resting across her round pregnant belly. He saw her lips shape a good-bye. He knew he would never leave her.

Who was he kidding? He wasn't seeing anybody. Like he would get over Jess in five months. His heart would never recover. He couldn't be with anyone else.

This was his fault. He had done that to her. In many ways, it was him who put that baby in her belly. He never should've put her on that path. They weren't a couple who could handle that.

When she'd gripped his hand sitting on the couch while he held the pendant he'd bought her his heart had almost exploded. He wanted that so bad, and when it happened, he was mad instead of happy. It felt too good to be true. He'd flashed forward to a vision of them all together with a new life in Cleveland, in a new home, a new baby. Jess could teach again.

Cleveland needs a new teacher of the year. It had been too much to take, too much to hope for, he'd lied to her to get out of there. Her touch had scared him. But...

He had to learn to deserve her. He *did* deserve her.

All he could see when he looked at her was the face of that worried girl trying to find her dance class before she got fired. He'd helped her that day and knew that he would give anything to be the one who got to help her every day for the rest of her life. She needed him now more than ever and he could never turn his back on her. She wasn't such a catch now, was she? She needed him as much as he needed her. He'd made her damaged goods. Now she was an adulterer. A bad girl who fucked some young guy. A guy who left her, took money from her, and now she was pregnant with his baby.

Pete had pushed her out. Pushed her into that oncoming Tyler train, the Pennsylvania Legacy, with its long wide coal carts that scraped the sides of her soft, wet tunnel. Maybe part of him created that trap for her to fall into. A rotten subconscious part of him that resented her sweetness. He gave her an opportunity to be bad, to do things she'd regret. Then maybe they'd both be self-hating pieces of shit and he wouldn't have her up on a pedestal where he was afraid he couldn't even reach her. She'd fallen right off that pedestal. He'd rocked it and rocked it, kicked it like Tyler's kickstand until she fell and shattered on the floor. He would pick up her pieces. He'd pick up each piece, clean it and lovingly put her back together.

He undid his seatbelt, briskly opened the door of his new car and he marched across the drive and up the walk. She saw the look in his eyes and he saw her exigent, trembling face. He went to her and he took her chin in his hand and he kissed her lips. Her hands touched his sides, his other hand felt her belly. She kissed him back, and he bit her lip. Then he let her go, looked deep into her quivering eyes. If she would take him back one thing for sure was he would never let her hurt him again—and he would never ask her to. He would raise that little girl in her belly like she was his own. He would love her as much as his boys.

He said, "We are coming home on Monday."

She nodded, her mouth open, her lips wet.

He turned around and headed back to the Buick.

When he got back in the car it was filled with high-pitched kid laughs. He looked at Petey who was smiling. "What's so funny?"

Andy was giggling so hard he almost couldn't be understood. He blurted, "Dad kissed mom, you kissed mom," being silly and rolling his head around, almost giddy, but trying to make fun of his old pop at the same time.

Pete said, "All right, calm down, calm down. I kissed her."

"Petey—"

"You kissed mom."

"—your seatbelt on?"

Jess waved from the doorway to them. She was crying, face screwed up, shoulders shaking, but she was smiling. The sun played on her silky hair, she had one leg bent, her foot crossed over the other. He waved and smiled, then drove out of the cul-de-sac. He couldn't wait for Monday.

"What are we going to do today, Dad?" Petey said.

"I'm going to take us away this weekend. I'm taking you to Calumet Bay. Show you boys where I grew up. Take you around all the places I used to go to when I was your age."

Andy said, "What's Calumet Bay?"

"You know the train set? That's Calumet Bay. It's not entirely how I remember it, things are just always changing, but there're pieces of it still there, if we look careful enough we'll find it."

OTHER BOOKS BY KT MORRISON

MAGGIE Series

[Tempting Maggie](#)

[Sharing Maggie](#)

[Secret Maggie](#)

Discovering Maggie

Max is a fourth year Government and Policy student engaged to wed the love of his life.

Maggie is a fourth year Art student and she can't wait for the summer to come so she can finally tie the knot with the guy she fell in love with when they were Freshmen.

They've been together four years at their prestigious private college nestled in the Green Mountains of Vermont. This is the year they'll graduate and set out into the world together as a couple.

But Maggie is surprised to find her desires set on fire by a gorgeous new figure model. She thinks she'd never cheat but she can't stop thinking about him.

When Max learns her secret he's crushed. It tears down everything he knows about her. But in the rubble he finds something shining: excitement.

Now, if he could just convince her it's okay...

Losing His Wife Series

[Losing His Wife: Book One](#)

[Losing His Wife: Book Two](#)

[Losing His Wife: Book Three](#)

Pete and Jess Mapplethorpe have been married for seven years now. They've got two wonderful little boys and an Irish Setter. Everyone that knows them would say they are the nicest couple you'd want to meet.

Well, they might say that Pete can be a bit of a jerk sometimes—but Jess? Regional Grade Three teacher of the year, three years running. Pretty, polite, sensitive, kind and thoughtful...

It must have been black magic that brought them together...

Behind closed doors everyone would be shocked at what goes on. They'd never believe the dirty things that sweet Jess might do or say. Pete doesn't think he has what it takes to please his beautiful wife and they fantasize about larger men taking her and making her happy.

She's just starting to discover herself at thirty-five... She wants to make up for lost time.

They've found a handsome, well-built young man to play along. It's better than they even imagined.

Now that they've started will she be able to stop? What if she doesn't want to?

Her husband loves enduring distressing levels of humiliation and she's finding a crazy pleasure now in delivering it...

Losing His Wife 2 Series

[Losing His Wife 2: Box 1](#)

[Losing His Wife 2: Box 2](#)

[Losing His Wife 2: Box 3](#)

Geoff J. Kane is a successful children's book illustrator. Ten years ago he married the girl of his dreams. She'd been his best friend and he'd helped her through tough relationships and gave her his shoulder to cry on many nights. Then after two years, she kissed him. Now they're married and they've got a beautiful seven-year-old daughter.

Nia Kane was a wild one. She liked to have fun and she liked to cause trouble. Everything she did, in the end, blew up in her face, hurt her. One night she realized the best man in her life was sitting with her, telling her it was all going to be okay. She kissed him and it was wonderful and he's always good to her.

Their daughter is growing up, she's away at school now and it seems like it might be a good idea for Nia to return to the workforce. The city isn't getting any cheaper. She gets a job offer from an old friend. The brother of her very hot ex-boyfriend. She cried on her husband's shoulder a lot over this guy, back when Geoff was just her buddy.

Having her ex back in her life stirs up old feelings in both of them. They both like it. There was something exciting about that time when they were twenty. It's safe now. He's got her. They can fantasize, right?

Obsessed Series

[Obsessed: Book One](#)

[Obsessed: Book Two](#)

Four couples lives intertwine as they explore their erotic boundaries. From simple wife-watching to cuckolding and domination and humiliation, these couples have one thing in common: they all share the same incredible bull. And he is far more than they even expected.

Mike and Gretch: Not married, but dating for a good long while. Two comedy writers just at the edge of love, that strange and delicate space where the act of sharing can be so dangerous. But they're two cool cats and they're sure they've got it all locked down. They call her ex-boyfriend from college, Atticus Hawke, a guy who has in the years since their breakup, and before Mike, been a reliable booty call for her.

Sean and Courtney: Sean's a Type A stick of dynamite. A rocketing studio exec, competitive and driven, he shares an incredible bond with his gym-toned wife. Courtney is all in for the new game she and her handsome husband have devised. Their ten-year-old daughter is out of the house and away at

boarding school. They've planned a one-year commitment to one another about honesty, openness, and exploration. They're going for broke. Their new thing? Sean likes to watch and Court likes to be watched. They've found a guy online. He seems too good to be true. A guy called Finch, endowed, muscular, handsome like a fashion model. Courtney's been working out and she's going to put this stud through his paces.

Steve and Becky: Becky's a headstrong X-Ray technician who landed herself a multi-millionaire tech investor husband thirty years her senior. Steve loves to be dominated and he found the girl of his dreams in Becky. She's got an iron will and she loves her husband. Loves him enough to lock him in chastity and keep him abstinent for months on end. It's okay, don't worry about Becky, she gets a regular visit from a drop-dead gorgeous man named Finch. He keeps her satisfied. Sometimes, if he's been good, she'll even let her husband watch.

JJ and Amy: Two young country bumpkins just arrived in Los Angeles. JJ wants to live a lifestyle he's only dreamed of and this city is part of it. He's married to the sweetest little nineteen-year-old outta Jackson Pond, South Carolina and he's sure she's on a fast ticket to stardom. She just needs her first big break. While they're waiting he's got a fantasy he wants to see lived out. He would do anything to see his little Amy with a man who's got a big one, one'll make her scream like those girls he watches on the internet. He found a guy online, one Amy didn't make her vomit-face at. He's got everything JJ's been looking for and, thank the stars, he's agreed to do it.

Atticus Hawke: Finch is his online name. His nighttime name. The one he uses on a site that puts him in touch with couples looking for a bull just like him. By day he is Atticus Hawke. You might have heard of him. You know the song from the eighties, 'Going With That Girl'? No? You'd know it if you heard it. That was Atticus' dad, Ricky Hawke. Yes, that Ricky Hawke. Now you know. Made a bunch of singer-songwriter hits in a time when all the kids wanted pop coming out of synthesizers and their stars to be pretty boys and have colourful hair. Ricky had real talent. So does Atticus. One of L.A.'s hottest emerging Modern artists, his work commands a fortune. But it pales against his enormous trust fund. These days his real work is done at night. His masterpieces. That's where his passion is. Watching and participating in intense psychological dramas in dark hotel rooms across the city. He gives women what they want. They're a canvas, a medium. His audience: their husband.

The Cayman Proxy Series:

The Cayman Proxy (Box One)

Mitchell Sutton's family is one of the wealthiest in London. But Mitch is an outsider, the handsome young son who took his own path. He's in love with a girl from the wrong side of the tracks.

Kate's a troubled Council house girl thrown into a lifestyle she never imagined. But she's more than his dressed up little princess.

He's got just about everything she needs. But she's got a mind full of dark thoughts she can't escape. And there's something Mitch can't give her.

She needs something his money can't buy.

He would do anything for her.

They hit the hot beaches of Grand Cayman, a reunion with an old friend and a handsome stranger. Passion boils in her blood. Can she make this work or will her desires destroy the man she loves?

Going A Little Too Far

You couldn't picture a sweeter couple than Troy and Emma.

Troy's a former Division One college wrestler. A walking water park at two-sixty-five, with shoulders no woman could get her arms around and a set of abs you could scrub laundry on.

Emma's a sweet little Georgia Peach. Pretty as can be in her proper dresses; she's a good girl from a good family that raised her right.

You couldn't tell by looking at them that they were two straight-up freaks that loved to push each other's kinky buttons.

Emma, with all her book club shyness, loves to be man-handled, loves to be lifted off her feet and dominated. Troy is a monster with a six-hundred-fifty pound deadlift and she's like a feather in his arms.

Troy likes to be humiliated. He knows he doesn't have much 'down there' and he likes his virginal wife to tell him he's no good and she'd have to get what she wanted elsewhere.

Couple of closet freaks.

A summer housewarming party on a scorching hot West Texas day puts a gift in their lap. A big, larger-than-life playtoy for Emma to tease her husband with. He wants her to. She wants to do it. But once it starts, where do you stop? What's going too far?

Taken While He Watches: On Their Honeymoon

Ken and Ashley just got married and while money is super-tight they've got themselves a weekend getaway in the Honeymoon Suite looking out over the ocean on the sunny Carolina coast.

The room was a steal. Turns out it's Bike Week and no one books the Honeymoon Suite during Bike Week. Especially not two dopey white kids from the suburbs.

A mix-up leaves them in trouble and they don't know how they can get out of it, don't even know how they'll get home. They get some help from their hotel neighbours. A half dozen handsome, muscular, and very wealthy black men.

Ken's wary but Ash is all in.

When they find out she's saved herself for her special night she becomes the star of the show and they'll offer anything to help her...

Ken doesn't like it but she's going to do what they ask. She says it's for their future...

Taken While He Watches: At The Combine

Coralee has put her own career on hold to help her husband keep his Sports Podcast afloat. He's spent eighty grand on his tiny entertainment empire.

Bobby just needs a big break. His business is a half second away from going belly-up. When their camera captures an XXL wardrobe malfunction by the combine's star prospect they see an opportunity.

Coralee will do anything to get an interview with him. She'll use the video as leverage. She'll get to this bad boy super-athlete, even if she has to break into the locker room...

She's doing it to save the family business, right?

Taken By His Best Friends: At The Hockey Rink

Marguerite was a sexy little French student Randall fell in love with at college. She loved hockey. He played hockey.

They fell in love and they married. They live a regular 9 to 5 now, but Randall and his best friends still play once a week. They are four big guys and they play rough and Marguerite is always there to cheer them from the stands.

When they all end up alone in the locker room after a bench-clearing brawl passions are already high. And when some innocent flirting starts it quickly tumbles out of control.

Marguerite does nothing to stop it. Randall is frozen...

He's going to watch his best friends do all the dirty things they've ever dreamed of doing to his wife...

Measured Next To Her Ex: A Medical Size Comparison Cuckold Fantasy

When Ben Watson went to the new Sexual Performance Clinic across from his office he was just looking to get some help.

But when he showed up on Opening Day the place was so overwhelmed they started doubling up in exam rooms to make sure all the patients were assessed.

Of all the gin joints in all the—

Guess who his exam partner is? Yeah, his honey-pie's ex-boyfriend. He is going to be sitting next to him, knees practically touching, while theses nurses assess their size and performance using only their latex hands.

He could leave, get the hell out of there. That would be sensible. But he's kind of curious. A dark part of him wants to know something. Wants to know what his precious girl's ex-lover has between his legs.

He's going to wish he left.

Then, when his obscenely endowed exam mate starts to relate to the nurses the casual but very dirty hook-ups he's been having with an ex, Ben's hands really start sweating.

This is going to be the worst day of Ben's life.

Size Curious Brat

Matt Walsh is on his way home from Harvard. It's Thanksgiving recess and he hasn't been with his sweet Chloe Rose in months. He can't wait to get off the bus and wrap his arms around his baby girl.

Chloe's a perverted little high-schooler with a habit for trouble. She loves her boyfriend Matt and she's been aching for him.

But there's a problem.

Matt's step brother came home early. He's a bully. A domineering man's man who made Matt's life miserable growing up. Now he's a sexy deep-sea welder just getting home from Louisiana after two months at sea and he hasn't even seen a woman in ages.

After a brief, naked encounter in the hallway little Chloe can't get something out of her mind. Matt's stepbrother Moric is built much better than other men and she can't stop thinking about it.

It makes Matt mad but Chloe is just naturally curious. She doesn't think it's a big deal. She's just never seen anything like that before.

Now Moric's got his eyes on his little brother's prize possession. She's not exactly unwilling. Moric is a big powerful stud and Matt is powerless to stop him. Once he starts neither of them could stop him. He could take whatever he wants. It might be better—if Moric would let him—to just join him...